
The IELTS Academic War Book

A complete preparation system for band 7.0 — built for one reader, and verified line by line against official sources.

How to read the blocks

■ Trap / band-6 mistake ■ Technique ■ Official rule ■ Worked example ■ Judgement / myth

■ How to recognise it ■ Your Arabic / French

Verified 31 July 2026. Nine research passes · six independent adversarial audits · every claim traced to an official source · nothing unverified in the text.

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Short of time? Every chapter opens with a *60-second summary* in a cream box. On a busy day that box is the chapter — the nine of them take about fifteen minutes and carry most of what moves a band. Coloured blocks are explained on the cover.

The IELTS Academic War Book

A complete preparation system for band 7.0 – built for one reader, verified against official sources.

Written for a native Arabic speaker (Tunisian) with fluent French, taking IELTS Academic on computer in Tunisia, studying about ninety minutes a day, targeting band 7.0 overall with a floor of 6.5 in every paper.

Verified 31 July 2026.

What "verified" means here, and what it does not

Every factual claim in this book about test format, timing, scoring, band conversion, penalties and policy was checked against **official sources** – ielts.org, the British Council, IDP, and Cambridge English – and carries an inline source note.

The book was then attacked by **six independent adversarial audits**, each instructed to find errors rather than confirm the text, and each forbidden from treating the research notes as evidence. They re-fetched sources themselves. Between them they raised 9 critical, 43 major and around 59 minor issues. All were resolved before this book was assembled, and a final verification gate traced sampled claims back to a sources ledger and re-derived the hardest findings from primary documents.

Nothing marked unverified survives into this text. Where something could not be confirmed, the book says so plainly and tells you to check it yourself, rather than presenting a guess as a fact.

What this book is not. It is not official. It is not a substitute for the published band descriptors, which you should read directly – the links are in Appendix E. No official test material is reproduced anywhere in it: every passage, question, cue card and model answer is original. And it is not current forever. Format and policy change; re-check anything time-sensitive before your test date.

Some things it could not settle

Five questions were researched properly and remain open, because no official source answers them:

- Whether **One Skill Retake** is available in Tunisia
- Whether an **Enquiry on Results can lower** a band (only IDP says it cannot)
- The exact **Speaking scheduling window** (three official figures conflict)
- Whether **paper** is still offered in Tunisia (the British Council site contradicts itself in English *and* French)

- Whether your test centre uses **AZERTY** or **QWERTY** keyboards

All five are answered by one phone call to your centre. Make it.

How to use this book

Read this page. It is the most important one in the book.

This book is about 94,000 words — roughly ten hours of reading. The study plan in [Chapter 9](#) allows you about **nine minutes of theory a day**, because practice with feedback is what raises a band and reading about IELTS is not.

Those two facts are in tension, and pretending otherwise would waste your time. So this book is **not designed to be read cover to cover**. Here is the route.

The design that makes this possible

Every chapter opens with a 60-second summary. That is deliberate. On a busy day, the summary *is* the chapter. It carries the load-bearing content; the rest is the working detail, the evidence, and the reference tables you consult when a specific problem arises.

If you read nothing else in this book, read the nine summaries. That is about fifteen minutes and covers most of what will change your score.

Day zero — before you start the plan (about 40 minutes)

Read	Why
Chapter 1 — 60-second summary + the band arithmetic	You need to know that 6.75 reports as 7.0, and that from a 6.5 floor you need two more half-bands, not four sevens. This changes what you practise.
Chapter 9 — the study plans and the reading route	Pick your 6, 8 or 10-week plan. Everything else hangs off this.
Appendix C — the error card	Your specific L1 traps, on one page. Keep it beside you whenever you write.

Then: one chapter section per skill day

Do **not** read a whole chapter in one sitting. Match the reading to the day's practice:

On a day you practise...	Read
Writing Task 2	Ch 5 — the question family you are drilling, plus its band decoder
Writing Task 1	Ch 4 — the visual type you are drilling
Reading	Ch 3 — the question type you are weakest at
Listening	Ch 2 — the relevant question type, plus the answer-rule reference
Speaking	Ch 6 — one part only

On a day you practise...	Read
Vocabulary	Ch 7 – the topic bank you are building

Read once, then never again

- **Chapter 1** – the mechanics. Once you know the arithmetic, you know it.
- **Chapter 9 §Test day** – reread only in the final week.

Skim, then return when a problem appears

- **Chapter 7** (vocabulary) and **Chapter 8** (grammar and your error map) are **reference works**. Read the summaries now. Return to the relevant table when a graded task shows you need it.

Keep open while working

- **Appendix A** – band descriptors, for grading your own writing
- **Appendix B** – question-type index, when you meet an unfamiliar task
- **Appendix C** – the error card, whenever you write
- **CHEAT-SHEETS.md** – the final 48 hours only

Mapping to the plans in **Chapter 9**

Week	Reading
1	Day zero block, then Ch 5 §families and Ch 3 §TFNG
2	The chapter section matching each day's practice
3	Ch 8 – your error map, properly, once you have logged real errors
4	Ch 7 §hedging kit, Ch 6 §Part 3
Final week	Ch 9 §Test day, Appendix D, then the cheat sheets

The error review matters more than the reading. Twenty minutes rereading your own logged mistakes beats an hour of this book. Errors you do not revisit, you repeat.

CHAPTER 1

1 How IELTS Academic Really Works

WHAT IT IS WORTH

The whole test

WHY IT MATTERS

Where your two missing half-bands actually are

FULL READ

~29 min

60-second summary

Read this first. Everything after it is the evidence.

Four papers — Listening (~30 min, 40 questions), Academic Reading (60 min, 3 passages, 40 questions), Writing (60 min, Task 1 ≥150 words / Task 2 ≥250 words), Speaking (11–14 min, 3 parts) — on a 0–9 scale in whole and half bands.

You are sitting it on a computer, in Tunisia, and paper is being retired from mid-2026. The most expensive consequence: **computer Listening has no ten-minute transfer window, only two minutes to check.** ielts.org's own Listening page still advertises the ten minutes with no computer caveat — ignore it.

Listening and Reading are marked out of 40, one mark per question; band 7 is officially 30/40 in both. ielts.org and the British Council publish four anchor points per paper (bands 5, 6, 7, 8); **IDP publishes the full table, half bands included** — Listening 6.5 = 26–29 and 7 = 30–31, Academic Reading 6.5 = 27–29 and 7 = 30–32 [[src: ielts.idp.com/thailand/results/scores/listening](https://ielts.idp.com/thailand/results/scores/listening) — IELTS Listening band scores; the table is on IDP's market pages, not the canonical /results/scores/listening URL] [[src: ielts.idp.com](https://ielts.idp.com) — Reading band scores]. So the last step is small and countable: **in Listening, band 6.5 runs all the way to 29 and band 7 begins at 30 — one mark.** Boundaries move slightly between versions, so aim at the *top* of a band, never its floor. Writing and Speaking are marked on four criteria of 25% each. Within Writing, Task 1 is worth a third and Task 2 two thirds; the combining formula is unpublished, but $(T1 + 2 \times T2) \div 3$ is a sound planning estimate. Task 2 alone is about 17% of your whole result.

The overall band is the four-paper average rounded to the nearest half — **.25 rounds up to the next half band, .75 up to the next whole band.** Hence the strategic centre of this book: an average of 6.75 reports as 7.0, which is 27.0 out of 28.0. From a 6.5 floor in all four papers you need exactly **two more half-bands**, not four sevens. Buy them in Listening and Reading, where technique converts directly into marks — and buy a third if you can, because 27.0 exactly leaves no margin for a bad morning. Then check the gate: a per-section minimum is not an average, and Writing is the paper most likely to break it. Start Writing in week one. It moves slowest, and it decides this.

What the test actually asks

IELTS Academic is four papers: Listening, Reading, Writing, Speaking. The official headline figure for the whole test is **2 hours 45 minutes** [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic test format and sections].

You will also see **2 hours 40 minutes** for the Listening + Reading + Writing session, with "no breaks between each section of the test" [src: ielts.org — What to expect on IELTS test day]. Both figures are official and both are published without any delivery-mode caveat — ielts.org applies the 2h40 figure to the written session generally, not to paper only, and this book will not invent a reconciliation the sources do not state. What is worth noticing is that neither headline is the sum of the papers: on computer, Listening 30 + a 2-minute check + Reading 60 + Writing 60 is about **2h32**, and the rest is instructions, seating and admin. **Treat 2h40 as the length of time you must be seated and concentrating, and budget your work against the individual paper timings below rather than against either headline.**

There is no pass or fail. Every paper, and the overall score, is reported on a nine-band scale in whole or half bands [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Guide for teachers (PDF)].

Two facts about your test that change everything downstream.

First, **you will sit this on a computer**. From mid-2026, "All IELTS tests will be delivered on computer. Exact timelines will vary by market" [src: ielts.org — Updates to IELTS test delivery]. British Council Tunisia's dates, fees and locations page lists only IELTS on computer at a centre and IELTS Online, across five locations: Tunis, Bizerte, Sousse, Sfax and Gabes [src: britishcouncil.tn — Test dates, fees and locations]. Other pages on the same site still quote a paper-based fee — in **English as well as French**, so this is not a stale translation — which means **the site is not internally consistent and cannot settle the question; phone the centre** [src: britishcouncil.tn — IELTS General Training (English page)]. Either way, paper is being retired from mid-2026, and every timing, technique and drill in this book assumes a screen and a keyboard.

Second, **the move to computer does not change what is measured**: "This update does not change the IELTS skills assessed, the test construct, or the way results should be interpreted by institutions" [src: ielts.org — Updates to IELTS test delivery]. Same descriptors. What changes is the clock, the input method, and one ten-minute window that no longer exists — see *Myths*.

Section order: British Council and ielts.org state Listening → Reading → Writing on one day [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS test format explained], and IDP says the same for computer delivery [src: ielts.idp.com — What to expect on IELTS test day]. For the *paper* test IDP's comparison page gives a different order. Both are official; the conflict is unresolved and does not affect you. Plan for Listening → Reading → Writing.

Speaking may be the same day or a different one, and the published windows disagree — "seven days before or after" [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS test format explained] versus "seven days before or two days after that, depending on local arrangements" [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Frequently asked questions]. For computer-delivered tests both partners point to the **same day**, before or after the other

papers [src: ielts.idp.com — What to expect on IELTS test day]. **Trust your booking confirmation over any published window**, and note that a later slot "may cause a delay in your IELTS results" [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Frequently asked questions].

Results on computer: about half are ready within one day and 80% within two [src: ielts.org — Fast IELTS results: get and share your score], though other official pages quote up to five days [src: ielts.org — Ways to take IELTS: online, computer or paper]. **Plan university deadlines against five days**. The Test Report Form is valid for two years, and there is no limit on retakes [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Frequently asked questions].

Question types, one by one

For this chapter, the "types" are the four papers. Here is the anatomy of each, and what the screen changes.

Listening — approximately 30 minutes, 4 parts, 40 questions

[src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Listening test format]

Each recording is played **once**: "You will hear each recording ONCE only", and questions follow the order of the recording in every question type [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module (PDF)]. If you cannot find the answer you are hunting for, the recording has already moved past it and you must move with it.

There is a pause between parts and one break inside each of Parts 1, 2 and 3 to read ahead.

Part 4's mid-part pause is short and is not announced on the recording [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module (PDF)] — which makes Part 4 the part with the least structured reading time, and the part to protect in training.

ielts.org's format page lists **six** Listening question types: multiple choice; matching; plan, map or diagram labelling; form, note, table, flow-chart or summary completion; sentence completion; and short-answer questions [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Listening test format]. **Chapter 2** works through **eleven** layouts rather than six, and the arithmetic is worth following so the two counts never look like a disagreement. It splits the fourth type — the completion family — into its five printed layouts, because form, note, table, flow-chart and summary each behave differently on screen even though the marking rules are identical. It also splits multiple choice into its **one-answer** and **multiple-answer** forms, because a *choose TWO* item occupies two question numbers and is worth two marks, which changes what a mistake costs. The remaining four types — matching, plan/map/diagram labelling, sentence completion and short-answer questions — carry across unchanged. Five plus two plus four is eleven.

Answers are marked for spelling and grammar, and both British and American spellings count [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module (PDF)]; **Chapter 2** takes the marking rules in detail.

The computer difference, and it is the big one: on paper you get ten extra minutes to copy answers onto an answer sheet [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS test format explained]. On computer you do not — "At the end of the Listening section you only have two minutes to check your answers" [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Frequently asked questions].

takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS on paper vs computer: how to choose], confirmed independently by "no extra time is given to transfer your answers... You will only have 2 minutes to review your answers at the end" [src: ielts.idp.com — How IELTS on computer works].

Academic Reading — 60 minutes, 3 passages, 40 questions

[src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Reading test format]

Total text length is 2,150–2,750 words across the three passages, and the 60 minutes **includes** transfer: "You must transfer your answers during the hour you are given for the Reading test. Unlike the Listening test, no extra transfer time is given" [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Reading test format]. Official pacing advice is "about 20 minutes on each text" [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module (PDF)].

ielts.org's format page lists eleven Academic Reading question types: multiple choice; identifying information (True/False/Not Given); identifying a writer's views or claims (Yes/No/Not Given); matching information; matching headings; matching features; matching sentence endings; sentence completion; summary/note/table/flow-chart completion; diagram label completion; and short-answer questions [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Reading test format]. Chapter 3 takes them one at a time.

Computer differences: you type answers, so illegible handwriting stops being a risk — on paper, "If an answer isn't clear on your answer sheet, you will lose the mark" [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module (PDF)]. You get a built-in highlighter (left-click-drag, right-click → highlight; right-click → clear all) that "your examiner will not be able to see" [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS on computer: Highlighting text], plus a permanently visible timer and free navigation between questions [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS on paper vs computer: how to choose].

Writing — 60 minutes, 2 tasks

[src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Writing test format]

Task 1 asks for **at least 150 words** and instructs you to spend **no more than 20 minutes** on it; Task 2 asks for **at least 250 words** in **no more than 40 minutes**, in a style that is "academic or semi-formal/neutral" [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Writing test format]. That instruction is printed on the task but not enforced by the software: the computer gives you 60 minutes, lets you move between tasks freely, and shows a live word counter, though "you still need to check your own spelling" [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS on paper vs computer: how to choose]. The response must be full connected prose — "it should not have sub-headings or bullet points" [src: ielts.org — Writing test resources].

Speaking — 11–14 minutes, 3 parts

[src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Speaking test format]

Part 1 runs 4–5 minutes, Part 2 runs 3–4 minutes including preparation time, Part 3 runs 4–5 minutes. It is "a face-to-face interview between the test taker and an examiner", and "The Speaking test is recorded" [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Speaking test format]. One British Council booking page instead describes it as "either face-to-face or via video call" [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS on computer

(booking page)], which conflicts with ielts.org and IDP; **which applies in Tunisia could not be confirmed — ask your centre, and if it is video, rehearse on video.** Either way it is a human examiner, never software [\[src: ielts.idp.com — IELTS on computer vs IELTS on paper\]](https://ielts.idp.com).

Tips & tricks

Ranked by how many marks they are worth to you.

1. Buy your extra half-bands in Listening and Reading, not Writing. [\[expert consensus\]](#) These are objectively marked — 40 questions, "Each correct answer is awarded 1 mark" [\[src: ielts.org — IELTS scoring in detail: band scores explained\]](#) — so technique converts directly into score, while Writing and Speaking are human-judged against criteria and move more slowly. The band math below shows you need only two extra half-bands above a 6.5 floor. **When this fails:** if Writing is below 6.5, no amount of Reading technique rescues you, because a sub-score floor is a gate, not an average.

2. Start Writing in week one and never stop it. [\[expert consensus\]](#) It is the slowest-moving paper and, for both your first languages, the lowest-scoring one (see *L1 alert*). **How, concretely:** [Chapter 9](#) §The weekly rotation gives Writing the largest share of every week from week one and shows what the other papers get; [Chapter 9](#) §Why Writing gets the most time explains the trade-off against this chapter's "buy your half-bands in Listening and Reading". Take the rotation from there rather than improvising a split. **When this fails:** doing Writing *only*. Daily essays plus untrained Listening produces 6.5 Writing, 6.0 Listening, and a miss.

3. Protect Task 2's forty minutes as arithmetic, not discipline. [\[verified\]](#) "Finish Writing Task 1 after about 20 minutes to allow enough time to answer Writing Task 2. Remember Task 2 contributes twice as much as Task 1" [\[src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module \(PDF\)\]](#). Ten minutes overrun on Task 1 is ten minutes stolen from the task worth double.

4. Rehearse the two-minute Listening close. [\[verified\]](#) You have 120 seconds, not ten minutes. Note on paper any item you want to revisit — the window closes automatically [\[src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS on paper vs computer: how to choose\]](#).

5. Answer every question, but guess one thing. [\[verified\]](#) "Try to answer all the questions, even if you don't feel sure about an answer" [\[src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module \(PDF\)\]](#) — there is no negative marking. Two answers in one gap, however, score zero.

6. Learn the interface before test day, then use it freely. [\[verified\]](#) The official familiarisation test is free, untimed, and uses the real test screens [\[src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Free IELTS familiarisation test\]](#). Once you know it, highlight without hesitation in Reading: "You can highlight as much or as little text as you want without any impact on your test result", and you need not clear it before moving **on** [\[src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS on computer: Highlighting text\]](#).

7. In Listening, write what you hear, not your paraphrase. [verified] (*Paraphrase*, throughout this book, means saying the same thing in different words. Listening pays you for the speaker's words; Writing and Speaking pay you for yours.) "Don't try to rephrase what you hear. Try to write down the words you hear which fit the question" [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module (PDF)]. **When this fails:** in Writing, where the rule inverts — "Don't simply copy words and phrases from the question paper" [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module (PDF)].

Myths that hold you back

"I get ten minutes at the end of Listening to transfer my answers." Not on computer. You get two minutes to *check* [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS on paper vs computer: how to choose]. **Why this myth survives:** ielts.org's own Listening format page still states "Approximately 30 minutes (plus 10 minutes to transfer your answers to an answer sheet)" with no computer caveat at all [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Listening test format]. It is describing paper. **Do instead:** train every Listening drill with answers entered as you hear them and a hard 2-minute close.

"I need band 7 in all four papers to get 7.0 overall." You do not: an average of 6.75 reports as 7.0 (see the next section). **Why the myth is expensive:** it makes you chase a Writing 7.0 you probably will not reach in six weeks, instead of a Writing 6.5 you can plus two half-bands in Listening and Reading that you certainly can.

"There's a raw-score table that tells me exactly what 6.5 needs." There is an official one — it is just not a guarantee. ielts.org and the British Council publish four anchors per paper (bands 5, 6, 7, 8) [src: ielts.org — IELTS scoring in detail: band scores explained]; IDP, the third joint owner of IELTS, publishes the full table including every half band [src: ielts.idp.com/thailand/results/scores/listening — IELTS Listening band scores; the table is on IDP's market pages, not the canonical /results/scores/listening URL] [src: ielts.idp.com — Reading band scores]. Both carry the same warning: "The precise number of marks needed to achieve these band scores will vary slightly from test version to test version" [src: ielts.org — IELTS scoring in detail], and IDP's own caveat is that its figures are the *average* marks required and "actual marks may vary slightly between tests" [src: ielts.idp.com/thailand/results/scores/listening — IELTS Listening band scores; the table is on IDP's market pages, not the canonical /results/scores/listening URL]. **Do instead:** use the table in the next section as a planning average, and read every boundary as a floor rather than a safe landing — Academic Reading 27 is the *bottom* of 6.5, not a comfortable 6.5. Aim a mark or two above every line you are targeting.

"Under-length costs you a fixed half band." There is no published arithmetic penalty, and the official positions differ in emphasis. [ielts.org](#) says "you will be penalised if your answer is too short" [\[src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Writing test format\]](#); Cambridge's FAQ says "There is no direct penalty for writing fewer than 150 words for the Task 1 question and 250 words for the Task 2 question. However, writing fewer words may impact on the range of ideas and evidence produced and may therefore affect your score" [\[src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module \(PDF\)\]](#). Cambridge is two-handed about it: the same FAQ that says there is no direct penalty also lists, under Writing → Don't, "Don't write less than the required number of words" [\[src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module \(PDF\)\]](#). Neither statement is a tariff, and neither contradicts the mechanism below. The May 2023 descriptors contain no word-count deduction — under-length appears only as a *cause* of low criterion scores — and the key criteria define the task as fulfilled "using a minimum of 150 words" / "250 words" [\[src: ielts.org — IELTS Writing key assessment criteria \(PDF\)\]](#). **What is certain:** "Responses of 20 words or fewer are rated at Band 1" [\[src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Writing band descriptors \(PDF\)\]](#). **Do instead:** stop asking what the deduction is. A 210-word Task 2 cannot fully develop a position, so Task Response is capped, and there is too little text to evidence lexical or grammatical range. That mechanism costs more than a flat half band would.

"One Skill Retake is my safety net." It may not exist for you. It requires all of: a full test completed at a centre that offers it, that full test taken on computer, the retake sat within 60 days [\[src: ielts.org — IELTS One Skill Retake: retake one section\]](#) and in the same country [\[src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS One Skill Retake\]](#), one retake per full test, and acceptance by the receiving institution — which IELTS tells you to verify directly before booking [\[src: ielts.org — One Skill Retake\]](#). British Council Tunisia publishes a One Skill Retake page but says only that it "is currently available at selected IELTS on Computer centres", naming no Tunisian centre [\[src: britishcouncil.tn — IELTS One Skill Retake\]](#). **Whether it runs in Tunis, Sfax, Sousse, Bizerte or Gabes could not be confirmed — ask your centre, and never build a band-7 plan that depends on it.**

"Copying the prompt gives me a free introduction." "Any copied rubric must be discounted" [\[src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Writing band descriptors \(PDF\)\]](#) — it does not count as your writing, so copying can silently push you under length. *Rubric*, throughout this book, means **the printed wording of the task**: the prompt statement, the instruction line above it, and any chart or table title. Copying any of that is what "copied rubric" refers to.

"A memorised essay is insurance." It is a band 0 risk: band 0 is used "where there is proof that a candidate's answer has been totally memorised" [\[src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Writing band descriptors \(PDF\)\]](#), and memorised phrasing is named in the descriptors as evidence *of* low bands. "Don't waste your time learning essays by heart to use in the exam. You will be penalised for this" [\[src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module \(PDF\)\]](#).

Band descriptor decoder — the band math

Listening and Academic Reading: raw marks to band

40 questions, one mark each [src: ielts.org — IELTS scoring in detail: band scores explained]. Two official sources publish the conversion, at two levels of detail, and you need both.

ielts.org and the British Council publish four anchor points per paper:

Band	Listening (/40)	Academic Reading (/40)
5	16	15
6	23	23
7	30	30
8	35	35

[src: ielts.org — IELTS scoring in detail: band scores explained] [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Guide for teachers (PDF)]

IDP — the third joint owner of IELTS — publishes the full table, half bands included:

Band	Listening (/40)	Academic Reading (/40)
9	39–40	39–40
8.5	37–38	37–38
8	35–36	35–36
7.5	32–34	33–34
7	30–31	30–32
6.5	26–29	27–29
6	23–25	23–26
5.5	18–22	19–22
5	16–17	15–18

[src: ielts.idp.com/thailand/results/scores/listening — IELTS Listening band scores; the table is on IDP's market pages, not the canonical

/results/scores/listening URL] [src: ielts.idp.com — Reading band scores]

The two tables agree exactly. Every ielts.org anchor is the bottom mark of the corresponding IDP band row — 16 and 15 at band 5, 23 at band 6, 30 at band 7, 35 at band 8 — which is as good a cross-check as this book gets on any number. Print the IDP table and use it; it is official, not a reconstruction.

Use it as an **average**, not a promise. IELTS states the caveat plainly: "The precise number of marks needed to achieve these band scores will vary slightly from test version to test version" [src: ielts.org — IELTS scoring in detail] — boundaries are equated per version, so "the Band 6 boundary may be set at a slightly different raw score across individual tests" [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Guide for teachers]

(PDF)]. IDP says the same of its own table: these are the *average* marks required, and "actual marks may vary slightly between tests" [src: ielts.idp.com/thailand/results/scores/listening — IELTS Listening band scores; the table is on IDP's market pages, not the canonical /results/scores/listening URL].

Why the half bands are worth printing, and why "aim for 30" is the weaker instruction. In Listening, band 6.5 runs to **29** and band 7 begins at **30**. If you are already at the top of 6.5, your last half-band — the one this whole book is organised around — is **one mark**: one gap you currently type an article into, one plural you currently guess at. Academic Reading behaves the same way at the top (29 → 30) and costs three marks from the bottom of 6.5 (27 → 30). Told only "band 7 is 30", you cannot see any of that. Told the ranges, you can score a practice paper on Monday morning and know exactly what you are short of, and whether the answer is another six weeks of technique or a single fixable habit.

Practical reading: **30/40 is band 7** in both papers, and the ranges tell you the cost of everything either side of it. Plan against the *top* of the band you are targeting, not its floor, because the boundary may sit a mark higher on your version. The anchors are identical from band 6 upward — 23, 30, 35 in both papers — but the **ranges between them are not**, and that catches people out. A raw 26 is a 6.5 in Listening and still a 6 in Academic Reading; a raw 32 is a 7.5 in Listening and still a 7 in Reading. Score each paper against its own column, and note that the lowest anchor differs too: Reading 15, Listening 16.

Writing and Speaking: four criteria, equal weight

Both are marked by certificated examiners on four criteria worth 25% each. Writing Task 1: Task Achievement, Coherence and Cohesion, Lexical Resource, Grammatical Range and Accuracy. Task 2 substitutes Task Response for Task Achievement. Speaking: Fluency and Coherence, Lexical Resource, Grammatical Range and Accuracy, Pronunciation [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Guide for teachers (PDF)]. "Each task is assessed independently. The criteria are weighted equally and the score on the task is the average" [src: ielts.org — Understanding and setting IELTS scores].

Two consequences people miss: Coherence and Cohesion is worth exactly as much as Task Response, not a linking-words afterthought; and Pronunciation is worth exactly as much as grammar in Speaking, making it a trainable quarter rather than a fixed accent tax.

Combining Task 1 and Task 2 into a Writing band

The ratio is official, stated two ways: "Task 2 contributes twice as much as Task 1 to the Writing score" [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Writing test format] [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module (PDF)], and more explicitly, "Task 1 is worth a third of your overall mark for Writing. Task 2 is worth two thirds" [src: ielts.org — Writing test resources].

What IELTS does **not** publish is the arithmetic combining the two task scores, or how the result is rounded. So:

Planning estimate, not IELTS's method: Writing band $\approx (\text{Task 1 band} + 2 \times \text{Task 2 band}) \div 3$

It follows directly from the published thirds, which makes it well grounded — but treat any number it produces as an indication, not a prediction. Used that way, it shows the asymmetry that matters:

Task 1	Task 2	$(T1 + 2T2) \div 3$	Reading
5.5	7.0	6.5	A strong Task 2 rescues a weak Task 1
7.0	5.5	6.0	A strong Task 1 does not rescue a weak Task 2
6.0	6.5	6.33	Sits between 6.0 and 6.5 — do not assume the round-up

Task 2 is roughly two thirds of Writing, and Writing is one quarter of your overall band. **Task 2 alone is therefore about 17% of your entire IELTS result** — more than any other single task in the test.

The overall band: averaging and rounding

The overall band is the average of the four section bands, rounded to the nearest half band; if the average ends in **.25 it rounds up to the next half band**, and if it ends in **.75 it rounds up to the next whole band** [src: ielts.org — IELTS scoring in detail: band scores explained]. The three official worked examples:

	L	R	W	S	Sum	Average	Reported
Test taker A	6.5	6.5	5.0	7.0	25.0	6.25	6.5 (up)
Test taker B	4.0	3.5	4.0	4.0	15.5	3.875	4.0 (nearest half)
Test taker C	6.5	6.5	5.5	6.0	24.5	6.125	6.0 (down)

[src: ielts.org — IELTS scoring in detail] [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Guide for teachers (PDF)] — identical examples on both, which is a strong cross-check.

The strategic core of this book

Because .75 rounds up to the next whole band, **an average of 6.75 reports as 7.0**. An average of 6.75 across four papers is a total of **27.0 out of 28.0**.

That single number reframes the whole project. Starting from 6.5 in every paper — your admission floor — you have 26.0. **You need exactly two more half-bands**. Not four sevens. Two half-bands, bought anywhere.

Route	L	R	W	S	Sum	Avg	Reported	Comment
A — both bought in L+R	7.0	7.0	6.5	6.5	27.0	6.75	7.0	The cheapest legitimate route
B — Listening-led	7.5	6.5	6.5	6.5	27.0	6.75	7.0	Both half-bands from one paper
C — Reading-led	6.5	7.5	6.5	6.5	27.0	6.75	7.0	Same, from the other
D — Speaking as third lever	7.0	6.5	6.5	7.0	27.0	6.75	7.0	Viable if Speaking is a strength
E — insurance route	7.5	7.5	6.5	6.5	28.0	7.00	7.0	Survives one half-band slip

Route	L	R	W	S	Sum	Avg	Reported	Comment
X near-miss	7.0	7.0	6.0	6.5	26.5	6.625	6.5	Writing 6.0 also breaks the sub-score floor

Read routes A–D against route E. A, B, C and D all land on exactly 27.0 — **zero margin**. Lose half a band anywhere on the day and you are at 26.5, which averages 6.625 and reports as 6.5. Route E is the same plan with one half-band of buffer, bought in the papers where marks are countable. That is what this book is built around: **push Listening and Reading toward 30–35 out of 40, and get Writing and Speaking securely to 6.5.**

One qualifier overrides all of it: a sub-score requirement is a gate, not an average. The last row scores 6.5 overall *and* fails Writing. Check the exact requirement of every institution you are applying to before you optimise anything.

YOUR L1 — ARABIC / FRENCH

L1 alert

Official IELTS test-taker performance data for 2024–25, IELTS Academic, by first language

[src: ielts.org — Test statistics → "Download test taker performance data 2024-2025 (XLSX)"; cite the parent page, because the CDN path to the file has already moved once]:

L1	Listening	Reading	Writing	Speaking	Overall
Arabic	5.70	6.10	5.54	6.22	5.95
French	6.95	7.01	6.15	6.65	6.75

For context, the global Academic means in the same period were 6.45 for Listening and 6.32 for Reading [src: ielts.org — Test statistics].

Four things follow, and they should shape how you spend ninety minutes a day.

Writing is the weakest skill for both of your languages, by a wide margin — 0.56 below Reading for Arabic L1, 0.85 below for French L1. (Both gaps are taken from the unrounded figures in the spreadsheet: French L1 is 7.006 for Reading and 6.152 for Writing, a gap of 0.85. Subtracting the rounded figures printed in the table above gives 0.86; the unrounded number is the right one.) The same pattern in two unrelated language families means the problem is the task, not the language. Writing is where 7.0 is won or lost, and it responds most slowly to work. Start it in week one.

Your target sits roughly a full band above the Arabic-L1 average (5.95) and 0.25 above the French-L1 average (6.75). That is calibration, not discouragement: feeling "about average" is evidence you are near 6.0, not near 7.0. Only timed, criterion-graded practice tells you where you actually are.

The Arabic-L1 profile has a Listening problem the French-L1 profile does not. Arabic-L1 Listening (5.70) is 0.40 *below* that group's Reading (6.10), while French-L1 Listening and Reading sit almost level (6.95 / 7.01), both above the global means. If your English was built through French-medium reading and academic study, Reading is probably your strongest paper and Listening the one hiding a gap — especially on computer, where there is no transfer window in which to recover a lost thread. "Buy your half-bands in Listening and Reading" still holds, but **diagnose Listening before assuming it is cheap**. Sit one timed 40-question set in week one and let the raw score decide which route you are on.

Your accent is not a penalty. Pronunciation is 25% of the Speaking band [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Guide for teachers (PDF)]; what is assessed is intelligibility and control of phonological features, which [Chapter 6](#) treats as a trainable quarter rather than a fixed ceiling.

Self-test checklist

Answer yes or no. Any "no" is a chapter you cannot skip.

1. Can you state the four papers in sitting order, with each time limit, from memory?
2. How many minutes do you get at the end of computer Listening — and is your answer "two"?
3. How many questions are in Listening and Reading, and what is each worth?
4. What raw mark officially corresponds to band 7 in Listening and Academic Reading?
5. What raw mark is the *bottom* of band 6.5 in Listening, what is the *top*, and how many marks is it from that top to band 7?
6. Can you state the rounding rule, including what happens at .25 and at .75?
7. Without help: what does 7.0 / 6.5 / 6.5 / 7.0 report as?
8. What total, out of 28, must you reach for a reported 7.0?
9. Can you name the four Writing Task 2 criteria and say what each is worth?
10. How much of your *entire* IELTS result rides on Task 2 alone?
11. What happens to a Writing response of 20 words or fewer?
12. Can you explain why under-length writing costs marks without naming a fixed deduction?
13. Have you confirmed with your centre whether Speaking is the same day, and whether it is face-to-face or by video call?
14. Have you confirmed whether One Skill Retake runs in Tunisia — and built a plan that does not need it?
15. Have you completed the free official familiarisation test at least once?

The 60-second summary for this chapter is at the top, before "What the test actually asks". If you are revising, start there.

CHAPTER 2

2 Listening: Complete Playbook

WHAT IT IS WORTH

40 marks, objective

WHY IT MATTERS

Band 6 to 7 is seven marks. From the top of 6.5, one.

FULL READ

~46 min

Listening is the only section where a mark is not an opinion. It is a box that either contains the right string of characters or does not. That makes it the most fixable section in the test — and the one where a candidate with adequate English quietly donates five or six marks to rules they never read.

This chapter assumes **computer-delivered** Listening: that is what Tunisia offers, and IELTS is withdrawing paper from mid-2026 [src: T1 ielts.org — Updates to IELTS test delivery; T1 takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Updates to how IELTS tests are delivered]. Everything here assumes you are typing answers live, while the audio runs.

60-second summary

Read this first. Everything after it is the working detail.

Forty questions, one mark each, four parts of ten, about thirty minutes of audio, played **once**. Five accents: UK, Australia, New Zealand, USA, Canada. Answers come in order for **every** question type, matching and maps included — so a missed gap is recoverable by moving forward, and hunting backwards turns one lost mark into three.

There are **no band descriptors**. There is a mark budget, and it is published: band 6 is 23–25 marks, band 6.5 is **26–29**, band 7 starts at **30** [src: T1 ielts.idp.com — Listening band scores]. From the bottom of band 6 to band 7 is seven marks; from the top of 6.5 it is **one**. Those are specific boxes holding the wrong string, not a vague standard, and most of them are rules rather than hearing.

The rules that pay: one answer per gap, never two — two scores zero even when one is right. Never a blank. Obey the printed word limit exactly. Articles and prepositions count; hyphenated words do not. Spelling must be right, but **American spellings are accepted** and capitalisation does not matter. Write the words you hear; do not paraphrase.

The traps that pay: options mentioned then rejected; positive language reversed in the final clause; corrections running **both** directions — the answer can come after the fix (*sorry, I mean...*) or before the contrast (*just six euros, down from the usual nine fifty*); *proposed* is not *actual* and *modern* is not *recently opened*; the item missing from a printed list is your answer.

 On computer there is **no transfer time and 2 minutes to check**. The 10-minute cushion was paper-only, and some official pages still describe it without saying so. Be right as you type. Flag four questions, not ten.

And the L1 line to hold: *informations, researches, advices* are zeros. So is *formation for training*. In Listening your Writing errors are marked twice as hard, because here they are not a criterion — they are the whole mark.

What the test actually asks

Four parts, ten questions each, forty questions, one mark per correct answer. No part or question type is weighted above another. Roughly thirty minutes of audio; raw score converts to a band in whole or half bands [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening test format]. **The recording plays once** [src: same; T1 cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS Academic FAQs p.3]. The Listening paper is identical for Academic and General Training, so any Listening material is usable [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.3].

Part	Context	Voices	Sounds like
1	Everyday / social	Two — conversation	A booking or enquiry: names, dates, prices, addresses [src: T1 takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Test format]
2	Everyday / social	One — monologue	A talk about a place or facility [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening test format]
3	Educational / training	Two to four	A tutorial or project discussion
4	Educational / training	One — monologue	A university-style lecture [src: T1 takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Test format]

On Part 3 the official sources differ — ielts.org says "two main speakers", the British Council "up to four people" [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening test format; T1 takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Test format]. Compatible, but train for the harder case: four voices, held apart by content rather than pitch.

Five national accents: Australia, Canada, New Zealand, the UK and the US — "a mix of native speaker accents from Australia, Canada, New Zealand, the UK and US in the Listening section" [src: T1 takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Guide for teachers (PDF), p.5]. **Only one official document names five.** The front-line format pages name four and leave the list open — "Different accents, *including* British, Australian, New Zealand and North American, are used" [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening test format] — and Cambridge's FAQ is explicitly illustrative: "a range of English native-speaker accents... (**for example**, Australian, British, New Zealand and North American speakers)" [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.4]. So treat five as the working number and the list as non-exhaustive; do not treat it as a closed set you can finish preparing for. If your ear knows only British and American English, the Australian and New Zealand vowels will cost you — in Parts 2 and 4, where one voice carries ten marks alone.

Between the parts. Before each part you hear a spoken description of the situation — who, where, what about — and **it is not printed anywhere**. There is a pause between parts, and one break inside Parts 1, 2 and 3 for reading ahead [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.3].

Part 4 is the exception, and the usual advice about it is slightly wrong. All ten Part 4 questions get their reading time **at the start**. There *is* a short pause mid-recording, but it is unannounced and officially described as time to refocus, not reading time [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.3]. So do not say "Part 4 has no break" — and do not plan to read questions 35–40 during a pause you cannot predict.

Answers come in order — for every question type. "Are the questions in the same order as the information in the recording? Yes. This is true for all question types in IELTS Listening" [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.3; corroborated T1 ielts.org — Academic test format in detail; debunked as a myth at T1 ielts.idp.com — 9 myths]. That includes matching and map labelling, which most prep books hedge on, and it is the most valuable fact here: it makes a missed answer recoverable by moving forward.

But options inside an item are not ordered. In an official multiple-choice sample the speaker names the three options in the sequence C, B, A [src: DERIVED from T1 ielts.org — Listening sample tasks pp. 8–9].

No negative marking. "Try to answer all questions; you will not lose points for incorrect answers" [src: T1 takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Test day advice]. A blank box is a guaranteed zero.

The timing that changes everything

Paper gave you **10 minutes** to transfer answers to an answer sheet [src: T1 takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Test day advice]. Computer gives you **no transfer time and 2 minutes to check** [src: T1 ielts.idp.com — How IELTS on computer works]. Two minutes, forty answers, three seconds each.

Be aware when reading around: **ielts.org's Listening page still describes the 10-minute transfer without flagging that it does not apply to computer delivery**, and IDP's marketing page claims the only difference is how you input answers — contradicted by IDP's own operational page. Follow the operational page, and confirm at ielts.org and with your centre before your test date.

On screen you get a volume control, free navigation across all 40 questions, and a **Review button that flags a question with a circle** [src: T1 ielts.idp.com — How IELTS on computer works]. Pen and paper are provided. Some paper centres used room speakers rather than headsets; computer candidates use their own headphones [src: T1 ielts.idp.com — 9 myths, myth 4; T1 ielts.idp.com — IELTS on computer vs IELTS on paper].

Consequence: you must be right as you type. There is no tidying up.

Question types, one by one

Officially there are six named types; one of them is a family of completion layouts sharing one rule set [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening test format; T1 ielts.idp.com — Question types in the IELTS Listening test]. Below are the eleven layouts you meet. **All examples are original**, written to reproduce the trap structure of official

material, not the material itself.

One official document disagrees with another here, and you will meet it. The 2023 official Listening sample tasks preamble lists only **five** types — it omits short-answer questions — and then ships a short-answer task and its answer key later in the same PDF [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening sample tasks 2023, p.1 vs pp. 11–13]. The format page's six is the authoritative count. Prepare for short-answer questions.

1. Form completion

LOOKS LIKE

A pre-printed form with numbered gaps — Part 1's home ground. An Example is worked at the top; that information is then skipped in the audio [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening sample tasks p.3].

RULES

Word limit as printed. Spelling correct. Numbers, postcodes and measurements are all answers.

TRAP

Numbers arrive in a run, each tied to a different label, faster than you can type — and totals are stated last, after components you were also given.

Length: · Width: · Total deposit: €.....

"The trailer's two metres long, one point two wide — sorry, one point four, I'm looking at the wrong model. Deposit's forty euros for the trailer, another twenty-five for the roof box, so sixty-five altogether."

2 m · 1.4 m · 65. The width was self-corrected; the deposit is a **sum stated last**; and the euro sign is already printed, so €65 copies the frame.

TECHNIQUE

Annotate each gap with its *category* — surname, will be spelled out, postcode, number + unit, €, figure. Scan labels for **total**, **altogether**, **each**, **per**: those guarantee arithmetic. In a number run, type digits only; add units in the 2-minute check.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

Re-typing what was already printed. "Don't copy any words before or after the gaps" [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.2]. On screen this is *easier* to get wrong, because the symbol sits outside the input box.

2. Note completion

LOOKS LIKE

Headed notes with indented sub-points and gaps — the standard Part 4 layout, common in Part 2 [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening sample tasks p.29].

RULES

Same word limit and spelling rules. Headings are your map: answers arrive in heading order and each heading is signposted.

Trap — three of them, and they stack.

(a) *The item you were not given.* The audio reads the whole printed list back plus one extra. Your job is subtraction, not comprehension.

*Facilities: gym, indoor pool, squash courts, café, "A gym, an indoor pool, two squash courts, a café — and, tucked away at the back, a **crèche**."*

(b) *Adjacent-fact substitution.* Three verbs, three dates, one sentence:

*1990s – site was · Reopened in "The mill was surveyed in the late eighties, **converted in the nineties**, and finally **reopened to visitors in 2004**."*

converted · 2004. Three verbs and three dates arrive in one sentence, and the pre-printed 1990s is the filter that picks the middle one: *surveyed* belongs to the eighties, *reopened* to 2004. Read the printed part of the gap and accept only audio that matches it.

(c) *Negated lead-in.* The wrong answer comes first and is fluent in the gap:

*Now funded by "It's **not** run on ticket sales any more, the way most galleries are — it's funded by **the regional council**."*

(d) *The status word.* The gap asks what something **is**; the audio describes what it was going to be, or what it used to be. **Proposed is not actual, and modern is not recently opened.**

*Currently houses the · Age of building: "A second footbridge was **proposed** in 2018 and never built. The **archive** moved in instead, into what looks like a modern building — it's actually **Victorian**, just refurbished two years ago."*

archive · Victorian. A plan is not a fact, so *footbridge* is not the answer to the first gap; and a refurbishment date is not a construction date, so *modern* is not the answer to the second. Scan every gap for the tense and the status it demands before the audio starts: does it ask what exists, what was intended, or what used to be?

TECHNIQUE

Read all ten Part 4 gaps in the opening window; there is no second one. Mark two or three gaps whose headings are furthest apart as re-entry points. Track the signposting, not individual words.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

Freezing on a missed gap. "Don't panic if you miss one question. Look ahead and concentrate on the next one" [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.2]. A missed gap costs one mark; hunting for it costs three.

3. Table completion**LOOKS LIKE**

A grid with numbered gaps; column headers name the category [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening sample tasks p.30]. A gap under "Price" can only be money.

RULES

Identical to note completion.

Trap — correction by contrast. Two values half a second apart, and the **first** is the answer.

Saturday · 7pm · '.....' · Ticket: "Saturday's the New Zealand documentary, '**Long Shadow**', at seven. Tickets are **just six euros** this month, a reduction on the usual nine fifty."

Long Shadow · 6 euros. This is the mirror of the self-correction trap; learn the pair together (Tip 4).

TECHNIQUE

Read the table **by row**, not by column — a row is one event and the audio delivers it as one chunk. Convert each row into a target: "Saturday, 7pm — I need a TITLE and a PRICE."

BAND-6 MISTAKE

Missing that a gap sits inside quotation marks. '*.....*' means a **title**: Long Shadow, not *a New Zealand documentary*.

4. Flow-chart completion**LOOKS LIKE**

Boxes joined by arrows showing process stages, with gaps in some [src: T1 ielts.idp.com — Question types].

RULES

Same as the rest of the completion family.

TRAP

The arrows impose a sequence; the speaker narrates with backtracks. The *questions* stay in order — the order rule holds — but the *process* does not arrive in a straight line.

Submit form → → *Attend induction* → "You send in the application form. Now — before the induction, and people forget this — you need **two references** in writing. Once those are through you come to the induction evening, and after that we allocate you a **supervisor**."

(two) references · supervisor. Note that the speaker delivers the second box *before* the third — "before the induction... you need two references" — while the questions themselves stayed in order.

TECHNIQUE

In the reading window, say each arrow out loud as a sequence word: "first → then → after that → finally." Then listen for **connectives** (*subsequently, prior to, once that's done*) rather than topic vocabulary. This is the one completion type where sequencing language carries more than content words.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

Writing a whole clause into a box. Boxes are short by design; if your answer needs a verb *and* an object *and* a preposition, you heard a paraphrase rather than the words to write down.

5. Summary completion**LOOKS LIKE**

Continuous prose with numbered gaps — sometimes with a **box of options** instead of free writing [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening test format].

RULES

With a word bank you write the **letter**, not the word, and the word limit disappears. Without one, the printed limit applies.

TRAP

Prose grammar constrains the answer far more tightly than notes do — and the audio hands you the wrong grammatical form.

*The team's main difficulty was the of suitable sites. "What held us up was that suitable sites were incredibly hard to **identify**."*

The gap needs a noun: **identification**. But note the official instruction — "Don't try to rephrase what you hear. Try to write down the words you hear which fit the question" [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.2]. When grammar and that instruction pull apart, the usual explanation is that the exact word *was* spoken and you missed it. Convert form only when you are certain. **This example is the rare forced case** — the noun is genuinely absent from the audio, and the sentence cannot take the verb. The decision procedure is: if you can hear the noun anywhere in the passage, write that; convert the form only when you are sure no noun was spoken.

TECHNIQUE

Read the summary once for **meaning** before predicting word forms. It gives you the whole argument in forty seconds, and that context is worth more than individual predictions.

Band-6 mistake — aimed at you specifically. Producing the right meaning in a French-derived form the speaker never used: *augmentation* for *increase*, *formation* for *training*, *evolution* for *change*.

6. Sentence completion

LOOKS LIKE

Stand-alone sentences, one gap each. Common in Part 3 [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening sample tasks p.14].

RULES

Word limit as printed — and **limits vary between tasks in the same paper**. The official sample sentence task carries **NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS**, with no "AND/OR A NUMBER" clause, while the form and note tasks in the same document carry **NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER** [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening sample tasks pp. 3, 14, 29].

TRAP

The sentence's grammar does work the audio does not. A gap before a head noun needs a modifier; the speaker gives you a predicate.

*The course improved Nadia's skills. "By the end I'd got very good at **budgeting**."*

budgeting fits. *Got good at budgeting* is over the limit and scores zero, however correct it is.

TECHNIQUE

For every gap decide **part of speech**, and whether the gap sits before or after the head noun, *before* the audio. A heard phrase can then be tested against the slot in a fraction of a second.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

Not stopping. Under TWO WORDS the discipline is literal: **stop typing at two words**, even when the third is true and you heard it.

7. Multiple choice — single answer**LOOKS LIKE**

A stem with three options, A, B, C [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening sample tasks p.8].

RULES

One letter only. Two letters scores zero even if one is right [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.3].

TRAP

All three options are named in one breath; the answer arrives as a **back-reference** that only works if you retained a definition given seconds earlier; and the only option the answering speaker names is the one being **rejected**.

(*Distractor* — the word used from here on — means a wrong option deliberately built to be attractive: it uses the words you were listening for, or it answers a question next to the one being asked. Every multiple-choice and matching item in this test has them, and they are the reason "I heard that word" is not evidence.)

Which plan does the customer choose? A Basic · B Flexible · C Unlimited "We've got Basic, which is pay-as-you-go; Flexible, which lets you carry data over; and Unlimited at the top end." — "Well, I ran out on Basic twice last year, so I'll take **the top one**."

C. *Basic* is the loudest word in the customer's turn and it is the rejection.

TECHNIQUE

Read the **stem** first and turn it into a question you are putting to the audio. Then mark what *distinguishes* the options: these three differ by level, so listen for a **comparative** — *top*, *cheapest*, *the middle one* — not for the names. Select provisionally, keep listening, use the Review flag if unsure [src: T1 ielts.idp.com — How IELTS on computer works; T2 IELTS Liz — Listening multiple choice essential tips].

BAND-6 MISTAKE

Choosing the option whose word you heard most clearly. Just because it is mentioned does not mean it is right [src: T2 E2 — Understanding distractors in IELTS Listening].

8. Multiple choice — multiple answer**LOOKS LIKE**

A longer list, A–G or A–H, with an instruction to choose **two or three** [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening test format].

RULES

Choose exactly the number asked. Each correct letter is normally worth one mark, so a "choose TWO" item occupies **two question numbers**.

TRAP

The instruction is the trap — candidates skim it and select one letter for a two-mark item. "Read the instructions for each task carefully" [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.2]. Then the audio touches most of the options and rejects them rapidly.

Which TWO problems does the speaker mention? A cost · B parking · C noise · D staffing · E opening hours · F access · G signage

"Cost was fine — we came in under budget. Parking, everyone assumed, would be the headache, but the council sorted it. What we underestimated was **how few volunteers we could keep on a Sunday**, and **how hard the side entrance was for anyone using a wheelchair**."

D and **F** — and neither word, *staffing* or *access*, is spoken.

TECHNIQUE

Circle the number word (TWO / THREE) before reading the options. On screen the interface enforces the count, which makes this type *easier* on computer. Use the two question numbers as a checklist: two numbers, two letters.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

Treating the option list as ordered. A "choose two" item is a single point in the audio, and the audio jumps around the list.

9. Matching**LOOKS LIKE**

Two forms. **(a) Repeated criteria** — a few categories applied to five items, with "you may choose any letter more than once". **(b) One-to-one from a box** — five options, four questions, one spare [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening sample tasks pp. 18, 22].

RULES

Write the **letter**, not the word. Check whether letters may repeat: in (a) they may, in (b) each is used once. Questions are in order.

Trap — positive language, then late reversal. In official matching tasks the same enthusiasm word sits against two different answers; the verdict comes at the **end** of each item's discussion.

What does Youssef decide? A definitely will · B may or may not · C will not "The field course? That does sound **useful** — I've heard good things from the second years." — "It clashes with your placement, though." — "Ah. **Forget that one, then.**"

C. Two endorsements — his own and a third party's — overturned in four words.

For the box form the mechanic differs: descriptions are paraphrased, and the distractors (defined under type 7 above) sit in the right semantic field and the wrong category.

Which café is in a quiet location? "Riverside is out past the industrial estate, so it's not central — but it's on the ring road, so you hear it. **Miller's** is ten minutes up the lane, nothing around it but fields."

Not central is not *quiet*.

TECHNIQUE

For type (a), mark three symbols — ✓ / ? / ✗ — while listening and convert to letters afterwards; faster than holding letters in working memory. For type (b), the box items are your fixed points: proper nouns survive paraphrase, descriptions do not.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

Committing on first evidence. Wait for the final clause.

10. Plan / map / diagram labelling

LOOKS LIKE

A building plan, town map or piece of equipment with numbered positions. Two variants: choose letters from a box, or write words within a limit [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening sample tasks p.26].

RULES

When lettered, write letters; when free-written, the word limit applies. Tests directional language — *straight on, turn left, opposite* [src: T1 ielts.idp.com — Question types].

Trap — orientation, not vocabulary. The description is given from the walker's point of view, and that point of view **rotates**.

"Come in through the main doors. Reception is **on your right**, and **directly opposite it** is the equipment store. Carry **straight on** past the lockers, then **turn left** — the room **on your right now** is the seminar room, and the one **beyond it** at the far end is the studio."

Fix left and right to the page and you invert half the plan from "turn left" onward. Watch also for the withdrawn label: "the studio **used to be** the darkroom, but that moved out last year."

TECHNIQUE

Find the entrance or "you are here" marker and put your cursor on it — every description starts there. Read the already-labelled features; they are the fixed points the speaker navigates from. Cross off letters as you use them; in a five-from-nine task that halves the search space by the fourth question. Track the speaker's body, not the page: when you hear "turn", rotate.

BAND-6 MISTAKE — L1-SPECIFIC

French and Arabic spatial prepositions do not map one-to-one. *En face de* covers both *opposite* and *facing*; *à côté de* covers *next to*, *beside*, *adjacent to*; Arabic أمام covers *in front of* and *opposite*. In a map task the preposition **is** the answer. Drill the English set as a closed list: opposite · next to · adjacent to · beyond · past · behind · in front of · at the far end · in the corner of · across from · bear left.

11. Short-answer questions**LOOKS LIKE**

Direct questions with a word limit, often in pairs sharing one prompt: *What TWO factors...* answered across questions 11 and 12 [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening sample tasks p11].

RULES

Word limit applies. Where one prompt covers two gaps, official keys mark them **in either order** [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening sample tasks p13].

TRAP

The two answers may be several sentences apart, separated by material answering neither.

In which TWO places can the timetable be found? (18, 19) "...which is why we print it. We used to leave copies in the sports hall, but that stopped. You'll find it **in the main reception**, and — new this term — **on the noticeboard by the canteen**."

Under a THREE WORDS limit the keyed answers are (main) reception and (the) noticeboard — **not** the full phrases as spoken. *In the main reception* is four words and *on the noticeboard by the canteen* is six; both score zero. Hear the whole phrase, then type only the noun that answers the question.

TECHNIQUE

Because either order scores, do not force the first thing you hear into the first gap. Collect both, then place them. This is the one type where you can safely listen ahead of your typing.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

Answering in a sentence. "You can find it in the main reception" is six words — zero under a **THREE WORDS** limit, for a completely correct answer.

Answer-rule reference

Rule	Precise version	Source
Word limit	Absolute. Over the limit = marked incorrect, however correct	[src: T1 ielts.org — Listening test format; T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.3]
Hyphenated words	One word (check-in , time-management)	[src: T1 ielts.org — Listening test format]
Articles & prepositions	Count toward the limit	[src: T2 IELTS Liz — How words are counted; DERIVED, below]
Compound as one word	One word (bookshop)	[src: DERIVED from T1 sample tasks p.31]
Compound as two words	Two words (town hall , summer school)	[src: DERIVED from T1 sample tasks p.13]
Digits	A number in digits = one number (1,700 , £4.50)	[src: DERIVED from T1 sample tasks pp. 7, 33]
Currency / percent symbols	Not counted as words	[src: T2 IELTS Liz — How words are counted]
Spelling	Must be correct	[src: T1 ielts.org — Listening test format; T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.4]
UK vs US spelling	Both accepted — the official key prints metre(s)/meter(s)	[src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.4; T1 ielts.org — sample tasks p.7]
Capitalisation	Does not matter	[src: T1 takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Test day advice]
Contractions	Not tested	[src: T1 ielts.org — Listening test format]
Two answers in one gap	Zero , even if one is right	[src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.3]

The derivation on articles, because bad advice circulates here. One official answer key offers a determiner-plus-two-noun answer under a **three-word** limit, and the document defines its own brackets as "words in brackets are optional — they are correct, but not necessary" [src: DERIVED from T1 ielts.org — Listening sample tasks p.33]. The article-bearing version is three words and fits only because the limit was three; under a two-word limit it would breach. Optional is not free. **Operating rule: never type an article you were not forced to type.** It can cost a mark; it can never gain one.

On ONE WORD ONLY. It is verbatim official — but in **Reading**, not Listening. The 2023 Academic Reading sample tasks print "Choose ONE WORD ONLY from the passage for each answer" twice, on Sentence Completion and on Summary Completion [src: T1 ielts.org — Academic Reading sample tasks 2023]. The 2023 Listening sample tasks use only **NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER** and **NO MORE**

THAN TWO WORDS, and research for this book could **not verify ONE WORD ONLY verbatim in any official Listening document** [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening sample tasks 2023]. So **Chapter 3** quotes it as standard Reading **rubric** — *rubric* meaning the printed instruction line above a set of questions, the sentence that tells you what to choose and how many words you may write — and this chapter does not quote it as standard Listening rubric. The two chapters are not in disagreement: **expect it in Reading; do not assume it in Listening**. Either way the behaviour it demands is what you need anyway: **read the instruction printed above every task, every time, and obey exactly that.**

Tips & tricks

Ranked by marks recoverable. **Each rule is stated once, here, with its source.** The *Myths* section that follows does not restate them: it names the false belief each rule kills, why that belief survives, and what believing it costs you. If you want the rule, read here; if you want to know why you currently believe otherwise, read there.

1. One answer per gap. Never two. 4.15/4.30 in one box scores zero even though one is right [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.3] **[verified]**. It converts a 50% chance into 0%. *Applies:* always. *Fails:* never.

2. Never leave a box empty. No negative marking [src: T1 takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Test day advice] **[verified]**. A blank is a certain zero; a guess of the right *type* is free expected value. Guess **one** answer.

3. Abandon a missed answer instantly. "Look ahead and concentrate on the next one" [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.2] **[verified]**, and answers are in order for every type [src: same, p.3]. Hear content answering Q19 while hunting Q17 and 17–18 are gone: type a guess, lock onto 19. *Fails:* never — hunting backwards always costs more.

4. Learn the two correction traps as a pair. [expert consensus] — the mechanic is evidenced in official tapescripts; the naming is Tier 2. - **Answer AFTER:** the speaker revises the *same* fact. Signals: *sorry · I mean · actually · no wait · hang on*. "It's on the twelfth — sorry, the **twentieth**." - **Answer FIRST:** the speaker contrasts *two different* facts. Distractor signals: *usual price · normally · was · used to be · before the discount · last year*. Answer signals: *just · only · now · this week*. "It's **six euros** now, down from the usual nine fifty."

Know only the first version and you lose every instance of the second.

5. Use the reading window to turn listening into slot-matching. Predict the answer *type* and *word class* for each gap [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.2, official Do; T1 ielts.org — Teacher's guide p.22] **[verified]**. *Fails:* nowhere, but it must be fast — Part 4 gives one window for ten gaps, so categorise, do not analyse.

6. Listen to the spoken introduction before each part. Speaker, setting and topic, free — and **not printed** [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.3] **[verified]**. Most candidates keep reading through it.

7. Don't use the mid-part break to check previous answers. Its stated purpose is reading the *next* questions [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.3] **[expert consensus]**. *Fails:* if you have genuinely finished reading ahead, a spelling glance costs nothing.

8. Write answers, not notes. "Write all your answers as you listen" [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.2]; "You should not take your attention away from the Listening to write things down" [src: T1 ielts.idp.com — 9 myths] **[verified]**. *Fails:* either-order pairs, where holding two items before placing them is correct.

9. Train on five accents, not two. Parts 2 and 4 carry 20 of the 40 marks in a single voice each, so one unfamiliar accent can cost ten marks. Read that against the mark budget in §Band descriptor decoder: ten marks is **at least a full band wherever you are on the table, and usually a band and a half** — 30 drops to 20, which is 7.0 down to 5.5 **[expert consensus]**, derived from the five-accent list above. This is only an instruction you can obey if you know where the audio comes from, so the next section names the sources, the weekly rotation and the exact ten-minute exercise: see §Where the audio comes from.

10. Read tables by row, maps from the entrance. **[expert consensus]** A table row is one narrative chunk; a plan description is a walk from a fixed origin.

11. Use the Review flag, not memory. You can flag a question and navigate back [src: T1 ielts.idp.com — How IELTS on computer works] **[verified]**. With 2 minutes at the end it is the only realistic way to find what is worth revisiting. *Fails:* flag ten and you have flagged nothing — cap it at four or five.

12. Type normally; no ALL CAPS. Capitals were a legibility tactic for handwritten answer sheets. On computer they cost keystrokes and introduce shift-key typos into words you heard correctly [src: T1 takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Test day advice, capitals or lower case] **[verified]**.

Where the audio comes from

You are studying alone. Nobody is going to read words out to you, and the `/listening` command in this repository is text-adapted — it drills prediction, traps and spelling on written transcripts, and cannot play sound. So this section names the supply, because "train on five accents" is not an instruction until it does.

Layer 1 — official IELTS audio, which is finite and must be rationed

Free, official, exactly the right format, and there is not much of it:

- **British Council free practice tests** — full Listening sections with audio and answer keys [src: T1 takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Free IELTS practice tests].
- **The official familiarisation test** — free, untimed, on the real computer screens; use it for the *interface*, not for score data [src: T1 takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Free IELTS familiarisation test].
- **ielts.org sample tasks** — the 2023 Listening sample tasks PDF and its answer key, the document this chapter quotes throughout [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening sample tasks 2023].

- **IDP's free practice material and IELTS Ready** [src: T1 ielts.idp.com — Free IELTS practice tests].

The re-use rule. A Listening part you have already answered is *not* used up. You cannot re-use it for a score, but you can use it twice more:

1. **Transcription pass.** Play the 30 seconds around each answer and type what you hear word for word, then check against the tapescript. This trains the thing you are actually short of — holding a phrase accurately for two seconds — and it works better when you already know the answer, because it removes the guessing.
2. **Speed pass.** Play it at 1.25× and answer again. If you are still right, the version at normal speed has slack in it.

Rationing: one *fresh* official part per Listening session, everything else re-used. Four Cambridge papers is sixteen fresh parts; at one a session that is sixteen sessions, and you want some of them left for the full mocks in the final fortnight.

Layer 2 — accent supply, which is unlimited and free

Official material will not give you enough Australian, New Zealand or Canadian English. Public broadcasters will, at any length you want, for nothing. One stable free source per accent [**expert consensus — these are ordinary news and documentary sources, not IELTS material, and no official body endorses any particular one**]:

Accent	Source	Why this one
UK	BBC Radio 4 podcasts; BBC Learning English	Documentary and discussion registers; BBC Learning English carries transcripts
Australia	ABC (Australian Broadcasting Corporation) news and Radio National podcasts	The vowel set that most often surprises a French-trained ear
New Zealand	RNZ (Radio New Zealand) podcasts	The accent least represented in prep material and closest to Part 2 monologue register
Canada	CBC Radio podcasts	Distinct from US English in exactly the vowels that carry numbers and place names
USA	NPR podcasts and news	Transcripts published for most segments; the flapped /t/ that turns <i>thirty</i> into <i>thirdy</i>

Prefer anything that publishes a **transcript** — without one you cannot mark yourself, and an unmarkable exercise is entertainment.

The ten-minute exercise, and it is the same for every source. It does not need the 90-minute study block — it needs headphones and a queue. Do it on a rotating accent, on your Listening day inside the session, and on any other day you have ten minutes standing up:

1. Play **60 seconds**. Do not pause it.
2. Write down every **number, date, price, proper noun and spelled-out word** you heard. Nothing else. These are what Parts 1 and 2 are made of, and they are what accent actually costs you.
3. Replay the same 60 seconds. Add what you missed, in a different colour.

4. Open the transcript and mark what is still wrong.
5. Anything wrong goes into `progress/error-log.md` as a Listening entry, with the accent named. After two weeks you will know which of the five is actually your problem, rather than assuming it is the Australian one.

Weekly rotation, so no accent goes cold: Monday UK · Tuesday Australia · Wednesday USA · Thursday New Zealand · Friday Canada · Saturday whichever produced the most errors this week.

Layer 3 — your own dictator, since there isn't one

You do not need a study partner to be dictated to. **Every phone and desktop operating system ships a text-to-speech voice with a selectable regional accent** — iOS and macOS under Spoken Content, Android through Google Text-to-Speech, Windows through Narrator or Edge's Read Aloud. Install the English (Australia), English (New Zealand), English (UK), English (US) and English (Canada) voices where they are offered, and you have five dictators for free.

The cross-training drill. Paste into a note: your uncountables list, the twenty words you have actually misspelled in `progress/error-log.md`, and thirty numbers of the `-teen / -ty` family (13/30, 14/40, 15/50, 16/60, 17/70, 18/80, 19/90) shuffled. Then:

1. Set the voice to one of the five accents and the speed to slightly faster than comfortable.
2. Play it with the screen turned away and **type blind**, one item per line, as if each were a gap.
3. Compare against the source text. Every miss is a Listening mark you were going to lose.
4. Change the accent and repeat the same list tomorrow. The same word in a different voice is a different exercise.

Its honest limit: a synthetic voice does not hesitate, self-correct, overlap another speaker or trail off, and those are exactly the behaviours the correction traps in Tip 4 are built on. So text-to-speech is for **spelling, numbers and single-word perception only**. Trap recognition has to come from Layer 1 and Layer 2, where real people speak untidily. Do not let the easy drill crowd out the hard one.

Myths that hold you back

Each entry names the false belief, the rule that kills it, why the belief survives, and what it costs. The rules themselves are stated once, above.

1 — "Write both answers if you're not sure." → Tip 1. **Why it survives:** hedging is rational in every other exam you have sat, because partial credit usually exists. It does not here. **Cost:** it converts a genuine 50% chance into a certain zero.

2 — "Always write in CAPITALS, it's safer." → Tip 12. **Why it survives:** it was sound advice for handwritten answer sheets, where an illegible letter lost the mark. **Cost:** on screen there is no legibility risk, so all you add is shift-key typos in words you heard correctly.

3 – "Articles don't count toward the word limit." → *Answer-rule reference*, and the derivation printed beneath it. **Why it survives:** official keys bracket articles as optional, and readers hear *optional* as *uncounted*. **Cost:** one breach of the limit, one mark, on an answer you got right.

4 – "You must use British spelling." → *Answer-rule reference*. **Why it survives:** IELTS is a British-branded exam and the assumption feels safe. **Cost:** it is not a marking risk at all — it is a study-time risk. You burn weeks on *-our/-ise* pairs that were never going to cost you a mark, instead of on the words you actually misspell.

5 – "Paraphrase the answer to show range." Score-destroying. Listening is one mark per correct answer and there is no vocabulary criterion: "Don't try to rephrase what you hear" [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.2]. **Why it survives:** it is carry-over from Writing and Speaking, where paraphrase is rewarded and copying is penalised. The rule inverts between papers, and nobody tells you.

6 – "Matching and map questions aren't in order." They are, for all question types [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.3; T1 ielts.idp.com — 9 myths]. **Why it survives:** it is true of IELTS **Reading**, where some types genuinely are not in text order, and prep books copy the caution across. **Cost:** you scan the whole task on every clue and fall behind permanently. *Refinement:* questions are in order; options within an item are not.

7 – "You get time at the end to fix things." → §The timing that changes everything, and Tip 11. **Why it survives:** the ten-minute paper transfer window was real, and ielts.org's Listening page still advertises it with no computer caveat. **Cost:** a study plan built around a tidy-up phase trains exactly the wrong reflex for a two-minute close.

8 – "There's a pause in Part 4 you can use to read ahead." → §What the test actually asks, *Part 4 is the exception*. **Why it survives:** the pause is real — it is just unannounced and officially described as time to refocus. **Cost:** you plan to read questions 35–40 in a window you cannot predict, and end up reading while the answers go past.

9 – "Take detailed notes while you listen." → Tip 8. **Why it survives:** note-taking is what you were trained to do in lectures, and it feels diligent. **Cost:** the audio does not wait, and every second spent writing prose is a second not spent typing an answer.

10 – "Guessing is risky." → Tip 2. **Why it survives:** several other international exams do penalise wrong answers. **Cost:** every blank box is a guaranteed zero you chose. Note the interaction with Myth 1: guess **one** answer, never two.

11 – "Everyone gets headphones." Not true across paper centres, some of which used room speakers [src: T1 ielts.idp.com — 9 myths, myth 4]. Computer candidates use their own headphones with on-screen volume [src: T1 ielts.idp.com — IELTS on computer vs IELTS on paper]. One more reason the computer test suits you.

12 — "Computer Listening is identical to paper apart from typing." Stated on an official marketing page and contradicted by an official operational page: 10 minutes of transfer versus 2 minutes of checking [src: T1 ielts.idp.com — 9 myths, myth 6 vs T1 ielts.idp.com — How IELTS on computer works]. Believe the operational page.

13 — "Every wrong plural is an automatic zero." Overstated. Official keys accept **summer school(s)**, **library/libraries** and **metre(s)** [src: T1 ielts.org — sample tasks pp. 7, 13, 17]. Number is marked when the gap's grammar or the audio's content makes it determinate — **modules** is required where the singular is ungrammatical. **Why the overstated version is dangerous for you:** it drives panic over-correction, and for a French-L1 candidate that means adding **-s** to English uncountables — *informations, researches, advices* — which **is** a real zero. The honest rule: match what you hear, then check the gap's grammar.

Band descriptor decoder

Listening has no band descriptors. None exist, and none are being withheld.

The four-criterion apparatus applies only to Writing and Speaking — Task Response/Achievement, Coherence and Cohesion, Lexical Resource and Grammatical Range and Accuracy in Writing; Fluency and Coherence, Lexical Resource, Grammatical Range and Accuracy and Pronunciation in Speaking. Listening and Reading are scored objectively: one mark per correct answer out of 40, converted to a band [src: T1 ielts.org — Listening test format]. Any site offering "IELTS Listening band descriptors" is showing a raw-score conversion table under a misleading title. So the decoder here is not a set of band descriptors. It is a **mark budget**.

Target band	Official raw marks / 40 (IDP)	Losses affordable
6.0	23–25	15–17
6.5	26–29	11–14
7.0	30–31	9–10
7.5	32–34	6–8
8.0	35–36	4–5

These are official figures, not interpolations. ielts.org and the British Council publish only the band 5/6/7/8 anchors; IDP, the third joint owner of IELTS, publishes the full table including every half band [src: T1 ielts.idp.com/thailand/results/scores/listening — IELTS Listening band scores; on IDP market pages, not the canonical

/results/scores/listening URL], and its anchors match ielts.org's exactly. IDP's own caveat travels with it: these are the *average* marks required, and "actual marks may vary slightly between tests due to the variation in listening questions used on different occasions" [src: T1 ielts.idp.com — Listening band scores].

Chapter 1 prints the same table beside Academic Reading; Chapter 3 prints the Reading half of it. All three agree.

Plan against the top of each band, not the bottom. And note what the ranges show that "band 7 is 30" hides: band 6.5 runs all the way to **29**, and band 7 begins at **30**. If you are scoring 29 in timed practice, your last half-band is **one mark** — one gap you type an article into, one plural you guess at. From the floor of band 6 the climb is seven marks. Neither number is "better listening"; both are specific boxes currently holding the wrong string.

Here is where six to nine of those marks are, and every one is a technique in this chapter. **Fix every row and you clear the gap with margin. Fix half of them and you do not.**

Marks	Source	Section
1–2	Word-limit breaches you stop committing	Answer-rule reference
1	The hedged double answer you stop writing	Tip 1
1	Blank boxes you now fill with a guess	Tip 2
1–2	Correction traps caught in both directions	Tip 4
1–2	Recovery after a missed gap instead of a three-mark stall	Tip 3
1	A spelling or plural fixed by drilling the uncountables	L1 alert

Every technique in this chapter has to justify itself in marks, because marks are all Listening is. Three consequences:

1. **All four parts are worth 10 marks each.** Part 1 is form completion of spelled-out names, numbers and prices — the cheapest ten marks in the whole test. Target 10/10, 9 at worst. Every mark conceded there is borrowed from Part 4, where earning it back is far harder. Equal study time across the four parts is misallocation.
2. **No partial credit, no negative marking, so the optimal policy is one answer in every box, always.** There is no defensive Listening answer.
3. **Mark-preservation beats listening skill at your level.** Three word-limit breaches plus two spelling slips is five marks — the distance from 6.5 to 7.5. A rules problem, not an ears problem.

YOUR L1 — ARABIC / FRENCH

L1 alert — Arabic and French traps in Listening

A Listening answer is a **written** answer. Every error family that costs you marks in Writing costs you marks here too, in the same words.

1. Uncountables pluralised. French pluralises nouns English does not. Typing *informations, researches, advices, knowledges, equipments, furnitures, softwares, evidences, feedbacks* into a gap is a spelling error and scores zero — however perfectly you heard the word. Drill this list as **Listening dictation**, not just as Writing grammar — that is the Listening-specific point, and it is why the words are reprinted here rather than only in [Chapter 7](#)

§Uncountables that French pluralises, which is the canonical list and explains the countability rule behind them. With Myth 13: match the number you hear, check the gap's grammar, and never add -s "to be safe".

2. French-form words that are not English words. *Adresse, exemple, développement, responsable, significative.* In Writing these cost a fraction of a criterion. Here they cost the whole mark.

3. The good news on -re . *Centre, metre, theatre* are British forms and correct — and so are *center, meter, theater*, because both varieties are accepted [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.4]. *Programme/program, labour/labor* likewise. Spend zero study time here.

4. False friends in summary and sentence completion. The gap needs the word the speaker used. *Formation* ≠ training. *Augmentation* ≠ increase. *Assist* ≠ attend. *Actually* ≠ currently. *Eventually* ≠ possibly. The French cognate is the wrong instinct almost every time. **The Listening-specific consequence is what matters here:** in Writing a false friend costs you a fraction of one criterion; in a Listening gap it is the whole mark, and there is no partial credit to soften it. The full annotated list lives in [Chapter 7](#) §The false-friend list, which is where vocabulary is scored; do not learn it twice.

5. Spatial prepositions in map tasks. The highest-value L1 fix in this chapter: *en face de* and *قابل* each cover two English prepositions, and in a map task the preposition **is** the answer. Learn the English set as a closed list and self-test on it.

6. Numbers: -teen versus -ty . *Thirteen/thirty, fourteen/forty, fifteen/fifty.* -teen carries final stress (thir-**TEEN**); -ty carries initial stress (**THIR**-ty), and in North American speech the /t/ is often flapped so it sounds like /d/ [src: T2 E2 — Understanding distractors; T2 IELTS Advantage — common mistakes]. Neither French nor Arabic gives you this contrast for free. Drill it across all five accents using the shuffled number list in **§Where the audio comes from, Layer 3** — it is the one drill in this chapter that a synthetic voice does perfectly well.

7. Sound contrasts worth ten minutes a week. The /p/–/b/ contrast deserves regular dictation — *pear/bear, cap/cab, port/board* — because a misheard proper noun in Part 1 is a mark gone. But be precise about what your difficulty actually is: you are a fluent French speaker, and **French supplies /p/, so the phoneme is not missing from your inventory.** What English adds is *aspiration* on word-initial /p t k/, and that is a production issue more than a perception one (see [Chapter 6](#)). For Listening, drill the contrast anyway — perceiving it under time pressure in an unfamiliar name is a separate skill from producing it. A language fact, not an IELTS rule.

8. The hedging habit. The more anxious you are about spelling, the more tempted you are to type both versions. Both in one box scores zero [src: T1 cambridgeenglish.org — FAQs p.3].

Cross-training. Take the real entries from your own error log — from your Writing drills — and dictate them back to yourself as Listening gap answers, using the text-to-speech procedure in **§Where the audio comes from, Layer 3**. You do not need another person for

this and you should not wait for one. The words that cost you Lexical Resource in an essay are the ones most likely to cost you a Listening mark; testing them once, in the harder modality, covers both.

Self-test checklist

Every "no" is a mark on the table.

1. Can I state my mark budget — band 6.5 is 26–29, band 7 starts at 30 — and how many losses each of those leaves me?
2. Do I read the word-limit instruction above **every single task**, knowing limits vary within one paper?
3. Do I know hyphenated words count as one, and that articles and prepositions count?
4. Have I stopped writing two possible answers in one gap, permanently?
5. Are all forty boxes filled at the end of every practice test — no blanks, ever?
6. Can I name the signals for **both** correction traps — answer-after (*sorry, I mean*) and answer-first (*just six euros, down from the usual*)?
7. When I miss a gap, do I move forward within two seconds instead of hunting backwards?
8. Do I use the reading window to mark each gap's **category and word class**?
9. Do I read all ten Part 4 questions in the opening window, expecting no second window?
10. Do I listen to the spoken introduction before each part instead of reading through it?
11. Have I named one free source per accent, put the weekly rotation in my calendar, and done the 60-second numbers-and-names exercise at least four times this week?
12. Have I installed the five regional text-to-speech voices, so I can dictate my own error log back to myself without needing another person?
13. Have I drilled the uncountables — *information, research, advice, equipment, furniture, software, evidence, feedback* — as spelling targets?
14. Have I drilled the closed list of English spatial prepositions for map tasks?
15. Do I type directly and normally — no ALL CAPS, no note-taking prose?
16. Do I flag four or five questions for review at most, knowing the final check is 2 minutes and nothing more?

The 60-second summary for this chapter is at the top, before "What the test actually asks". If you are revising, start there.

CHAPTER 3

3

Reading: Complete Playbook

WHAT IT IS WORTH

40 marks, objective

WHY IT MATTERS

Band 6.5 to 7 is three marks. Every tip here is priced in marks.

FULL READ

~57 min

Every example in this chapter is invented for this book. No passage extract, statement or answer below comes from a real or published IELTS test. Where an official worked example established a rule, the rule is cited and then demonstrated on original material of the same logical shape.

60-second summary

Read this first. It is at the top of the chapter on purpose: if today's theory budget is nine minutes, spend them here and on §The FALSE / NOT GIVEN decision procedure, and go and do a passage.

Three passages, 40 questions, 60 minutes, no transfer time. One mark per item, no negative marking, band converted from the raw score. There are no band descriptors. On the published conversion, **band 7 starts at 30/40 and band 6.5 at 27** [src: ielts.idp.com — Reading band scores] — so from the floor of 6.5 the gap to 7 is **three marks**, and from the top of 6.5 (29) it is **one**. Treat **30 as the target** and everything above it as insurance.

The test measures paraphrase recognition — spotting the same idea said in different words — and information location, not comprehension. So: **survey** 20 seconds (look at the layout: title, headings, pictures, glossary), **skim** the topic and final sentences (read fast, for the shape of the argument only), then **scan** only where the question sends you (hunt the page for one specific word or figure, reading nothing else). Never read the passage through first.

Know the order table. Ordered — multiple choice, T/F/NG, Y/N/NG, matching sentence endings, sentence completion, short answer. Not ordered — matching information, matching features. Order not guaranteed, but the answers cluster in one region — summary/note/table/flow-chart completion, diagram labelling. **Matching headings is the special case:** the *questions* run one per paragraph in paragraph order, so work the paragraphs top to bottom — but the Roman *numerals* are scrambled, so never expect heading (i) to belong to paragraph A. On an ordered type, resume from the last answer; on an unordered one, find the region and work locally.

FALSE / NO requires a contradiction you can point at; NOT GIVEN is the absence of a sentence.

A vague quantifier in the text against a precise one in the statement is NOT GIVEN. **A scope mismatch is NOT GIVEN too** — unless the text explicitly rules the statement's population out, in which case it is FALSE. Narrow in the passage against wide in the statement is a *gap*, not a contradiction. If you are constructing an argument, you are inferring, and the answer is NOT GIVEN.

Completion answers are transcription, not composition — every word you need is already in the passage. On computer, copy-paste them and spelling stops being a risk, which removes an entire category of loss for you. Write the word limit down; it changes between sets. Add no article, no plural, no preposition the gap did not ask for.

Multiple choice comes in two forms and the second is worth two marks, not one: *Choose TWO letters, A–G* occupies two question numbers and the letters are accepted in either order [src: ielts.org — Academic Reading Sample Tasks 2023 PDF, Multiple Choice: more than one answer + key]. **Never answer one of the two.**

Twenty minutes a passage is the official baseline; 19 / 19 / 19 plus a three-minute sweep is the working version. Fill every blank. A guess costs nothing and a blank scores zero.

What the test actually asks

Three long passages, 40 questions, 60 minutes — and the 60 minutes is the whole budget: *"Unlike the Listening test, no extra transfer time is given."* [src: ielts.org — Reading test format] Total text length is **2,150–2,750 words**, taken from *"books, journals, magazines, newspapers and online resources, written for a non-specialist audience."* Styles are narrative, descriptive or discursive, and **at least one text contains detailed logical argument**. Texts may contain diagrams or graphs, and *"if texts use technical vocabulary, then a simple dictionary definition is provided"* — a glossary, and people miss it.

[src: same]

Each correct item is worth one mark and the band is converted from the raw score. [src: britishcouncil — IELTS Guide for teachers (PDF), p.10, fetched 2026-07-31]

Two things the test does **not** ask, and both matter more than anything it does.

It does not ask you to understand the passage. It asks you to locate information and recognise it through paraphrase. Cambridge: the paper *"tests their knowledge and understanding of synonyms and paraphrasing as the language used in the questions is not the same as in the text."* [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 6 PDF, step 7] Nothing official rewards reading the whole text well; everything rewards reading the right 40 sentences well.

It does not ask what you know. *"You must be careful not to use any information you already know about the topic of the text."* [src: ielts.org — Reading test format]

Do passages get harder as you go? No official source says so — the format page, the Guide for teachers, the Cambridge FAQs and the 2023 sample-tasks PDF all describe Parts 1–3 without ranking difficulty. It is universal coaching folklore and may be true of *your* performance, but do

not build a timing plan on it until your own timed data says so.

Question types, one by one

11 types or 14?

Both numbers are official; the difference is naming. ielts.org's format page defines **11 numbered task types**, grouping summary / note / table / flow-chart completion as Type 9 [src: ielts.org — Reading test format]. The 2023 sample-tasks PDF names **14** by splitting those four apart [src: ielts.org — Sample Tasks 2023 PDF, p.1]. **This book uses the 11**, because Cambridge files its own teaching material under that numbering.

The order table

Knowing whether a set runs in passage order tells you where to start searching — the difference between one scan and six. Cambridge: *"Don't go back to the beginning of the text for each question when you know from the task type that the answers will come in the order of the information in the text."*

[src: cambridgeenglish — FAQs PDF]

#	Task type	In passage order?
1	Multiple choice	YES — <i>"the questions are in the same order as the information in the text"</i> (on a <i>Choose TWO letters</i> item, that fixes where the item sits, not the order of your two letters)
2	Identifying information (T/F/NG)	YES — <i>"the answers are in the same order as the text"</i>
3	Identifying writer's views (Y/N/NG)	YES — the same official note covers both
4	Matching information	NO — weakest sourcing in this table, see below
5	Matching headings	Questions yes; the heading numerals no — see below
6	Matching features	NO — <i>"the answers are NOT in the same order as the text"</i>
7	Matching sentence endings	YES — the beginnings are in text order
8	Sentence completion	YES
9	Summary / note / table / flow-chart	NOT GUARANTEED — but <i>"they will usually come from one part of the text"</i>
10	Diagram label completion	NOT GUARANTEED
11	Short-answer questions	YES, usually — <i>"sometimes... slightly, but never totally, different order"</i>

[src: ielts.org — Reading test format] • [src: britishcouncil — T/F/NG (and Y/N/NG) lesson PDF, p.2] • [src: britishcouncil — Matching Headings PDF, p.2] •

[src: britishcouncil — Matching Features PDF, p.2] • [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 11 PDF]

Two honest caveats. ielts.org's format page states an order rule for only **4 of the 11 types** in so many words — 1, 7, 8 and 11, each with a sentence of the shape *"the questions are in the same order as the information in the text"* [src: ielts.org — Reading test format, fetched 2026-07-31]. Types 9 and 10 carry the opposite note on the same page — *"The answers may not come in the same order as in the text. However, they will usually come from one part of the text rather than the whole text"* [src: same] — which is why they are marked NOT GUARANTEED and why the strategy for both is *find the region first*. Rows 2, 3, 5 and 6 are closed from British Council lesson PDFs and Cambridge activity PDFs. Row 4 is weaker still: no official statement exists, and the "NO" rests on [src: ielts.idp.com — Matching Information] plus a structural argument that holds anyway — a task in which paragraphs may be skipped and reused cannot be strictly ordered. Treat it as unordered; being wrong costs nothing.

Type 5 — settled, and the book states one position throughout. The official note reads *"NB The answers are NOT in the same order as the text."* [src: britishcouncil — Dealing with Matching Headings questions (PDF), p.2, fetched 2026-07-31] On its own that sentence is ambiguous: does it mean the questions jump around the passage, or that the list of headings is shuffled? Two pieces of official evidence resolve it.

1. **The same British Council document says which.** Its teacher's notes ask the class to notice how the *list of headings* is organised — *"not in text order, use of roman numerals, and there are more headings than paragraphs."* [src: same, Exercise 5 teacher's notes] It is the **headings** that are out of order.
2. **The official 2023 sample task numbers the questions in section order.** The task covers five lettered sections; question 1 is the first section, one section is done for you as the Example, and the remaining questions run consecutively through the sections that follow. The numerals awarded are scattered across the list — none of them the first heading. [src: ielts.org — Academic Reading Sample Tasks 2023 PDF, Matching Headings task and answer key, fetched 2026-07-31]

So the operating rule, used identically in the table above, in Type 5 below, in Tip 4 and in the 60-second summary: **the questions run in paragraph order — work the paragraphs top to bottom — and the Roman numerals do not, so never expect heading (i) to belong to paragraph A.** No official source says the questions jump around, and no official sample shows them doing it.

One thing you cannot budget for: ielts.org answers *"How many questions are there?"* with **"Variable"** for all eleven types. [src: ielts.org — Reading test format]

Type 1 — Multiple choice

Multiple choice ships in **two forms**, and the official 2023 sample-tasks PDF prints them as two separate sample tasks — *Multiple Choice: one answer* and *Multiple Choice: more than one answer* [src: ielts.org — Academic Reading Sample Tasks 2023 PDF, contents and pp. 24-29, fetched 2026-07-31]. They are worth different numbers of marks and they punish different mistakes. Form A is below; **form B has its own block after it, and you must not meet it for the first time on test day.**

FORM A — ONE ANSWER

APPEARANCE

A question or sentence-stem with four options A–D. One mark.

RULES

"You should read the question carefully to check how many answers you need to choose." Tests detailed or general understanding. [src: ielts.org — Reading test format]

THE TRAP

Distractors — the wrong options, deliberately engineered to be attractive — are built from the passage's own vocabulary. Scan for the question **stem**, not the options, "*as these are often distractors*", and grammar cannot narrow the field: "*all answer options (A–D) are grammatically possible*." [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 1 PDF, steps 2 and 8]

TECHNIQUE

Underline key words in the stem only; cover A–D; locate the region; **answer the stem in your own words from the text**; only then uncover the options and pick the match. If two survive, prove one wrong. [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 1 PDF, steps 3–7]

MINI-EXAMPLE

Text: "The 1908 prototype was abandoned within a year — not because the mechanism failed, but because the workshop could not source the tempered steel it required." *Stem*: The prototype was abandoned because... → your words: *a material was unavailable*. Options: A the mechanism was unreliable · B a material could not be obtained · C the workshop closed · D it was too expensive. → **B**. A is the distractor: *mechanism* and *failed* both appear — in the clause that says the opposite.

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Reading the options first, then hunting for their words. That guarantees you find the distractor.

Order: YES.

FORM B — MORE THAN ONE ANSWER**APPEARANCE**

A lead-in sentence, then "*Choose TWO letters, A–G*" (or A–F), then the option list. It occupies **two question numbers** — the rubric says "*Write the correct letters in boxes 1 and 2 on your answer sheet*" — and a paper can carry two such items back to back, as the official sample does. [src: ielts.org — Academic Reading Sample Tasks 2023 PDF, Multiple Choice: more than one answer, fetched 2026-07-31]

Rules — the five that matter, and they are not the same as form A's.

	Form A — one answer	Form B — more than one
Options	Four, A–D	A longer list — A–F and A–G in the official samples

	Form A — one answer	Form B — more than one
Question numbers used	One	Two (a three-answer variant uses three)
Marks available	One	Two — one per correct letter
Order of your two letters	n/a	Either order is accepted — the official key prints "1&2 IN EITHER ORDER"
What the stem asks	Which single option is right	Which two of a long list the writer actually mentions

[src: ielts.org — Academic Reading Sample Tasks 2023 PDF, Multiple Choice: more than one answer + its answer key, fetched 2026-07-31] • [src: ielts.org —

Reading test format: "Sometimes you are given a longer list of possible answers and you have to choose more than one answer. You should read the question carefully to check how many answers you need to choose."]

The trap — and it is a different trap. In form A you discriminate between four options, one of which is right. In form B you run an **exclusion sweep across a long list**, and the list is built so that most of the wrong options are *true of the world, plausible about the topic, and simply never said by the writer*. The official sample's lead-in is of exactly that shape — which TWO advantages are **mentioned by the writer** — and *mentioned* is not *true*. Five of seven options can be perfectly sensible statements about the topic and still wrong, on exactly the T/F/NG logic: no sentence, no mark.

A second, purely mechanical trap: the two correct letters are **not** required to appear in passage order. In the official sample item the two ideas occur in the text in the opposite order from the letters in the key. Do not reject a candidate letter because "we already passed that part of the passage".

TECHNIQUE

1. Read the lead-in and fix the exact relation it asks for — *mentioned by the writer, given as advantages, stated as causes*. Write that word down. 2. **Do not scan for the options.** Locate the region from the lead-in's topic words, then read that region once, properly. Form B items are drawn from a short stretch of text. 3. Work the list **A to G in order**, once, marking each option ✓ / ✗ / ? against what you just read. Two ✓ ends it. 4. If you finish with three ✓, the extra one is almost always the option that is *true but not stated* — cut the one you cannot point at a sentence for. 5. If you finish with one ✓, guess the strongest ? and move on. **Never write one letter.**

MINI-EXAMPLE

Text: "Volunteers who catalogue the parish registers tell us the same three things. The work is unexpectedly sociable — most sessions end in a pub. It has taught them to read secretary hand, a skill none expected to acquire. And it is slow: a single register can absorb a winter. They are not, whatever the county council's press office implies, saving the archive money; the supervision alone costs more than the labour is worth."

Q: Which **TWO** benefits of the cataloguing work are mentioned by the writer? A It saves the archive money · B It is a social activity · C It is quick to complete · D It teaches a new skill · E It attracts younger volunteers · F It improves the registers' condition

→ **B and D** (or **D and B** — either order). **A** is explicitly denied, so it is not a benefit *and* it is not merely absent. **C** is contradicted (*it is slow*). **E** and **F** are the dangerous ones: both are entirely plausible things to say about volunteer archive work, and the writer never says either. Nothing to point at, no letter.

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Two of them, and both are free marks. - **Writing one letter.** The item is worth two marks and you have thrown one away even though your single letter may be right. If you are sure of one and unsure of the rest, write your certain letter *and* your best guess. - **Treating it as two separate one-answer questions** and answering the first from the first half of the region and the second from the second half. It is one exclusion problem over one region, decided by the whole list at once.

Order: the item sits in passage order relative to the questions around it; the two letters within it do not have to.

Type 2 — Identifying information (True / False / Not Given)

APPEARANCE

"Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?" — TRUE / FALSE / NOT GIVEN.

RULES

"False' means that the statement contradicts the information in the text. 'Not given' means that the statement neither agrees with nor contradicts the information." [src: ielts.org — Reading test format] British Council sharpens FALSE: "*the passage states the opposite of the statement in question*", and the type is "*used with more factual texts.*" [src: britishcouncil — T/F/NG PDF, p.2]

THE TRAP

FALSE where the answer is NOT GIVEN — the biggest avoidable loss on the paper. Its own section follows.

Technique — the official 7-step British Council strategy, set out in full in the decision-procedure section below. Its second step is the one almost nobody is taught and is officially prescribed: **turn the statement into a Yes/No question** before you go looking. [src: britishcouncil — T/F/NG

PDF, Worksheet 3 Ex.1 + key]

Mini-example (deliberately trivial, to isolate the logic).

Passage, entire: "The meeting room occupies the top floor of the four-storey annexe." · "The meeting room is on the second floor." → **FALSE**, direct contradiction. · "The meeting room is on the fourth floor." → **TRUE**. Not a word of the statement appears in the passage; the information does. That is the whole test. · "The building has a lift." → **NOT GIVEN**. You may be certain a four-storey office has one. The passage does not say so — *"even if you know [it], based on the information given in the TEXT/PASSAGE, the correct answer is NOT GIVEN."* [src: britishcouncil

— T/F/NG PDF, Worksheet 1 key]

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Answering FALSE when the passage never addresses the point — and spending three minutes proving a NOT GIVEN: *"don't spend too long thinking about it. Choose an answer choice and move on."* [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 2 & 3 PDF]

Order: YES.

Type 3 — Identifying writer's views/claims (Yes / No / Not Given)

APPEARANCE

"Do the following statements agree with the views/claims of the writer?" — YES / NO / NOT GIVEN.

RULES

"No' means that the statement contradicts the writer's view or claim. 'Not given' means that the statement neither agrees with nor contradicts the writer's view or claim." Tests recognition of opinions; *"often used with discursive or argumentative texts."* [src: ielts.org — Reading test format] British Council on NO: the writer *"explicitly disagree[s] with the statement."* [src: britishcouncil — T/F/NG PDF, p.2]

The precise split.

	T/F/NG	Y/N/NG
Object judged	Facts / information in the text	The writer's opinions and claims
Negative label	FALSE — text <i>"states the opposite"</i>	NO — writer explicitly claims the opposite
Third label	<i>"no information on this"</i>	<i>"impossible to say what the writer thinks about this"</i>
Text type	<i>"more factual texts"</i>	<i>"discursive or argumentative texts"</i>

In one line: **T/F/NG asks "is this so, according to the text?"; Y/N/NG asks "does the writer think this?"** A statement can be factually present in the passage and still be NOT GIVEN in Y/N/NG, because the writer never took a position.

The trap and technique. Strategy is identical — "*NB (1) Both task types can be answered using the SAME strategy.*" [src: britishcouncil — T/F/NG PDF, p.2] Add one filter: hunt **stance language**. Cambridge teaches the split — findings are "*expressed by language such as the study shows, reveals, proves*"; opinions by "*the researchers believe, argue, claim.*" [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 6 PDF, step 4]

Mini-example — five shapes you will meet. Note what the statements are *about*: in a Y/N/NG set the object judged is what the **writer** thinks. A bare statistic is not a view, and a statement of that shape would not carry a YES or NO key here at all.

Text: "Every regional library I visited had cut its opening hours since 2015. The Association of County Archivists, which has campaigned for decades against branch closures, published the figures. Defenders of the cuts point to falling visitor numbers, but that argument gets the causation backwards: shorten the hours and of course fewer people come. In my view the decline is a policy choice, not a public verdict."

· *The writer thinks falling visitor numbers caused the reduction in opening hours* → **NO. Explicit contradiction of the writer's view** — he names that argument and says it "*gets the causation backwards.*" You can put a finger on the sentence, and the sentence is about what he believes. That is what NO requires. · *The writer regards the reduction as a decision by policymakers rather than a response to demand* → **YES. Legitimate paraphrase**, marked as the writer's own by *In my view*. · *Library funding has fallen in real terms since 2015* → **NOT GIVEN**.

Adjacent proposition — hours and visitors are discussed, funding never is. · *The Association of County Archivists compiled the figures* → **NOT GIVEN. Attribution gap** — it *published* them; who compiled them is never said. · *Every regional library in the country reduced its opening hours* → **NOT GIVEN. Population gap**. The writer's claim covers the libraries **he visited**; the statement covers all of them. The passage neither confirms nor denies the wider claim — there is no sentence to point at. **Narrow in the passage, wide in the statement, is a gap, not a contradiction.**

On that last one, because it is the item most guides — and most candidates — key backwards.

It is tempting to reason: *he only saw some libraries, so the statement over-claims, so mark it NO*. That is constructing an argument, which step 7 below forbids. Compare a scope mismatch that genuinely **does** contradict: if the text read "*outside the two northern counties, not a single library changed its hours*", then "*every regional library reduced its opening hours*" is **NO** — the passage asserts precisely what the statement denies. The difference is not the size of the mismatch; it is whether a sentence exists that rules the statement out. §The qualifier trap works this through again.

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Treating Y/N/NG as T/F/NG. If the statement is true of the world and its topic appears in the passage, but the writer takes no position, it is NOT GIVEN, not YES.

Order: YES.

Type 4 — Matching information (to paragraphs)

APPEARANCE

"Which paragraph contains the following information? Write the correct letter A–H." Often with "NB You may use any letter more than once."

RULES

"Not every paragraph (or section) may be used and some paragraphs may be used more than once. When [they] may be used more than once, the instructions will say: 'You may use any letter more than once'." Unlike matching headings, it targets "specific information rather than the main idea." [src: ielts.org — Reading test format]

THE TRAP

Word-level matching. Cambridge has students mark **Disagree** to *"if the exact same words appear in the text as in an information point, then this must be the correct paragraph"*, because *"more than one paragraph may deal with the same general area... You need to look for the information not the words."* [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 4 PDF, Key to Ex.3]

Technique — paragraph-led, not question-led. Paraphrase every information point first. Read paragraph A, then look **through the points** to see if any is in it — *"because you are looking for specific information, it is easier to read a paragraph and then look through the information points."* Never re-read a paragraph repeatedly. If nothing matches quickly, move on. After each paragraph, re-scan **all** points including matched ones — *"keep an open mind about your answers until you have read all the paragraphs."* [src: same]

MINI-EXAMPLE

Point: "a comparison of the running costs of two heating systems." Paraphrase first: *which of the two is cheaper per year*. You are now scanning for a **comparison**, not for *costs* — which appears in three paragraphs, only one of which compares anything.

[expert consensus] Do this type **last within its passage**, when the other sets have taught you the passage. [src: ieltsliz.com] · [src: ieltsadvantage.com] Not official, but free: the type is order-independent, so deferring it loses nothing.

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Working question-by-question: 8 paragraphs × 6 questions = 48 scans instead of 8 reads.

Order: NO.

Type 5 — Matching headings

APPEARANCE

Headings in lower-case Roman numerals; paragraphs lettered A, B, C. One or more may be done as an **Example**.

RULES

"There will always be more headings than paragraphs... some paragraphs or sections may not be included... No heading may be used more than once." Tests identifying a paragraph's general topic and *"the difference between the main idea and a supporting idea."* [src: ielts.org — Reading test format]

And it always comes first — this task type *"will be the first set of questions in the section."* [src: ielts.org]

— News & Insights: matching headings] That is not a strategy choice; it is where the paper puts it.

THE TRAP

Choosing a heading that matches one sentence rather than the paragraph's main idea — and working from the headings: *"if they start with the headings and scan for the key words in them, they will be finding specific information rather than the main idea."* [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 5]

PDF, step 13]

Technique — the official 10-step British Council strategy. Survey the passage → skim first and final sentences of each paragraph → read the headings, underline key words → **eliminate any heading used as the Example** → match heading key words to topic sentences → if no match, read the paragraph's final sentence → if still none, read the whole paragraph → repeat → finalise as you learn more of the text → transfer the **Roman numerals**, not the heading text. Caution: *"while topic sentences are very often the first sentence of the paragraph they can be elsewhere."* [src: britishcouncil — Matching Headings PDF, Q7 + key]

MINI-EXAMPLE

Paragraph: "Rope-making guilds guarded their techniques closely. A Genoese master could be fined for teaching an outsider. Yet by 1610 the same twist-count was in use in three ports, and no one has explained how it travelled." *Headings:* (i) Punishments imposed on Genoese craftsmen · (ii) An unexplained spread of technical knowledge · (iii) The economics of the rope trade. → **(ii)**. (i) matches one sentence — the fine — which is support, not the main idea.

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Reading each paragraph in full before looking at the headings, which doubles the work — or leaving a blank when torn between two. No penalty; pick one.

Order: the questions run in paragraph order; the numerals do not. Work the paragraphs top to bottom; never expect heading (i) to belong to paragraph A. The evidence for that split is set out under the order table above, and this chapter uses the same wording in all four places it

comes up.

Type 6 — Matching features

APPEARANCE

Statements matched to a lettered list of features — researchers, studies, countries, periods.

RULES

"It is possible that some options will not be used, and that others may be used more than once. When it is possible to use any option more than once, the instructions will say: 'You may use any option more than once'." [src: ielts.org — Reading test format] **Reuse is permitted only when the instructions say so.** If the rubric is silent, assume single use. Many guides state this backwards. (*Rubric*, throughout this chapter, means the printed instruction line above a set of questions — the sentence that tells you what to choose and how many words you may write.)

THE TRAP

Attribution. In a passage discussing three researchers, every option is genuinely in the text; the question is *whose* claim it is.

Technique — the official 5-step British Council strategy. From your skim, **note which parts of the text belong to each lettered option** — build the map of where each feature lives *before* reading the statements. Then read the questions and underline key words; generate synonyms; scan the relevant regions; close-read around the hits. [src: britishcouncil — Matching Features PDF, Ex.5 + key]

MINI-EXAMPLE

Text: "Restrepo's team **showed** that the sediment layer forms in under a decade. Halvorsen **argues** this rules out a volcanic origin — a claim Restrepo herself has never made."

Statement: "concluded that the layer cannot be volcanic" → **Halvorsen**, though Restrepo's name sits closer to the sediment vocabulary.

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Scanning for the proper noun and taking the first sentence near it. The name recurs; the attribution of that specific claim does not.

Order: NO.

Type 7 — Matching sentence endings

APPEARANCE

"Complete each sentence with the correct ending, A–F, below."

RULES

"There will be more sentence endings than beginnings, so you will not use all of them." Tests understanding of main ideas. [src: ielts.org — Reading test format] A Cambridge variant shows endings can be reusable when the rubric says so. [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 7 PDF]

THE TRAP

Grammatical fit. *"There are often distractors which have slightly different meanings",* and you need the ending *"which contains exactly the same information as in the text, even if the words used are different."* [src: same, step 5] The two classic mechanisms are **number** (singular swapped for plural) and **agent** (right claim, wrong body).

TECHNIQUE

Underline key words in the **beginnings only**; cover the endings. Scan; decide what the sentence must say from the text; *then* read the endings; then highlight the phrase that proves your choice. *"Remember, the information is always stated specifically, and is not inferred, in the text."* [src: same, steps 3–8]

MINI-EXAMPLE

Text: "The harbour authority's 2019 report contained **a single review** of dredging practice. It was **the port operator**, not the authority, that then called for a seasonal ban." *Beginning:* "The 2019 report..." *Endings:* A included several reviews of dredging · B led the harbour authority to demand a seasonal ban · C contained one review of dredging practice. → **C**. A fails on **number**, B on **agent**. Both read perfectly.

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Choosing the ending that reads most naturally. Every wrong ending reads naturally — that is the design.

Order: YES (the beginnings are in text order).

Type 8 — Sentence completion**APPEARANCE**

"Complete the sentences below. Choose ONE WORD ONLY from the passage for each answer."

On ONE WORD ONLY , so that this chapter and Chapter 2 do not appear to disagree. That wording is **verbatim official in Academic Reading**: it appears twice in the official 2023 Academic Reading sample tasks — once on a Sentence Completion set and once on a Summary / Notes Completion set. [src: ielts.org — Academic Reading Sample Tasks 2023 PDF, fetched 2026-07-31]

Chapter 2 says the phrase could **not** be verified in any official *Listening* document, and that is also correct: the 2023 Listening sample tasks use only **NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER** and **NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS** . [src: ielts.org — Listening Sample Tasks 2023 PDF, fetched 2026-07-31] Two papers, two different findings, no contradiction: expect **ONE WORD ONLY** in Reading, do not assume it in Listening.

RULES

"Read the instructions very carefully as the number of words or numbers you may use to fill the gaps can change." The limit is absolute: *"Answers which are over the word limit will be marked as incorrect."* Hyphenated words count as one; contractions are not tested; numbers may be figures or words. [src: ielts.org — Reading test format] • [src: cambridgeenglish — FAQs PDF]

THE TRAP

The word limit changes **between sets in the same paper**. Reading the previous rubric from memory loses marks on items you understood perfectly.

TECHNIQUE

Write the limit at the top of the set. Predict the **grammar** of each gap before scanning — *"you will need to think about the type of word(s) that will fit into a gap."* [src: ielts.org — Reading test format] Scan in order. **Copy the word exactly**. Re-read the completed sentence: *"Make sure your answer is grammatically correct."* [src: cambridgeenglish — FAQs PDF]

MINI-EXAMPLE

*Rubric: ONE WORD ONLY. Text: "...a compass whose needle was mounted on a bearing of polished **agate**." Q: The needle was mounted on a bearing made of _____. → **agate**. Not *the agate*, not *agate stone*, not *polished agate*.*

The band-6 mistake — yours specifically. Adding a word the gap did not need: an article (*the society*) or a plural on an uncountable (*informations, researches*). Here that is not a style slip. It is a **zero**.

Order: YES.

Type 9 — Summary / note / table / flow-chart completion

APPEARANCE

Four surface forms: continuous **summary**; **notes**; a **table** with empty cells; a **flow chart** — "*a series of boxes or steps linked by arrows*." [src: ielts.org — Reading test format]

Rules — and two variations that behave differently. "*The summary is not normally of the whole text*"; it covers one part. [src: same]

	Variation 1 — words from the passage	Variation 2 — word bank A–G
You write	The word(s), exactly as in the text	A letter
Word limit	Applies absolutely	Does not apply
Spelling risk	High — the mark is lost for a misspelling	Zero
Words appear in the passage?	Yes, verbatim	Often not at all — they are paraphrases
Skill	Scan and transcribe	Paraphrase recognition + grammatical fit

The paraphrase point is established by the official word-bank sample, where none of the four correct option words appears anywhere in the passage it summarises [src: ielts.org — Sample Tasks 2023 PDF, Summary Completion from a list]. Bank answers "*most frequently consist of a single word*." [src: britishcouncil — Completion questions PDF, p.2]

THE TRAP

Variation 2's bank is full of grammar decoys — every option fits the slot, so only meaning can decide. Variation 1's trap is simply over-writing.

TECHNIQUE

The official British Council pre-reading routine, **before** you read the text: for each gap, identify the format, write down the word limit, find the clue words, decide what to look for, and **predict a possible answer**. Then check each answer three ways: "*contextually, grammatically and adherence to instructions*." [src: britishcouncil — Completion questions PDF, Worksheets 1–2a + teacher's notes] For **tables**, "*the key words to scan for are the column headings*", and predict the answer *class* per gap — a month, a number, a material. [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 9 PDF, Key to Worksheet 3–4]

Mini-example, variation 2.

Bank: A gradual · B official · C deliberate · D accidental · E rapid · F local *Gap:* "The spread of the technique was largely _____. "*Text:* "No guild ever sanctioned the transfer, and no master ever set out to teach it beyond his own yard; it travelled by chance contact between crews wintering in the same harbour." → **D, accidental.** Every option fits the slot grammatically, so grammar decides nothing; only meaning does. B is what the text denies, C is what the text denies twice over, and *accidental* — the word the passage never uses — is what *chance contact* means.

Marking notes from the official key: words in brackets are optional, alternatives are separated by a slash, both UK and US spellings are accepted, and numbers count as figures or words. [src:

cambridgeenglish — Task Type 9 PDF, Key to Worksheet 5]

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Treating variation 2 like variation 1 — searching the passage for the bank words. They are not there.

Order: NOT GUARANTEED — but *"they will usually come from one part of the text."* That sentence **is** the strategy: find the region first, then work the gaps locally. [src: ielts.org — Reading test format]

Type 10 — Diagram label completion

APPEARANCE

"Label the diagram below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer." The diagram *"may be a type of machine, part of a building or of other information in the text that can be shown through pictures."* [src: ielts.org — Reading test format]

RULES

Word limit absolute; hyphenated words count as one. Tests relating a detailed description in the text to information in a diagram. [src: same]

THE TRAP

Position and orientation. The label you need is distinguished from a decoy by **where** it sits, not by what it is.

TECHNIQUE

Study the diagram first — is the gap a name, a material, a step? Then find the region: *"the words will probably only come from one part of the text but... they do not necessarily occur in the order of the passage."* Then the key instruction: *"pay particular attention to expressions relating to location and position as these are likely to be the ones relating to the diagram."* Scan for the diagram's own key words, skim each hit for relevance, and *"detailed reading should only happen when students are sure they have found the relevant section."* [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 10 PDF,

teacher's notes steps 1–6]

MINI-EXAMPLE

Text: "A brass bezel rings the dial and a brass pin secures the arm. A brass collar sits **immediately below** the spindle; the **outer** casing, made of lacquered oak, encloses both."

Label on the lower ring: → **brass collar**, chosen by *immediately below*, not by *brass*, which describes three parts in three lines and therefore discriminates nothing.

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Reading the passage linearly hunting for labels. They cluster in one region. Find the region, then read densely.

Order: NOT GUARANTEED.

Type 11 — Short-answer questions

APPEARANCE

Direct factual questions: *"Answer the questions below using NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS for each answer."*

RULES

"Answers must be taken from words in the text." Word limit absolute. *"Numbers can be written using figures (1, 2, etc.) or words (one, two, etc.)."* [src: ielts.org — Reading test format]

THE TRAP

Over-answering — more items, or more words, than the question asked for. [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 11 PDF, Additional information]

TECHNIQUE

Note the limit. Underline key words per question. Scan and **write the paragraph number beside each question before answering anything**. Then skim only that paragraph. *"If they don't find the answer quickly, skim read around the relevant section, and keep the other questions in mind at all times."* [src: same, step 3]

MINI-EXAMPLE

Rubric: NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS. *Text:* "The charter was finally sealed in 1247, after eleven years of argument." *Q:* When was the charter sealed? → **1247**. Not *in 1247*, not *in the year 1247*.

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Answering in a sentence, or adding an article or preposition. The extra words either break the limit or introduce a grammar error; both cost the mark.

Order: YES, usually — Cambridge admits answers are *"sometimes... in slightly, but never totally, different order."* [src: same]

The FALSE / NOT GIVEN decision procedure

Most guides get this backwards, and it is where 27 becomes 30 or stays 27.

- 0 Read the rubric. T/F/NG or Y/N/NG? Fact, or writer's view?
- 1 Underline the key words in the statement.
- 2 Turn the statement into a YES/NO QUESTION.
- 3 Generate synonyms for the key words.
- 4 From your skim, pick the relevant paragraph (ordered type — start where the last answer was).
- 5 Scan that region for the key words or synonyms.
- 6 Close-read that sentence, plus the one before and after.
- 7 DECIDE — can I put my finger on a sentence that ANSWERS my yes/no question?
 - NO → NOT GIVEN. Stop. Do not reason further.
 - YES → it answers yes → TRUE / YES
 - it answers no → FALSE / NO
- 8 Convert to the required label.

[src: britishcouncil — T/F/NG PDF, Worksheet 3 Ex.1 + key]

Cambridge frames step 7 as three questions comparing your statement (A) with the text sentence (B): does B mean the same as A → **True/Yes**; does B contain information that **contradicts** A → **False/No**; are the two sentences' main points **completely different** → **Not Given**. [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 2 & 3 PDF, Worksheet 2]

FALSE requires a contradiction you can point at. NOT GIVEN is the absence of a sentence. If you catch yourself constructing an argument — *"well, it probably isn't, because..."* — you are inferring, not reading, and the answer is NOT GIVEN.

Officially corroborated: *"The main difference between 'False' or 'No' and 'Not Given', is that 'False' and 'No' can be proven (that is, there is evidence in the article)."* [src: ielts.idp.com — Examples of how to use 'not given']

The qualifier trap, the right way round

Every qualifier in the statement — quantity, proportion, rate, timing, comparison, exclusivity — is **a separate claim that must itself be present in the text**. [src: ielts.idp.com — Examples of how to use 'not given']

Statement says	Text says	Answer	Mechanism
<i>most / the majority</i>	<i>numerous / many / several</i>	NOT GIVEN	A vague quantifier gives no basis to confirm or deny a precise one
<i>both / all / every</i>	one case explicitly excluded (<i>the sole recipient</i>)	FALSE / NO	Explicit exclusion is a contradiction
a wide population (<i>employees, all the villages</i>)	a narrow one only (<i>managerial staff, the villages I visited</i>), and nothing about the rest	NOT GIVEN	Scope mismatch, gap version — a narrower fact neither confirms nor denies a wider claim
a wide population (<i>nowhere in the UK</i>)	the text rules the statement out (<i>the practice survives only in Scotland</i>)	FALSE / NO	Scope mismatch, contradiction version — a sentence exists that excludes the statement
<i>only a few</i>	no proportion stated at all	NOT GIVEN	Proportion dimension absent
<i>rapidly</i>	the event described, its speed not	NOT GIVEN	Rate dimension absent
<i>more X than Y</i>	one side described, no comparison made	NOT GIVEN	The comparison was never made
<i>before they started school</i>	the fact stated, the timing not	NOT GIVEN	Time dimension absent

Row 1 is the one candidates fail, and an official worked example settles it: a passage says *numerous* creatures are of a certain kind, a statement claims something about **most** of them, and the answer is **NOT GIVEN** — because *numerous* "might refer to most species, but also might not; we don't have enough information." [src: britishcouncil — T/F/NG PDF, Worksheet 3 key Q3] On original material:

"Numerous villages along the estuary still draw water from wells." vs "*Most villages along the estuary draw water from wells.*" → **NOT GIVEN**. "Every village along the estuary was surveyed except Portsea." vs "*All the villages along the estuary were surveyed.*" → **FALSE**. Now there is a sentence contradicting you.

Rows 3 and 4 are the pair candidates get wrong, and they look identical from a distance. Both are scope mismatches — the statement talks about a bigger population than the passage does. Only one of them is a contradiction. On original material:

Gap version → NOT GIVEN. Passage: *"Two thirds of the households on the eastern bank were connected to the mains supply by 1968."* Statement: *"Two thirds of households in the district were connected to the mains supply by 1968."* The eastern bank is part of the district; the passage says nothing at all about the rest of it. The district figure could be two thirds, could be a tenth. **No sentence answers the question, so NOT GIVEN.**

Contradiction version → FALSE. Passage: *"Two thirds of the households on the eastern bank were connected by 1968; on the western bank, mains water did not arrive until the 1980s."* Same statement: *"Two thirds of households in the district were connected to the mains supply by 1968."* Now the passage has told you about the rest of the district, and what it says rules the statement out. **FALSE, and you can point at the clause that does it.**

The discriminator is never *how much* wider the statement is. It is: **has the writer said anything about the part the statement adds?** If no — NOT GIVEN. If yes, and it goes the other way — FALSE / NO.

Reading vs inferring — the line

"She paid for her brother's apprenticeship on the understanding that he would later fund her own training. In 1884 that undertaking was honoured, and she enrolled at the Institute." vs *"She enrolled because of her brother's financial help."* → **TRUE.** Two sentences, but **the writer supplied the link** (*undertaking → honoured*).

"At fourteen she won the district prize for arithmetic and was known for reciting long tables from memory." vs *"She became interested in instrument-making as a child."* → **NOT GIVEN.** Her childhood is described; that proposition is not. **You** would be supplying the link.

The test: **did the writer supply the connection, or did I?**

Tips & tricks

Ranked by marks recovered per hour of practice.

1. Copy-paste every completion answer. [verified] 

Computer-delivered callout. Completion answers are **transcription, not composition.**

Official: *"All the words you will need in order to answer the questions will be given in the text"; "Copy words accurately from the text. Spelling mistakes will mean that you will lose the mark for that question."* [src: cambridgeenglish — FAQs PDF] And *"you can copy and paste from the text for the Reading and Writing tests."* [src: ielts.idp.com — Seven benefits of IELTS on computer]

Select the word in the passage, copy, paste, then count the words against the rubric.

Spelling error becomes structurally impossible on types 8, 9-variation-1, 10 and 11 — exactly where a French/Arabic L1 reader otherwise bleeds marks on doubled consonants and *-tion/-sion*.

CTRL+F does not work. There is no find function. Locating is done by skimming and scanning, and by the **highlight** tool: left-click and drag, right-click, select *highlight*; right-click → *clear all* removes it. Highlighting is invisible to markers — *"you can highlight as much or as little text as you want without any impact on your test result."* [src: britishcouncil — IELTS on computer: Highlighting text]

A **notes** panel and a **flag** tool are available, and font size can be increased. [src: britishcouncil — IELTS on computer: Making notes] • [src: ielts.idp.com — using IELTS on Computer features]

Paper habits map straight across: *underline key words* → highlight; *put a mark next to this question* → flag; *write the paragraph number* → notes panel.

2. Never leave a blank. [verified] *"Test takers are not penalised for wrong answers"; "a blank answer will get no marks."* [src: ielts.org — News & Insights: matching headings] • [src: ielts.idp.com — Reading band scores] Reserve the last three minutes for this. If you currently time out on Passage 3, this alone can be the three marks.

3. Write the word limit at the top of every set. [verified] It changes between sets, and *"answers which are over the word limit will be marked as incorrect."* [src: cambridgeenglish — FAQs PDF] Mechanical marks, recovered with no reading improvement whatsoever.

4. Learn the order table. [verified] On an ordered type, resume searching from where the last answer was. It **fails** on types 4, 6, 9 and 10 — applying it there makes you abandon correct answers. **Type 5 is the special case:** the *questions* still run in paragraph order, so work the paragraphs top to bottom, but the Roman *numerals* do not, so never expect heading (i) to belong to paragraph A. [src: cambridgeenglish — FAQs PDF] • [src: britishcouncil — Dealing with Matching Headings questions (PDF)] • [src: ielts.org — Academic Reading Sample Tasks 2023 PDF]

5. Answer from the text before you look at the options. [verified] Types 1, 6, 7. It **fails** when you cannot locate the region — then flag it and move on rather than guessing from the options.

6. Survey, skim, scan, close-read — in that order. [verified] Officially defined: **surveying** is *"looking at a text very quickly before reading to get an idea of lay-out: title, pictures, graphs, headings, glossary etc."*; **skimming** is *"reading a text very quickly to get the general understanding and... the organisation of the text"*; **scanning** is *"reading a text with the specific purpose of extracting information"*

such as numbers, facts, words." Official drill timings: survey **20 seconds**; skim topic and final sentences **60 seconds** for a three-quarter-page text; scan one paragraph **45 seconds**. [src: britishcouncil — Developing Reading Skills PDF, Ex.2 and Ex.4]

7. Separate unchangeable from changeable key words. [expert consensus] Proper nouns, dates, figures and glossary terms survive paraphrasing — scan for those. Every other content word will have been swapped for a synonym; generate two or three paraphrases first and scan for the **idea**. [src: ielts.idp.com — Matching Information] • [src: britishcouncil — T/F/NG PDF, step f]

8. Keep a paraphrase log. [expert consensus, on official practice design] After every practice passage, two columns: *question wording* → *text wording*. This is what Cambridge's own answer keys do. [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 2 & 3 PDF, Key to Worksheet 1] It feeds `progress/vocab-bank.md` and your Writing Lexical Resource at the same time.

9. Never write two answers in one gap. [verified] *"Even if one of your answers is correct, you will not receive a mark."* [src: cambridgeenglish — FAQs PDF]

Timing

Official baseline: *"You have 60 minutes to read three texts and answer 40 questions. You should spend about 20 minutes on each text."* Also official: *"Start at the beginning of the test and work through it. If you cannot do a particular question, leave it and go on to the next", and "take care not to spend too much time on any one text or question."* [src: cambridgeenglish — FAQs PDF]

Because the last three minutes must go on blanks, the working budget is **19 / 19 / 19 + 3**. Set a per-question ceiling of about 90 seconds and a hard stop per passage.

A **back-loaded** split — roughly 17 / 19 / 21, plus the three-minute sweep — is a legitimate **personal tactic**, not a rule, and it rests on a premise no official source states. Earn it from your own data: if across three timed tests your Passage 1 accuracy is at or above 90% and Passage 3 is below 70%, shift time to the end. Otherwise stay flat — and note that Myth 13 below warns against exactly this move when it is made on folklore rather than on your own numbers, because it under-budgets Passage 1, where marks are cheapest.

Myths that hold you back

1. "Read the whole passage carefully first." Official: *"Don't waste time reading the whole text each time for each set of questions... you need to skim quickly through the text rather than reading it all carefully."* [src: cambridgeenglish — FAQs PDF] **Why it fails:** 2,150–2,750 words at comprehension speed eats a large share of your 60 minutes and you still have to re-locate every answer.

2. "NOT GIVEN is the safest blind guess, because candidates over-choose FALSE." No official data supports this. No official source publishes the answer-key distribution for T/F/NG, and this book will not invent one. **Why it fails:** it trains you to reach for NOT GIVEN before finishing the

decision procedure, converting findable FALSE items into wrong answers. The defensible version is procedural, not statistical: *if you have located the region and cannot point at a contradicting sentence, it is NOT GIVEN*. That is step 7 done properly, and it is not a guess.

3. "An absolute in the statement (all / never / only) means FALSE." Wrong. Official worked examples produce **FALSE** for one absolute — where the text explicitly excludes a case — and **NOT GIVEN** for another, where the text says nothing about proportions at all. [src: ielts.org — Sample Tasks 2023 PDF] • [src: ielts.idp.com — 'not given' examples] **Why it fails:** it replaces reading with pattern-spotting on the statement, which is what the distractor design punishes.

4. "Answers always come in order." Order is **type-specific**. **Why it fails:** you abandon correct answers during matching information — precisely the type where the belief is false.

5. "Answers never come in order, so search the whole passage every time." The opposite error, equally costly, and directly contradicted by the "don't go back to the beginning" rule. [src: cambridgeenglish — FAQs PDF]

6. "Do all the T/F/NG sets across all three passages first." Contradicted: *"Start at the beginning of the test and work through it."* [src: same] **Why it fails on computer:** passage and questions are bound together on screen, so jumping costs navigation time and throws away the familiarity that makes later sets within a passage cheap.

7. "Pick the multiple-choice option that fits grammatically." Explicitly debunked: *"all answer options (A–D) are grammatically possible."* [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 1 PDF, step 8]

8. "Same words in the paragraph means it's the right paragraph." Explicitly debunked: *"You need to look for the information not the words."* [src: cambridgeenglish — Task Type 4 PDF] **Why it fails:** word-matching is the mechanism by which distractors are built, in every type.

9. "Leave it blank if you're unsure." There is no negative marking. A blank scores zero; a wrong guess also scores zero. The guess has positive expected value; the blank has none.

10. "Write two possible answers and let the marker choose." *"Even if one of your answers is correct, you will not receive a mark."* [src: cambridgeenglish — FAQs PDF]

11. "Use your background knowledge to go faster." *"You must be careful not to use any information you already know about the topic of the text."* [src: ielts.org — Reading test format] **Why it fails:** on T/F/NG, knowing the right answer about the world produces the wrong answer on the test.

12. "You must understand every word — build a topic glossary per subject." *"Don't worry if you don't understand every word. It may not be necessary to understand all the words in order to answer the questions correctly."* [src: cambridgeenglish — FAQs PDF] Technical terms are glossed for you. The caveat that stops this being a licence to skip vocabulary: some T/F/NG items turn on a **single** lexical item — *benign* → *harmless* → *not unhealthy*. [src: britishcouncil — T/F/NG PDF, Q5] The efficient target is **paraphrase range**, not subject glossaries.

13. "Passage 3 is hardest, so budget 25 minutes for it." No official source states that difficulty increases across passages. The *tactic* may suit you; the *reason* given for it is not established. **Why it fails as taught:** it persuades people to under-budget Passage 1, where marks are cheapest.

14. "Cambridge item analysis shows X% of band-6 candidates fail NG questions." No such published dataset was found during research for this book, and claims of this shape circulate with fabricated-looking attributions. Do not act on any Reading statistic you cannot trace to ielts.org, the British Council or Cambridge.

Band descriptor decoder

Reading has no band descriptors. There is no Task Response, no Coherence and Cohesion, no examiner judgement of any kind. It is an objective test converted from a raw score: *"Each correct item is awarded one mark. Band scores... are awarded to test takers on the basis of their raw scores."* [src: britishcouncil — IELTS Guide for teachers (PDF), p10, fetched 2026-07-31] The only band-level prose for Reading is the general nine-band ability scale — Band 7 = *"Good user"*, Band 6 = *"Competent user"* [src: ielts.idp.com — Reading band scores] — which describes you, not your answers.

So the decoder is arithmetic:

Raw /40	Band
39–40	9
37–38	8.5
35–36	8
33–34	7.5
30–32	7
27–29	6.5
23–26	6
19–22	5.5
15–18	5

Where this table comes from, and how far to trust it. It is **published**, not reconstructed: IDP prints the full Academic Reading conversion including the half-bands [src: ielts.idp.com — IELTS Reading band scores, fetched 2026-07-31]. It carries its own caveat, and you should carry it too: *"The IELTS Reading band score charts that are displayed illustrate the average number of marks needed to get each band score. As a result of the variations in texts used on different occasions, actual scores may differ slightly between tests."* [src: same] The co-owners say the same thing from the other direction — *"the band score boundaries are set so that all test takers' results relate to the same scale of achievement... the Band 6 boundary may be set at a slightly different raw score across individual tests."* [src: britishcouncil — IELTS Guide for teachers (PDF), p10, fetched 2026-07-31]

So: the whole-band rows are hard anchors, the half-band rows are a published average, and **neither is a guarantee for your particular paper**. Use the table to set a target, never to argue that you "should have got" a band.

Cross-checked against the coarser official anchor table — **8 → 35, 7 → 30, 6 → 23, 5 → 15** out of 40 — which is consistent with it row for row. [src: britishcouncil — IELTS Guide for teachers (PDF), p.10] Note the band-5 figure: Academic Reading is **15**, Listening is **16**. That one-mark asymmetry at band 5 is the only difference between the two papers' conversions; from band 6 upward they are identical. If [Chapter 1](#)'s table looks different from this one at band 5, that is why.

Band 7 starts at 30. From the floor of 6.5 that is three marks; from the top of it, one.

Get the arithmetic exactly right, because the old version of this line over-stated it. Band 6.5 is the range **27–29** and band 7 is **30–32**. So the distance from *a* 6.5 to *a* 7 depends entirely on where in 6.5 you are sitting:

You scored	Marks to band 7
27	3
28	2
29	1

Three marks is the **worst case**, and it is the number to plan against. Three careless completion answers — one unnecessary article, one plural the text did not have, one answer a word over the limit — *is* the whole gap in the worst case. That is this chapter's job. Every technique here must justify itself against that number:

Source of loss	Fix	What it is worth
Mechanical losses on completion types: over the limit, misspelling, an added article or plural	Limit written at the top of each set; copy-paste on computer; re-read the completed sentence	Fully preventable. For a French/Arabic L1 reader, usually the largest single block
FALSE-for-NOT-GIVEN errors	Step 7 and the qualifier table	A systematic error costs several marks in one set, because these questions cluster
Blanks from timing out on Passage 3	The three-minute sweep	Every blank filled is a free positive-expectancy guess

Note what is *not* on that list: reading speed, vocabulary breadth, general comprehension. They matter, but they move slowly and they are not where your three marks are sitting.

One honest constraint: the Academic paper has *"more items pitched at bands 5–8"* than General Training does, which has more at bands 3–6 [src: britishcouncil — IELTS Guide for teachers (PDF), p.4, fetched 2026-07-31]. That is a claim about the *distribution* of item difficulty, not a floor — but the consequence stands: 30/40 means converting some genuinely hard items. There is no version of this where you answer only the easy ones and reach band 7.

L1 alert

Arabic and French traps inside the passage.

Reading is the one paper where your French helps before it hurts. Academic English is Latinate, and a French speaker reads *ubiquitous*, *mitigate*, *paucity*, *elucidate*, *nascent*, *concomitant* faster than most candidates ever will. Do not give that away — but know where it turns on you.

False friends inside the passage are more dangerous here than in Writing, because a misread word produces a wrong answer with no warning signal. The full annotated list lives in [Chapter 7](#) §The false-friend list — false friends are scored under Lexical Resource, so vocabulary is their canonical home. The table below is the Reading subset, and the fourth column — *what the misreading costs you on the answer sheet* — is the part that is specific to this paper and worth memorising here.

In the passage	You will read	It means	Consequence
<i>actually</i>	<i>actuellement</i> — currently	in fact	Reverses time claims; kills T/F/NG timing items
<i>eventually</i>	<i>éventuellement</i> — possibly	in the end	Turns a certainty into a possibility
<i>sensible</i>	sensitive	showing good judgement	Misreads the writer's evaluation in Y/N/NG
<i>library</i>	<i>librairie</i> — bookshop	a lending library	Wrong entity in matching features
<i>to control</i>	to check, inspect	to direct, restrain	Reverses a power relationship
<i>assist</i>	to attend	to help	Wrong role for an agent
<i>deception</i>	disappointment	trickery	Inverts a moral judgement
<i>achieve</i>	<i>achever</i> — to finish	to accomplish	Changes the outcome claimed
<i>demand</i>	to ask	to require forcefully	Overstates a stance in Y/N/NG
<i>support</i>	to tolerate	to back, to bear	Turns endorsement into endurance
<i>formation</i>	training	shape, structure	Wrong topic entirely
<i>stage, engaged, preservative</i>	internship, <i>engagé</i> , <i>préservatif</i>	a phase; committed; a food additive	Wrong referent

Drill: when a T/F/NG or Y/N/NG answer turned on a single word and you got it wrong, check that word against this list before blaming your reading speed.

Sentence rhythm. Long chains joined by commas and *and* are normal in Arabic rhetorical structure and French academic prose. English academic writing subordinates instead — *although*, *whereas*, *despite*, *given that* — and **the subordinator carries the answer**. "*Although the yield rose, the practice was abandoned*" and "*Because the yield rose, the practice was abandoned*" differ by one word and give opposite T/F/NG answers. At step 6, read the connector first.

Articles and plurals become zeros, not style marks. Your two commonest Writing errors — an article before an abstract noun (*the society, the nature*) and a plural on an English uncountable (*informations, researches, equipments*) — cost a whole mark in a completion gap. The passage reads "*research suggests*"; write *researches* and the mark is gone. [Chapter 8 §](#)The article decision procedure explains *why* your two languages push you into the article error and how to stop producing it in your own prose; here the fix is simpler and total, because you are not producing prose at all. It is **copy-paste**: never retype a completion answer.

Litotes. English academic prose uses understatement where French would negate directly — *not uncommon, far from conclusive, hardly negligible*. Each is a claim in disguise: "*the evidence is far from conclusive*" means the evidence is weak. Misreading one flips a FALSE into a TRUE.

Where French does not help at all: phrasal verbs. *Bring about, rule out, account for, carry out, put down to, bear out* have no Latinate transparency, and they are exactly what question stems paraphrase with (*account for* ↔ *explain*, *rule out* ↔ *eliminate*, *bear out* ↔ *confirm*). This is your highest-value vocabulary block in Reading, and it belongs in `progress/vocab-bank.md` before any subject glossary does.

Self-test checklist

Every "no" is a mark you are currently paying for.

1. Can I say, for each of the 11 task types, whether its answers follow passage order?
2. Do I write the word limit at the top of every completion set, even when I think I remember it?
3. On computer, do I copy-paste every completion answer rather than typing it?
4. Do I know CTRL+F does not work, and have I practised locating by skim and highlight?
5. Can I state the difference between T/F/NG and Y/N/NG in one sentence each, from memory?
6. When I mark FALSE, can I always point at the sentence that contradicts the statement?
7. When the passage says *numerous* and the statement says *most*, do I answer NOT GIVEN without hesitating?
8. Do I answer multiple-choice, matching-features and sentence-ending items from the text **before** reading the options?
9. On matching information, do I work paragraph-by-paragraph rather than question-by-question?
10. Do I know matching-features options may be reused **only when the instructions say so**?
11. On a word-bank summary, do I stop myself searching the passage for the bank words?
12. Do I reserve the final three minutes to fill every blank, without exception?
13. Do I keep a two-column paraphrase log after every practice passage?
14. Have I stopped reading the whole passage before looking at the questions?
15. Do I check my passage-by-passage accuracy in timed practice, rather than assuming Passage 3 is the hard one?

16. On a *Choose TWO letters* item, do I know it is worth two marks, that both letters are accepted in either order, and that leaving one blank throws away a mark I may already have earned?
17. When the passage says something about a narrow group and the statement says it about a wider one, do I answer NOT GIVEN rather than FALSE?

The 60-second summary is at the top of this chapter, not the bottom. Re-read it before every Reading drill.

CHAPTER 4

4

Writing Task 1: Every Visual Type Mastered

WHAT IT IS WORTH

One third of Writing

WHY IT MATTERS

The overview and the grouping
decide Task Achievement.

FULL READ

~59 min

60-second summary

Read this first. It is at the top of the chapter deliberately: on a nine-minute theory budget this page is the chapter, and everything after it is the detail behind one of these lines.

Twenty minutes, at least 150 words, about a third of your Writing score. Summarise, select, compare — and report only what the visual shows: no causes, no opinions, no predictions of your own.

The chapter in one line: band 7 Task Achievement requires a clear overview, the data appropriately categorised, and the main trends identified; band 6 only requires that an overview be attempted. An **overview** is one or two sentences, usually your second paragraph, that say what the whole visual shows — the big picture, with no individual figures in it. It is a named requirement in the mark scheme, not a stylistic preference. Grouping is in the mark scheme too. A perfect list is a band-6 answer.

Four paragraphs: one-sentence introduction in your own words, two-sentence figure-free overview, then two body paragraphs on the *same* grouping. Never copy the prompt or the chart title — it is struck out before your words are counted and it tells the examiner you cannot paraphrase. Decide tense before typing: past for dated history, present for undated data, future forms for projections, present simple passive for man-made processes, active for natural cycles, present simple for a static diagram with no time axis, and for maps whatever the two dates dictate.

Before you use any trend verb, ask one question: does this visual have a time axis? If it does not — a categorical bar chart, an undated table, a labelled diagram of an object — then *rose*, *fell* and *increased* are factually wrong, and the whole toolkit in §The trend toolkit is illegal. Comparison language replaces it.

Precision beats rarity. **Collocation** — the word this chapter and the next three lean on hardest — means the pairings English habitually makes: *heavy rain* is right and *strong rain* is not, though both are grammatical and both are understood. Band-7 LR is judged on collocation, not on rarity. So *rose sharply* outscores *skyrocketed* used wrongly, and *plummeted* for a 3% fall is an accuracy error as well

as a lexical one. Keep the six families apart: proportion, figure, rate, amount, trend and period are not synonyms. Your three costliest L1 leaks here are the article on abstract nouns (*the car use*), the preposition on figures (*rose of* for *rose by/to*), and the sixty-word coordinated run-on.

If you do only one thing: spend ninety seconds, before writing anything, deciding your two groups and composing the overview sentence that names them. Everything else in Task 1 follows from that decision.

Task 1 is the most learnable thing in the test: fixed instruction, a short list of visuals, a closed vocabulary, no opinion to invent. It is also your highest-value twenty minutes — official 2024–25 data puts mean Academic Writing at 5.54 for Arabic-L1 candidates and 6.15 for French-L1 candidates, the weakest skill for both groups [src: R1, official IELTS performance data 2024–25].

One change in the May 2023 descriptors is the spine of this chapter. Band 7 Task Achievement requires that **"the data are appropriately categorised"** [src: May 2023 IELTS Writing band descriptors, Task 1, band 7 TA]. Band 6 only asks you to select information and *attempt* an overview. "Group, don't list" is therefore not folklore — it is the mark scheme. A script that picks exactly the right figures and reports them in x-axis order is a band-6 script **by the wording of the descriptor**, however clean its English.

What the test actually asks

Mechanics. Sixty minutes, two tasks. Task 1: at least 150 words, no more than 20 minutes [src: ielts.org Academic Writing format page; official 2023 sample-tasks rubric]. Official pages put Task 1 at about a third of the Writing score, Task 2 at two thirds; the exact averaging arithmetic is not published, so treat $(T1 + 2 \times T2) \div 3$ as an estimate. Bands are whole or half only.

The instruction is fixed. Every Academic Task 1 ends with the same sentence: summarise the information by selecting and reporting the main features, and make comparisons where relevant [src: verbatim on all three Task 1 prompts, official 2023 sample-tasks PDF]. *Summarise, select, compare*. Not describe, not explain, not list.

It is information transfer. The official criteria tie the task narrowly to the factual content of the visual and exclude speculative explanation lying outside the data [src: Key Assessment Criteria PDF p.2]. Hence the three prohibitions: no causes, no opinions, no predictions of your own.

Task Achievement measures five things [src: Key Assessment Criteria PDF p.2]: **selecting** key features; enough **detail** to illustrate them; reporting figures **accurately**; **comparing and contrasting** rather than mechanically describing; and an **appropriate format**. So a mis-copied number costs you on *content*, not grammar — and "group, don't list" is IELTS's own wording, not a teacher's.

The 150 words. There is **no published penalty tariff**. What the documents say is that Task Achievement is *defined* as how fully, appropriately, accurately and relevantly the response fulfils the task **using a minimum of 150 words** [src: Key Assessment Criteria PDF p.1] — the count sits inside the definition of the criterion, so a short answer cannot fully satisfy TA. That is a TA effect, not a deduction. Shortfall also spreads: the band-3 descriptors attribute an inadequate lexical resource partly to significant under-length and note that a very short response may not show enough sentence forms to judge control; twenty words or fewer is band 1 on all four criteria [src: May 2023 descriptors, band 1 row; band 3 LR and GRA]. So the rule is not "don't go under 150" but **150 is the floor at which TA can even be satisfied — write 170–190**. Past 200 you rob the task worth double.

Copied rubric is struck out before your words are counted. The **rubric** is the printed wording of the task itself — the chart title, the instruction line above the visual and the fixed sentence below it. It is not yours, so it cannot be marked as yours. Triple-sourced: the band-1 TA wording says copied rubric must be discounted; official examiner comments on the 2023 samples twice record that no credit is given for it, and add that copying reveals an inability to paraphrase — an *LR* judgement; and IELTS's own teaching guidance says copying does not count toward the word requirement [src: May 2023 descriptors band 1 TA; official 2023 examiner comments; official IELTS teaching article on Task 1]. Do the arithmetic: write 175 words, open by copying the chart's 20-word title, and you submitted **155**. Copy the 17-word instruction line too and you submitted **138** — under length — while announcing you cannot paraphrase. **Copying the chart title is the commonest silent way a candidate drops below 150.**

 **Computer-delivered.** The **word count is displayed on screen** as you type (reported as the lower-left corner — check the position on your familiarisation test, not on the day). Answers **auto-save**; you may **start with either task** [src: ielts.idp.com, "How computer-delivered IELTS works"]. Use the counter as a pacing instrument, not a final check.

The 20-minute budget. Run every timed drill in this chapter on **the same keyboard layout you will meet at the test centre** — if you train on AZERTY and sit on QWERTY, every minute in this table is optimistic. [Chapter 9's](#) L1 alert covers the Tunisian keyboard question and what to do about it.

Minutes	Action
0:00–0:03	Identify visual type, units, time frame, and whether there is a time axis at all — that decides tense. Mark biggest, smallest, biggest <i>change</i> , any crossover or outlier.
0:03–0:05	Decide the grouping — body 1 and body 2 — and compose the overview in your head.
0:05–0:17	Write: introduction → overview → body 1 → body 2.
0:17–0:20	Check word count, figures, tense, agreement, articles.

Overrunning to 28 minutes usually costs a full band on Task 2, which is worth twice as much. **Stop and move on.**

The shape, every type: one-sentence introduction (your paraphrase, no data) → two-sentence overview beginning *Overall* (no figures — this is the gate) → body 1 → body 2. **No conclusion.** The overview may legitimately sit at the end instead; official IELTS teaching guidance says a closing paragraph is not required unless the overview was not near the start. What is never wanted is an opinion, a recommendation, or a cause.

Question types, one by one

The official list of inputs is verbatim "*a diagram, graph, table, chart, map or other visual input*" [src: ielts.org — Writing key assessment criteria PDF, p.2, fetched 2026-07-31]; the format page adds "*one or more graphs, charts or tables*" and "*a diagram of an object, device, process or event*" [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic format: Writing, fetched 2026-07-31]. Read that second phrase slowly: **object** and **device** are separate items from **process**, so a diagram is not automatically a sequence. That is why there are nine sections below and not eight. The nine-way split is a **teaching convention, not an official taxonomy**, but it covers every input those two documents name.

"Or other visual input" is an open category by construction, and one day you may meet something that fits none of the nine. Do not panic and do not reach for a template. Ask the two questions that actually decide your writing, in this order:

1. **Is there a time axis?** If yes, you have a trend task: trend verbs, tense set by the dates, group by trend behaviour. If no, trend verbs are banned and your organising principle is comparison — §2 (categorical bars), §4 (table) and §9 (static diagram) all live here.
2. **Is there a sequence?** If yes, you have a process: stages, sequencers, present simple passive, group into phases (§5, §6). If neither a time axis nor a sequence, you are in §9.

Those two questions classify every visual IELTS can print, including one that has no name in this chapter. The fixed instruction never changes — *summarise, select, compare* — so whatever the input, the marks come from selecting the main features and comparing them.

Tense by visual type — decide this before you write

Visual	Time frame	Tense
Line graph / time-series bar	dated past range	past simple
Line graph	running to "the present day"	present perfect
Any chart	projected tail	<i>is projected to, is expected to reach</i> — switch tense at the projection boundary
Any chart	undated ("a typical day")	present simple
Categorical bar / table	no time axis	present simple, comparison language only
Process — man-made	any	present simple passive

Visual	Time frame	Tense
Process — natural cycle	any	present simple, largely active (§6)
Static diagram of an object or device	no time axis, no sequence	present simple, largely active for what a part does (<i>the blade rotates**</i>), passive for what is done to it (§9)
Static diagram of a historical artefact or a past event	dated to the past	past simple: <i>the chamber was lined with brick</i> (§9)
Maps	past → past	past simple passive: <i>a car park was built**</i>
Maps	past → "today"	present perfect passive: <i>the woodland has been cleared**</i>
Maps	present → proposed	modal passive: <i>a marina will be constructed**</i>

Five seconds here prevents a systematic error across 180 words.

The trend toolkit — valid only where there is a time axis

Direction	Neutral	Strong	Very strong
Up	rise, increase, grow, climb	surge, jump, leap	rocket, soar
Down	fall, decline, drop, dip	plunge, slump, tumble	plummet, collapse
Flat	remain steady/stable/unchanged	level off, plateau, flatten out	—
Irregular	fluctuate, vary, oscillate	—	—
Turning point	peak (at), reach a peak (of), bottom out	—	—
Recovery	recover, rebound, pick up	—	—

Degree: *dramatically · sharply · steeply · markedly · substantially* → *moderately · noticeably · appreciably* → *slightly · marginally · minimally*. Speed: *rapidly · abruptly · suddenly* against *steadily · gradually · progressively*.

Four grammar points decide marks. *Rise, fall, increase, decrease, grow, decline* are **intransitive** (*X the number was increased*). *Peak* takes **at**; *reach a peak* takes **of**. *Rise/rose/risen* is irregular — *raise* is a different, transitive verb. *Level off* and *plateau* mean **stop rising**, not *fall*; using them for a fall is a TA accuracy error.

Cheapest range win: **write every trend both ways** — *Sales rose sharply* ↔ *There was a sharp rise in sales*. Two further shapes: change-as-subject (*The steepest decline occurred between 1995 and 2000*) and the **participle clause** — a clause with no subject of its own, hooked onto the main clause by an *-ing* or *-ed* form, which takes its subject from the main clause: *Sales climbed steadily, rising to a peak of 40% before falling back***. It is the cheapest complex structure in Task 1 because it adds a second piece of information without adding a second subject and verb to get wrong.

Six word families you must keep apart

Treating these as synonyms is exactly the imprecise word choice band 6 names [src: R7 §Paraphrase

families for Task 1; May 2023 descriptors band 6 LR].

- **PROPORTION** (proportion, percentage, share, ratio) — part of a whole. ✗ *the proportion of 5 million*.
- **FIGURE** (figure, number, total, level) — the number itself. *The number of* + plural takes a **singular** verb; *a number of* takes a plural one.
- **RATE** — always *per* something. *The rate of increase* ≠ *the increase*: if growth slows, the rate falls while the figure still rises.
- **AMOUNT** (amount, quantity, volume) — uncountable only. ✗ *the amount of children* → **the number of children**; French *la quantité de* covers both, and an official **band-6** sample script contains exactly this error.
- **TREND** — direction over time only. A bar chart comparing countries has no trend; it has **differences**.
- **PERIOD** (period, decade, span) for time; **stage/phase** for processes. ✗ *a twenty-years period* is a word-formation error scored under LR.

1. Line graph

Change over time, two to six series: the task is *trend*, not *value*. **Group by trend behaviour, never legend order** — one paragraph for what rose, one for what fell or held flat; a crossover belongs in the overview. Past simple for a dated range, present perfect to "now", future forms for a projected tail. This is the one type where *fluctuate*, *peak*, *bottom out*, *level off* and *rebound* all apply.

TRAP

Four lines described separately, in legend order, in four paragraphs — the mechanical recounting the band-5 TA descriptor names. An official examiner criticised exactly this, calling the reporting somewhat mechanical, on a script rated band 6 [src: official 2023 examiner

comments, Task 1A].

WORKED EXAMPLE

Visitors (thousands) at three coastal-town attractions, 2000–2020: castle 120 → 70; art gallery 40 → 95; aquarium 60 → 62, fluctuating.

Overall, the two long-established attractions moved in opposite directions over the two decades, with the gallery overtaking the castle around the midpoint of the period. The aquarium, by contrast, saw almost no net change.

A category, a named trend, the crossover flagged, the flat series separated, no figures. **Thirty-four words** — counted, not estimated, because this chapter tells you to count. Add a 20-to-25-word introduction and you land inside the 55–70-word checkpoint in tip 12 with nothing to spare, which is the point: an overview this tight is a target, not a maximum.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

In 2000 the castle had 120,000 visitors, the aquarium 60,000 and the gallery 40,000. In 2010 the castle had 95,000... Numbers right, nothing categorised, no trend named.

2. Bar chart

Two sub-species behaving completely differently. **Time-series bars** are a line graph: trend verbs, past simple. **Categorical bars with no time axis** are a table: comparison language, superlatives, present simple, **no trend verbs at all**. Group categorical bars by magnitude band (the dominant few / the middle / the negligible) or a natural split (male vs female, developed vs developing); for grouped or stacked bars, decide whether the story is *between* or *within* groups and commit. Language: comparatives, superlatives, multiples, *outstripped*, *lagged behind*, *accounted for*.

TRAP

Rise/fall vocabulary on a chart with no time axis. *Sales increased in Germany compared to France* is wrong; it is *were higher in Germany than in France*. A band-6 LR marker **and** a TA accuracy error — you reported a change the chart does not show.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Average daily domestic water use per person, litres: A 210, B 185, C 90, D 75, E 40.

Overall, consumption divides the five countries into two clearly separated groups: two use more than twice as much water per head as any of the remaining three, and the gap between the highest and lowest figures is more than fivefold.

Check the multiple against the *closest* pair before you write it, exactly as §4 tells you to check a range against the worst column. The narrowest gap across the group boundary is B against C — $185 \div 90 = \mathbf{2.06}$, which is *more than twice* but nowhere near *well over twice*. Tip 8 warns that *well over* means clearly above; using it for 2.06 would be the same TA accuracy error as *plummeted* for a 3% fall. The wider claim is safe: $210 \div 40 = \mathbf{5.25}$, so *more than fivefold* is true.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

Country A increased to 210 litres, while country E decreased to 40. Two trend verbs, no time dimension.

3. Pie chart

Composition of a whole — and pies almost always come in twos, so the real task is **comparing two compositions**. Body 1: what grew or dominates. Body 2: what shrank or is marginal. Overview: which slice dominates each pie and which moved most. Past simple for dated pies,

present for undated. Language: *account for, make up, constitute, represent, comprise* (no of — *✗ comprises of*), *the largest share, the remainder*, fractions.

Trap — two. Reading off all six slices of both pies: twelve figures, no comparison. And, more expensive: **percentage pies cannot tell you a number rose** — only the *share* rose, so "the number of car users increased" is a factual error under TA. Related: 20% to 30% is a rise of **10 percentage points**, or of **50 per cent**; if unsure, write *rose from 20% to 30%* and sidestep it.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Household waste sources, 2010 → 2025 (%): food 32 → 22, packaging 25 → 34, garden 18 → 17, paper 15 → 9, other 10 → 18.

Overall, packaging displaced food waste as the largest single component over the fifteen-year period, though together the two continued to account for well over half of all household waste in both years. Paper showed the sharpest proportional decline.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

Food waste was 32% and became 22%, so it decreased by 10%. Ten percentage points, or roughly a third — and a fall in share, which may not mean less waste was produced.

4. Table

Tables carry the most raw numbers and the least built-in story, so **selection is the whole game**. Mark the biggest and smallest in every row and column, plus the biggest change if there is a time axis, and **ignore mid-range values entirely** [expert consensus: IELTS Simon; derivable from the band-7 categorisation requirement]. Tense follows the table's time frame; undated → present simple. Language: superlatives, comparatives, ratios, ranking (*ranked first, came bottom, at the other end of the scale, the sole exception*).

TRAP

The easiest place to write 200 fluent words, cover every cell, and still sit at TA 5 — everything covered, nothing categorised. **A table overview must say something that appears in no single cell.**

WORKED EXAMPLE

Graduates in employment six months after graduating, 2022 (%).

	Canada	Ireland	Portugal
Nursing	96	97	89
Engineering	92	88	74
Law	84	79	66
Fine art	51	47	39

Overall, the subject studied mattered far more than the country of study: nursing graduates found work most readily everywhere and fine art graduates least readily, with a gap of between forty-five and fifty percentage points separating the two in every country. Canada led on all subjects except nursing, where Ireland narrowly took first place.

Do the arithmetic before you write the range: $96-51 = 45$, $97-47 = 50$, $89-39 = 50$. *Roughly forty-five points in every country* would have been faster to write and would have been **wrong in two countries out of three** — a TA accuracy error inside the very sentence meant to demonstrate categorisation. A stated range (*between forty-five and fifty*) costs three words and is true of all three columns. When an approximation has to cover several figures, check it against the **worst** one, not the first one you looked at.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

Twelve sentences, one per cell, in reading order.

5. Process diagram — man-made

A sequence with a defined start and end. Count the stages; name input and output. There are **no figures**, so the trend and comparison apparatus is irrelevant. Introduction (paraphrase; state the number of stages) → overview (name the **phases**, not the count) → first half → second half. **Present simple passive** throughout, unless the diagram is explicitly historical.

Rotate sequencers rather than heading every sentence with one: *initially* · *at the outset* · *subsequently* · *following this* · *meanwhile* · *once X has been completed* · *in the final stage*. Vary the passive: passive + adverb (*is then thoroughly heated*), passive + purpose infinitive (*is pressed to remove excess water*), present perfect passive (*once the bricks have been fired, they are packed*), passive after *before* + *-ing* (*is crushed before being melted*). **Verb precision is the only LR lever a process gives you:** *extracted, quarried, crushed, ground, sieved, blended, smelted, moulded, cast, annealed, cured, packaged, distributed* — never *put in, made, done*.

Trap, documented at the top of the scale. An official process script rated **8.5** was held below 9 for one reason: its overview said only that the process had seven consecutive steps, and the examiner noted that a fuller overview naming the actual phases was needed. **Counting stages is not an overview; naming phases is.** A second script from the same pack, whose language the examiner called sophisticated and largely error-free, was **held to band 7 overall** for opening like a letter, including personal comments, and having no clear overview. Format failures cap Task Achievement independently of your English [src: official 2023 examiner comments, Task 1C].

WORKED EXAMPLE

New bottles from recycled glass: collection → sorting by colour → washing → crushing into cullet → melting with sand and soda ash → moulding → annealing → inspection and packing.

Overall, the process falls into three broad phases: the collection and preparation of used glass, its conversion into molten material and forming into new containers, and finally quality control and despatch. The sequence is linear, though the bottles it produces will eventually return to the collection stage that begins it.

Watch the word *linear* here, because §6 is about to make it load-bearing. This process is linear: it has a defined start (used glass arriving) and a defined end (packed bottles leaving). The fact that those bottles may one day be collected again is a fact about the world, not a loop drawn on the diagram. Say *ending with bottles that re-enter the same system* and you have described a cycle while calling it a line — which is exactly the contradiction §6's trap punishes. **Test: is the return arrow drawn on the diagram?** If yes, it is a cycle and §6 applies. If no, it is a line, and any return you mention belongs in a subordinate clause, not in the verb.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

There are eight stages. First the glass is collected. Then it is sorted. Then it is washed. A count where an overview should be, plus *then* repeated — mechanical cohesion, the band-6 CC definition.

6. Process diagram — natural (cycle / life cycle)

As above, but usually **cyclical** — no true end point — with a natural agent acting. The overview must state that the process is **cyclical** and name a point at which it can be said to begin. Cycle language: *the cycle begins when... · this in turn triggers · at which point · thereby completing the cycle.*

Tense and voice. Present simple. On voice, a recommendation offered as advice rather than a sourced rule: natural cycles usually read better in the **active**, because there is a genuine agent — *water evaporates, the larva hatches*. Reserve the passive for what is genuinely done to the subject (*the eggs are laid in gravel*). Blanket-passivising a cycle produces unnatural English, and unnatural collocation is what band-7 LR watches for. I have found this stated in no official document, so weigh it as a style judgement.

TRAP

Treating a cycle as a line and ending with *finally*. If it is a cycle, the last sentence returns to the start.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Life cycle of the Atlantic salmon: eggs laid in river gravel → alevins hatch → fry → smolt migrate to the sea → adults mature at sea → return upriver to spawn.

Overall, the salmon's life cycle is a continuous loop alternating between two very different environments: the fish spends its early development in fresh water and its period of growth at sea, before returning to the river of its birth to spawn and begin the cycle again.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

Finally, the salmon lays the eggs and the life cycle is finished. A cycle does not finish — and *the eggs* imports the French article where English takes a bare plural on first mention.

7. Map comparison

Two (occasionally three) plans of the same place at different dates. The task is **change**, plus what stayed the same. No figures. Structure either **by area** (north half / south half; either side of the river) — usually stronger, because the grouping is built in [expert consensus] — or **by time**, safer but risking two separate descriptions with no comparison, which fails categorisation. The overview gives the character shift (*rural* → *residential*, *industrial* → *leisure*), the biggest structural change, and the one thing untouched. Tense is set entirely by the dates: see the table above. This is the type where tense goes wrong most.

Language: *in the north* means inside the area, *to the north of* means beyond its edge — worth a mark. Then four change families — replace (*gave way to*, *was converted into*, *made way for*), add (*was constructed*, *was erected*, *appeared*), remove (*was demolished*, *was cleared*, *disappeared*), resize (*was extended*, *doubled in size*, *was scaled back*) — plus continuity (*remained unchanged*, *was retained*, *was left intact*).

TRAP

Not saying what stayed the same: band 7 asks for main trends **or differences**, and a constant is a finding. Second: assuming you cannot use compass language when no compass rose is drawn. **North is the top of the map.**

WORKED EXAMPLE

Ashcombe village in 1985 and today. 1985: farmland north of the river; a fishing harbour, cottages, a church and a primary school to the south; a ferry crossing. Today: the farmland is a housing estate; the harbour is a marina; the school has been extended; a road bridge replaces the ferry; the church is unchanged.

Overall, Ashcombe has been transformed from a working agricultural and fishing settlement into a residential and leisure-oriented village, the most far-reaching change being the loss of farmland on the north bank. The church at the centre of the old village is the one feature to have survived the period untouched.

Why present perfect passive throughout — and do not guess this. The second plan is labelled *today*, not with a date, so the change runs up to the present moment and English marks that with the present perfect: *has been transformed*, *has been extended*, *the woodland has been cleared*.

Change one word of the prompt and the whole report changes tense. Had the second plan read *2025* — two dated snapshots, both closed — you would be describing two finished moments, and the report goes into the **past simple passive** throughout: *the farmland was*

replaced by a housing estate, a road bridge was built in place of the ferry, the church was left untouched. Both versions are in the tense table above; they are different rows.

The decision procedure, three seconds: read the label on the second plan. A **date** (2025, last year, 2010) → past simple passive. An **undated present** (today, now, at present, the present day) → present perfect passive. A **future or proposed** plan (*proposed, planned*) → modal passive, *will be constructed*. Never infer "today" from the fact that a date is recent — 2025 is a date, and this book is being read in 2026.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

In 1985 there was a farmland in the north. Today there is a housing estate in the north. In 1985 there was a harbour... Two parallel descriptions, no change verbs, and *a farmland* where English takes no article.

8. Mixed / multiple charts

Two different visuals on a related theme — a pie plus a bar chart, a line graph plus a table. Sanctioned by the format page's "one or more graphs, charts or tables" [src: ielts.org Academic Writing format page]. The mistake is writing two mini-reports; the band-7 move is **one integrated overview covering both visuals** [expert consensus: IELTS Simon], then one body paragraph per visual, with at least one sentence that **links** them. Use whatever tense each visual requires — switching between paragraphs is correct here, provided it switches for a reason.

TRAP

Time, and invented causation. Two visuals in twenty minutes means *fewer figures per visual*, not more words. You may point out that two figures correspond; you may **not** say one caused the other.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A line graph of national electricity consumption 2000–2020, plus a pie chart of generation sources in 2020.

Overview: Overall, national electricity consumption rose by roughly a third over the two decades, while by the end of the period the country drew more than half of its supply from just two sources. Renewables, though still a minority share in 2020, accounted for a larger slice than any single fossil fuel.

Link, in body 2: The steep growth in demand shown in the graph therefore had to be met from a supply mix that remained heavily concentrated: the two leading sources together supplied 54 per cent of output.

"Had to be met from" states a relationship visible in the data and claims no cause.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

Two overviews, one per chart, and no sentence that mentions both.

9. Static diagram — an object, a device, or an event

This is the type nobody prepares for, and the rubric names it explicitly. The format page lists *"a diagram of an object, device, process or event"* [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic format: Writing, fetched 2026-07-31], and the assessment criteria list *"a diagram, graph, table, chart, map or other visual input"* [src: ielts.org — Writing key assessment criteria PDF, p.2, fetched 2026-07-31]. *Object* and *device* sit alongside *process* as separate items. So a diagram need not be a sequence.

What it looks like. Any of these, and they behave the same way:

- **Two designs of the same thing** side by side — two kinds of pump, two roof constructions, two styles of bridge, an old and a new version of a tool. This is the commonest shape.
- **One labelled artefact**, cut away or exploded, with its parts named — a cross-section of a wall, the inside of a machine, the layout of a building.
- **A diagram of an event or an arrangement** — how something is set out at a single moment, with no before and after.

How to recognise it in three seconds. Two absences, both decisive:

- **No time axis.** There are no dates, no years, no *before/after* pair. Therefore **not one verb from the trend toolkit is legal here** — no *rose*, no *fell*, no *increased*, no *remained stable*, no degree adverbs. Writing *the second design increased the number of moving parts* is a TA accuracy error, because the diagram shows no change; it shows a difference. This is the single most likely way to lose marks on this type, because the trend toolkit is your default.
- **No sequence.** Nothing happens first and nothing happens last. Therefore the process apparatus is wrong too: *initially · subsequently · once X has been completed · in the final stage* all invent an order the diagram does not contain. A reader can start anywhere on a static diagram, which is exactly what makes it static.

What it demands instead: comparison of features. The fixed instruction has not changed — *summarise the information by selecting and reporting the main features, and make comparisons where relevant*. And the criteria document is explicit that the comparison requirement is not limited to numbers: Task Achievement assesses *"comparing or contrasting the information by adequately highlighting the identifiable trends, principal changes or differences in the data and other inputs (rather than mechanical description reporting detail)"* [src: ielts.org — Writing key assessment criteria PDF, p.2, fetched 2026-07-31]. *Differences* and *other inputs* are what you are being marked on. **Grouping is still the band-7 gate**, exactly as it is everywhere else in this chapter; the only thing that changes is what you group *by*.

Structure. The same four paragraphs, and still no conclusion.

Paragraph	Content
Introduction	One sentence, your own words: what the diagram shows, and — if there are two — that they are alternative designs of the same thing.
Overview	The organising difference, no part-by-part detail. For two objects: the one structural distinction everything else follows from. For one object: its two or three main divisions, and what the whole thing is for.
Body 1	One functional group, across both objects — not one object.
Body 2	The second functional group, across both.

Group by function or component system, never object by object. Writing all of object A and then all of object B is this type's version of "list, don't group": it produces two descriptions and no comparison, which is precisely the categorisation failure band 7 tests for. Useful groupings: *structure / power source / user interface; what it is made of / how it is held together; the part above ground / the part below; the parts that move / the parts that do not.*

Tense: present simple, and mostly active. A device *has* parts and its parts *do* things, in a permanent present: *the handle pivots, the filter traps sediment*. Reserve the passive for what is genuinely done to the object by someone else — *the frame is welded at the joints, the cylinder is sealed with a rubber gasket*. If the diagram is dated to the past, or shows a historical artefact or a past event, switch the whole report to past simple and say so in the introduction.

The language, and there are three sets of it.

Parts and what they do — the LR lever on a figure-free task, exactly as verb precision is on a process: *consists of · comprises (no of) · is made up of · is fitted with · is mounted on · houses · is encased in · serves to · functions as · acts as · is responsible for · allows the water to pass · prevents heat from escaping · draws · channels · supports · secures · seals · absorbs · traps.*

Spatial relationships — worth real marks, because most candidates own five of these and repeat them: *at the base · at the upper end · directly beneath · immediately above · adjacent to · alongside · at either end · running the length of · on the underside · at right angles to · flush with · set into · protruding from · vertically · horizontally · at the centre*. Note the same distinction the maps section makes: *in the upper section* means inside it, *above the section* means beyond it.

Comparison between two objects — the sentences that actually earn the band: *whereas · by contrast · unlike the first design · in place of · the equivalent component in the second design · a comparable function is performed by · both designs share · neither design · the chief difference lies in · the second design dispenses with the X found in the first · where the first uses X, the second uses Y.*

Trap one — the label inventory. Walking round the diagram naming every label in the order your eye happens to meet them. It is fluent, it is accurate, it covers everything, and it is a band-5 answer: "*mechanical description reporting detail*" is the criteria document's own phrase for what it is not looking for. A labelled diagram routinely carries more labels than 170–190 words can hold, so **you must leave some out** — and the ones you keep must be grouped. Selection is a band-7 virtue here for exactly the reason it is on a table: coverage is cheap, categorisation is not.

Trap two – commentary. With no numbers to report, the temptation is to explain which design is better, why it was invented, or what it costs. All three are outside the visual, and Task 1 relates *narrowly to the factual content* of the input, not to speculative explanation. You may say the second design has fewer moving parts. You may not say it is therefore more reliable, unless the diagram labels it so.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Two designs of a hand-operated well pump used to raise drinking water in rural areas. Design A, a lever pump: a pivoting handle above ground drives a piston up and down inside a sealed cylinder sunk in the well; a foot valve at the base of the rising main holds the water column; the outlet is a short spout below the handle. Design B, a rope pump: a hand-turned wheel above ground draws a continuous loop of rope, fitted at intervals with rubber washers, up through a narrow pipe; the rope runs over a guide block at the bottom of the well and back down; the water leaves at a spout beside the wheel.

Overall, the two pumps perform the same task by fundamentally different means: design A lifts water intermittently with a piston in a sealed cylinder, whereas design B lifts it continuously on a moving loop of rope. Almost all of design B's moving parts sit above ground, while design A's are submerged.

Fifty-one words – counted, not estimated. Both objects held inside one sentence, the organising difference named first, a second grouped difference named after it, **and not one trend verb, not one figure and not one sequencer**. That is what categorisation looks like when there is no data to categorise: you group by *mechanism* and then by *position*, and the two groupings become your two body paragraphs. Body 1 would take the lifting mechanism in both designs; body 2 would take the parts above ground – the drive, the outlet and the access for repair – again in both.

BAND-6 MISTAKE

✗ There is a handle at the top of design A. Under the handle there is a cylinder. Inside the cylinder there is a piston. There is also a valve at the bottom and a spout. In design B there is a wheel at the top. There is a rope with washers. There is a guide block at the bottom. There is a spout.

Every label present, nothing selected, nothing grouped, no comparison, and *there is/there are* eight times – the restricted range band-6 LR describes and the mechanical description the criteria document names under TA. The repair is not more vocabulary; it is one decision made before writing: **what are my two groups, and what is the one difference the overview will state?**

Tips & tricks

Ranked by band impact for a candidate currently around 6.0.

1. **Write a real overview, and make it categorise.** [verified] The ladder: no overview → band 6 is unavailable, because band 6 requires that a relevant overview be *attempted*, so **TA is capped at 5**. Attempted but vague, or a mere count → **TA 6**. Clear, data grouped, trends named → **TA 7**. A two-band swing on a quarter of the task, bought with two sentences and ninety seconds [src: May 2023 descriptors, Task 1 TA bands 5–7].
2. **Group, don't list.** [verified] One habit damages four criteria: a full list fails categorisation (TA), forces repetitive sentence patterns (GRA range), forces the same nouns and verbs (LR range, CC repetition), and burns words on mid-range data so the notable features go unillustrated.
3. **Never copy a word of the prompt — including the chart title.** [verified] Struck out before counting, and it costs you on LR.
4. **Decide the tense before you write.** [verified] Five seconds prevents a systematic error across 180 words.
5. **Count your clean sentences after every drill.** [expert consensus – derived] The descriptor wording is official: band 7 GRA requires error-free sentences to be *frequent*, band 8 requires the *majority*. The **number** is not — no official source quantifies *frequent*. So the honest derivation is that band 7 sits **below** a majority: a working target of **four sentences in ten completely clean, rising to five**, with anything consistently above half reading as band-8 evidence rather than band-7. Nine sentences with three clean is a band 6, however ambitious the other six. [Chapter 8](#) §How accurate is "accurate enough"? owns this reasoning; the same number is used there and in [Chapter 5](#).
6. **Train reference and substitution.** [verified] Band 7 CC names them explicitly; band 6 says they lack flexibility. *This shift · the former · the latter · both · those · doing so · the remaining two categories*. Almost nobody drills this; it is the fastest CC upgrade available.
7. **Aim for 170–190 words.** [expert consensus] The buffer absorbs anything discounted and satisfies the demand for sufficient detail.
8. **Approximate rather than guess off an unlabelled axis.** [verified] *Just over 40,000 · in the region of 200 · some 15 per cent · upwards of half* protect TA accuracy and add free LR range — but rotate them, because *approximately* six times is the restricted range band-6 LR describes. Warning: *nearly, almost, just under* mean **below**; *just over, well over, upwards of* mean **above**. The wrong side is an accuracy error, not a preference.
9. **Match the intensity of the word to the size of the change.** [verified] *Plummeted* for a 3% fall is a TA accuracy error as well as an LR imprecision.
10. **Say what did not change.** [expert consensus] A flat series and an unaltered building are both main features.
11. **Alternate the two grammatical shapes** — verb+adverb and there+be+adjective+noun. [expert consensus] Cheapest GRA range win here.
12. **On computer, check the counter at the end of your overview.** [verified] You should be at 55–70 words. At 100, your overview has figures in it.

Myths that hold you back

"Memorise a template", "open with 'The given graph illustrates...'", "copy the prompt to save words". One family, one mechanism. Band 4 LR explicitly names the inappropriate use of memorised phrases, formulaic language and language taken from the input material [src: May 2023 descriptors, band 4 LR]. Copied rubric is discounted before counting *and* evidences an inability to paraphrase. And a template cannot adapt — applied to a map or a process it produces format errors, and format errors cap TA, documented on an official script whose language was excellent and which was still held to band 7.

"Use as many linking words as possible." Band 6 CC is *defined* by cohesion that is faulty or mechanical through misuse, overuse or omission; band 7 still names *some over- or under-use*; and only at **band 9** does cohesion stop attracting attention altogether. **Nothing anywhere in the grid rewards quantity.** Examiners flagged overuse at band 6 *and* still flagged some overuse of sequencers on a script rated 7.5 [src: May 2023 descriptors, bands 6, 7 and 9 CC; official 2023 examiner comments].

"Use impressive vocabulary wherever possible." Band 6 LR explicitly covers the risk-taker who reaches wider and gets it wrong. The descriptor tells you outright that thesaurus-reaching does not buy band 7 — precision and collocation do.

"Explain why the trend happened", "give an opinion at the end". Officially excluded: the task relates narrowly to factual content, not to speculative explanation outside the data. Causal speculation is irrelevant content, a limiting feature at band 6, and it spends words you needed for figures. An official script was penalised on format partly for personal comments.

"Write a conclusion paragraph." Redundant with the overview and usually pure restatement — repetition is a named weakness at bands 5 and 6. Legitimate only if you deliberately placed the overview at the end.

"Describe every data point so you don't miss anything." Coverage is a band-5 virtue; selection is a band-7 one.

"Longer is better — write 300 words." No upper limit and no length reward, but a hard sixty-minute budget and a Task 2 worth double. More words also means more error opportunities, and band-7 GRA is judged on the *frequency* of clean sentences.

"Use the passive everywhere in a process." Sound for man-made processes; questionable for natural cycles, where there is a genuine agent — flagged in §6 as a style judgement, not a sourced rule.

"Use increase/decrease for any chart." Only where there is a time axis. On a categorical bar chart or undated table, *increase* is factually wrong — an imprecision under LR **and** an accuracy error under TA.

"A missing overview means you cannot get band 7." Half-true, and the naive version misleads. Missing the overview caps **Task Achievement** at 5; it does not cap the overall band. An official sample script with no clear overview was rated **band 7 overall**, carried there by CC, LR and GRA at band 8–9 level [src: official 2023 examiner comments, Task 1C]. State the cap, not the absolute. For a candidate whose other criteria sit at 6–7 the cap still makes an overall 7 arithmetically unreachable, so the practical advice is unchanged. Note also that the band-5 TA cell describes a script showing *a tendency to focus on details without referring to the bigger picture* — an overview-less script in all but the word; the word *overview* itself does not appear at band 5. So the common claim that no overview means **below** band 5 is wrong, but say it by paraphrase, not by claiming the descriptor uses the term.

"An overview just says how many categories or stages there are." Documented as insufficient by an official examiner on a script rated **8.5**: the count was not enough, the phases had to be summarised.

"There's a fixed penalty of X bands for going under 150 words." No such rule exists in any current official document. You may read about an automatic band-5 penalty on Task Achievement; that is reported only by ex-examiner blogs, is said to have been withdrawn around 2018, and appears in no official IELTS publication. Treat it as unverified history, not policy — the real mechanism is above.

"Bullet points are fine for a process, since it's a list of stages." Explicitly penalisable: bullet points anywhere in the response, and note form, are named in the official assessment criteria [src: Key Assessment Criteria PDF p.1].

Band descriptor decoder

Restated in my own words from the **May 2023** Task 1 descriptors [src: ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/ielts-writing-band-descriptors.pdf, created 2023-05-03, pp. 3-5]; one short official phrase quoted per criterion, everything else paraphrase. **Each criterion runs bands 8 down to 5**, because your baseline is undiagnosed and a first drill can land at 5.5 — a decoder that stops at 6 leaves you without the language for what you actually wrote. Find your own script in the rows first, then

work upward. If you find a descriptor PDF whose band-7 TA line reads "presents a clear overview of main trends, differences or stages", you have the superseded 2013 edition — close it.

Task Achievement

- **8** — All requirements covered appropriately, relevantly, in depth. Key features chosen skilfully, made prominent and illustrated. Occasional omissions.
- **7** — Requirements covered; content relevant and accurate with at most a few omissions; format right; chosen features clearly foregrounded, though they could be illustrated further. And for Academic: a clear overview, "**the data are appropriately categorised**", main trends or differences identified.
- **6** — Focused on the task, format appropriate, features given adequate prominence, information selected and supported with figures, and an overview *attempted* and relevant. But some detail may be irrelevant, inappropriate or inaccurate, and some missing or excessive.
- **5** — The task's requirements are *generally* addressed; format may be inappropriate in places. Selected key features are **not adequately covered** and the recounting of detail is **mainly mechanical**; there may be a tendency to focus on details *without referring to the bigger picture*; irrelevant or inaccurate material in key areas detracts; limited detail when extending and illustrating. This row also carries the page's **one bolded clause** — "*There may be no data to support the description*" — and the PDF's legend reserves bold for negative features that limit a rating.

Why band 5 is printed here. Your baseline is undiagnosed, and a first drill can land at 5.5. Read the band-5 row as the description of a *list*: features covered mechanically, detail without the bigger picture. That is the answer this whole chapter is built to stop you writing, and recognising it in your own script is worth more than admiring band 8.

The 6→7 gate — three things, all required: the overview must be **clear**, not merely attempted; the data must be **categorised**; the main trends or differences must be **named**, not left for the reader to infer.

✗ **6.** *In 1990 walking was 13 million and car was 4 million. In 2000 walking was 9 million and car was 8 million. In 2010 walking was 6 million and car was 11 million.*

✓ **7.** *Overall, the two dominant modes exchanged places over the period: car travel rose steadily throughout while walking declined by a comparable margin, so that by 2010 the ranking of 1990 had been reversed. The remaining two modes changed far less.*

Same data — now grouped, the trend named, the relationship stated. Nothing rare.

Coherence & Cohesion

- **8** — The message can be followed **with ease**. Information and ideas logically presented and sequenced, cohesion **well managed**, paragraphing sufficient and appropriate; occasional

lapses allowed. (*Cohesion that "very rarely attracts attention" and a message followed "effortlessly" are band 9, not band 8 – a distinction worth holding, because aiming at band 9 invisibility is aiming a band higher than you need.*)

- **7** – Logical organisation, clear progression throughout, at most a few lapses. A range of cohesive devices – **including reference and substitution** – used flexibly, though with some inaccuracy or some over- or under-use.
- **6** – Generally coherent, progression clear, devices working to some good effect, but cohesion within or between sentences may be **"faulty or mechanical"**, and reference and substitution may lack flexibility, producing repetition or error.
- **5** – Organisation is evident but not wholly logical, and overall progression may be lacking, though an underlying coherence survives. The relationship of ideas can be followed, but the sentences are **not fluently linked** to each other. Cohesive devices may be limited or overused, with some inaccuracy, and the writing may be repetitive because reference and substitution are inadequate or inaccurate.

Note what separates 5 from 6 here, because it is not the number of linkers: at 6 the progression is *clear*, at 5 it is merely *underlying*. Adding *moreover* to a band-5 script does not move it; ordering the paragraphs so the reader never has to work out why one follows another does.

The 6→7 gate – two moves, and nobody makes the second. Stop bolting a connector onto every sentence; and **use reference and substitution**, which band 7 names.

✗ **6.** *Firstly, car use increased from 4 to 11 million. Moreover, walking decreased from 13 to 6 million. Furthermore, cycling decreased from 4 to 2 million. In addition, bus use decreased from 7 to 5 million.*

✓ **7.** *Car use more than doubled over the period, climbing from 4 to 11 million trips. Walking moved in the opposite direction, falling from 13 million to 6 million – a decline almost exactly matching the growth in car travel. The two remaining modes followed the same downward path, though far less steeply: cycling halved to 2 million and bus use slipped from 7 to 5 million.*

Four bolted-on connectors have become zero. In their place: contrast expressed lexically (*the opposite direction*), reference (*the two remaining modes, the same downward path*), substitution (*a decline* standing in for a whole clause).

Lexical Resource

- **8** – A wide resource used fluently and flexibly for precise meaning within the task's scope; uncommon and idiomatic items handled skilfully, occasional inaccuracy.
- **7** – Resource sufficient for some flexibility and precision; some ability with less common items; **"an awareness of style and collocation is evident"**, though inappropriacies occur; a few spelling or word-formation errors that do not detract.
- **6** – Generally adequate and appropriate; meaning clear despite a fairly restricted range or imprecise word choice; a risk-taker shows more range but more inaccuracy; some spelling and word-formation errors that do not impede.

- **5** — The resource is **limited but minimally adequate**. Simple vocabulary may be accurate, but the range does not permit much variation in expression; there may be frequent lapses in appropriacy of word choice, and inflexibility shows in frequent simplification or repetition. Spelling and word-formation errors may be **noticeable and may cause the reader some difficulty**.

The 5→6 step is about *impeding*: at 6 the errors do not impede communication, at 5 they cause the reader difficulty. The trend toolkit and the six word families above are the whole difference on a Task 1 report.

The 6→7 gate: precision and collocation, not rarity. Note the scope hedge the 2023 wording adds at bands 7–9 — precision is judged *within the scope of the task*. Task 1 has a narrow lexical field: you are not expected to produce essay vocabulary, only **accurate data vocabulary**. The six word families above are most of it.

✗ **6.** *The number of car users augmented significantly, whereas the number of people who use the walk decreased strongly. In the other hand, the cycling had a important diminution.*

Eight problems in twenty-eight words, and they do not all land on the same criterion — which is the point of counting them this way:

- **Six against LR:** *augmented* (French *augmenter*), *significantly* (not an English word), *use the walk* and *decreased strongly* (both wrong collocations), *in the other hand* (the fixed phrase is *on the other hand*), *diminution* (French register).
- **Two against GRA:** *a important* — determiner choice is grammar, not vocabulary — and ***the cycling, the generic article on an abstract noun, which is your single highest-frequency error and is sitting in the middle of this sentence. It is easy to miss precisely because it looks harmless. Chapters 7 and 8 both file article errors under GRA*****; this chapter follows them.

There is a ninth fault the error list does not name because it is not a word choice at all: *who use the walk* is present simple inside a past-simple sentence. Tense clashes inside a relative clause are the commonest way a Task 1 report loses its tense discipline after the first paragraph.

✓ **7.** *Car use rose sharply, whereas the number of journeys made on foot fell steeply over the same period. Cycling, by contrast, saw only a marginal decline.*

Not one rare word — common items in **correct collocation**. That is band-7 LR.

Grammatical Range & Accuracy

- **8** — A wide range of structures within the task's scope, used flexibly and accurately; most sentences error-free; punctuation well handled.
- **7** — A variety of complex structures with some flexibility and accuracy; grammar and punctuation generally well controlled and **"error-free sentences are frequent"**; a few errors that do not impede communication.

- **6** — A mix of simple and complex forms, limited flexibility, and **complex structures noticeably less accurate than simple ones**; errors occur but rarely impede.
- **5** — The range of structures is **limited and rather repetitive**. Complex sentences are *attempted* but tend to be **faulty**, and the greatest accuracy is achieved on simple ones. Grammatical errors may be **frequent and cause the reader some difficulty**, and punctuation may be faulty.

Read bands 6 and 5 as one continuum and the diagnosis is easy. At 5 your complex sentences are *faulty*; at 6 they are merely *less accurate than your simple ones*; at 7 they are as accurate as your simple ones. Your position on that ladder is decided by the four low-risk structures below — whether you can run them without breaking them, not whether you know harder ones.

The 6→7 gate — two independent things, both required. (1) Around **four sentences in ten completely error-free**, rising to five — see tip 5 for why this is a derived working number and not an official one. (2) Complex sentences as accurate as simple ones — band 6 is *defined* by the gap between them. The fix is not more complexity; it is complexity you can control. Four low-risk structures do the whole job:

Structure	Example
Non-defining relative clause	<i>Car use, which had been the least common mode in 1990, became the most common by 2010.</i>
Participle clause after a main clause	<i>Numbers climbed steadily, peaking at 11 million in 2010.</i>
Fronted adverbial	Over the same period , walking fell by more than half.
Concessive subordinator	Although bus use declined, it remained the second most common mode.

✗ **6.** *The peoples who travelled by car was increase during this period, and the number of childrens walking to school it decrease a lot, and this is a big change between the two years and we can see it in the chart.*

One forty-word run-on joined twice by *and*; *peoples*, *childrens*, *was increase*, resumptive *it*, plus commentary that adds nothing.

✓ **7.** *The number of children travelling by car rose over the period, while the number walking to school fell substantially. This reversal, which took place gradually rather than abruptly, was the most striking change in the chart.*

Two sentences, and four structures: a participle clause modifying a noun (*travelling by car*, *walking to school* — see §The trend toolkit for what a participle clause is), **ellipsis** (*the number walking* leaves *of children* unwritten because the reader can supply it), a subordinator (*while*), and a non-defining relative clause. Both error-free.

An earlier draft of this model read *while those walking to school fell* — and it was wrong. *Those* is a substitution item, so it has to stand in for something already on the page, and the only candidate is *the number*, which is singular. It also produces a claim the chart cannot support: numbers fall, children do not. Tip 6 is right that substitution is worth marks, but the rule that comes with it is **every substitute must have exactly one possible antecedent**. When it does not, ellipsis is the safer device and costs the same number of words.

YOUR L1 — ARABIC / FRENCH

L1 alert — French and Arabic in Task 1

Task 1 is dense with **numbers, articles, prepositions and comparatives** — exactly where French transfer lives, and where Arabic definiteness habits compound it.

1. Articles. French keeps the article on general and abstract nouns; English drops it: ~~the car use increased~~ → **car use** · ~~the tourism grew~~ → **tourism** · ~~the electricity consumption fell~~ → **electricity consumption** · ~~the people prefer cars~~ → **people prefer cars** · ~~the cycling declined~~ → **cycling declined**.

But the error is never *the by itself* — it is *the on a bare generic*. The moment the noun is made specific, English wants the article back, and a defining relative clause is one of the things that makes it specific. So *the people **who travelled by bus* is correct English in a Task 1 report: the clause says *which* people — the ones in the chart. Compare the pair and the rule is visible:

~~The people prefer cars.~~ → ✓ *People prefer cars.* (bare generic — no article) ✓ *The people who travelled by bus outnumbered cyclists three to one in 1990.* (specified by the clause — the article is required)

Chapter 8 gives the full trigger list — an *of*-phrase, a defining relative clause, a superlative, an ordinal, a date, or previous mention — and the decision procedure that goes with it. Task 1 also *demand*s the article in fixed frames, and over-correction costs as much: **the** number of · **the** proportion of · **the** percentage of · **the** amount of · **the** figure for · **the** majority of · **the** remainder — and superlatives (*walking was the highest*). Drill sentence, three different decisions: *Overall, car use rose while the number of children who walked to school fell to the lowest figure recorded*. Arabic marks definiteness heavily and doubles the pressure toward *the*: **when in doubt on a bare general noun with nothing after it, leave it out.**

2. Uncountables pluralised. The full nine-word list and the reason it never fixes itself with practice are in **Chapter 8 §The nine words**. What is specific to Task 1 is *which* uncountables the visuals hand you, and they are the industrial ones: *transport · traffic · consumption · expenditure · electricity · employment · pollution · waste* — never with -s, however many countries the chart shows. Two Task-1-only points that live nowhere else in the book:

- **Treat *data* as plural.** *The data show that...* This is not a style preference: it matches the band-7 descriptor's own wording, "*the data are appropriately categorised*".
- **Quantify with a partitive, not a plural:** *a unit of electricity, a category of expenditure* — because a table with five rows makes *expenditures* feel right, and it is not.

3. Prepositions with figures — the highest-value drill in this chapter. Every one is French transfer: invisible to you, instantly visible to an examiner.

Meaning	✓	✗
Start and end values	rose from 4 million to 11 million	<i>rose of 4 to 11</i>
Size of the change	rose by 7 million / by 40%	<i>rose of 7 million (augmenter de)</i>
Level reached	rose to 11 million	<i>rose at 11 million</i>
Peak (verb / noun)	peaked at 11 million / a peak of 11 million	<i>peaked to / a peak at</i>
Stability	remained stable at 5 million	<i>stable to 5 million</i>
Time point	in 1990 · in March · at 10 a.m.	<i>at 1990</i>
Time span	between 1990 and 2010 · over the period · for twenty years	<i>between 1990 to 2010 · during 20 years</i>
Proportion	accounted for 40% · a rise in sales	<i>accounted 40% · a rise of sales</i>
Comparison	compared with/to · twice as many as	<i>comparing to · twice more than</i>
Difference	the difference between X and Y	<i>the difference of X and Y</i>

The pair that catches nearly everyone: **rise to a level** versus **rise by an amount**. *Sales rose to 40%* and *sales rose by 40%* are different facts, and confusing them is a **TA accuracy error**, not merely a grammar slip.

4. False friends — only the five that a chart actually produces. The full annotated list is in **Chapter 8 §French: 3. False friends**; do not learn it twice. What matters here is that Task 1's narrow lexical field concentrates the damage into a handful of words you will reach for on *every* chart, so these five are worth knowing cold:

significant → **significant** (not an English word at all) · *augmented* → **rose / increased** · *diminution* → **decline / drop** · *evolution* (of a trend) → **change / trend** · *important* (of a quantity) → **substantial**, because *an important increase* is wrong in English however natural *une augmentation importante* feels.

Why these five and not the others: each one attaches to a **figure**, and Task 1 is made of figures. A false friend that costs you one word in an essay costs you four occurrences in a report.

5. Agreement traps this task manufactures. Long noun phrases separate subject from verb constantly, which is exactly when agreement fails. *The number of cars **was** but a number of cars **were**; the proportion of women **was*** (head noun *proportion*) but *the majority of respondents **were***. *People* is already plural (✗ *peoples are*, ✗ *people is*). Never stack a bare auxiliary against

a bare verb (*✗ was increase, ✗ has increase*), and keep third-person -s (*the figure rises*). Arabic copula drop: *✗ The highest figure the car use.* → ✓ **The highest figure was car use.**
 Number–noun: ✓ *five million, 20 per cent, a ten-year period* — *✗ five millions, ✗ 20 per cents, ✗ a ten-years period.*

6. Run-on sentences. The most expensive habit here: four series invites one enormous comma-and-*and* chain, and band-7 GRA is measured by the *frequency* of error-free sentences, so a single sixty-word run-on destroys what four clean short sentences would have earned. Arabic preference for coordination compounds the French pattern; English Task 1 wants subordination.

✗ In 1990 the walking was the most used mode with 13 million and after that it decreased a lot until 6 million in 2010, and in the other hand the car increased from 4 to 11 million and became the first mode, and this is the biggest change of the chart.

✓ *In 1990, walking was the most common mode, at 13 million trips, but it had fallen to 6 million by 2010. Car travel moved in the opposite direction, climbing from 4 to 11 million to become the leading mode. This exchange of positions was the chart's most striking feature.*

Rule of thumb: if a sentence contains more than one figure-pair and more than one *and*, split it.

7. Register borrowed from French academic writing. *In the other hand* → **on the other hand** · *In a first time* → **initially** · *We can see that / We remark that* → drop it, or **the chart shows that** · *It is to be noted that* → **notably** · *In conclusion* on a Task 1 → don't. First person (*I, we*) is out of register for an Academic report.

Self-test checklist

Run this on every drill, before looking at any model answer. Any "no" is the fix.

1. Is my introduction **one sentence**, in my own words, with **no** phrase lifted from the prompt or the chart title?
2. Does my second paragraph begin with *Overall* and contain a **general statement**, not a figure?
3. Does the overview **group** the data into categories rather than naming items one at a time?
4. Does the overview **name the trend or difference** in words?
5. If it is a process, does the overview name the **phases** rather than count the stages? If a cycle, does it say the process is cyclical? If it is a **static diagram**, is the report grouped by **function or component across both objects**, rather than all of object A followed by all of object B — and have I left some labels out?
6. Are my body paragraphs built on the **same groups** the overview announced?
7. Have I checked whether the visual has a **time axis**, and used trend verbs *only* if it does?

8. Is my tense right for the visual type, and consistent except where the data genuinely change time frame?
 9. Have I said what **did not change**?
 10. Is every figure **correct**, and is every degree adverb proportionate to the change it describes?
 11. Have I used at least **two reference or substitution items** instead of repeating full noun phrases?
 12. Does any paragraph contain **three or more** bolted-on connectors? If yes, delete two.
 13. Have I used **both** grammatical shapes — verb+adverb *and* there+be+adjective+noun?
 14. Counting only my own words, am I between **170 and 190**?
 15. Sentence by sentence: are **at least four in ten** completely error-free (tip 5), and is any sentence over about forty words?
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CHAPTER 5

5 Writing Task 2: Every Question Family Mastered

WHAT IT IS WORTH

Two thirds of Writing

WHY IT MATTERS

Worth double Task 1 — and Writing is
your weakest paper.

FULL READ

~53 min

60-second summary

Read this first. It is at the top of the chapter deliberately: this is the highest-value page in the book, and everything after it is the evidence behind one of these lines.

Task 2 is two thirds of your Writing band, and Writing is your weakest paper. Of six official examiner-marked scripts from band 4 to 8.5, **not one was capped for weak ideas** — they were capped for paragraphing, grammatical control, copied rubric, spelling and length. Spend your ninety minutes there.

Find the final instruction line and count the demands. Write one body paragraph per demand. **If a prompt has two parts and you answer one, ielts.org states the outcome in its own words: "If you don't discuss both, you will be limited to Band 5."** [src: ielts.org — Writing test resources, verbatim, fetched 2026-07-31]. That is the cheapest band in the test to lose and the cheapest to keep.

Paraphrase the prompt properly: copied rubric earns nothing, counts as evidence that you cannot paraphrase, and should be assumed not to count toward your 250 words.

The four-move body paragraph — claim → because → so what → instance. This is the single most actionable thing in the chapter and it is the official gloss on Task Response, not a teaching trick: ielts.org defines *extension* as going into more detail and *support* as giving examples. Two ideas built this way, not four asserted ones. Band 6 states ideas; band 7 extends and supports them.

Aim for 270–290 words. There is a floor, not a ceiling — an official 7.5 exemplar runs to about 375 words and nobody mentioned it. And since the grid contains no rating-limiting feature anywhere above band 5, under-length carries no tariff; it carries a mechanism. Too short means undeveloped, and undeveloped is what the examiner marks.

Concede once, then counter. **Hedge** every generalisation — hedging means softening a claim so that it is defensible rather than asserting it flat: *most people* instead of *everyone*, *tends to* instead of *does*. An examiner credited *tend to* and *appears to be* as higher-level lexis, and hedging also kills band 7's named weakness, the tendency to over-generalise.

Cap discourse markers at about two per paragraph but never zero — one official script was docked for overuse, another for underuse. Replace the rest with reference and substitution, which band 7 names explicitly. Four or five paragraphs, blank line between each.

Then spend three minutes on four mechanical passes: articles before abstract nouns, pluralised uncountables, comma splices, third-person *-s*. Those four are your systematic errors, and *systematic* is the word that decides whether errors merely cost you or cap you.

This is the most important chapter in the book, and the arithmetic says so. [ielts.org](#) states that Task 1 is worth a third of your Writing mark and Task 2 two thirds [\[src: ielts.org — Writing test resources\]](#); the format page puts it the other way round, that Task 2 contributes twice as much as Task 1 [\[src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Writing test format\]](#). Writing is also the weakest paper for both of your language backgrounds: in the official 2024–25 data, Arabic-L1 candidates averaged 5.540 on Academic Writing and French-L1 candidates 6.152. Half a band gained here is worth a full band gained on Task 1.

Carry one fact through the whole chapter. Six officially awarded Task 2 scripts have published examiner commentary attached, spanning bands 4 to 8.5 [\[src: ielts.org — Academic Writing sample tasks 2023 PDF; CD sample responses PDF\]](#). **Not one was capped for lacking impressive ideas.** The named limiting factors were paragraphing, grammatical control, copied rubric, spelling and length. Your ideas are almost certainly good enough. Your organisation and your error density are what hold the band down — and both are mechanical, and both are trainable in weeks.

What the test actually asks

Every Academic Task 2 has the same skeleton: a statement or situation, one or two questions about it, then two fixed lines — give reasons for your answer and include any relevant examples from your own knowledge or experience, and write at least 250 words [\[src: ielts.org — sample tasks 2023 PDF, pp6–7\]](#).

Time	About 40 minutes of the 60-minute Writing paper
Length	At least 250 words ; no upper limit is published anywhere
Style	"Academic or semi-formal/neutral" [src: ielts.org — Writing test format]
Form	Continuous prose. No sub-headings or bullet points; note form is penalisable anywhere in the response [src: ielts.org — Writing test resources; Key assessment criteria PDF, p.1]
Criteria	Task Response · Coherence and Cohesion · Lexical Resource · Grammatical Range and Accuracy — four, equally weighted inside the task. The four names come from the Key assessment criteria PDF, p.1; the equal weighting is stated elsewhere and is quoted in Chapter 1 [src: ielts.org — Understanding and setting IELTS scores: "The criteria are weighted equally and the score on the task is the average"]
Marking	Each task assessed independently; a strong Task 1 cannot lift Task 2 [src: same]
Plagiarism	Scripts may be penalised if partly or wholly plagiarised [src: same]

Computer-delivered	Live word counter on screen; you may start from either task [src: ielts.idp.com — How computer-delivered IELTS works]
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Officially, Task Response asks you to form and develop a position on the prompt in a minimum of 250 words, with ideas supported by evidence — and the criteria document says outright that examples may be drawn from your own experience [src: Key assessment criteria PDF, p.2]. Five things are judged: how fully you respond, how well main ideas are **extended** and **supported**, how relevant they are, how clearly you establish a position and reach conclusions, and whether the format is appropriate [src: same, p.3].

Two of those words carry the chapter, and ielts.org defines them: **extension** is adding greater detail and depth to an idea; **support** is relevant examples, which may come from your own knowledge or experience; and **no specialist knowledge is required** [src: ielts.org — Writing test resources]. Band 6 states ideas. Band 7 extends and supports them. That distinction is worth more to you than any vocabulary list in this book.

The band-5 cap most candidates walk into. This is not an inference and it is not a teacher's rule of thumb. ielts.org's Writing test resources page says it in these words:

"If you don't discuss both, you will be limited to Band 5."

[src: ielts.org — Writing test resources, quoted verbatim from the live page, fetched 2026-07-31]. Take it as the published fact it is, and note that the same page states verbatim two other things this chapter relies on: *"Task 1 is worth a third of your overall mark for Writing. Task 2 is worth two thirds"*, and *"You can 'extend' your ideas by going into more detail and you can 'support' them by giving examples."*

The grid corroborates the band-5 sentence independently: the band-5 Task Response cell describes main parts that are *incompletely* addressed, and that phrase is set in **bold**, which the PDF's own legend reserves for negative features that limit a rating [src: ielts.org — Writing band descriptors PDF, p.8]. Two sources, one rule. Band 6 tolerates *uneven* coverage; band 5 is where a part is left incomplete. Unevenness costs you the 7; absence costs you the 6.

Length: a floor, and no ceiling

Only one arithmetic threshold is published: responses of 20 words or fewer are rated band 1 in all four criteria. Under-length is also named as a cause at band 3 — lexical resource inadequate because the response is significantly under length, and length insufficient to show control of sentence forms [src: descriptors PDF, p.9]. No deduction for being under 250 is published anywhere.

Here is the structural evidence, and you can check it yourself. The descriptor PDF carries its own legend: *"Bolded text indicates negative features that will limit a rating."* So extract the bold runs from the Task 2 descriptor pages **by font name**, not by eye, and see where they land. They land at bands 5, 4, 3, 2, 1 and 0. **There is not one bolded negative feature at bands 6, 7, 8 or 9** [src: descriptors PDF, pp.7-9, bold extracted by font].

Three details make the extraction reproducible, and one of them is a trap:

- **Page 7** carries bands 9, 8 and 7 and contains **zero** bolded negative features.
- **Page 8** carries bands 6, 5 and 4, and its only two bolds — *"incompletely addressed"* and *"Paragraphing may be inadequate or missing"* — both belong to the **band-5** row. This is the trap: the band labels are **vertically centred** in their cells, so a bold phrase can sit level with the 6 label while belonging to the row beneath it. Read the row boundaries, not the vertical position of the number.
- **Page 9** (bands 4 to 0) is dense with them.

There is no tariff waiting at the top of the scale. There is a *mechanism*: 190 words cannot contain two extended and supported ideas, so the examiner marks the missing development, not the missing words.

Cambridge is two-handed about this, and you should see both hands. The same FAQ document answers *"Will I be penalised if I don't write enough words?"* with *"There is no direct penalty for writing fewer than 150 words for the Task 1 question and 250 words for the Task 2 question. However, writing fewer words may impact on the range of ideas and evidence produced and may therefore affect your score"* — and, a page earlier in the same document, prints a flat instruction in its Writing **Don't list: "Don't write less than the required number of words"** [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module (PDF), pp. 7–8, fetched 2026-07-31]. Quote only the permissive half and Cambridge looks more relaxed than it is; quote only the prohibition and you have invented a tariff. **Neither sentence is a deduction, and the two together say exactly what the grid says:** going short is a real mistake, and Cambridge names the place it is marked — the *range of ideas and evidence produced*. That is Task Response first, with Lexical Resource and Grammatical Range following, because a short script simply shows the examiner less of either. A mechanism, not a subtraction.

Official commentary on a computer-delivered script of roughly 198 words does exactly that. The examiner notes the position is clear and the ideas relevant, observes that they need further development, then frames the shortfall as *room for further development* — headroom unused, not a deduction. The rating was 5.5, not a forced 5 [src: CD sample responses PDF, p.4]. At the other end, the official band **7.5** exemplar in the same pack runs to roughly 375 words and its length drew no comment at all [src: same, p.5]; British Council's practice page says aim for about 250 and do not be afraid of going a little over [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Academic Writing practice test Task 2]. Any advice about a hard ceiling of 300 or 320 words is invented.

Your target: 270–290 words, hard floor 260 — not because 250 is penalised, but because two properly developed ideas do not fit inside 250, and because of the next section. The real constraint on length is not a word count; it is how much you can still check.

Copied rubric: the most expensive shortcut in the test

Three independent official statements converge. The band-1 Task Response cell states that any copied rubric must be discounted [src: descriptors PDF, p.9]. An examiner noted that the first five lines of one official script were directly copied rubric and that no credit is given for copied rubric; that

script was rated 5.5 [src: sample tasks 2023 PDF, p.24]. British Council tells candidates not to copy entire sentences from the question because they earn no marks [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Test day advice].

Then it gets worse. On a second official script, rated 6.5, the examiner observed that the first paragraph and the start of the second were mainly lifted from the rubric, and concluded that this repetition — even though smoothly integrated — revealed an inability to paraphrase [src: same, p.20]. Copying was used as evidence against **Lexical Resource**, not just Task Response. It is penalised twice.

The consequence is quantitative. A prompt statement runs 25 to 45 words. Copy it verbatim, write 265 words, and your counted length can land near 225–240 — under length, invisibly, while the on-screen counter tells you that you are fine. Official sources say copied rubric is "discounted" and earns no credit but never spell out the mechanics; independent teaching authorities say the words are simply not counted, and you should assume they are not. Paraphrasing is not a stylistic nicety; it is what keeps your word count real.

Memorised language. In the official grid, memorised and formulaic language is named at bands 4, 3, 2 and 0 — and **nowhere above band 4** [src: descriptors PDF, p.9]. At band 3 it is explicitly discounted for grammar. British Council states that examiners can spot model answers and that such an answer is deemed invalid [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Test day advice]. A memorised opener is not a neutral shortcut that fails to earn credit; it is listed in the grid as *diagnostic of a low band*.

Question types, one by one

Read this before the five families. IELTS publishes **no official taxonomy of Task 2 essay types** — not on the format pages, not in the sample tasks PDF, not in the key assessment criteria, not in the descriptors. The two official owners' teaching pages both publish lists, and they do not match: British Council teaches five categories, IDP six [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — How to write an English essay for IELTS; ielts.idp.com — How to understand Task 2 writing questions]. What ielts.org says is generic: the prompt typically ends with one or two questions asking you either to agree or disagree, or to discuss multiple perspectives [src: ielts.org — Writing test resources].

The five families below are a **recognition heuristic, not an examined category**. They are reliable shapes and they save planning time, but the rule that earns the marks is the official one: **count the instructions in the prompt and answer every one**. Memorise five templates, meet a hybrid prompt, and you will misfire. Count demands, and you never will.

The 30-second triage. The family is decided by the *final instruction line* — not the topic, not the statement. Find the last sentence containing a question mark or an imperative and count the separate demands. That count is the number of things your essay must visibly deliver.

The final line says...	Demands	Family
<i>To what extent do you agree or disagree?</i>	1 — your position	1. Opinion
<i>Discuss both views and give your own opinion.</i>	3 — view A, view B, your view	2. Discussion

The final line says...	Demands	Family
<i>What are the causes? What can be done?</i>	2 — diagnose, prescribe	3. Problem–cause–solution
<i>Do the advantages outweigh the disadvantages?</i>	2 — both sides, plus a verdict	4. Advantages–disadvantages
Two questions of different shapes	2 — one each	5. Two-part / direct question

Two at once means a hybrid: obey the demand count, not the family name. And there are always **two more demands than the family implies**, because every official rubric ends with the same two lines. A response with a clear position, two developed reasons and two concrete examples satisfies the rubric even if you misjudged the family entirely.

Family 1 — Opinion (agree / disagree)

RECOGNISE IT BY

To what extent do you agree or disagree? · Do you agree or disagree? · What is your opinion? One demand: judge the proposition.

Intro	~45 w	Paraphrase the proposition · state your position in one sentence
Body 1	~100 w	Reason 1 — claim, because, so what, instance
Body 2	~100 w	Reason 2 — claim, because, so what, instance
Conc.	~35 w	Restate the position in new words. No new argument.
Total	~280 w	← inside the 270–290 target

WORKED SKELETON

Original prompt: *Some people believe universities should concentrate on subjects that lead directly to employment and reduce provision in fields with no clear career path. To what extent do you agree or disagree?*

- **Position:** disagree in the main; concede the funding pressure is real.
- **Body 1:** the labour market a degree is designed for does not exist yet. Curricula built around today's vacancies age badly, and the narrowly trained graduate is the first to need retraining. *Instance:* a translation graduate whose specific technical skill was automated within a decade but whose analytical training transferred.
- **Body 2:** general capability, not job-matching, is what universities do efficiently — argument, evidence handling and writing survive occupational change, and they are cultivated in precisely the fields the prompt wants cut.
- **Concession, one clause:** where public money is scarce some prioritisation is defensible; the error is treating it as a principle rather than as rationing.

THE TRAP

To what extent invites "I partly agree", after which candidates write one paragraph for and one against with no adjudication. Partial agreement is legitimate and often stronger — but state it as a rule. *"This holds for vocational subjects but not for the humanities"* is a position; *"there are arguments on both sides"* is not.

BAND-6 FAILURE MODE

Position in the introduction and the conclusion, but two neutral bodies that would fit either side. Band 6 Task Response covers this exactly: position relevant, conclusions unclear, unjustified or repetitive [src: descriptors PDF, p.8]. **Fix:** every topic sentence carries the stance — *"The stronger reason for rejecting this claim is..."*, not *"Another factor is..."*

Family 2 — Discussion (both views + your own opinion)**RECOGNISE IT BY**

Discuss both views and give your own opinion. Three demands, and the third is the one people drop.

Intro	~45 w	Paraphrase both views · state YOUR position now, not at the end
Body 1	~95 w	View A — presented fairly, developed
Body 2	~110 w	View B — developed, and this is where you side with one, with reasons
Conc.	~35 w	Your position restated
Total	~285 w	← inside the 270-290 target

Safer alternative at 6 or 6.5: three bodies of about 75 words — view A, view B, mine. It costs a little cohesion polish but makes the third demand impossible to miss.

WORKED SKELETON

Original prompt: *Some argue that city centres should be closed to private cars. Others believe such restrictions damage local businesses and inconvenience residents. Discuss both views and give your own opinion.*

- **Intro ends:** *"Restrictions are justified, in my view, but only where the public alternative is already in place."* The third demand, delivered in the first forty seconds.
- **Body 1:** street space is finite, and rationing it by congestion is the worst available mechanism, because the cost falls on everyone including the people not driving.
- **Body 2:** the objection, then the adjudication. Topic sentence agrees with the intro — *"The objection is serious, but it is an argument about timing rather than about cars."* Instance: a Mediterranean town pedestrianised before its bus network was extended, where trade fell, against the same measure elsewhere after a tram line opened, where it did not.

THE TRAP

Reporting the views like a journalist. *"Some people say X. Other people say Y."* Reported opinion is not developed opinion, and your own view ends up as a seven-word clause at the end.

BAND-6 FAILURE MODE

Both views covered well, opinion tacked on at the end — the literal definition of band 6 Task Response, main parts addressed though some more fully than others [src: descriptors PDF, p.8]. **Fix that costs nothing:** put your opinion in the introduction's last sentence *and* make Body 2's topic sentence agree with it. The position is then visible in three places and band 7's "clear and developed position" test is met.

Family 3 — Problem, cause and solution**RECOGNISE IT BY**

What are the causes of this problem and what measures could be taken to address it? · Why is this happening and what can be done? Two demands, and they are **coupled**.

Intro	~45 w	Paraphrase the problem · signpost causes then remedies
Body 1	~100 w	Cause 1 developed fully, Cause 2 briefly — or one cause, deeply
Body 2	~100 w	A remedy for cause 1, a remedy for cause 2, named as such
Conc.	~35 w	The problem is tractable if the named causes are attacked
Total	~280 w	← inside the 270-290 target

WORKED SKELETON

Original prompt: *In many countries young people are leaving rural areas to live in large cities. What are the causes of this trend, and what measures could reduce it?*

- **Cause 1:** employment concentration. The jobs that pay for a household are spatially clustered, and each departure raises the probability of the next because the local network thins.
- **Cause 2:** service withdrawal. Clinics and secondary schools close as the population falls, which is itself a cause of the next departure. A feedback loop, not a list.
- **Remedy 1, keyed to cause 1:** *"The first of these causes is the easier to attack..."* — relocating public-sector employment and connectivity, because remote-capable work is the only job category that does not need the cluster.
- **Remedy 2, keyed to cause 2:** a guaranteed service floor below which closure is not permitted, because the loop only breaks if the withdrawal stops.

THE TRAP

Mismatched halves. Causes: rural poverty and weak enforcement. Solutions: *"governments should raise awareness and people should be more responsible."* Nothing in the solution paragraph attacks anything in the cause paragraph — which costs two criteria, not one: Task Response loses on relevance of ideas, and Coherence and Cohesion loses because logical organisation fails at the level of the whole essay [src: Key assessment criteria PDF, p.3]. The fix, explicit back-reference (*"the first of these causes"*), also does free work for CC, since reference and substitution are named in the band-7 CC descriptor.

BAND-6 FAILURE MODE

Vague, unimplementable remedies: *"the government should take action"*, *"people should change their mentality."* Under band 6 LR these read as a lack of precision in word choice; under band 6 TR they are supporting arguments that are less relevant or inadequate. **Fix:** name the actor, the instrument and the mechanism — *who does what*, and *why that changes the cause*.

Family 4 — Advantages and disadvantages**RECOGNISE IT BY**

two sub-shapes that need genuinely different essays.

Wording	What it demands
<i>What are the advantages and disadvantages?</i>	Describe both. No verdict required, though one is safe.
<i>Do the advantages outweigh the disadvantages?</i>	Both sides and an explicit judgement of weight .

The *outweigh* version is what the official 2023 sample task 2B uses [src: sample tasks 2023 PDF, p.7], so it is not a rare shape.

Intro	~45 w	Paraphrase · state the verdict now
Body 1	~90 w	The weaker side, honestly presented
Body 2	~110 w	The stronger side, developed further — and say WHY it weighs more
Conc.	~35 w	Verdict restated with the reason for the weighting
Total	~280 w	← inside the 270-290 target

Give the winning side more words. The asymmetry is itself an argument; a symmetrical essay reads as a draw.

WORKED SKELETON

Original prompt: *An increasing number of employees now work from home for most of the week. Do the advantages of this development outweigh the disadvantages?*

- **Verdict in the intro:** the advantages are the greater, but unevenly distributed.
- **Body 1, weaker side:** the loss of informal mentoring. Junior staff learn by overhearing, and that channel does not survive scheduled video calls. Honest, developed, not strawmanned.
- **Body 2, stronger side:** the release of housing pressure on capital cities and the widening of the hiring pool — then the *weighting clause*: this benefit is structural and compounding, while the mentoring loss is a training problem firms can deliberately solve. One is reversible; the other is not.

THE TRAP

Answering *outweigh* as though it were *what are*: three advantages, three disadvantages, then *"in conclusion there are both advantages and disadvantages."* That is a missing demand, and by ielts.org's own statement a missing main part caps Task Response at band 5.

BAND-6 FAILURE MODE

The verdict exists but is asserted, never weighed: *"Overall, I think the advantages are more important."* Weighing means naming a criterion — *more people affected, longer-lasting, reversible versus irreversible, falls on those least able to bear it.* One clause of criterion turns a band-6 verdict into a band-7 one.

Family 5 — Two-part / direct question**RECOGNISE IT BY**

two question sentences of *different shapes*. *"Why do you think this is happening? Is this a positive or negative development?"* The positive/negative prompt lives here when paired, and behaves like Family 1 when it stands alone.

Intro	~45 w	Paraphrase · one-line answer to BOTH questions
Body 1	~100 w	Question 1, fully
Body 2	~100 w	Question 2, fully — and it must be an evaluation, not more causes
Conc.	~35 w	Both answers, compressed
Total	~280 w	← inside the 270-290 target

WORKED SKELETON

Original prompt: *In many households children now spend more time on screens than outdoors. Why is this happening, and is it a positive or negative development?*

- **Intro's last sentence answers both:** *"The shift is driven mainly by what has become easy rather than by what children prefer, and on balance it is a negative development."*
- **Body 1, causes:** outdoor space has been rationed by traffic and by parental risk perception, while indoor entertainment became free and frictionless. The default choice changed; children did not.
- **Body 2, evaluation** — and this must not slide back into causes: the cost is not screens themselves but what they displace, namely unsupervised physical activity and unstructured social negotiation. *Judgement clause:* the harm is cumulative and hard to reverse in adulthood, which is what makes it negative rather than merely different.

THE TRAP

Answering question 1 twice. Causes are easy and evaluation is hard, so Body 2 quietly becomes another cause paragraph.

BAND-6 FAILURE MODE

Unequal coverage — precisely band 6's wording, that some main parts are more fully covered than others. If Body 2 shrinks to three sentences you are a band 6 on Task Response no matter how good your English is; if it disappears, you are looking at band 5. **Test before writing the conclusion:** point at the sentence that answers question 2. If you cannot point at one, you have not written it.

Tips & tricks

Ranked by how much band they buy. **[verified]** = the mechanism traces to an official source.
[expert consensus] = independent teaching authorities agree, no official statement exists.

1. Count the demands before choosing a structure. **[verified]** Underline the final instruction line, count the demands, write one body paragraph per demand as a minimum. *Fails when* you force a memorised family shape onto a hybrid prompt.

2. Paraphrase the prompt; never copy it. **[verified]** Change the nouns and the verb, keep the proposition. *Fails when* you paraphrase so hard the proposition changes — then you are off-topic, which is worse.

3. Two developed ideas, not four asserted ones. **[expert consensus]** At 280 words, four ideas get 70 each — assertion length. Two get 110 — development length. Band 6 names underdeveloped main ideas as the fault. *Fails when* the prompt has three demands; then it is one developed idea per demand.

4. The four-move body paragraph: claim → because → so what → instance. **[verified]** This is the official gloss on Task Response: extension means detail and depth, support means relevant examples. *Fails when* you run all four moves on a claim nobody disputes.

5. Four or five paragraphs, blank line between each. **[verified]** Paragraphing is expected at band 6 and above, and "inadequate or missing" paragraphing is a bolded limiter at band 5. Two official scripts were held down partly by paragraphing (5.5 and 6.5); one at 7.5 was told its long paragraphs should have been broken up. *Fails when* you paragraph every four sentences regardless of where the idea turns. [src: descriptors PDF, p.8; sample tasks 2023 PDF, pp.20, 24; CD sample responses PDF, p.5]

6. Position in the introduction, echoed in every topic sentence. **[verified]** Band 7 TR wants a clear and developed position; band 7 CC wants clear progression *throughout*. Echoing the stance delivers both. *Fails when* the echo becomes verbatim repetition — band 6's "repetitive" fault arriving early.

7. Cap discourse markers at about two per paragraph — and never zero. **[verified]** An examiner reading an official **7.5** script logged four sequencers in one paragraph as "some overuse" and wrote it down; four is visible, two is demonstrably safe. The reverse also happened: an official **6.5** script was told better use of linkers would have improved its cohesion. Over-use *and* under-use are both named at band 7. [src: CD sample responses PDF, p.5; sample tasks 2023 PDF, p.20]

8. Replace half your connectors with reference and substitution. **[verified]** Band 7 CC names reference and substitution specifically: *this shift, that mismatch, these pressures, the former, one, so*. IDP's teaching page says the same. Highest-value CC move available to a band-6 writer. *Fails when* the referent is ambiguous — *this* with three possible antecedents is a clarity fault, not a device. [src: descriptors PDF, p.7; ielts.idp.com — coherence and cohesion]

9. Hedge every generalisation. [verified] *tend to · appears to · is likely to · in most cases · broadly · often.* An examiner explicitly named softeners of this kind as evidence of higher-level lexis in a 7.5 script. It double-scores: it raises LR *and* defuses band 7 TR's named weakness, the tendency to over-generalise. Cheapest upgrade in the chapter. *Fails when* everything is hedged — a position hedged into invisibility is a band-6 position. [src: CD sample responses PDF, p.5]

10. Target 270–290 words; hard floor 260. [expert consensus] The floor sits above 250 because near-copied rubric is discounted and two developed ideas do not fit in 250. *Fails when* you pad to hit a number — padding is band 6's "irrelevant detail".

11. Concede once, then counter. [verified] The official 7.5 script was praised for considering an alternative position and rejecting it. Conceding demonstrates a developed position and hands you a free complex structure (*While X is undeniably true, ...*). *Fails when* you concede and forget to counter.

12. Build topic lexis, not synonym lists; memorise mechanisms, not sentences. [verified] / [expert consensus] LR assesses topic-specific items and **collocation** — the word partnerships English habitually makes, so that *heavy rain* is right and *strong rain* is not, though both are grammatical and both are understood. So ten precise education nouns (*curriculum, streaming, tuition fees, attainment gap, vocational training, drop-out rate, teacher retention, rote learning, contact hours, lifelong learning*) outscore twenty synonyms for *important* [src: Key assessment criteria PDF, p.4]. For ideas, memorise nine concepts rather than sentences: *externality · opportunity cost · irreversibility · displacement lag · certainty beats severity · default choice · signalling · brain drain · free-rider*. A memorised sentence is penalised language; a memorised concept is a thinking tool and is invisible.

13. Spend 5 / 32 / 3 inside the 40 minutes. [expert consensus] Five minutes to analyse and plan, thirty-two to write, three to check. At roughly nine words a minute that yields about 290 words. Checking time is not optional — ielts.org advises reserving time to proofread. *Fails when* you plan for ten minutes and then write 220 words. **Two conditions on the nine-words-a-minute figure:** it counts thinking *and* typing together, so it is only true if you have already planned; and it assumes you are typing on the keyboard layout you will actually meet. Run every timed drill on that layout — [Chapter 9](#)'s L1 alert covers the AZERTY/QWERTY question for Tunisian centres. Nine words a minute on an unfamiliar layout is optimistic by a wide margin, and the shortfall lands on the criterion length hurts most, Task Response.

14. Proofread for *your* three errors, not for "mistakes". [verified] Band 8 is blocked by *systematic* errors, and an L1 pattern is systematic by definition. Three targeted one-minute passes beat one vague re-read. Yours: articles before abstract nouns, pluralised uncountables, comma splices.

15. Write abbreviations out. [verified] An examiner listed *e.g.* as a lapse in an **8.5** script. *For example*, not *e.g.*; *and so on*, not *etc.* [src: sample tasks 2023 PDF, p.22]

On which task to write first. No official source expresses a preference or advises an order, and computer-delivered IELTS lets you start from either task [\[src: ielts.idp.com\]](https://ielts.idp.com). The argument for Task 2 first is real — it is worth two thirds, so minutes stolen from it cost double — but expert opinion is split, and some teachers recommend Task 1 first as a warm-up. **This is an open question, not a rule.** Settle it in your own timed practice, and if you go Task 2 first, set a hard forty-minute stop so Task 1 still gets its twenty.

Myths that hold you back

M1 — "Open with a strong general statement about the modern era." *"In this contemporary era of rapid globalisation, it is an undeniable fact that..."* This is formulaic memorised language, named at bands 4, 3 and 2 as a marker of low lexical resource and discounted for grammar at band 3. It also burns about 25 of your 280 words on text that responds to nothing. Nothing in the descriptors rewards a hook. [\[src: descriptors PDF, p.9\]](#)

M2 — "Memorise a template essay for common topics." British Council states that examiners can spot model answers and that such a response is deemed invalid; band 0 is reserved for answers with proof of total memorisation. The risk is not that it fails to help — the risk is band 0.

[\[src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Test day advice; descriptors PDF, p.9\]](#)

M3 — "Start every sentence with a linker." Over-use is a named fault at band 7 *and* band 6, and an examiner docked a 7.5 script over four sequencers in one paragraph. Linker density is one of very few things that can actively *lower* your CC band rather than merely fail to raise it. [\[src: descriptors](#)

[PDF, pp.7–8; CD sample responses PDF, p.5\]](#)

M4 — "Use the most advanced synonyms you can find." Band 6 LR describes exactly this behaviour: the risk-taker who deploys a wider range at the cost of higher inaccuracy and inappropriacy. Band 7 asks for awareness of *collocation*. The thesaurus moves you toward 6, not toward 7. [\[src: descriptors PDF, pp.7–8\]](#)

M5 — "Write 400+ words to show off your range." Not penalised as length — but every extra sentence is another chance to break band 7's requirement that error-free sentences be *frequent*, and it eats proofreading time. It also invites band 7's other named weakness: supporting material lacking focus and precision.

M6 — "Never go over 300 words." The reverse myth, and it is written into most prep material. The official 7.5 exemplar runs to roughly 375 words and drew no comment on length; British Council's practice page says do not be afraid to go a little over. There is a floor. There is no ceiling. [\[src: CD sample responses PDF, p.5; takeielts.britishcouncil.org\]](#)

M7 — "Under 250 words is an automatic band 5 in Task Response." A real *unpublished* examiner rule before about 2018, reported as removed. No current official document contains it; the only published arithmetic is 20 words or fewer equals band 1. The claim that the old rule survives is

unverified, and the evidence runs the other way, since the May 2023 grid contains no rating-limiting feature at all above band 5. The correct model is causal: too short means undeveloped, and undeveloped is what the descriptor marks. [src: descriptors PDF, p.9]

M8 – "Contractions or any informality will cap you at band 6." Overstated. **Register** – the level of formality a piece of language belongs to, the difference between *kids*, *children* and *minors* – belongs to LR, and errors are weighed by density and effect rather than by presence. The official **7.5** script uses *don't* three times and contains the redundancy "*In my opinion, I think*" – and still scored 7.5. **Keep avoiding both** – they buy nothing and cost a little – but do not spend exam minutes hunting contractions while a whole question part sits unanswered. [src: CD sample responses PDF, p.5]

M9 – "You need real statistics and named studies." No specialist knowledge is required and examples may come from your own experience. Invented statistics earn nothing – no criterion mentions data – and can look absurd. *A significant minority* and *in many low-income neighbourhoods* score identically to a number you made up, and cannot embarrass you. [src: Writing test resources; Key assessment criteria PDF, p.2]

M10 – "Never use I or personal experience." Contradicted directly: the printed rubric on every official task invites examples from your own knowledge or experience. A first-person position statement is exactly what Task Response asks for. [src: sample tasks 2023 PDF, pp.6–7]

M11 – "Sit on the fence to sound balanced." Band 6 names conclusions that are unclear, unjustified or repetitive; band 7 needs a clear, developed position. Balance without adjudication is a band-6 signature. [src: descriptors PDF, pp.7–8]

M12 – "Learn the five essay types and you have learned Task 2." IELTS publishes no official taxonomy, and its two owners' teaching pages give lists of five and six that do not align. Types are a recognition aid; the examined requirement is to address every main part of *this* prompt.

M13 – "Bullet points and sub-headings make the structure clearer." Explicitly penalised: the response should not have sub-headings or bullet points, and note form is penalisable in any part of the response. [src: Writing test resources; Key assessment criteria PDF, p.1]

M14 – "Copy the question into your introduction to save time." No credit, discounted from your effective word count, and used by an examiner as evidence that you cannot paraphrase. Two official scripts were held down for it. [src: sample tasks 2023 PDF, pp.20, 24]

M15 – "Rhetorical questions make a strong introduction." Honestly: **no official rule exists either way**, and every prohibition traces to prep sites, not to IELTS. So this is not a penalty claim. But the descriptor logic runs one way – a question is not a position, so an introduction built on questions delays what Task Response asks for, and questions are not cohesive devices, so they do nothing for CC. Upside zero, downside real. Treat as *avoid*, not *forbidden*, and know that this is a derived recommendation rather than a verified rule.

Band descriptor decoder

Paraphrased from the **May 2023** Task 2 descriptors [src: ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/ielts-writing-band-descriptors.pdf, Task 2 grid pp.7-9; PDF metadata confirms creation 2023-05-03], with at most one short quoted phrase per criterion. The 2013 edition still circulating online differs in at least one place that matters, and must not be used.

Each table runs bands 8 down to 5. Band 5 is included because your baseline is undiagnosed and a first essay can land at 5.5, and because the two bolded rating-limiting clauses on the whole bands 6/5/4 page — *incompletely addressed* and *paragraphing may be inadequate or missing* — **both sit in the band-5 row**, which is the extraction §Length asks you to reproduce yourself. Reading band 5 is how you check that finding rather than take it on trust.

Task Response

Band	What it actually requires
8	The prompt is addressed appropriately <i>and sufficiently</i> . Position clear and well developed. Ideas relevant, well extended, well supported. Only occasional omissions or lapses in content.
7	The main parts are addressed appropriately. " A clear and developed position " is presented. Main ideas are extended and supported — but there may be a tendency to over-generalise, or supporting material may lack focus and precision.
6	The main parts are addressed, but some more fully than others. Format appropriate. Position relevant, yet conclusions may be unclear, unjustified or repetitive. Main ideas relevant but some underdeveloped; some support weak or less relevant.
5	The main parts of the prompt are incompletely addressed ; format may be inappropriate in places. A position is expressed, but its development is not always clear. Some main ideas are put forward but they are limited and insufficiently developed, and there may be irrelevant detail or repetition.

Read the band-5 row, because it is the row you can fall into by accident. Its opening clause is one of only two bolded phrases on the whole bands 6/5/4 page, and bold means a negative feature that limits the rating. *Incompletely addressed* is what happens when a two-part prompt gets one part — the same failure ielts.org describes in plain words as being limited to band 5. Band 6 tolerates *uneven* coverage; band 5 is where a part is left incomplete. **Unevenness costs you the 7; absence costs you the 6.**

A correction most books get wrong. The 2013 edition said band 7 presents a clear position *throughout*. The **2023 edition does not** — band 7 now reads simply that a clear and developed position is presented. *Throughout* survives at band 9 and, usefully, in **Coherence and Cohesion at band 7**, where progression must be clear throughout. So "hold your position throughout" is still correct advice; its descriptor home has moved. TR wants the position **clear and developed**; CC wants **progression throughout**.

6 → 7 in one line: at 6, ideas are *stated*; at 7, ideas are *extended and supported*.

Band 6 (asserted): Remote work is convenient for employees. It saves time and money. Therefore many workers prefer it.

Band 7 (extended + supported): Remote work removes the daily commute, which for someone travelling into a capital from a satellite town can absorb two hours a day. Those hours are not merely saved; they are redirected into rest or into domestic work that would otherwise be crowded into the evening. The gain tends to be largest for exactly the households with the least slack in their week.

Three moves in one paragraph: a *mechanism* (commute becomes reclaimed hours), an *instance* (satellite-town commuter), a *consequence* (which households gain most). The final *tends to* hedges, pre-empting band 7's named weakness.

Band 6 conclusion: In conclusion, there are advantages and disadvantages to restricting cars in city centres, and governments should think carefully.

Band 7 conclusion: In conclusion, the losses fall on a small number of businesses during a transition that ends, while the gains in air quality and street safety are permanent and shared. That asymmetry is why the restriction is worth making.

The second *justifies* — it names the criteria the verdict rests on.

Coherence and Cohesion

Band	What it actually requires
8	The message is followed with ease; ideas logically sequenced; cohesion well managed; occasional lapses; paragraphing sufficient and appropriate.
7	Information and ideas logically organised with clear progression throughout, a few minor lapses allowed. A range of cohesive devices <i>including reference and substitution</i> used flexibly, though with inaccuracies or " some over/under use ". Paragraphing generally effective; sequencing within paragraphs generally logical.
6	Generally coherent with clear overall progression. Cohesive devices work to some good effect, but cohesion within or between sentences may be faulty or mechanical through misuse, overuse or omission. Reference and substitution may lack flexibility, producing repetition or error. Paragraphing may not always be logical.
5	Organisation is evident but not wholly logical, and overall progression may be lacking, though an underlying coherence survives. The relationship of ideas can be followed, but the sentences are not fluently linked to each other. Cohesive devices may be limited or overused, with some inaccuracy. Writing may be repetitive through inadequate or inaccurate reference and substitution. " Paragraphing may be inadequate or missing. "

That last clause is the page's **second** bolded phrase — the only other rating-limiting feature printed anywhere on the bands 6/5/4 page. It is why tip 5 exists, and it is the cheapest band in this book to protect: four or five paragraphs with a blank line between them, decided before you start writing.

This is the criterion most damaged by well-meant advice. Over-use is named at band 7 and again at band 6; **nothing in the grid rewards quantity of linkers**. Officially, cohesive devices come in three families — logical connectors, conjunctions, and pronouns/reference — and reference and substitution are the ones band 7 asks for by name [src: Key assessment criteria PDF, p.3; descriptors PDF, p.7].

Band 6 (five markers, five sentences): Firstly, cities are becoming overcrowded. Moreover, housing is expensive. Furthermore, transport systems cannot cope. In addition, air quality is poor. Therefore, governments should act.

Band 7: Cities are absorbing people faster than they can house them. That mismatch shows up first in rents, then in transport systems built for a smaller population, and finally in the air itself. None of these pressures eases on its own, which is why they end up on the government's desk.

Devices in the rewrite, all named in the grid: *that mismatch* (reference to the previous clause), *these pressures* (substitution plus reference), *first / then / finally* inside one sentence rather than at the head of four, and a relative clause carrying the causal link instead of *therefore*.

6 → 7 in one line: at 6 the joins are visible; at 7 the reader stops noticing them and simply follows the argument.

Lexical Resource

Band	What it actually requires
8	Wide resource used fluently and flexibly for precise meaning; skilful use of uncommon and idiomatic items despite occasional inaccuracy in choice and collocation; occasional spelling or word-formation errors with minimal impact.
7	Resource sufficient for some flexibility and precision. Some ability with less common and idiomatic items. "An awareness of style and collocation" is evident, though inappropriacies occur. Only a few spelling or word-formation errors, and they do not detract from clarity.
6	Generally adequate and appropriate. Meaning generally clear despite a rather restricted range or a lack of precision in word choice. A risk-taker will show wider vocabulary but with higher inaccuracy. Some spelling or word-formation errors, but they do not impede communication.
5	The resource is limited but minimally adequate . Simple vocabulary may be used accurately, but the range does not permit much variation in expression. Frequent lapses in appropriacy of word choice, and inflexibility showing as frequent simplification or repetition. Spelling and word-formation errors may be noticeable and may cause the reader some difficulty .

The 5→6 line is *impeding*: at 6 the errors do not impede, at 5 they cause the reader difficulty. This is where the false friends in §L1 alert land — *alimentation* for *diet* was the official examiner's own cited example on a script held at 5.5.

Read the band-6 risk-taker clause twice. The descriptor explicitly anticipates the thesaurus strategy and places it *at band 6*. Reaching for rare words without collocation control is a band-6 behaviour by definition, not an ambitious one.

Band 6: Governments must ameliorate the pecuniary predicament of impecunious households. / Pollution is a big problem that gives bad effects to the environment.

Band 7: Governments must relieve the financial pressure on low-income households. / Industrial emissions place sustained strain on air quality, particularly in cities that grew before emissions rules existed.

Ameliorate is a real word; *ameliorate a predicament* is not a collocation, and *relieve pressure on households* is. In the second pair, *big problem* becomes a named mechanism, *gives bad effects to* becomes *place strain on* (the real collocation), and *the environment* becomes *air quality* (specific).

6 → 7 in one line: at 6 the word is understandable; at 7 it is the right word and it keeps the company it normally keeps.

Grammatical Range and Accuracy

Band	What it actually requires
8	A wide range of structures used flexibly and accurately. The majority of sentences are error-free; punctuation well managed. Occasional, non-systematic errors with minimal impact.
7	A variety of complex structures used with some flexibility and accuracy. Grammar and punctuation generally well controlled, and "error-free sentences are frequent" . A few errors persist but do not impede communication.
6	A mix of simple and complex forms with limited flexibility. Complex structures are less accurate than the simple ones. Errors occur but rarely impede communication.
5	The range of structures is limited and rather repetitive . Complex sentences are <i>attempted</i> but tend to be faulty , and the greatest accuracy is achieved on simple sentences. Grammatical errors may be frequent and cause the reader some difficulty ; punctuation may be faulty.

Bands 5, 6 and 7 are one ladder on this criterion: at 5 your complex sentences are *faulty*, at 6 they are *less accurate than your simple ones*, at 7 they are as accurate as your simple ones. The comma splices in §L1 alert 5 are the single commonest way a French-influenced writer sits on the 5 rung — *punctuation may be faulty* is printed right there in the row.

This one is measurable, so measure it — but measure it against the right number. Band 7 needs error-free sentences to be *frequent*; band 8 needs them to be *the majority*. No official source quantifies *frequent*, so band 7 must sit **below** a majority, not at it. [Chapter 8](#) §How accurate is "accurate enough"? owns the derivation and [Chapter 4](#) tip 5 restates it: **four sentences in ten completely clean, rising to five**. Scaled to a 280-word essay of about sixteen sentences, four in ten is 6.4 and five in ten is 8, so: **fewer than six clean and you are arguing for a 6; six, seven or eight is band-7 territory; nine or ten — a genuine majority of sixteen — and you are arguing for an 8**. It is a derived working proxy, not a published threshold. It is still the only criterion you can audit yourself with any reliability.

What "complex" officially means at band 7 and above: passive constructions, modal verbs, comparative forms and complex noun phrases — not merely subordinate clauses [src: Writing test resources]. And **systematic versus non-systematic decides band 8:** a repeated article error across the whole script is systematic and blocks band 8, while three unrelated slips are not [src: same]. For an Arabic/French L1 writer that is decisive, because article errors are the archetypal systematic error. Punctuation also lives inside GRA — the official 7.5 script was told its punctuation was unhelpful at times.

Band 6 (complex but faulty): Although many people believes that technology improve the education, but the students in rural areas they cannot access to internet, this is the real problem.

Band 7 (same idea, controlled): Although many people believe that technology improves education, students in rural areas often cannot access the internet, and that gap is the real problem.

Repairs: subject–verb agreement; no *although ... but* doubling; no resumptive pronoun (*students ... they*); *access* takes no preposition; the comma splice replaced by a coordinator; the article dropped from *education* used generally.

Band 7 range-builder — four structures in two sentences: Where broadband has been rolled out, attainment has risen; where it has not, the gap has widened. Unless connectivity is treated as infrastructure rather than as a consumer product, the technology that was meant to level the field will continue to tilt it.

Parallel fronted adverbial clauses, a semicolon, *unless* plus a present-perfect passive, the comparative *rather than*, a relative clause. That is "a variety of complex structures used with some flexibility".

YOUR L1 — ARABIC / FRENCH

L1 alert

You are not being paranoid about this. In published commentary on an official Task 2 script, an examiner noted that there appeared to be interference from the test taker's first language — and the example chosen was *alimentation*, a French word pressed into English service where *diet* or *nutrition* was needed. That script was held at 5.5 partly because the level of error was too high [src: CD sample responses PDF, p4]. Official examiners name L1 interference in writing, in print.

These errors bite in two places: **GRA**, because band 8 requires errors to be *non-systematic* and an L1 pattern is systematic by definition; and **LR**, because word-formation and appropriacy errors are counted there.

1. Articles before abstract nouns — your highest-frequency, highest-cost error. Task 2 is *made of* abstract nouns used generally, so this recurs on every line. *The society is changing* → Society is changing. *The technology has transformed the education* → Technology has transformed education. *The unemployment among the young people* → Unemployment among young people. **Why:** an uncountable abstract noun used in a general sense takes no article in English; French *la société* forces it, English drops it. Same family: *society, nature, life, technology, education, history, crime, poverty, health, pollution, science, work, research, progress*.

Now the counter-list, and get this the right way round, because over-correction after this rule is taught is a real and predictable failure mode. These abstract nouns **keep** their article in ordinary generic use, and stripping it is just as wrong as adding it:

the government · the environment · the media · the economy · the internet · the public · the police

✓ *The government should regulate emissions more strictly.* — not *Government should...*

Government is the trap on this list, because it looks like *society* and behaves like *the economy*. The article-less *Government is expensive* exists, but it is the abstract-activity sense, and it is not what a Task 2 writer is ever producing: when you mean the institution — which you always do — it takes **the**. This chapter uses it correctly in §6 below (*the government decides*); [Chapter 8](#) owns the full counter-list and the decision procedure behind it.

The article is also required whenever you narrow the noun — the education system of Tunisia, the crime rate, the poverty **that this policy creates. Test: if something after the noun specifies *which one*, keep the article.

2. Uncountables pluralised. The nine-word list, the partitives (*a piece of research, some advice*) and the research finding that this is the one error type which does **not** resolve as proficiency rises all live in [Chapter 8 §The nine words](#). Two things belong here rather than there:

- **Which criterion it costs.** [Chapter 8](#)'s hedged version is the honest one: **GRA, and arguably LR too**. IELTS files word formation under LR and says nothing about which side countability falls on, so a book that states the allocation as settled is inventing a ruling. Either way it is scored, and the repair is identical.
- **Why Task 2 is where it bites.** Five of [Chapter 8](#)'s nine words — *research · information · evidence · knowledge · advice* — are the working vocabulary of argument itself, so an abstract Task 2 essay hands you most of the list in every paragraph, while a Task 1 report might not use one of them. The official **7.5** script itself contains "*reading gossips*", so this family reaches strong writers. It is a scan, not a lesson.

3. Preposition transfer — the six that essay argument actually produces. The full table is in **Chapter 8**. These six recur because they attach to the verbs of *arguing*: *depend of* → *depend on*; *discuss about* → *discuss* Ø; *participate to* → *participate in*; *responsible of* → *responsible for*; *access to* (as a verb) → *access* Ø; *in the other hand* → *on the other hand*. Add one that is specific to Task 2's concessive machinery: *prevent somebody to do* → *prevent somebody from* doing.

4. False friends in essay register — the register-specific ones only. The annotated twenty-plus-item list is in **Chapter 8 §French: 3. False friends**, and **Chapter 7** covers how to test yourself on it; reading it a fifth time will not move your band. What is specific to Task 2 is that a false friend here is not a slip in a data label — it lands inside an *argument*, where it changes what you are claiming. The four that do that most:

formation → **training / education** (a whole education essay can be built on the wrong word) · *evolution* meaning a trend → **change / development** · *inconvenient* used as a noun → **drawback** · *society* (from *société*) meaning a firm → **company**. Plus the two that are not English words at all: *significative* → **significant**, and *alimentation* → **diet / nutrition** — the second of these is the official examiner's own cited example of L1 interference, quoted at the head of this section.

5. Run-ons and comma splices. Both your languages tolerate long coordinate chains, and Arabic rhetorical structure adds sentence-initial connectives that English handles with subordination or a full stop. Under GRA this reads as faulty punctuation and, at band 5, complex sentences that tend to be faulty.

✗ *Many students today they cannot find a work after the university, this is a big problem for the society and the government must find solutions, moreover the companies they don't want to train the young people.*

✓ *Many graduates cannot find work, and that failure is now a public problem rather than a private one. Governments are expected to respond, yet employers are increasingly unwilling to train new entrants themselves.*

Rules: **a comma cannot join two independent clauses** — use a full stop, a semicolon or a coordinator (*and, but, so, yet*). **No resumptive pronoun** (*the students they think* → *the students think*). **Never *although ... but* together** — French *bien que ... mais* is normal, English permits only one. **Never *because of that's why***. **Discourse markers open sentences, not clauses** — *moreover* after a comma is a splice.

6. Agreement, stacked verbs, third-person -s. *people is / peoples are* → **people are** (*people* is already plural; *peoples* means ethnic groups); *the government are decide* → the government **decides**; *he do not have* → he **does not** have; *this affect society* → this **affects** society; *is depend on* → **depends on**. Never stack a bare auxiliary against a bare verb (*can to do*). Third-person -s is the most common systematic error in Arabic-L1 academic writing, and *systematic* is precisely the word that blocks band 8.

7. Register imported from French academic prose. French favours abstraction, **nominalisation** and formulaic openings. Nominalisation means turning a verb or an adjective into a noun and then hanging a weak verb off it — *the globalisation possesses numerous incidences* instead of *globalisation affects*. English tolerates a little of it and French academic prose runs on it; overdone, it produces sentences that are grammatical but imprecise — band 6 LR, not band 7.

✗ *It is necessary to underline the fact that the problematic of the globalisation possesses numerous incidences on the societies.* ✓ *Globalisation affects societies in several ways, and three of them matter most here.*

Also drop *In my opinion I think* (pick one), *nowadays* at the head of every paragraph, *we can say that, it is a fact that*.

Your three-minute, four-pass proofread. Not "read it through" — four separate mechanical sweeps: **articles** (every *the* before an unmodified abstract noun, and every abstract noun on the counter-list above that has lost one); **plurals** (*information / research / advice / knowledge / evidence / equipment* carrying an *s*); **commas** (any comma with a complete sentence on both sides); **-s** (every present-simple verb with a singular subject).

Chapter 8 owns this procedure — the same four passes, with the timings and the Arabic and French sweeps that sit alongside them. One rule from there is worth importing because it is the one people break under time pressure: **in the three minutes you may delete and repair; you may not add.** A new sentence written at minute 39 is unproofread by definition, and it is the sentence most likely to carry an error into a script that was otherwise clean.

Self-test checklist

Run this on every practice essay before you look at any answer key. Any *no* is a named repair.

1. Can I underline the final instruction line and say how many separate demands it makes?
2. Does my essay contain one clearly identifiable paragraph per demand?
3. Is my introduction free of any clause lifted verbatim from the prompt?
4. Is my position stated in the introduction, in one unambiguous sentence?
5. Does every body topic sentence carry my stance or the demand it answers, rather than just announcing a topic?
6. Does each body paragraph make all four moves — claim, because, so what, instance?
7. Is there a concrete instance in at least two paragraphs, from my own knowledge or experience, with no invented statistics?
8. Am I **at or above 260** words, counting only words I wrote myself — with 270–290 as the comfortable target, and **no upper limit** beyond what I can still proofread in three minutes?

(See M6: there is a floor, not a ceiling. Do not cut 320 well-developed words to satisfy a number this book never set.)

9. Are there four or five paragraphs, each separated by a blank line?
10. Does any paragraph contain more than two discourse markers — and does any paragraph contain none?
11. Have I used at least three reference or substitution devices (*this shift, these pressures, the former, one, so*)?
12. Have I hedged every sweeping generalisation with *tend to, often, in most cases*?
13. Does my conclusion give a *reason* for the verdict rather than repeating the introduction in other words?
14. Counting sentences: are at least **six of about sixteen** completely error-free (see the GRA decoder)?
15. Have I run all four proofread passes — articles, plural uncountables, comma splices, third-person -s?
16. Is the essay free of *e.g., etc.*, bullet points and sub-headings?

What is still unsettled

- **Rhetorical questions.** No official rule exists either way; the recommendation above is derived from descriptor logic, not quoted.
- **Which task to write first.** No official preference exists. Decide it in your own timed practice.
- **Whether copied rubric literally comes off the word count.** Official sources say it is discounted and earns no credit but never state the mechanics; independent teaching authorities say the words are not counted. Assume they are not.
- **The exact Writing band formula.** The 1:2 weighting is official; the precise arithmetic and rounding rule is not published. Chapter 1 covers this.

CHAPTER 6

6

Speaking: All Three Parts

WHAT IT IS WORTH

A quarter of your overall

WHY IT MATTERS

Four criteria, equally weighted, one of them free.

FULL READ

~61 min

60-second summary

Read this first. Everything after it is the evidence and the drills.

Speaking is 11–14 minutes in three parts — a 4–5 minute interview, a 1–2 minute long turn from a card with one minute to prepare and one or two short **rounding-off questions** after it, and a 4–5 minute abstract discussion — with a live examiner, recorded, marked on four equally weighted criteria. You are rated on your **average across all parts**, and you must **fully** fit a band to be awarded it. "Face-to-face" means a live examiner in real time, not necessarily in the room; video call is a real mode, you do not choose it, and the partners' own research — 99 test-takers in Shanghai, 2015, each sitting both modes — found the score difference negligibly small. You are computer-delivered, so plan for Speaking on the **same day** — and trust your booking confirmation over any published window.

The most widely mistaught thing about this test is the 6→7 Fluency line. Band 7 still hesitates, still repeats, still self-corrects — **often mid-sentence** — and that hesitation is still about reaching for language. The only requirement is that it does not break coherence; hesitating about *content* is band 8. So the trainable skill is **sentence recovery**: when you stall, hold the structure and finish it — pause and breathe, or paraphrase round the missing word. Abandon and restart only when the proposition is genuinely gone. Repeating your own last two or three words is a rescue that works, but keep it rare: repetition is a **descending** feature of the whole scale — bands 8 and 9 are defined by *very occasional* repetition, band 6 names it as a coherence-breaker, and band 5 is defined by *relying on it* [src: ielts.org — Speaking band descriptors (PDF, 2025), bands 9–5 Fluency & Coherence].

Grammar has moved too — but read the tolerance strictly. Band 7 permits **a few** basic errors to persist; band 8 permits that a few *may* persist. *A few* is a density claim, and accuracy is officially rated on **error density** [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023)]. The IELTS-published study puts third-person -s at **70.6% error at band 6 and 7.6% at band 7** [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019 — Speaking data, L1 mix unreported], so an *occasional* dropped -s will not keep you at 6 and a *habitual* one is precisely what does. Get it down to occasional in writing practice, where you have time to monitor; then stop hunting slips in the room and make complex sentences **land** — six of them, drilled to automaticity.

Pronunciation holds your cheapest band-point. Band 7 has no features of its own: it is all of band 6 plus some of band 8. Band 6 now names **chunking**, **stress-timing** and **rapid speech rate** — the exact three prosodic habits that transfer from French and Arabic — and band 8's named feature is

sustained rhythm. Buy the rhythm: the three-beat drill and the slash drill, daily. Add the paper-strip aspiration drill, because your /p/ problem is almost certainly missing air, not a missing sound. Drill English **final** clusters, and test — do not assume — whether you have any initial-cluster problem at all, because Tunisian Arabic probably gives you those for free.

Accent is never rated in itself, only through its effect on intelligibility, and it does not appear at bands 6 or 7 at all. Spend nothing on sounding British.

And close the one loop this book cannot: record every Part 2 on your phone, and listen back for speech rate, stress-timing and chunking. Nothing else. Those three are the difference.

What the test actually asks

Speaking is **11–14 minutes** in three parts, with a live examiner, and it is **recorded** [src: ielts.org —

Academic Speaking test format] [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Test format explained].

Part	Time	What happens
1 — Interview	4–5 min	Examiner introduces themselves, checks your ID, then asks general questions on home, family, work, studies, interests
2 — Long turn	3–4 min	You get a task card, 1 minute to prepare and make notes , then speak 1–2 minutes , then answer one or two short rounding-off questions
3 — Discussion	4–5 min	Questions connected to the Part 2 topic, treated generally and abstractly

Four criteria — **Fluency & Coherence, Lexical Resource, Grammatical Range & Accuracy, Pronunciation** — at **25% each** [src: ielts.org — Academic Speaking test format] [src: ielts.idp.com — Mastering IELTS Speaking: fluency and coherence].

Three words you need before the rest of this chapter makes sense

All three are named in the official band-6 Pronunciation cell, so this box is also the fastest way to make the descriptor decoder below legible [src: ielts.org — Speaking band descriptors (PDF, 2025), band 6 Pronunciation].

- **Chunking** — grouping words into meaning units and pausing only at the joins: *To be honest, / the thing I value most / is an old watch*. Pausing in the **middle** of a unit is what makes ordinary hesitation sound like breakdown.
- **Stress-timing** — English keeps its stressed beats roughly evenly spaced in time and squashes everything between them. French and Arabic give every syllable roughly equal length. This is the single biggest audible difference between your English and a band-8 delivery, and it is a motor habit, not a set of new sounds.
- **Schwa** — the weak, neutral vowel English uses in almost every **unstressed** syllable: the *a* in *about*, the *er* in *water*, the vowel in *the* when you are not emphasising it. It is close to the French *e* in *le* and *je*. Stress-timing works *by* crushing unstressed syllables into schwa; French does not crush them, which is exactly why your rhythm comes out flat and even. Wherever

this chapter shows a phonetic symbol, an ordinary-letters respelling is printed beside it — you never need to read the symbols.

Two footnotes on the official grid matter more than candidates realise. **Note (i):** you must *fully* fit a band's positive features to be awarded it — partly fitting band 7 is a 6. **Note (ii):** you are rated on your **average performance across all parts** [src: ielts.org — Speaking band descriptors (PDF, 2025)]. A shaky Part 1 decides nothing. Do not walk out of it defeated; you have nine more minutes of evidence to produce.

"Face-to-face" does not mean "in the room." ielts.org calls it "a face-to-face interview"; the British Council says it "can be conducted face-to-face or via video call" and that the video version "maintains the face-to-face feature" (sources above). Both are accurate. In IELTS copy, *face-to-face* means **a live human examiner in real-time two-way interaction** — not a recording, not a machine. It does not promise the examiner is present. In Video Call Speaking you sit at the centre with a computer and headset, an invigilator sets up the technology, the Part 2 topic appears **on screen**, and pen and paper are still provided [src: ielts.idp.com — Speaking format: face-to-face vs video call]. **You do not choose the mode** — it follows from the centre you book (same source). Nor should it change your preparation: the partners' own research — **99 test-takers in Shanghai in 2015, each sitting both modes**, in a study its own authors describe as a preliminary comparison — found scores essentially equivalent, the difference "negligibly small", with **80% of examiners** judging the modes to give equal opportunity [src: ielts.org — Exploring performance across two delivery modes, Phase 2]. One useful behavioural finding: under video-conferencing **63.3%** of candidates asked for clarification in Part 1, against **26.7%** face-to-face. Have the phrases ready.

When is it? The official pages disagree, including with each other. The British Council's FAQ says same day or "seven days before or two days after" [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Frequently asked questions]; its own test-format page says "seven days before or after". IDP says up to seven days either side for paper, and for computer-delivered, **the same day, before or after the other three papers** [src: ielts.idp.com — What to expect on test day]. You are computer-delivered: **plan for the same day, and trust your booking confirmation over any published window**. Practical consequence — you may speak after 2h40 of Listening, Reading and Writing, so rehearse some Part 2 drills late in a study session, tired, not fresh at the start.

Asking for help. The rules differ by part, and the split is **officially stated**, part by part, in the same Cambridge FAQ document this book relies on elsewhere:

"You should tell the examiner that you don't understand. **In Part 1, the examiner will be able to repeat the question. In Part 2 you should look carefully at the task card** because you may be able to guess the meaning of a word you have not understood. **In Part 3, the examiner will be able to repeat the question or ask it in a different way, or may be able to help you to understand the question. If you don't understand a word, the examiner will be able to give you a brief explanation.**" [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module (PDF), p.11]

Part	Repetition?	Explanation / rephrasing?
1	Yes	No — repetition is the only help named, and the examiner is reading a fixed script
2	n/a — no question during the long turn	No — you are told to work with the card you were given
3	Yes	Yes — the examiner may rephrase <i>and</i> may explain a word

The table is the official paragraph read by contrast: repetition is named for Parts 1 and 3; rephrasing and word explanation are named **only** for Part 3, and Part 2 is told to consult the card instead. The same page states the limit that makes the permission usable: "The most important thing is not to ask the examiner to repeat every question or explain every word" (same source).

There is a descriptor argument underneath it too, and it is airtight: the grid rates four things, and **listening comprehension is not one of them**. Asking for a repeat cannot cost you a mark; guessing and answering a different question can, through coherence.

Question types, one by one

Part 1 — Introduction and interview

ASSESSED

not your life — whether you can produce fluent, accurate, appropriately worded English about predictable everyday content, across a spread of tenses [src: ielts.org — The three parts of IELTS Speaking]. IDP adds what is listened for here specifically: cohesive devices, varied language for personal experience, clear speech at an appropriate pace with proper intonation and rhythm [src: ielts.idp.com — Speaking Part 1].

Part 1 runs in **topic blocks of about four questions**. The official transcript shows the examiner saying "Let's talk about your home town or village", asking four questions, then "Let's move on to talk about accommodation" — reading verbatim, adding nothing [src: ielts.org — Speaking sample tasks (PDF, 2023)]. Confirmed families: home town, accommodation, family, work, studies, interests, your country, personal experiences. Longer lists on preparation sites are aggregated candidate reports, not an official inventory.

Technique: answer + reason + detail, two to six sentences. That range is official, and bare yes/no answers are named as a mistake because they showcase nothing [src: ielts.idp.com — Seven mistakes to avoid]. Better formulation: **extend before the examiner has to ask "why?"** Then three cheap wins. **Match the tense to the question** — Part 1 frames deliberately sample tense ("What kind of place is it?" present; "How long have you lived there?" present perfect; "What sort of accommodation would you most like?" conditional, all in the official frame), and answering a present-perfect question in the past is a named common error. **Do not parrot the question** — "Do I enjoy cooking? Well, I do enjoy cooking..." burns three seconds and forfeits a paraphrase, which

Lexical Resource is graded on at bands 6, 7 and 8. **Control which version of your life you present** – do not claim you both work and study; the examiner expects you to choose. Pick the version you have the best vocabulary for.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Do you prefer studying at home, or somewhere else?

Band 6. "I prefer at home. It is more quiet and I can concentrate better. Yes, that's it."

Nothing is wrong; nothing reaches 7 either. Two short clauses, nothing less common, no complex structure, no willingness to hold the floor.

Band 7. "At home, mostly – though it depends what I'm doing. If I'm just reading, the flat is fine. But for anything that needs real concentration I'll walk down to the café on the corner, because at home there's always someone wanting something. Which is odd, really: noise I don't control seems to bother me less than noise I do."

One conditional, one contrast, one causal clause, an elliptical opener, a piece of stance. Twelve seconds, nothing rare in it.

TRAPS

Over-answering – 4–5 minutes and eight to twelve questions; examiners stop long answers to manage time and being stopped does not lower your score [src: ieltsliz.com – Why the examiner stops your answer], but an answer that forces a cut-off gained nothing three sentences would not have.

Memorised openers – "examiners are highly trained to spot memorised answers, which never bodes well" [src: ielts.org – Don't overdo it], and Part 1 is where the rehearsed hometown paragraph appears. *Register collapse* – "Concerning my domicile, it is situated..." is not sophistication; band-7 Lexical Resource requires **awareness of style**, and French academic register in spoken English fails it. (*Register* = the level of formality a piece of language belongs to – the difference between *my place*, *my flat* and *my domicile*. [Chapter 7](#) §3 is the full treatment; in Speaking the formal end is the wrong end.)

BAND-6 FAILURE MODE

two-clause answers that are grammatically fine and completely flat. "Yes, I like cooking. It's very nice."

Part 2 – The long turn

ASSESSED

talking continuously about a topic and developing ideas about it. The only uninterrupted monologue in the test, so it is where Fluency & Coherence is most exposed.

What the card says. You will talk for **one to two minutes**, you have **one minute to think**, and "you can make some notes to help you if you wish" — notes are **optional**. The examiner's frame before you start includes: *"Remember you have one to two minutes for this, so don't worry if I stop you. I'll tell you when the time is up."* [src: ielts.org — Speaking sample tasks (PDF, 2023)] Being stopped is announced as normal **before you speak**. Pencil and paper are provided [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Practice test, Speaking Part 2]. Three concrete bullets plus a final explain-clause is the standard shape:

Describe a skill you learned from someone in your family. You should say: what the skill is · who taught it to you and when · how you practised it — and explain why this skill still matters to you.

The one minute. Keywords, never sentences — roughly the first 35 seconds, one or two words per bullet, reminders not a script [src: ieltsadvantage.com — Speaking Part 2 tips] [src: e2language.com — Note-taking in Speaking Part 2]. Lay the paper out as four boxes for the three bullets plus the final clause, abbreviate, and **keep writing until told to start** [src: ielts.idp.com — Speaking Part 2]. The move that buys a band: **plan the grammar, not just the content** — decide which structures you will show, which is exactly what band-7 GRA requires.

bullet 1	→	2-3 keywords	+ one specific: a name, a number, a place
bullet 2	→	2-3 keywords	+ the tense I'll use here
bullet 3	→	2-3 keywords	
why/how	→	the feeling word + one comparison	
SPARE	→	if I dry up: how I felt / compare to X / would I do it again	

The SPARE line is the insurance against the 40-second collapse. Write it every time.

Sustaining two minutes. Paraphrase the card, then go bullet by bullet with markers between. IDP suggests "Today I would like to describe ... to you" — serviceable, but a fixed opener used by thousands of candidates is exactly what examiners notice. Vary it. When you run dry, the extension moves are: describe the people or place · compare it to something · a past memory · a future hope · your opinion · a recommendation [src: ieltsliz.com — Speaking Part 2 tips]. Glance back at the card, and **always say yes** if asked whether you have more to add. Speak at a **measured** pace and breathe between sentences — not a soft tip: "a rapid speech rate" is a named cause of band-6 rhythm failure [src: ielts.org — Speaking band descriptors (PDF, 2025)]. Speeding up to *seem* fluent caps your Pronunciation band.

Worked example — the first fifteen seconds of that card.

Band 6. "I want to talk about a skill I learned from my family. The skill is cooking. My grandmother taught me the cooking. She taught me when I was young, maybe ten years old. It was very nice."

Every sentence the same shape, the card echoed rather than paraphrased, and no forward momentum.

Band 7. "The one that comes to mind is bread — flatbread, specifically, the kind my grandmother made every second morning. I'd been watching her do it for years before she ever let me touch the dough, and when she finally did, around the summer I turned eleven, it turned out that watching had taught me almost nothing."

A relative clause, a past perfect continuous, a *when*-clause, and an idea with somewhere to go. It also plants specifics — *every second morning, the summer I turned eleven* — which is what stops you stalling at fifty seconds.

Finishing early is the real risk, not being stopped. In the official transcript the sample candidate stops well short of two minutes; the examiner says "Thank you" and moves on. Nothing rescues you, and band-7 Fluency requires readily producing **long turns**. If time runs out first, "don't worry... you have already shown the examiner that you can speak at length" [src: ielts.idp.com — Speaking Part 2]. And being stopped is not merely harmless — it is official confirmation that you did the task: "Don't worry if the examiner stops you in the Part 2 long turn. **It means you have spoken for 2 minutes.** The examiner has to keep to the timing of the test" [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module (PDF), p.10]. The same document sets the target explicitly: "You should try to talk for the full 2 minutes to give the examiner a good sample of your English" (p.11). What you will *also* read elsewhere — that you must signal when you finish early — is unsupported by anything official, and the official transcript shows the examiner simply moving on after a short turn with no signal from the candidate. **Keep going until you are stopped; aim to be stopped.**

The rounding-off questions — an examined stretch of speech almost nobody prepares.

"Rounding off questions" is IELTS's own heading on the published sample task card, which carries two of them, and the official transcript shows the examiner asking one immediately after saying "Thank you", with the candidate answering in a couple of clauses before Part 3 begins [src: ielts.org — Speaking sample tasks (PDF, 2023), p.5]. They sit **inside Part 2** and are rated on the same four criteria as everything else. Three things to know:

- **What they look like.** One or two short, concrete, closed questions about the same thing you have just described — its value, whether it could be replaced, whether other people share it, whether you would do it again. Originals in the same shape, for the family-skill card above: *Do many people your age still learn to do that? · Would you teach it to someone else?*
- **How long the answer should be — and this is the one place in the test where short is correct.** Cambridge says so directly: "A short answer is usually expected only when the examiner asks a question at the end of the long turn in Part 2 as they need to move on to Part 3 of the test" [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module (PDF), p.10]. Do not launch a second long turn here. Over-running eats Part 3, which is where band 7 is actually won.
- **The band-6 mistake, and it is audible.** A bare "Yes." or "No, it wouldn't." landing immediately after two minutes of your best English. The examiner hears the **drop in level** between the long turn and the rounding-off answer, and the four criteria do not pause for it. **The shape that fixes it: answer + one clause, then stop.**

Would you teach it to someone else?

Band 6. "Yes. Maybe."

Band 7. "I'd like to, yes — though I suspect I'd be a far less patient teacher than she was."

One sentence, a stance marker, a **hedge** (*I suspect* — softening a claim so that it is defensible instead of asserting it flat; the full kit is below in Part 3) and a comparative. Still short, still not flat.

The eight card shapes, and the tense each one hands you. IELTS publishes no taxonomy of cue cards, so treat this as a **preparation heuristic, not an official list**. What is official is only that the card "asks you to talk about a particular topic" and "instructs you to explain one aspect of the topic" [src: ielts.org — Academic Speaking test format], and that the published sample card is an *object* card. The reason to map the shapes anyway is specific to you: **card shape decides tense, and tense is your costliest grammar area**. [Chapter 4](#) does exactly this for Task 1 visuals; Part 2 deserves the same table. Every example card below is mine, not IELTS's.

Card family	Example card (original)	Tenses it hands you	One structure worth planting	Characteristic failure
Person	<i>Describe a teacher who changed how you study.</i>	past simple for events · <i>used to</i> / <i>would</i> for habits · present for what is still true	habitual <i>would</i> : <i>She'd always start by...</i>	telling it entirely in present simple, so nothing is anchored in time
Place	<i>Describe a part of your city you take visitors to.</i>	present simple for description · present perfect for change · <i>there is</i> / <i>there are</i>	present perfect for change: <i>It's become much busier since...</i>	listing features with no change and no evaluation — a postcard, not a turn
Object	<i>Describe something you have kept for a long time.</i>	present for description · past simple for how you got it · present perfect for duration	present perfect + <i>for</i> / <i>since</i> : <i>I've had it for about nine years</i>	<i>I have it since</i> — the French/Arabic present for English present perfect
Event or experience	<i>Describe a journey that did not go as planned.</i>	past simple for the sequence · past continuous for background · past perfect for what came before	past perfect: <i>We'd already missed the first connection when...</i>	one flat chain of past simples joined by <i>and then</i>
Activity or habit	<i>Describe something you do every week to relax.</i>	present simple + frequency adverbs · <i>tend to</i> · present continuous for the current phase	<i>I tend to...</i> <i>whenever...</i>	drifting into the past because it feels more like a story
Media — a book, film or programme	<i>Describe a documentary that taught you something.</i>	present simple for the content (<i>the film follows...</i>) · past simple for your viewing of it	reported speech / <i>what struck me was...</i>	narrating the whole plot and never reaching <i>why it mattered</i>
Abstract idea or quality	<i>Describe a skill you think every adult should have.</i>	present simple for generalisation · modals for obligation · second conditional	second conditional: <i>If more people could do it, we'd...</i>	slipping into Part 3 essay mode with no concrete example at all

Card family	Example card (original)	Tenses it hands you	One structure worth planting	Characteristic failure
Future plan or wish	<i>Describe something you would like to learn in the next few years.</i>	<i>going to / will · would like to · present continuous for arrangements · conditionals</i>	<i>I'd like to... because it would let me...</i>	using present simple throughout, which reads as a plan you have already carried out

Use it in the one-minute preparation: name the family first, write the tense on your note page (that is what the "the tense I'll use here" line in the note template is for), and only then fill in the content.

TRAPS

Reading your notes aloud — they are reminders; read them and delivery goes flat, which costs twice: flat delivery is the band-6 Pronunciation line, and a read-out register reads as memorised. *A memorised story bent to fit the card* — the commonest high-cost failure. *Racing the bullets* — three in fifty seconds and stop is worse than two covered properly for two minutes. There is no task-achievement criterion in Speaking; the long turn is what is rated.

BAND-6 FAILURE MODE

runs out at 50–70 seconds, the last twenty audible searching — "...and, erm... yeah, that's... that's basically it" — coherence fraying at the end.

Part 3 — The two-way discussion

ASSESSED

explaining opinions, and analysing, discussing and speculating about issues; depth, analysis, justification [src: ielts.org — The three parts of IELTS Speaking]. This is where 6.5 becomes 7. Parts 1 and 2 can be carried by prepared personal content. Part 3 cannot.

The answer shape is officially published: direct answer → reasons → supporting examples → alternatives or consequences (same source). In four words:

Answer → Because → For instance → Although / which means

The fourth slot separates bands, and the official version allows *alternatives or consequences* — broader and easier under pressure than a forced concession.

Expect pushback; it is designed in. "Expect to be interrupted by the examiner from time to time during this part of the test. This is completely normal." The official transcript shows an examiner interrogating the candidate's own claim four times — "Is that a new development?", "You don't think of it as a healthy way of thinking?", "Can you tell me a little bit more about that?"

[src: ielts.org — Speaking sample tasks (PDF, 2023)]. Two things follow. **You are allowed to disagree** — constant agreement is explicitly warned against, and disagreeing respectfully cannot harm you because

examiners assess coherence, grammar and pronunciation, not whether they share your view [src: ielts.org — Don't overdo it]. And **concede, then hold** — granting the point and re-establishing your own with a reason produces a concessive clause and demonstrates flexible discourse-marker use in one breath.

The three grammars Part 3 needs. The official frame moves from "things we own" to what gives people status, whether things have changed since your parents' time, and whether advertising influences buying. Three axes: **generalisation, change over time, causation**. The British Council's Part 3 material confirms the functional set and that pausing to think is acceptable [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Speaking Part 3 lesson (PDF)].

Function	Language that earns credit
Generalising, hedged	<i>tend to · on the whole · as a rule · broadly speaking · there are exceptions, but</i>
Change over time	<i>present perfect + over the last decade · used to · whereas a generation ago</i>
Speculating	<i>it's likely that · I'd imagine · that could well lead to · presumably</i>
Unreal conditions	<i>if governments were to..., they'd... · had that not happened, ...</i>
Causation	<i>which in turn · that stems largely from · the knock-on effect is · driven less by X than by Y</i>
Conceding	<i>granted, ... even so · true up to a point, but · I can see why people say that, although</i>

Hedging — softening a claim so that it is defensible, instead of asserting it flat — is not decoration: band-7 Lexical Resource requires awareness of style, and unhedged absolutes ("all young people are addicted to their phones") read as stylistically wrong *and* analytically thin. [Chapter 7](#) §5 builds the full kit; it is the cheapest band-7 lexical feature there is, because it uses no words you do not already own.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Should schools teach practical skills like cooking and basic repairs?

Band 6. "Yes, I think the schools should teach this. Because it is very useful for the life. Many students don't know how to cook or to repair. So it is a big problem, in my opinion I think."

Opinion, one reason, then a stall rescued by restating the opinion. No example, no consequence, no concession.

Band 7. "I do, yes — though I'd put it slightly differently. It's less about cooking specifically than about the fact that a lot of young people leave school without ever having had to solve a small practical problem on their own. My cousin's a good example: three years of an engineering degree, and he still had to call someone in to change a tap washer. Granted, schools are already stretched, and you can't simply keep adding subjects. But if something has to go, I'd argue a term of practical work earns its place — which over a decade would give you a generation that's noticeably less helpless."

Direct answer, reframing, a specific example, a genuine concession, a consequence.
Structurally: *less about X than about Y*, a perfect participle, a modal, a non-defining relative. Not one rare word in it.

TRAPS

Reverting to the personal — Part 3 asks about people in general, and IDP says the examiner will actively push you off personal ground: "If you try and talk about yourself and your family, the examiner will steer you away from these familiar topics and will encourage you to speak in a general way", the instruction being to "discuss all topics in a general manner" [src: ielts.idp.com — How to perform at your best in part 3 of the Speaking test, fetched 2026-07-31]. Use yourself as an example *inside* a general claim, never as the claim. *Length inflation* — longer than Part 1, but still answers, not speeches. The same page's positive instruction is "It is important that you attempt to extend your responses as much as you can" (same source), which is the ceiling *and* the floor: extend, do not orate. *Silence* — saying something imperfect beats saying nothing, and the reason is the grid rather than any teaching page: going off-topic is a **coherence** risk, because relevance to the purpose of the turn is a named coherence indicator, and a bare non-answer is a **fluency** risk, because band 7 is defined by readily producing long turns. *Over-asking for clarification* — allowed here, and the same IDP page confirms it ("Your examiner will explain a term to you if you ask"), but not on every question; stop after two attempts and pivot.

BAND-6 FAILURE MODE

opinion, one reason, stall — then rescue by restating the opinion in different words.

Tips & tricks

1. Train sentence recovery, not hesitation elimination. [expert consensus — descriptor-derived, not officially stated] The band-7 Fluency cell says hesitation, repetition and self-correction **do** occur at 7, often mid-sentence, and **do** signal difficulty accessing language — the only requirement is that they not affect coherence [src: ielts.org — Speaking band descriptors (PDF, 2025)]. So the target is not silence; it is a thread that survives. **In order of preference when you stall mid-clause:**

1. **Pause, breathe, and complete the structure you started.** A filled pause costs less than a repeat.
2. **If the word is gone, route round it.** Paraphrase is separately credited in Lexical Resource at bands 6, 7 and 8.
3. **Only if both fail, repeat your last two or three words and continue the same structure.**

Keep step 3 rare, and note why the tag on this tip is not **[verified]**: the descriptor *tolerates* repetition at band 7, it does not reward manufacturing it. Repetition is a **descending** feature of the entire scale — bands 8 and 9 are defined as "fluent with only very occasional repetition or self-correction", band 6 names repetition as a thing through which "coherence may be lost at times", and band 5 is *defined* by relying on repetition to keep going [src: ielts.org — Speaking band descriptors (PDF, 2025), bands 9–5 Fluency & Coherence]. The assessment criteria list "functionless repetitions of words and phrases" as a negative continuity indicator [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023)] — and the examiner cannot see inside your head to classify yours as functional. He hears repetition and rates density. **When this fails:** if the proposition is genuinely gone, end the clause short, breathe, and open a clean new sentence rather than forcing the wreckage.

2. Buy band-8 features in Pronunciation. **[verified]** Band 7 in Pronunciation has no features of its own; it is all of band 6 plus "**some, but not all**" of band 8 [src: ielts.org — Speaking band descriptors (PDF, 2025), band 7 Pronunciation]. Band 8 lists five positive features, so *some* means budget for **two**, not one. Take **sustained rhythm** first — the cheapest, because it is a motor habit rather than a set of new sounds — then **flexible stress and intonation across long utterances**, which the same drills give you. Drills below.

3. Stop hunting basic slips — once they are already occasional — and make complex sentences land. **[verified]** Band-7 GRA states that both simple and complex sentences are used effectively despite some errors, and that **a few** basic errors persist; band 8 says a few *may* persist. Read *a few* strictly. It is a density claim, and accuracy is officially rated on **error density** [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023)]. The IELTS-published study measured third-person -s at **70.6% error at band 6 and 7.6% at band 7** [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019 — Speaking data, L1 mix unreported] — so an *occasional* dropped -s will not keep you at 6, and a *habitual* one is exactly what does. Fix the habit in writing practice until it is occasional (**Chapter 8**). Then stop monitoring it in speech and spend the attention on making the conditional land — a botched conditional costs the whole proposition.

4. Mark your attitude. **[verified]** Indicating your attitude to the content — favourable, neutral, unfavourable — is a named Lexical Resource indicator that almost nobody trains [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023)]. *Regrettably · to be fair · worryingly · it's encouraging that · I'm not entirely convinced*. In Part 3 this is usually worth more than a rare noun.

5. Use real-word fillers; drop the non-word sounds. **[verified]** Spoken discourse markers **and fillers** are listed in the official criteria as a device for marking the stages of a discussion (same source). "Well", "to be honest", "let me see" carry language; "umm" carries none. **When this fails:** overuse of markers is itself a band-5 feature — one or two stock phrases across the whole test, not one per answer.

6. Self-correct once, fast, and only when the error obscures meaning. [verified] Self-correction is a *limiting* feature at every band from 4 to 9; there is no band at which more is better. GRA accuracy is rated on **error density** and the **communicative effect** of errors, so an error that does not obscure meaning is the cheapest kind to leave alone. Never correct twice; never return to a finished sentence.

7. Drill the named range indicators, not "complex sentences" in the abstract. [verified] The official list: sentence length, subordinate clauses, verb-phrase complexity (perfect and continuous aspect, **modality**, the **passive**), phrase complexity (modification before and after the head noun), and **moving elements for information focus** — that last meaning *clefting* and *fronting*, which are simply the two ways English reorders a plain sentence to put the spotlight on one part of it: *What really matters is...* · *It's the parents who...* · *That, I think, is the real issue.* ([Chapter 8 §7](#) has the patterns.) Almost no band-6 candidate does it.

8. Speak in spoken sentences, not written ones. [verified] The official definition of a "spoken sentence" includes verbless structures and ellipsis doing a sentence's job. "Depends on the country, really." is **not an error**. Forcing every utterance into a full written sentence solves a problem that does not exist and costs you on style.

9. Aim to be stopped in Part 2. [verified] Being stopped is pre-announced and harmless; finishing at fifty seconds forfeits the long-turn evidence band 7 requires.

How to rehearse being stopped when nobody is there to stop you. Practising alone, an audible timer trains the exact reflex you are trying to unlearn: the beep teaches you to stop yourself, and self-halting at 1:20 is the band-6 failure mode. So make the clock **silent and invisible** — start your phone's voice recorder, put the phone face down, and speak until you genuinely run out. Check the length afterwards, never during. Three rules for reading the result:

- **Under 1:50** — that turn does not count. You stopped yourself. Note which bullet you were on when the momentum died, and add that content to your SPARE line.
- **1:50 to 2:00, still going when you checked** — a pass. You produced a full long turn under your own steam, which is the thing the examiner's interruption is a receipt for.
- **Past 2:00** — also a pass, and the most useful one: it proves you have more than two minutes of material, which is what makes being stopped feel like an interruption rather than a rescue.

Recording it is free, because tip 13 and the three-check procedure at the end of *L1 alert* need the same recording anyway. One take, four uses.

10. Never reuse the same words across the test. [verified] It signals limited spoken vocabulary [[src: ielts.idp.com — Seven mistakes to avoid](#)]. If you have said *important* three times, the fourth should be *decisive* or *what really counts*.

11. Do not import written connectives. [verified] "Furthermore" and "moreover" sound wrong spoken, and overuse of cohesive features is named at band 5. Spoken English links with *the thing is* · *mind you* · *which is why* · *that said* · *then again*.

12. If you blank, say so in good English. [verified] "I'm so sorry, my mind's just gone completely blank" is itself a display of lexical resource [src: ielts.org — Don't overdo it]. Silence is not.

13. Record every practice answer. [expert consensus] The one feedback channel a text-based coaching system cannot supply — see the end of *L1 alert*.

Myths that hold you back

"At band 7 your hesitation should be about ideas, not words." The most widely taught error about this test. The current band-7 Fluency cell says the opposite: hesitation, repetition and self-correction occur at 7, **often mid-sentence**, and they *do* indicate difficulty accessing language — the requirement is only that coherence survives. Hesitating about *content* is the **band 8** line. **Why it hurts:** unreachable bar, wrong practice target.

"Study the Cambridge public-version descriptors." That file was created in 2008 and last modified in 2013; the current descriptors carry a 2025 revision. Studying the old one means missing chunking, stress-timing, rapid speech rate, and the band-7 GRA clauses — most of what tells you what to do. Some official partner pages still quote the old wording; being on an official site does not make a document current.

"Content is irrelevant — the examiner only marks language." Half true, dangerously stated. **Relevance of your spoken sentences to the general purpose of the turn is a named coherence indicator** [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023)], topic development is rated explicitly at the top bands, and IDP states that failing to address the question risks marks deducted for coherence. **Correct version:** your story need not be *true* — nobody verifies it — but it must be **relevant and developed**.

"Learn a British or American accent." ielts.org explicitly warns against manufacturing an accent you do not have. *Accent* appears in the descriptors only at bands 8 and 9, and only as **effect on intelligibility**. **Why it hurts:** it eats the weeks that should go to rhythm, stress, and the three or four phonemes that actually cost you clarity.

"Memorise strong answers for common topics." Examiners are trained to spot memorised answers, and memorised utterances are named as a **band 2/3** feature in the grid itself. **Correct version:** flexible frameworks, **collocations** — the word partnerships English habitually uses, *strike a balance* rather than *hit a balance*; [Chapter 7 §1](#) is where they are defined and drilled — and functional language. Never scripts.

"Use idioms to prove your Lexical Resource." Band 7 asks for *some* ability with less common items **and awareness of style and collocation**. A forced idiom fails both to gain one. The right ordinary word beats the wrong unusual one.

"Open every answer with 'That's an interesting question'." Overuse of discourse markers is a band-5 feature, and using them "not always appropriately" is band 6's fault. A stock opener on every answer is overuse *and* a memorised-language flag.

"Speak fast to sound fluent." Rapid speech rate is a named cause of band-6 rhythm failure. Fluency is continuity of production, not words per minute — speed buys nothing on Fluency and caps Pronunciation.

"Correct every mistake so the examiner knows you know." Self-correction is a limiting feature at every band from **4 to 9**; there is no band at which more is better. Frequent correction cannot raise a band and can lower Fluency by a full band via the "coherence lost" clause.

"Never ask the examiner to repeat." The four criteria contain no comprehension component, and the permission is now quotable rather than derived: "In Part 1, the examiner will be able to repeat the question... In Part 3, the examiner will be able to repeat the question or ask it in a different way... If you don't understand a word, the examiner will be able to give you a brief explanation" [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module (PDF), p.11]. Asking cannot cost a mark; guessing and answering a different question can. **Real caveat, also official:** word explanation is named only for Part 3, and the same page warns against asking the examiner "to repeat every question or explain every word".

"You must cover all three bullet points." If time runs out first, "don't worry... you have already shown the examiner that you can speak at length" [src: ielts.idp.com — Speaking Part 2]. There is no task-achievement criterion in Speaking.

"You must signal if you finish Part 2 early." Unsupported — no official source says so, and the official transcript shows the examiner simply moving on after a short turn with no signal from the candidate [src: ielts.org — Speaking sample tasks (PDF, 2023), p.5]. What *is* official is the other, reassuring half of the same folklore: being stopped means you got there. "Don't worry if the examiner stops you in the Part 2 long turn. **It means you have spoken for 2 minutes.** The examiner has to keep to the timing of the test" [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS FAQs, Academic module (PDF), p.10], and "You should try to talk for the full 2 minutes to give the examiner a good sample of your English" (p.11). **Do instead:** keep going until you are stopped; aim to be stopped, and treat the interruption as a receipt, not a rebuke.

"Arabic speakers must drill initial clusters – *istudy, ispring*." Probably not you. See *L1 alert*.

"You can't get band 7 with an obvious accent, or with basic grammar slips." Both false, with one condition attached to the second. Accent is not mentioned at 6 or 7 at all. Band-7 GRA permits **a few** basic errors to *persist*, and band 8 permits that a few *may* persist – but *a few* is a density statement, not a blanket amnesty, and at a 70% omission rate your -s is not "a few", it is the band-6 profile (Tip 3). **Why it matters:** the opposite belief pushes you into slow, over-monitored speech, trading a real Fluency band for an imaginary Grammar gain – but the cure is fixing the habit on paper first, not ignoring it forever.

"Speaking is always seven days before or after the written test." Partner-specific and internally contradicted – see above. For computer-delivered, same day is the expectation, and planning recovery time you will not get is expensive.

"Video-call Speaking is easier or harder, so pick your centre accordingly." You do not choose, and the partners' own research found the difference negligibly small, with 80% of examiners judging the modes equivalent.

Band descriptor decoder

Paraphrased from the current official descriptors [src: ielts.org — Speaking band descriptors (PDF, 2025)], with operational definitions from [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023)]. One short quotation per criterion; everything not in quotation marks is paraphrase.

Each criterion runs bands 8 down to 5. Band 5 is here on purpose: your baseline is undiagnosed, a first recorded Part 2 can land at 5.5, and a decoder that stops at 6 gives you no language for what you actually produced. Read the band-5 row first, find the sentence that describes your own recording, and work upward from there.

Fluency & Coherence

Band	What it means
8	Fluent, only occasional repetition or self-correction. Hesitation may still occasionally be for language, but most is about content . Topic development coherent, appropriate, relevant.
7	Keeps going, readily produces long turns, no visible effort. Hesitation, repetition and self-correction occur, often mid-sentence , and do signal difficulty reaching the right language – but <i>"these will not affect coherence."</i> Markers, connectives and cohesive features used flexibly .
6	Keeps going, willing to produce long turns. Coherence is lost at times through hesitation, repetition or self-correction. Uses a range of markers, but not always appropriately.

Band	What it means
5	Usually able to keep going, but relies on repetition and self-correction to do so, and/or on slow speech . Hesitations are often mid-sentence searches for fairly basic lexis and grammar. Overuse of certain discourse markers and cohesive features. More complex speech usually causes disfluency; simpler language may still be fluent.

Band 5 is printed here because it is the row that diagnoses tip 1. Look at what separates it from 6: at 5 you *rely* on repetition to keep going, at 6 repetition merely costs you coherence at times, and at 7 it happens without costing coherence at all. Same behaviour, three bands, distinguished only by how load-bearing it is. That is why tip 1 makes repeating your last words step **3** and not step 1. Note also that *slow speech* appears as a band-5 limiter – which is the other jaw of the trap the Pronunciation section closes with: slow costs Fluency, fast costs Pronunciation.

The 6→7 jump is coherence survival, not silence.

Band 6 – thread dropped: "I think it depends on... the government should – well, actually the *parents* should... hmm. What was I... sorry. Yes, so, parents."

Band 7 – same hesitation, thread intact: "I think it depends largely on – well, on how early it starts, really. If children are taught to budget at, say, ten or eleven, then by the time they're earning they've already got the habit."

Two visible language-searches in the band-7 version. Neither loses the sentence. The examiner hears a speaker retrieving language, not a speaker losing control.

Lexical Resource

Band	What it means
8	Wide resource, used readily and flexibly across all topics for precise meaning. Skilful use of less common and idiomatic items despite occasional slips. Paraphrases effectively.
7	Used flexibly across a variety of topics. Some ability with less common and idiomatic items; awareness of style and collocation visible, though inappropriate choices occur. " <i>Effective use of paraphrase as required.</i> "
6	Sufficient to discuss topics at length. Word choice may be inappropriate, but meaning comes through. Generally able to paraphrase.
5	Resource sufficient to discuss familiar <i>and</i> unfamiliar topics, but with limited flexibility . Paraphrase is <i>attempted</i> but not always with success .

Notice what band 5 does *not* say: it does not say your vocabulary is too small. It says you cannot move it around. The 5→6→7 ladder on this criterion is entirely about paraphrase – *attempted, not always successfully* at 5, *generally successful* at 6, *effective as required* at 7 – which is why the drill is rerouting round a missing word, not learning more words.

Band 6 – paraphrase succeeds, but visibly: "...the thing you use for, you know, to keep the food cold."

Band 7 – paraphrase effective, plus collocation: "...some sort of cold storage – a chill cabinet, I suppose you'd call it."

Neither *cold storage* nor *chill cabinet* is rare. They are the right collocations, produced without stalling. Paraphrase is credited **with or without noticeable hesitation** – groping audibly toward the words and getting there still counts. Not knowing a word is not the problem. Going silent is.

Grammatical Range & Accuracy

Band	What it means
8	Wide range of structures, flexibly used; majority of sentences error-free. Occasional inappropriacies, non-systematic errors. A few basic errors may persist.
7	A range of structures used flexibly. " <i>Error-free sentences are frequent.</i> " Both simple and complex sentences used effectively despite some errors. A few basic errors persist.
6	A mix of short and complex sentence forms and a variety of structures, with limited flexibility. Errors frequent in complex structures, though they rarely block communication.
5	Basic sentence forms are fairly well controlled for accuracy. Complex structures are attempted, but they are limited in range, nearly always contain errors, and may lead to the need for reformulation.

Band 5 is where the six drilled structures earn their place. At 5 a complex sentence *nearly always* breaks and you have to start it again – which costs Fluency as well, because reformulation is exactly the repetition-and-self-correction band 5's Fluency cell is built on. One collapsing conditional damages two criteria at once, and that is the whole argument for drilling six structures to automaticity rather than collecting more of them.

Read that carefully; it reverses the standard revision priority – but read the quantifier too. Band 7 does **not** demand that you eliminate article errors or missing third-person -s: those are precisely the basic errors permitted at 7, and permitted as *may* occur at 8. What it demands is that there be only **a few** of them. That is a density claim, and the official criteria rate accuracy on exactly that – "error density (the number of grammatical errors in a given amount of speech)"

[src: ielts.org – Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023)]. A candidate omitting -s seven times in ten obligatory contexts is not exploiting a band-7 tolerance; he is producing the band-6 measurement ([Chapter 8](#) has the figures and the repair). The tolerance is real once your rate is occasional, and not before.

The range clause no longer says "complex structures" either: it says a range of structures, and explicitly credits **simple sentences used effectively**.

Band 6 — complex attempted, fails: "If the government would invest more in the public transport, so the people will use it more." Two errors inside the conditional (*would* in the if-clause, *so + will*). The complex structure is the thing that broke.

Band 7 — complex lands, a basic error survives: "If the government invested more in public transport, people would use it far more readily — and that in turn take pressure off the roads." The second conditional is clean. *that in turn take* is a missing third-person -s: a basic error persisting, explicitly permitted at 7.

Drill six, in this order: second and third conditionals; concessives (*although, whereas*); non-defining relatives (*which in turn*); present perfect for change over time; the passive for generalisation (*it's often argued that*); modality (*might well, would have to, is bound to*).

Pronunciation

Band	What it means
8	Wide range of features conveying precise and subtle meaning. Can sustain appropriate rhythm. Flexible stress and intonation across long utterances, occasional lapses. Easy to understand throughout. Accent has minimal effect on intelligibility.
7	Defined only by reference to its neighbours: all the positive features of band 6, plus some — not all — of band 8.
6	Uses a range of features, but control is variable . Chunking generally appropriate, but " <i>rhythm may be affected by a lack of stress-timing and/or a rapid speech rate.</i> " Some effective use of intonation and stress, not sustained. Individual words or phonemes may be mispronounced, causing occasional lack of clarity. Can generally be understood throughout without much effort.
5	Defined only by reference to its neighbours, exactly as band 7 is: all the positive features of band 4, plus some — not all — of band 6.

Band 5 is worth reading precisely *because* it is empty. It confirms the structure this section turns on: on Pronunciation, IELTS writes out bands 9, 8, 6, 4, 2 and 1, and defines 7, 5 and 3 by reference to the rows above and below. So there is nothing to "do" at band 7 except own band 6 outright and take some of band 8 — which is the cheapest, most mechanical instruction anywhere in this test.

Bands 5 and 7 have no positive features of their own. That is not a drafting accident — it tells you exactly how to reach 7: **secure every band-6 feature completely, then buy band-8 features outright**. Band 7 asks for "*some, but not all*" of band 8's features, and band 8 lists five of them (wide range of features conveying precise and subtle meaning · sustained rhythm · flexible stress and intonation across long utterances · easily understood throughout · accent has minimal effect). *Some* of five is not one. **Budget for two: sustained rhythm** first, because it is a motor habit, then **flexible stress and intonation across long utterances**, which the same drills give you.

Band 6 delivery — syllable-timed, flat, every syllable the same length: I · THINK · THAT
· THE · GOV · ERN · MENT · SHOULD · IN · VEST · MORE

Band 7 delivery — stress-timed, prominence chosen: I think that the GOVERNment should inVEST MORE with *that, the, should* squeezed down to the weak schwa vowel — "thuht thuh... shud" — and three clear beats landing on **GOV**, **VEST** and **MORE**. **Same words. Same accent. Different band.**

One nuance the two official documents create together: the assessment criteria warn against speech that is **too slow**, because it makes the links between propositions hard to hold (a Fluency risk), while the band-6 descriptor names a **rapid** rate as a rhythm-wrecker (a Pronunciation risk). They bracket the target. Slow costs Fluency; fast costs Pronunciation. The instruction is **measured**.

YOUR L1 — ARABIC / FRENCH

L1 alert

You are a **Tunisian Arabic** L1 speaker who is also fluent in French. That is not the same as "an Arabic speaker" and not the same as "a French speaker", and the generic advice for either is partly wrong for you.

Feature	Why it transfers
/p/ heard as /b/	Tunisian Arabic has /p/ and /v/ only in loanwords, usually replaced. But French supplies [p] — the phoneme is not missing. See below.
The two <i>th</i> sounds substituted — /θ/, the <i>th</i> of <i>think</i> , becoming <i>t</i> or <i>s</i> ; /ð/, the <i>th</i> of <i>this</i> , becoming <i>d</i> or <i>z</i>	Nonstandard Arabic merges these two sounds into <i>t/d</i> or <i>s/z</i> ; French has neither at all, so French speakers substitute <i>s</i> and <i>z</i> — <i>zis</i> , <i>sink</i> .
/h/ dropped, or inserted where it doesn't belong	/h/ is absent from French, and French learners do both — deleting it from <i>heat</i> , adding it to <i>eat</i> .
Word stress drifting to the end	French has no lexical stress; prominence falls at the end of the rhythmic group. English stress moves and changes word class: PHOtograph → phoTography → photoGRAPHic.
Syllable-timing instead of stress-timing	French and Arabic are far closer to syllable-timed than English. Every syllable gets equal duration; nothing reduces to schwa.
English final consonant clusters	<i>asked</i> , <i>texts</i> , <i>strengths</i> — three or four consonants stacked at the end of a word. Arabic of any variety does not supply clusters at that density finally.

Those phonological descriptions come from descriptive linguistics, not IELTS documentation, and I have not verified them to the standard applied to the descriptor claims in this book. **The consequence, though, is fully official:** the band-6 Pronunciation cell names chunking, stress-timing and speech rate by name, and the official criteria name chunking, rhythm and stress timing, linking and elision, stress and intonation, word- and phoneme-level production, and the effort required of the listener. The 2025 descriptor has effectively published your pronunciation syllabus.

Two corrections to the standard advice

1 – the initial-cluster drill is probably not for you. Generic material tells "Arabic speakers" they will insert a vowel into initial clusters: *istudy, ispring, sitreet*. That is built on Modern Standard Arabic and on Gulf and Egyptian dialects, whose phonotactics forbid onset clusters. **Tunisian Arabic does not have that constraint** – descriptions of Tunisian phonology state that where Standard Arabic allows one consonant in an onset, Tunisian commonly has two, and initial *kt-* is allowable. Be clear about the status of that: it is a dialect-level generalisation from sources I could not verify to this book's usual standard, and it is about a population, not about you. Treat it as **strong reasoning to test, not established fact**. The test costs four minutes: record yourself saying *street, spring, school, sprint, splash, study* and listen for an inserted vowel. If it is not there, stop drilling initial clusters forever. What is much more likely to be costing you clarity is the **final** cluster – drill 7.

2 – /p/ is almost certainly not a missing phoneme. You speak French; French has [p]. The likely problem is **aspiration**: French voiceless stops /p t k/ are unaspirated, whereas English word-initial /p t k/ carry a substantial puff of air, and a /p/ with near-zero voice onset time is heard by English ears as **/b/** – *pin* arrives as *bin*, *port* as *bought*. That reframe changes the remedy completely: you are not learning a new sound, you are adding air to one you have. Two minutes a day with a strip of paper.

Seven drills, each naming what it changes

1. Aspiration – the paper-strip drill. Hold a strip of thin paper a few centimetres from your lips. Say **pin – bin · pack – back · pear – bear · port – bought · pray – bray**. The paper must visibly jump on every *p* and stay still on every *b*. Then transfer to speech: "*a perfect plan for public transport*." *Why*: band 6 tolerates mispronounced phonemes only where they cause **occasional** lack of clarity, and a systematic /p/–/b/ merge is not occasional.

2. The two *th* sounds – visible tongue, minimal pairs, connected speech. English has two of them: the voiceless one in *think* and *three*, and the voiced one in *this* and *mother*. Both are made the same way – tongue tip at or lightly between the teeth, air kept **flowing**. Diagnose your substitution first: if *think* comes out as *tink*, you are stopping the airflow with the tongue; if it comes out as *sink*, the airflow is right and the tongue is too far back. Five minutes: (i) mirror, tongue tip visible; (ii) *think, thought, author, three, this, those, mother, weather*; (iii) minimal pairs in random order – **thin/tin, thank/tank, three/tree, then/den,**

they/day, breathe/breed, plus **think/sink, thing/sing, mouth/mouse** for the French route; (iv) "*I think they'd rather breathe the other air*"; (v) **record one sentence and listen back** — step (v) is the one that transfers. *Why: think, the, this, that, they, there, with, three* are among the most frequent words in spoken English, so a systematic substitution is a running tax on intelligibility.

3. Word stress — learn the suffix rules, not the words. English stress is largely predictable from the ending, so this is a rules problem. *-ion, -ic, -ical, -ity* pull stress onto the syllable immediately before: eduCAtion, ecoNOMic, poLIitical, possiBILity. (Note where the capitals fall in the last one — *bil* is the syllable immediately before *-ity*, and *posSiBility* is the mistake this rule exists to prevent.) The endings *-graphy, -ology, -ography* behave the same way: phoT0graphy, bi0Logy, ge0Ggraphy. Two-syllable noun/verb pairs shift:

REcord/reCORD, INcrease/inCREASE, PREsent/preSENT — high-yield in Part 3, where you use both forms in one answer. *Drill:* mark the stressed syllable in capitals in your vocabulary bank for your ten most-used topic words, and **hum the word before you say it** — just the rhythm, *da-DA-da-da*. Wrong hum, wrong word. *Why:* stress is named at bands 6 and 8 and needs no new articulation — the fastest fix here.

4. Stress-timing — the three-beat drill. (No equipment. Just a table to tap on.) English squeezes unstressed syllables down to the weak schwa vowel so that the stressed beats stay evenly spaced in time. French and Arabic do not squeeze, which is why an English sentence spoken with French rhythm gets longer as you add words instead of staying the same length.

CATS · EAT · FISH The **CATS** will **EAT** the **FISH** The **CATS** would have **EATen** the **FISH**

Three beats every time — **CATS, EAT, FISH** — and each line must take **the same number of seconds to say**, even though the third line has more than twice the syllables. Tap the three beats on the table at a steady speed and force the words to fit between them. That forcing is the whole drill: *would have* has to collapse to one quick unstressed blur, "wud-uv" (never "would have" with two full vowels), and *the* has to become the weak "thuh", never "thee". Say each line five times, then check on a recording that your taps are still evenly spaced on line three. *Why:* sustained rhythm is a **band-8** feature and band 7 is band 6 plus some of band 8. This is your single most efficient route out of Pronunciation 6.

5. Chunking — the slash drill. Grouping words into thought units with the pauses at the boundaries. Pausing *inside* a chunk — flat even-tempo delivery, or a mid-phrase word search — is what breaks it.

To be honest, / the thing I value most / is an old watch / my grandfather gave me / when I turned eighteen. //

Read aloud pausing **only** at slashes. Then say it from keywords and check the recording: did the pauses land on the slashes, or in the middle of *an old / watch*? *Why*: it converts hesitation from a coherence-breaker into a normal prosodic boundary — precisely the 6-vs-7 Fluency distinction. **This drill pays into two criteria at once. No other drill here does.**

6. /h/ — the hot-air check. Palm in front of the mouth. **eat / heat · art / heart · air / hair · old / hold · I / high.** Warm air on the *h* words, nothing on the vowel-initial ones. Over-insertion matters as much as deletion: "*an 'igh 'ill*" and "*a high-old man*" are equally damaging.

7. Final clusters — the exit-consonant drill. Slow, then compress. **ask → asks → asked → he asked me. text → texts → the texts. strength → strengths.** Exaggerate the final consonants at half speed, then run them at full speed. Do not insert a vowel and do not drop the cluster — English reduces it (*asked* usually comes out as "ahst", one syllable, no *k* audible) but does not delete it: "ahs" alone is a different word. *Why here specifically*: on a video-call test, final consonants are the first thing a headset and a compressed audio channel take from the listener.

The grammar transfers — and why to mostly stop worrying about them in speech

Every written error pattern you have will surface in speech too — generic *the* on abstract nouns, pluralised uncountables, the preposition set, the false friends, *peoples are / he do not*, missing third-person -s, and French-style run-on chains. **The full lists live in [Chapter 7](#) (false friends, uncountables, spelling) and [Chapter 8](#) (articles, agreement, the counter-list of nouns that keep *the*); this chapter does not reprint them.** What differs in Speaking is only the *ranking*, and that is what this section is for.

The uncomfortable, useful truth: in **Speaking**, most of these are not what holds you at 6 — once their rate is already low. Band 7 permits **a few** basic errors to persist and band 8 permits that a few *may* persist; accuracy is rated on **error density** and on the **communicative effect** of errors. *The society is changing* costs almost nothing in comprehension. A collapsed conditional costs the whole proposition. So, in priority order:

- 1. Errors that obscure meaning** — wrong tense on a hypothetical, a false friend that inverts your point (*eventually* for *possibly* changes the claim), a preposition that flips a relationship. Fix these.
- 2. Complex structures that fail mid-flight.** Fix these by rehearsing the six structures above to automaticity — not by slowing down.
- 3. Run-on chains.** Fix these, because they are a *coherence* problem as well as a grammar one: they destroy chunking, which pays into Pronunciation too.
- 4. Articles, uncountables, third-person -s — but only once your written error rate on them is already low.** Leave them alone *during the test*; fix them in writing practice, where you have time to monitor. If your written rate is still one in three, this is not a reallocation you have earned yet — it is your binding constraint, and [Chapter 8](#) is where it gets fixed.

Point 4 is not permission to be sloppy, and it is conditional. It is a reallocation of attention: every unit of monitoring spent on articles while speaking is a unit not spent keeping the sentence alive, and abandoned sentences cost a full Fluency band where an occasional article costs nothing. But the descriptor's word is *a few*, and the IELTS-published study puts third-person -s at **70.6% error at band 6 against 7.6% at band 7** [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019 — Speaking data, L1 mix unreported]. At 70% you are not spending a tolerance, you are producing the band-6 measurement. The target is **occasional slip, not habitual omission** — the same line [Chapter 8](#) draws, and it applies in the room as much as on paper.

On accent — the official position, stated plainly

The official pronunciation indicators end with **the overall effect of accent on intelligibility** [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023)]. Accent is assessed *only* through that effect; there is no indicator for accent itself, for accent quality, or for resemblance to any native variety. In the grid the word *accent* appears exactly twice — band 9 (no effect) and band 8 (minimal effect). It appears nowhere at 6 or 7. **A Tunisian-and-French- accented delivery that is easy to follow is fully compatible with band 8.** Spend nothing on sounding British.

The one thing this book cannot do

A book cannot hear you. Everything here is testable except the thing that matters most — what you actually sound like — and no amount of reading tells you whether your pauses land at chunk boundaries or inside noun phrases.

Close that loop yourself. This is a procedure with a written output, not an intention. Record every Part 2 on your phone — the voice-memo app is enough — and run these three checks, in this order, on the same recording. Five minutes, and you write down three numbers.

1. **Speech rate.** Play the first fifteen seconds and count the words you actually produced. Write the number in your log and track it week to week. You are looking for stability, not a target: a number that jumps upward under pressure is you rushing, and a rapid rate is a named band-6 limiter. **Pass:** roughly the same count across three consecutive recordings.
2. **Stress-timing.** Play any ten seconds and tap the beats on the table as you listen. **Pass:** your taps land at roughly even intervals on the content words. **Fail:** you find yourself tapping on every syllable, because every syllable got the same length — that is the syllable-timing transfer, and drill 4 is the repair.
3. **Chunking.** Type out one sentence from the recording, then listen again and draw a slash wherever you actually paused. **Pass:** the slashes fall at the joins between meaning units. **Fail:** a slash inside a noun phrase — *an old / watch* — which is drill 5's repair.

Nothing else on the recording. Vocabulary, grammar and structure you can assess from a transcript — and your coaching system can grade a transcript. These three it cannot hear either, and these three are the difference between Pronunciation 6 and Pronunciation 7.

Self-test checklist

1. Can you state the three parts, their timings, and the four criteria with their equal weighting, from memory?
2. Do you know you are rated on your **average across all parts**, so a weak Part 1 decides nothing?
3. Have you confirmed with your centre whether Speaking is face-to-face or by video call, and whether it is the same day?
4. Can you state, per part, whether you may ask for repetition and whether you may ask for an explanation — and do you know this is officially stated, not inferred?
5. Can you explain why asking for repetition cannot cost you a mark — by naming the four criteria?
6. When you stall mid-sentence, do you finish the structure you started — by pausing, or by paraphrasing round the gap — rather than abandoning and restarting, and is repeating your own last words a rare last resort rather than your default?
7. Can you produce a Part 1 answer of four to five sentences containing one conditional or one contrast?
8. In your last five Part 2 practices, did the **silent** recording run past 1:50 every time — checked afterwards, never with an audible timer, because a beep trains you to stop yourself (tip 9) — and did you answer the rounding-off question with a *short* answer plus one clause, not a bare *yes* and not a second long turn?
9. Does your one-minute note page always include a SPARE line **and the tense the card's family hands you**?
10. Can you name the four steps of the Part 3 answer shape, and do you reach the fourth step in most answers?
11. Have you drilled all six high-yield structures to automaticity — and is your third-person -s now an *occasional* slip in written practice rather than a habit, which is the condition for being allowed to stop monitoring it in speech?
12. Have you tested your **initial** clusters on a recording and settled whether you need that drill at all?
13. Does the paper strip move on *pin* and stay still on *bin*?
14. Have you recorded a Part 2 this week and listened back for speech rate, stress-timing and chunking — and nothing else?
15. Have you practised Part 2 at the end of a long study session, tired, to rehearse same-day conditions?

The 60-second summary for this chapter is at the top, before "What the test actually asks". If you are revising, start there.

CHAPTER 7

7

The Band 7 Vocabulary System

WHAT IT IS WORTH

A quarter of Writing and of Speaking

WHY IT MATTERS

Precision beats rarity — and the scale says so.

FULL READ

~57 min

60-second summary

Read this first. Everything after it is the evidence and the word lists.

The one word you must have before anything else here makes sense: *collocation* — which words habitually keep company with which in English. You *strike* a balance, you do not *hit* one. You *pose* a threat, you do not *make* one. You *conduct* research, you do not *do a research*. Collocations are learned as whole phrases, never as single words, and they are the assessed unit: the official criteria list "control of collocations" as a sub-feature, band 7 requires that an awareness of collocation is evident, and in the official examiner comments collocation is named at **both** ends of the scale — a band-4 script faulted for it, a band-8.5 script credited for it. Rarity is named at neither [src: ielts.org — Writing key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p.4; Academic Writing sample tasks (PDF, 2023)]. This chapter is where the book defines and drills the term; the earlier chapters that lean on it are pointing here.

Lexical Resource is six things, and only one of them is range. The other five are precision, collocation, register, attitude, and spelling and word formation. If your vocabulary study has consisted of acquiring more words, you have been working on a sixth of the criterion.

At **band 6**, in Task 1 and Task 2 alike, the current descriptors describe the candidate who reaches for a wider range at the cost of accuracy: *"If the writer is a risk-taker, there will be a wider range of vocabulary used but higher degrees of inaccuracy or inappropriacy"* [src: ielts.org — Writing band descriptors PDF (May 2023), band 6 LR, T1 and T2]. That is a **positive-feature description of what a band-6 script looks like**, and the descriptors' own header says a script must **fully** fit a band's positive features to be rated there. IELTS has written the thesaurus candidate into the definition of band 6. Two official scripts prove the mechanism: same error types, same adequate range, 5.5 versus 7.5 — the only variable the examiner recorded was whether errors were *frequent* or *occasional*. The metric is **density**, not presence.

And in the official 7.5 script whose lexis an examiner discussed in detail, the vocabulary is completely ordinary — fast food, obesity, gadgets, laziness, plus a misspelling and a countability error. What the examiner named as the higher-level lexical feature was **softening**: *they tend to, this appears to be, might disagree*. **Hedging** — deliberately weakening a claim so that it is defensible,

instead of asserting it flat — is the neglected band-7 lexical feature. It is built from words you already own, it adds no error risk, and it pays into Lexical Resource, Task Response and Coherence at once. Build that kit first.

Spelling and word formation are scored **here**, not under grammar — which means your predictable French and Arabic misspellings concentrate on one criterion instead of dispersing across four. Thirty words of rote learning is worth a half band.

"Idiomatic" in the descriptors means natural collocation — *strike a balance* — not figurative idiom. The first raises Writing LR; the second lowers it on register. In Speaking it flips: idioms are recommended there, and paraphrase, not precision, is the named skill.

French gives you most of the academic word list for free. It also gives you *significant, alimentation* and *informations* — and an official examiner has already put French interference in writing about someone else's script. Take the cognates. Check the suffix, the countability and the false friend, every time.

The one thing: learn ten collocations per topic and the hedging kit, and stop looking for impressive words. Range gets you considered for band 7. Precision, collocation and spelling decide whether you get it.

What the test actually asks

Lexical Resource is one of four **equally weighted** criteria in Writing Task 1, one of four in Writing Task 2, and one of four in Speaking [src: ielts.org — Understanding and setting IELTS scores]. So it is a quarter of your Speaking band and a quarter of your Writing band — and because Task 2 counts double, two thirds of that Writing quarter is decided in Task 2. It is also the criterion candidates spend the most preparation time on and get the most catastrophically wrong advice about.

Start with the sentence that decides everything else in this chapter. It sits in the **band 6** Lexical Resource cell of the current Writing descriptors, in Task 1 and Task 2 alike:

"If the writer is a risk-taker, there will be a wider range of vocabulary used but higher degrees of inaccuracy or inappropriacy." [src: ielts.org — Writing band descriptors PDF (May 2023),

band 6 LR, T1 and T2]

A note on its status, because it is easy to overclaim. This clause is *not* one of the bolded rating-limiting features. The descriptors' header says "Bolded text indicates negative features that will limit a rating", and if you extract the bold runs from the PDF by font name you find that on the two pages covering bands 6 and 5 every bolded phrase sits at **band 5** — nothing at 6, and no bold body text at all on the page covering bands 9, 8 and 7 [src: ielts.org — Writing band descriptors PDF (May 2023), per-

character font extraction; the same test [Chapter 5](#) asks you to run]. The clause does not need the bold. The header's other rule is what makes it bite: **a script must fully fit the positive features of the descriptor at a particular level**, and this is a positive-feature description of what a band-6 script *is*.

Read it, then, as an official personality sketch. IELTS has written into its published scale a description of the candidate who deliberately reaches for bigger vocabulary, and it has filed that candidate at **band 6** — the same band as the candidate with a "rather restricted range". The scale is telling you, in print, that widening your range while degrading your accuracy **does not move you**. It is the default result of thesaurus strategy, and it is the thing most vocabulary advice is designed to produce.

What the criterion actually contains

The *IELTS Writing Key Assessment Criteria* defines LR as the range of vocabulary used **and** the accuracy and appropriacy of that use *in terms of the specific task* [src: ielts.org — Writing key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p.4]. Three nouns, not one. And the qualifier matters: a word is never "good vocabulary" in the abstract. It is good only if it fits this task, this sentence, this **register** — *register* being the level of formality a piece of language belongs to, the difference between *kids*, *children* and *offspring*, none of which is a better word than the others in the abstract and only one of which belongs in an Academic Task 2.

The same page lists what the criterion assesses. Restated in my own words:

#	Sub-feature	What it means for you
1	Range of general words, e.g. synonyms used to avoid repetition	Don't write <i>problem</i> five times
2	Adequacy and appropriacy — topic-specific items, and words that signal the writer's attitude	Topic lexis plus hedging and stance — <i>hedging</i> = softening a claim so it is defensible (<i>tends to</i> , <i>in most cases</i>) rather than asserting it flat; <i>stance</i> = words that show what you think of it (<i>worryingly</i> , <i>encouragingly</i>)
3	Precision of word choice and expression	The exact word, not the nearby one
4	Control of collocations , idiomatic expressions and sophisticated phrasing	Word partnerships, not single words — <i>collocation</i> = which words habitually go together in English: you <i>strike</i> a balance, you do not <i>hit</i> one. §1 below is the full treatment
5	The density and communicative effect of spelling errors	Spelling is marked here
6	The density and communicative effect of word-formation errors	<i>significative</i> , <i>economical growth</i> → LR, not GRA

Three consequences a 6.5 candidate usually does not know.

Only one of six sub-features is about range. The other five are about control. If you have been studying vocabulary by acquiring more words, you have been working on one sixth of the criterion.

Spelling and word formation are scored under Lexical Resource, not under Grammatical Range and Accuracy. Every band from 3 to 9 mentions them in the LR cell. This matters enormously for you: a French/Arabic speaker's misspellings are predictable and repetitive, which means they do not dilute across four criteria — they land, concentrated, on one.

The metric on errors is density and communicative effect, not presence. The official phrasing says so twice. Errors are counted per unit of text and weighted by how much they damage the message. This is the arithmetic heart of the chapter: reaching for an exotic word adds risk to the numerator without adding anything to the denominator.

The proof that it is density, not range

Two official examiner-marked Task 2 scripts, same prompt set, published together [src: ielts.org — Academic Writing sample tasks (PDF, 2023), Task 2B Scripts A and B].

	Band 5.5 script	Band 7.5 script
Range of vocabulary	attempted, adequate for a good response	wide, flexibly used
Word-choice / spelling errors	present	present ("awkward expressions or inappropriacies")
Frequency of those errors	frequent	occasional
Examiner's verdict on rating	kept the lexical rating down	did not limit the rating

Both candidates made word-choice errors. Both had a usable range. The examiner recorded that the weaker script's range was *adequate* — range was never the diagnosis. The variable that separated the two scripts by two whole bands was **error density**, which is precisely the metric the assessment criteria names.

Now look at what **another** official 7.5 script wrote — a different response, to a different prompt, published with its own examiner comment. A separate official publication reproduces that 7.5 Task 2 response in full with the examiner's comments [src: ielts.org — CD Academic Writing example responses with examiner comments (PDF, 2023), Part 2, Response 2]. Its vocabulary inventory: *fast food, sweets and chocolate, busier, obesity, gadgets, video games, bad eyesight, laziness, spend time outdoors, applications, downloading*. Not one showpiece word. It also still contains a misspelling and a countability error.

What did the examiner single out as the higher-level lexical feature? **Softening**. And the three examples chosen were *they tend to*, *this appears to be* and *might disagree*. Every one of those is a hedging structure assembled from the commonest words in English.

That is the most useful thing in this chapter. **The band-7 lexical feature that examiners actually reward, and that candidates systematically neglect, is stance and hedging — not rare nouns.** It is also the cheapest to learn, because you already own every word in it.

Question types, one by one — the six components of Lexical Resource

The three words this chapter defines for the rest of the book. Chapters 4, 5, 6 and 8 all use these terms and all point back here. If you read nothing else in this chapter, read this table — it is the vocabulary you need in order to read the vocabulary advice.

Term	In plain words	Test it on yourself
Collocation	Which words habitually keep company with which. Not a rule of grammar and not a matter of meaning — pure habit. <i>Strike</i> a balance, <i>pose</i> a threat, <i>conduct</i> research. <i>Hit a balance</i> is perfectly logical and completely wrong.	Say the phrase aloud without the noun: <i>strike a...</i> If nothing comes, you have a word, not a collocation. §1
Hedging	Deliberately weakening a claim so that it is defensible instead of asserting it flat. <i>Young people are addicted to phones</i> → <i>Young people appear to be increasingly reliant on phones</i> . The stance half of the same job is marking what you think of the claim: <i>worryingly</i> , <i>encouragingly</i> , <i>admittedly</i> .	Find every <i>all</i> / <i>always</i> / <i>never</i> / <i>everyone</i> in your draft. Each one is an unhedged claim. §5
Register	The level of formality a piece of language belongs to — <i>kids</i> / <i>children</i> / <i>offspring</i> . None is a better word in the abstract; only one belongs in an Academic Task 2. Academic Writing is formal and impersonal; Speaking is conversational, and forcing written register into speech is itself an error.	Would you write it in a letter to a university admissions office? If not, it fails Writing register. §3

Two more terms the descriptors use and this chapter borrows. **Appropriacy** is IELTS's word for "does this word fit *this* task, sentence and register" — it is the *appropriate* half of "accurate and appropriate", and it is why a real word can still be a scored error. A **cognate** is a word that looks and means roughly the same in two languages — French *analyser* / English *analyse* — which is the free gift French gives you, and the trap the false-friend list below covers.

1. Collocation

WHAT IT IS

Which words habitually keep company with which. *Strike a balance*, not *hit a balance*. *Pose a threat*, not *make a threat to the environment*. Individual words are easy; combinations are what separate a learner from a user [src: ielts-simon.com — vocabulary advice].

HOW IT IS SCORED

Sub-feature 4 names it directly. Band 7 requires that an awareness of style and collocation is *evident*, while still forgiving inappropriacies. Band 8 credits uncommon and idiomatic items but only *when appropriate*. And collocation is named at both extremes of the official examiner comments: a band-4 script was faulted for errors in word choice and collocation, and a band-8.5 script was credited for appropriate modification, collocation and precise word choice [src: ielts.org — Academic Writing sample tasks (PDF, 2023)]. Rarity is named at neither end.

THE TECHNIQUE

Learn phrases, never headwords. IDP adds a detail worth money: the **noun and adjective forms** of a collocation are the more complex, higher- scoring ones — *have a great influence on* outranks *influence greatly*; *have a preference for* outranks *prefer* [src: ielts.idp.com — collocations for IELTS].

Verb + noun — the argumentative engine of Task 2.

Verb	Nouns it takes	Do not say
pose	a risk, a threat, a challenge, a question	✗ <i>make a risk</i>
address	a problem, an issue, a concern, the needs of	✗ <i>solve a concern</i>
tackle	a problem, crime, poverty, unemployment	✗ <i>tackle a solution</i>
raise	awareness, standards, concerns, taxes, an issue	✗ <i>raise the attention</i>
meet	a need, a demand, a target, a deadline, a standard	✗ <i>achieve a need</i>
place / put	a burden on, pressure on, emphasis on, a strain on	✗ <i>make pressure on</i>
draw	a conclusion, a distinction, attention to, a parallel	✗ <i>take a conclusion</i>
implement / enforce	a policy, a measure, legislation, a ban	✗ <i>apply a law</i>
allocate / devote	resources, funding, time, attention <i>to</i>	✗ <i>give money for</i>
exacerbate / alleviate	a problem, poverty, congestion, inequality	✗ <i>exacerbate a benefit</i>
undermine	confidence, authority, an argument, stability	✗ <i>undermine a problem</i>
foster / promote	growth, innovation, cooperation, independence	✗ <i>foster a decision</i>
incur	costs, expenses, debt, a penalty	✗ <i>incur a benefit</i>
reap	the benefits, the rewards	(fixed — nothing else)
bridge / widen	the gap, the divide	✗ <i>close the difference</i>
shape	attitudes, opinions, behaviour, policy	—
impose	a ban, a tax, restrictions, sanctions <i>on</i>	✗ <i>impose to</i>
conduct / carry out	research, a study, a survey	✗ <i>do a research</i>
play	a role, a part <i>in</i>	✗ <i>play an important rule</i>
strike	a balance <i>between</i>	(fixed)

Adjective + noun.

Adjective	Nouns	Note
substantial / considerable	increase, proportion, evidence, investment, impact	Safest big-quantity pair
significant	difference, increase, impact, contribution	Neutral academic
widespread	belief, use, poverty, adoption, criticism	Not <i>large belief</i>
profound	effect, impact, change, influence	Stronger than <i>big</i>
detrimental / adverse	effect <i>on</i> , impact <i>on</i> , consequences	Never <i>adverse advantages</i>

Adjective	Nouns	Note
compelling	evidence, argument, reason, case	Not <i>compelling problem</i>
viable / feasible	solution, alternative, option	<i>feasible</i> = doable; <i>viable</i> = able to survive
rigorous	testing, standards, analysis	—
pressing / urgent	need, issue, problem, concern	<i>pressing</i> is the more academic
ample / scarce	evidence, resources, opportunity	<i>scarce resources</i> is near-fixed
stark	contrast, difference, reality	<i>a stark contrast between</i>
vested	interest	Fixed pair
sedentary	lifestyle	Fixed — health topics
disposable	income	Fixed — economics topics
finite	resources	Fixed — environment topics

Adverb + adjective — cheap, safe range. *widely* regarded / believed / accepted · *increasingly* common / reliant on · *heavily* dependent on / criticised · *highly* effective / controversial / unlikely · *deeply* rooted / entrenched · *strictly* regulated / enforced · *fundamentally* different / flawed. (For the Task 1 trend adverbs — *markedly, dramatically, marginally* — see [Chapter 4](#); this chapter does not repeat that toolkit.)

Compound nouns — the highest value-to-risk ratio in the whole chapter. Two ordinary words locked together. They read as topic-expert vocabulary and are almost impossible to get wrong:

climate change · carbon emissions · renewable energy · fossil fuels · waste disposal · air quality · traffic congestion · public transport · population growth · urban sprawl · housing shortage · life expectancy · mental health · work–life balance · job satisfaction · skills shortage · labour market · income inequality · living standards · social media · screen time · data privacy · digital divide · online learning · student debt · class size · crime rate · custodial sentence · peer pressure · cultural heritage · language barrier · brain drain · economic growth · government spending · tax revenue

ORIGINAL EXAMPLE

Band 6: The government must do a solution for the traffic problem, because it gives a bad effect on the city and makes pressure on the public transport.

Band 7: The government must address traffic congestion, which has a detrimental effect on air quality and places a growing strain on public transport.

Nothing in the band-7 version is a rare word. *Address · detrimental effect on · place a strain on* are three ordinary partnerships used correctly.

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Building sentences out of *do / make / give* plus an abstract noun. *Do a solution, make a pressure, give an effect, take a decision*. Every one is a collocation error, and collocation errors are the ones examiners name.

The ten topic banks

Learn the **whole phrase**, never the headword. Eight to twelve genuinely usable items per topic beats forty recognised ones. Topic-specific vocabulary is what raises the vocabulary score; linking words do not [src: ielts-simon.com].

Topic	Core items	Collocations to drill
Education	compulsory education · vocational training · tuition fees · the curriculum · rote learning · critical thinking skills · academic attainment · drop-out rate · lifelong learning · transferable skills	pursue higher education · acquire skills · instil discipline · narrow the attainment gap · equip students with · tailor teaching to
Environment	greenhouse gas emissions · carbon footprint · fossil fuels · renewable energy · deforestation · biodiversity · finite resources · single-use plastics · sustainable development	curb emissions · deplete resources · preserve biodiversity · switch to renewables · pose a threat to ecosystems
Technology	digital literacy · the digital divide · automation · data privacy · screen time · misinformation · technological advances · obsolete · remote working	keep pace with change · automate routine tasks · safeguard personal data · render a skill obsolete · be heavily reliant on devices
Health	preventive medicine · a sedentary lifestyle · a balanced diet · processed food · obesity rates · chronic illness · life expectancy · well-being · health care provision	lead a sedentary lifestyle · adopt a healthier diet · place a strain on health services · tackle obesity · be linked to heart disease
Globalisation	multinational corporations · free trade · outsourcing · supply chains · cultural homogenisation · economic interdependence · labour migration · the brain drain	erode cultural identity · relocate production to · open up new markets · widen the gap between · integrate into the global economy
Crime	crime rate · petty / organised crime · deterrent · rehabilitation · reoffending · custodial sentence · community service · law enforcement · social deprivation	commit an offence · serve a sentence · act as a deterrent · reintegrate offenders into society · impose harsher penalties
Work	job security · job satisfaction · the gig economy · a skills shortage · career progression · to be made redundant · minimum wage · disposable income · burnout	pursue a career · retain skilled staff · strike a balance between work and family · offer competitive salaries
Urbanisation	urban sprawl · population density · rural depopulation · infrastructure · public amenities · affordable housing · green spaces · regeneration · overcrowding	ease congestion · invest in infrastructure · preserve green space · migrate to urban centres · revitalise a run-down area
Media	mass media · editorial bias · sensationalism · censorship · freedom of the press · a media outlet · investigative journalism · echo chamber · target audience	shape public opinion · distort the facts · exert influence over · hold power to account · be exposed to advertising

Topic	Core items	Collocations to drill
Culture	cultural heritage · a language barrier · cultural exchange · assimilation · integration · intangible heritage · a sense of belonging · social cohesion · generational divide	preserve heritage · pass down traditions · bridge cultural differences · foster mutual understanding · erode local customs

2. Precision

WHAT IT IS

Choosing the word that names the thing exactly, rather than the word in the same neighbourhood. Sub-feature 3.

HOW IT IS SCORED

The band-6 cell says meaning is generally clear *in spite of a lack of precision in word choice* — imprecision is the named band-6 symptom. Band 7 requires enough resource for "some flexibility and **precision**". Band 8.5 examiner credit was for "precise vocabulary choice" [src:

ielts.org — Writing band descriptors PDF (May 2023); Academic Writing sample tasks (PDF, 2023)].

THE TECHNIQUE

Learn the boundaries between the words candidates treat as interchangeable. These six families cover most of the damage in Task 1 and a great deal in Task 2. [Chapter 4](#) supplies the trend verbs, approximation and proportion toolkits; this is the layer underneath them — where each family *breaks*.

Family	Means	Breaks when
PROPORTION — proportion, percentage, share, fraction, ratio	Part of a whole; always relative	Attached to a raw count. ✗ <i>the proportion of 5 million</i> . <i>Ratio</i> needs two things and <i>to</i> : <i>a ratio of three to one</i>
FIGURE — figure, number, total, level, value	The reported number itself	✗ <i>the figure of unemployed people</i> when you mean <i>the number of</i> . The number of + plural noun + singular verb ; a number of + plural noun + plural verb
RATE — rate, pace, frequency, incidence, density	A quantity per something — per year, per 1,000, per capita	Substituted for <i>number</i> . ✗ <i>the rate of cars was 11 million</i> . Note: <i>the rate of increase</i> ≠ <i>the increase</i> — growth can slow while the figure still rises
AMOUNT — amount, quantity, volume, level, extent	Quantity of an uncountable thing	Attached to a countable noun. ✗ <i>the amount of children</i> → the number of children . French <i>la quantité de</i> covers both, which is why this is a top-three error for you
TREND — trend, pattern, shift, trajectory	Direction of movement over time	Applied to a chart with no time axis. A bar chart comparing four countries has no trend; it has differences . <i>Fluctuation</i> = up and down with no net direction; <i>pattern</i> = a shape that repeats
PERIOD — period, era, decade, span, phase, stage	A stretch of time	Used for a point. ✗ <i>in the period of 1990</i> → <i>in 1990</i> . ✗ <i>during two years</i> → over a two-year period . <i>Phase</i> and <i>stage</i> belong to processes , not time series

One line to memorise: *Proportion* = part of a whole. *Figure* = the number itself. *Rate* = per something. *Amount* = of uncountable stuff. *Number* = of countable things. *Trend* = direction over time. *Period* = the stretch of time. They are not synonyms.

ORIGINAL EXAMPLE

Band 6: The amount of commuters using the metro grew with a big rate during the period of 2010.

Band 7: The number of commuters using the metro rose sharply in 2010, although the rate of growth slowed over the following decade.

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Treating a semantic family as a synonym set — reaching for *amount* because you already used *number*, and creating a precision error in order to avoid a repetition that would have cost less.

3. Register

WHAT IT IS

Whether the word fits the formality of the task. Academic Writing is formal and impersonal; Speaking is conversational and allows much more.

HOW IT IS SCORED

Band 7 names an awareness of **style** alongside collocation. The Speaking assessment criteria names style — formal/informal — as an explicit appropriacy dimension [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023)]. The British Council names wrong register as one of the commonest mistakes in the Writing test, says slang is never appropriate in formal contexts, and singles out phrasal verbs such as *figure out* and *call off* as not always academically appropriate [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org/blog/formal-vs-informal-english-ielts-writing — formal vs informal English for IELTS Writing].

THE TECHNIQUE

Three rules, and they run in opposite directions for the two papers. In **Academic Writing**: no contractions, no slang, no *stuff/kids/a lot of*, no exclamation marks, and phrasal verbs only where there is no single-word alternative (*carry out research* is fine; *sort out the problem* is not). In **Speaking**: contractions are expected, phrasal verbs are natural, and forcing written register into a spoken answer is itself an appropriacy error.

ORIGINAL EXAMPLE

Band 6 (Writing): Loads of people reckon the government should crack down on this stuff and sort it out ASAP.

Band 7 (Writing): Many people believe the government should impose stricter penalties and address the problem without delay.

Band 7 (Speaking), same idea: Honestly, most people I know think the government should just crack down on it — and pretty quickly.

The *Speaking* version is not a lower-quality answer. It is the correct register for a different paper.

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Two opposite failures, both scored the same way. Writing an essay in spoken English; or speaking in memorised written English ("Furthermore, it is widely acknowledged that..."), which sounds rehearsed and triggers the memorised- language problem below.

4. Paraphrase

WHAT IT IS

Saying the same thing in different words. In Writing it is how you avoid lifting the prompt. In Speaking it is how you get round a word you do not have.

HOW IT IS SCORED

Asymmetrically, and this is the single most important cross-skill fact in the chapter. In **Speaking**, paraphrase is a **named, separately assessed skill** — the criteria describe getting round a vocabulary gap by using other words, with or without noticeable hesitation, and paraphrase is named in the descriptors at bands 6, 7 and 8 [src: ielts.org — Speaking band descriptors (PDF, 2025); Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023)]. In **Writing** it is not named at all as a skill; it surfaces only inside sub-feature 1 (using synonyms to avoid repetition) and indirectly through Task Response, because copied rubric earns no credit.

So: **in Speaking, not knowing a word is not penalised — failing to route around it is.** In Writing, an unnecessary substitution is a precision error you did not have to make.

THE TECHNIQUE

For Speaking, drill the three escape routes and use them out loud, at speed: *define it* ("the system they use for getting water to the fields"), *give the function* ("the thing you use to..."), *give an example* ("like the pipes farmers put in the ground"). For Writing, paraphrase at the level of the **whole clause**, not the word — change the grammar, not the vocabulary. *Some people believe that university education should be free* becomes *It is sometimes argued that the state should meet the full cost of a degree.*

Original example (Speaking, routing round a gap):

Band 6: It's a... I don't know the word. A thing for the water. [stops]

Band 7: I don't know the technical term, but it's the system farmers use to bring water to their fields when there isn't enough rain — irrigation, I think it's called.

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

In Speaking, stopping. In Writing, paraphrasing everything — including words that have no synonym. There is no synonym for a country, for *carbon dioxide*, or for *people*. Substituting one costs more than repeating.

5. Hedging and stance

WHAT IT IS

Softening a claim so that it is defensible, and marking your attitude to it. *Tend to · appears to · in most cases · arguably · admittedly.*

HOW IT IS SCORED

Sub-feature 2 names vocabulary that signals the writer's attitude. The Speaking criteria names indicating the speaker's attitude — favourable, neutral or unfavourable — as a key lexical indicator. And an official examiner, given a free hand to say why a 7.5 script's lexis was band-7-plus, named **softening**, quoting *they tend to, this appears to be* and *might disagree*

[src: ielts.org — CD Academic Writing example responses with examiner comments (PDF, 2023)].

Why this is the best-value block in the chapter. It pays into three criteria at once. It feeds **Lexical Resource** through attitude and appropriacy. It feeds **Task Response**, because the band-7 Task 2 cell names a tendency to over-generalise as the weakness that keeps a script at 7 — and hedging is the direct cure. And it feeds Coherence, because hedges signal the logical status of a claim. Nothing else in vocabulary study does that. It is also built entirely from words you already own, which means it adds no error density.

Function	Items
Soften a generalisation	tend to · have a tendency to · are inclined to · are likely to · in most cases · on the whole · broadly speaking
Soften a claim	appears to · seems to · would appear to · suggests that · indicates that · points to
Modal hedge	may · might · could · is likely to · is unlikely to
Quantify cautiously	many · a significant proportion of · the majority of · relatively few · a minority of
Attribute	it is widely believed that · critics argue that · proponents claim that
Concede	admittedly · while it is true that · granted · although this may be the case
Assert (sparingly)	clearly · undoubtedly · there is little doubt that · it is evident that
Limit scope	to some extent · in certain contexts · particularly in developing countries · at least in the short term

ORIGINAL EXAMPLE

Band 6: Young people are addicted to their phones and they never read books any more. Social media destroys concentration.

Band 7: Young people appear to be increasingly reliant on their phones, and in most cases they read fewer books than previous generations did. Social media may well erode concentration, at least among heavy users.

Same idea, same words, two extra criteria satisfied. Nothing rare was added.

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Writing absolute claims — *all, always, never, everyone* — because they sound confident. They read as unsupported, and they are the named band-7 Task Response weakness in a single word.

6. Spelling and word formation

WHAT IT IS

Getting the letters right, and getting the suffix right — *economic* versus *economical*, *significant* not *significative*, *maintenance* not *maintainance*.

HOW IT IS SCORED

Under Lexical Resource, at every band from 3 to 9, measured by **density and communicative effect**. The band-5.5 official script was held down on the lexical criterion **specifically** because frequent spelling errors caused the reader some difficulty. Note also: computer-delivered IELTS has **no spellchecker**.

THE TECHNIQUE

Word families, not words. French gives you the stem for free — the risk is never the stem, it is the suffix.

Verb	Noun (thing)	Noun (person)	Adjective	Trap
analyse	analysis (<i>pl.</i> analyses)	analyst	analytical	✗ <i>an analyse</i> (Fr. <i>une analyse</i>)
benefit	benefit	beneficiary	beneficial	<i>beneficial to**</i>
compete	competition	competitor	competitive	✗ <i>concurrence</i>
conclude	conclusion	—	conclusive	draw a conclusion
consume	consumption	consumer	—	✗ <i>consummation</i>
develop	development	developer	developed / developing	✗ <i>developement</i>

Verb	Noun (thing)	Noun (person)	Adjective	Trap
—	economy, economics	economist	economic / economical	economic = of the economy; economical = cheap to run
employ	employment	employer / employee	(un)employed	—
—	environment	environmentalist	environmental	<i>✗ enviroment, ✗ environmentally</i>
finance	finance(s)	financier	financial	<i>✗ financier</i>
govern	government, governance	governor	governmental	<i>✗ goverment</i>
—	industry	industrialist	industrial / industrious	industrial = of industry; industrious = hard-working
maintain	maintenance	—	—	<i>✗ maintainance</i> — top-five error
produce	production, productivity	producer	productive	—
rely	reliance	—	reliable, reliant <i>on</i>	<i>reliant on**</i>
respond	response, responsibility	respondent	responsive, responsible <i>for</i>	<i>responsible for (Fr. responsable de)</i>
signify	significance	—	significant	<i>✗ significative</i> — not an English word
stabilise	stability	—	stable	<i>✗ stabilty</i>
succeed	success	—	successful	<i>✗ succesful, ✗ sucess</i>
sustain	sustainability	—	sustainable	—
—	technology	technologist	technological	<i>✗ technologic</i>
vary	variety, variation	—	various, variable, varied	—

Nominalisation — a range gain and a collocation gain at once. *Nominalisation* is turning a verb or an adjective into a noun and building the sentence around it: *governments invest* → *investment*; *cities grow rapidly* → *the rapid growth of cities*. English academic prose does this constantly, which is why the noun version often reads as the more academic of two otherwise identical sentences.

Plain (band 6)	Nominalised (band 7 shape)
Governments should invest more in transport.	Increased investment in transport is needed.
Because cities are growing quickly...	The rapid growth of cities has...
Technology influences education a lot.	Technology has a profound influence on education.
People prefer online shopping.	There is a clear preference for online shopping.

-ise vs -ize. Both are accepted. Be **consistent**, and prefer *-ise* since you are writing British-leaning English. Never *-ize* on these: *advise, revise, exercise, supervise, comprise, compromise, surprise, arise, promise*. Mixing conventions within one script is what looks careless.

ORIGINAL EXAMPLE

Band 6: The goverment should give more importance to the developement of a sustainible economical growth, which is a significative challenge.

Band 7: The government should place greater emphasis on sustainable economic growth, which is a significant challenge.

Three spelling errors (*goverment*, *developement*, *sustainible*), one wrong suffix (*economical* for *economic*) and one non-word (*significative*) — five LR hits in a single sentence, all of them fixable by rote.

THE BAND-6 MISTAKE

Treating spelling as a cosmetic issue and proofreading for grammar only. Your misspellings are a closed, learnable set. See *L1 alert*.

How to actually learn all this in ten minutes a day

Vocabulary is not one of the four skills, so it cannot own a session. It has to run alongside and cost almost nothing.

The evidence for spacing is solid. A peer-reviewed meta-analysis of spaced practice in second-language learning — 98 effect sizes from 48 experiments — found that spaced conditions outperformed massed ones, that longer spacing was better at longer retention intervals, and that equal and expanding schedules were statistically equivalent [src: Kim & Webb 2022, *Language Learning* 72(2), 269–319]. Two operational conclusions follow, and only two. **Space it** — ten minutes daily beats seventy minutes on Sunday. **Do not over-engineer the interval** — since equal and expanding schedules came out equivalent, a fixed ladder is fine; do not spend study time tuning an algorithm.

The card. The front is **never a single word**. It is a collocation with a gap: *place a strain ___ health services*. The back is the full phrase plus one sentence **you wrote yourself** on an IELTS topic. Meaning in English if you can, French only if you must.

The ladder. Day 1 → Day 3 → Day 7 → Day 16 → Day 35. Anything you fail drops back to Day 1. Five successful reviews over five weeks survives a test date six to ten weeks out.

The daily ten minutes, inside your ninety. Five at the start, reviewing due cards, recalling **actively** — say or type the phrase before you flip. Recognition is worthless; you need production. Five at the end, mining the session you just did: no more than **five items**, taken from your own graded work — words I corrected, or words you needed and did not have. Nothing from a listicle.

Three rules that make it work.

1. **Harvest from your own errors first.** Your error log is a better vocabulary syllabus than any published list, because it targets your actual gaps and because you already have a retrieval

cue attached — you remember the essay.

2. **Cap the intake.** Five items a day for six weeks is around 200 items, of which perhaps 140 will be usable. That is already far more less-common lexis than a band-7 script needs. More intake does not help; retention and accuracy do.

3. **A word is not learned until you have used it in a graded piece and it was not corrected.**

Move every item through three states: *learned* → *used* → *survived grading*. Only the third state counts.

Fit it to the topics. One topic per week, with that week's Task 2 drill and Speaking session on the same topic. Every item then gets a production test in the week you meet it.

Tips & tricks

1. **Fix error density before you add range.** [verified] Two official scripts with the same error types and the same adequate range scored 5.5 and 7.5; the only difference the examiner recorded was *frequent* versus *occasional*. Removing ten errors is worth more than adding ten words. **Procedure:** on your next graded script, circle every LR error — wrong word, wrong collocation, wrong suffix, misspelling — and divide by the word count. That number, errors per hundred words, is the only vocabulary metric worth tracking. Put it in `band-tracker.md` beside the LR band and do not add a single new item to your cards until it has fallen twice in a row.

2. **Build the hedging kit first.** [verified] It is the one lexical feature an official examiner explicitly named as higher-level at band 7.5, it costs nothing in new vocabulary, and it simultaneously repairs the band-7 Task Response weakness of over-generalising. **Procedure:** the hedging table in §5 has eight rows. Take one row a day for eight days and use every item in that row at least once in the day's writing or speaking drill. On day nine, run self-test item 3 on an old essay and repair every absolute claim you find. That is the whole kit, learned inside the ten-minute daily slot.

3. **Learn phrases, never headwords.** [verified] Sub-feature 4 assesses collocation; band 7 requires evident awareness of it; the band-8.5 script was credited for it and the band-4 script faulted for it. **Procedure:** the front of the card is a phrase with a gap in it — *place a strain* ___ *health services* — never a single word, and never the English word with its French meaning on the back. If you cannot write the card as a gapped phrase, you have not yet found the collocation, only the word.

4. **Spend a full study block on your own spelling list.** [verified] Spelling sits inside LR, appears at every band, held one official script down by itself, and there is no spellchecker on computer-delivered IELTS. Your misspellings are a closed set of perhaps thirty words.

5. **Prefer compound nouns over adjectives you half-know.** [expert consensus] *Traffic congestion*, *income inequality*, *screen time* — two common words locked together, near-zero error risk, and they read as topic command.

6. Nominalise four times per essay, no more. [verified] IDP notes the noun and adjective forms of a collocation are the higher-scoring ones. But English academic prose tolerates verbs; nominalising everything produces the ornate French-academic register examiners call awkward.

7. Check every "upgrade" against three questions. [expert consensus] What part of speech follows it? Which preposition does it take? Does it fit an academic register? If you cannot answer all three, the common word scores higher. That is the band-6 risk-taker clause restated as an instruction.

8. Use a collocation dictionary or a learner's dictionary with example sentences — never a thesaurus. [expert consensus] A thesaurus gives synonyms stripped of collocation, register and countability, which are three of the things LR measures [src: myieltsclassroom.com — 5 common IELTS Lexical Resource mistakes].

9. In Speaking, drill routing round gaps; in Writing, drill precision. [verified] The Speaking scale names paraphrase at bands 6, 7 and 8 and tolerates inappropriate vocabulary at band 6 provided meaning is clear. The Writing scale does neither. Same criterion name, different priorities. **Procedure:** for Speaking, pick five concrete nouns you do not know in English (a tool, a dish, a piece of infrastructure) and record yourself getting round each one in under fifteen seconds using the three escape routes in §4 — define it, give its function, give an example. For Writing, take a graded essay and for every substituted word ask only: *is this the exact word, or the nearby one?* Put back every substitution you cannot defend.

10. Repeat *people* and *in conclusion* without guilt. [expert consensus] Some words have no synonym, and linking phrases are scored under Coherence and Cohesion, not LR [src: ieltsliz.com — paraphrasing tips] [src: ielts-simon.com].

11. Keep one spelling convention. [verified] *-ise* throughout, or *-ize* throughout. Mixing them within one script is an appropriacy signal you control for free.

12. Test every new item by writing one sentence with it, on a real IELTS topic. [expert consensus] If you cannot produce the sentence, you have recognised the word, not learned it.

Myths that hold you back

This is the section that matters most in this chapter. Vocabulary is where IELTS preparation actively damages candidates, because almost all of the popular advice optimises for the wrong half of the criterion.

MYTH 1 — "Use rare, impressive words to show your range." The band-6 cell contains a description of exactly this candidate — the risk-taker with the wider range and the higher inaccuracy — and places them at band 6. Band 8 credits uncommon items only *when appropriate*. The 7.5 script whose lexis an examiner discussed in detail contains no showpiece vocabulary at

all. **Why it hurts:** rare words add error density — the metric the criteria actually names — without adding credit unless collocation, part of speech and register are all correct simultaneously. IDP states plainly that you do not need very uncommon words [src: ielts.idp.com — Understanding the IELTS Speaking band descriptors].

MYTH 2 — "Paraphrase every word from the prompt; never repeat anything." Two mechanisms of harm. Forced paraphrase is the biggest single source of precision errors — students try so hard to paraphrase that they make mistakes that lower the score [src: ieltsliz.com — paraphrasing tips]. And some words have no synonym. Repetition of a general word costs you under sub-feature 1; a wrong substitution costs you under sub-features 3 **and** 4.

MYTH 3 — "Memorise band-9 sentences and drop them in." The LR descriptor names this at **band 4:** inappropriate use of lexical chunks, e.g. memorised phrases and formulaic language [src: ielts.org — Writing band descriptors PDF (May 2023), band 4 LR]. Band 3 names over-dependence on memorised language, and a wholly memorised response is band 0. The band-4 clause is not one of the bolded limiters — bold in this document starts at band 5 and runs downward — but it does not need to be: it is a description of what a band-4 script *is*, and a script must fully fit a band's positive features to be rated there. **Why it hurts:** memorised phrases are not neutral, they are a scored negative, and an examiner spots them instantly because they sit at a different level from the rest of the script. *Since the dawn of time, humanity has always...* is a band-4 signal.

MYTH 4 — "Learn the Academic Word List — all 570 word families." The AWL is a real, well-built list: 570 word families from a 3.5-million-word academic corpus, selected for range and frequency across disciplines, covering roughly a tenth of that corpus [src: Coxhead 2000, described in Therova 2020, TESL-EJ 24(1)]. **Why it is wrong for you** rests on two things, and I want to be precise about which. First, **the unit is wrong:** the AWL is organised by frequency, and it was built as a *reading-comprehension* tool — it tells you which words you will meet. Lexical Resource assesses *collocation*, which a frequency list cannot teach. Second, **the time budget is impossible:** 570 word families at five items a day is arithmetic suicide in six to ten weeks.

There is a well-known academic critique of the AWL — that its items are not of equal value across disciplines, and that a single transferable list can mislead learners [src: Hyland & Tse 2007, TESOL Quarterly]. In fairness, **that critique bites less hard for IELTS than for university study**, because Task 2 is deliberately general-interest and non-disciplinary. The case against memorising the AWL for this test rests on the wrong unit and the time budget, not on Hyland and Tse.

The honest verdict: the AWL is an excellent *checking* resource. If a word is in its first three sublists, it is safe, mid-frequency academic register — and it probably has a French cognate you already half-own. Use it that way. Learn ten collocations per topic instead of memorising a list.

MYTH 5 — "Use lots of idioms to sound natural." This one is muddled in both directions and the distinction is worth real marks. **"Idiomatic" in descriptor language means natural, native-like collocation** — *strike a balance, a growing body of evidence* — **not colourful figurative idiom** — *rain cats and dogs, the ball is in their court*. The first raises Writing LR. The second lowers it on

register: the British Council names wrong register as a top Writing mistake and says slang is never appropriate in formal contexts [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org/blog/formal-vs-informal-english-ielts-writing — formal vs informal English for IELTS Writing].

And in Speaking it flips. IDP explicitly recommends idiomatic language for Speaking, notes it is assessed from band 7, and warns only against overuse, topic mismatch and forced ones [src: ielts.idp.com — Understanding the IELTS Speaking band descriptors]. **Rule:** figurative idioms → Speaking Parts 1 and 3, sparingly. Never in Academic Writing. Idiomatic *collocation* → both papers, as much as you can control.

MYTH 6 — "Replace linking words with sophisticated alternatives to boost your vocabulary score." Linking words are assessed under **Coherence and Cohesion**, not Lexical Resource. Swapping *In conclusion* for something exotic gains zero LR marks and risks register [src: ielts-simon.com]. Worse, the CC descriptors at bands 5 and 6 penalise **overuse** of cohesive devices — so decorating them can lose marks on the criterion they *are* scored under.

MYTH 7 — "Cambridge research shows that most test-takers lose Lexical Resource marks on collocation." This circulates as a precise-sounding percentage attributed to "Cambridge Assessment research". I traced it. It appears on a single commercial listicle with **no study named, no year and no link**, and a targeted search surfaced only that same page. It appears in no Cambridge or IELTS publication. **Treat the figure as fabricated.** I am deliberately not repeating the number, because authoritative-sounding numbers propagate even through their own debunking. The underlying qualitative claim — that collocation matters more than range — is well supported by everything above. The statistic is not.

MYTH 8 — "Long words are more academic than short ones." Sub-feature 3 is *precision*, not length. The band-8.5 script was credited for precise word choice, not long words. *Use* beats *utilise* in almost every IELTS sentence — *utilise* implies putting something to a practical use it was not designed for. Reaching for the longer word by reflex is the risk-taker profile in miniature.

MYTH 9 — "Spelling is minor" / "spelling is marked under grammar." Spelling is inside Lexical Resource, at every band from 3 to 9, and one official script was held down on that criterion by spelling alone. **Why it hurts you specifically:** your misspellings are predictable and repetitive, so they concentrate on a single criterion instead of dispersing. Thirty words of rote learning is worth a half band.

MYTH 10 — "A thesaurus is a study tool." A thesaurus supplies synonyms without collocation, register or countability. It is named as a top-five LR mistake by practitioners [src: myieltsclassroom.com — 5 common IELTS Lexical Resource mistakes]. Use a collocation dictionary, or a learner's dictionary with example sentences, because you need to see the word inside a phrase — the phrase is the assessed unit.

Band descriptor decoder

All Writing wording below is paraphrased from the current descriptors [\[src: ielts.org — Writing band descriptors PDF \(May 2023\)\]](https://ielts.org); all Speaking wording from the current Speaking descriptors [\[src: ielts.org — Speaking band descriptors \(PDF, 2025\)\]](https://ielts.org). Two rules from the Writing descriptors' own header apply throughout, and the first is the one that does the work: a script must **fully** meet a band's positive features to be rated there, and "Bolded text indicates negative features that will limit a rating." Note what the second rule does *not* give you here — **nothing in the Lexical Resource column at bands 6 to 9 is bolded**. Bold body text begins at band 5 and runs downward, and on the page covering bands 6 and 5 it does not touch Lexical Resource at all: the only bolded run on the Task 1 page is *There may be no data to support the description* under Task Achievement, and on the Task 2 page it is *incompletely addressed* under Task Response and *Paragraphing may be inadequate or missing* under Coherence & Cohesion [\[src: ielts.org — Writing band descriptors PDF \(Updated May 2023\), pp.2 and 6 of the grid; per-character font extraction, re-run 2026-07-31\]](https://ielts.org). So every band-6 and band-7 statement below is a *positive-feature* description, and the "fully meet" rule is what makes falling short of it cost you a band. Do not go looking for a bolded lexical limiter at your boundary; there is not one, and the argument does not need it.

Writing — Lexical Resource

Band	What it requires, restated
8	A wide resource used fluently and flexibly to convey precise meaning. Skilful use of uncommon and idiomatic items when appropriate , despite occasional inaccuracies in word choice and collocation. Occasional spelling or word-formation errors with minimal impact.
7	Resource sufficient to allow some flexibility and precision. Some ability with less common and idiomatic items. An awareness of style and collocation is evident, though inappropriacies still occur. Only a few spelling or word-formation errors, and they do not detract from clarity.
6	Generally adequate and appropriate for the task. Meaning generally clear in spite of a rather restricted range or a lack of precision in word choice . A risk-taker shows wider vocabulary but higher inaccuracy or inappropriacy. Some spelling or word-formation errors, but they do not impede communication.
5	Limited, but minimally adequate for the task. Simple vocabulary may be used accurately, but the range does not permit much variation in expression. Frequent lapses in the appropriacy of word choice, and inflexibility showing as frequent simplification and repetition. Spelling or word-formation errors may be noticeable and may cause the reader some difficulty.

Band 5 is here because your baseline is not yet diagnosed and a first Task 2 can land at 5.5 — you need the language for what you produced, not only for what you are aiming at. The official band-5 wording is the same in the Task 1 and Task 2 columns. Read the rows as one variable turned up: at 5 the lapses are *frequent* and the spelling errors *cause difficulty*; at 6 the errors *do not impede*; at 7 they are *few* and *do not detract*. That is density again — the same word choice, counted differently.

Read the 6→7 gate carefully. The words *some* and *awareness* are doing the work. Band 7 sets a **low bar on range** — some ability with less common items — and a **real bar on control**. It even forgives inappropriacies outright. Nothing in band 7 asks for impressive vocabulary. It asks for evidence that you know how words combine.

Before / after — Writing.

Band 6: Nowadays the pollution is a very big problem which gives many bad effects to the society and the healthy of the peoples. **Band 7:** Air pollution now poses a serious threat to public health, particularly in densely populated cities.

Poses a threat to and *public health* are the whole upgrade. Five errors disappear with them: **two** articles on abstract nouns (*the pollution, the society* — your flagship error, twice in one sentence), *gives effects to*, a pluralised *peoples*, and *the healthy* for *health*.

Band 6: Companies must utilise their pecuniary resources to ameliorate the predicament of their employees. **Band 7:** Companies must use their financial resources to improve conditions for their employees.

This pair is the risk-taker clause in action. *Pecuniary* and *ameliorate* are real words. *Ameliorate a predicament* is not a collocation, and *pecuniary* is a legal register. The plainer version is the higher-scoring one.

Speaking — Lexical Resource

Band	What it requires, restated
8	A wide resource used readily and flexibly across all topics, conveying precise meaning. Skilful use of less common and idiomatic items despite occasional inaccuracy in choice and collocation. Effective use of paraphrase as required.
7	Resource used flexibly across a variety of topics. Some ability with less common and idiomatic items, and an awareness of style and collocation is evident, though inappropriacies occur. Effective use of paraphrase as required.
6	Resource sufficient to discuss topics at length. Vocabulary use may be inappropriate, but meaning is clear. Generally able to paraphrase successfully.
5	Resource sufficient to discuss familiar and unfamiliar topics, but flexibility is limited. Paraphrase is attempted, but not always successfully.

Note where the Speaking scale puts the 5→6 line: not on how many words you have — band 5 already covers unfamiliar topics — but on **flexibility** and on whether the paraphrase lands. That is the whole of this chapter's argument, printed in the descriptor.

The asymmetry, stated plainly. In Writing, LR is precision plus collocation plus spelling. In Speaking, LR is flexibility plus paraphrase plus collocation, with style explicitly in scope. Speaking band 6 tolerates an *inappropriate* word as long as meaning is clear; Writing band 6 does not put it that way. So the same word can be a good choice in one paper and a bad one in the other, and Speaking practice should drill **routing round a gap fluently**, not word lists.

Before / after — Speaking.

Band 6: Yes, I like reading books. Books are good for the knowledge. I read books when I have free time. It's a good hobby. **Band 7:** I'm a fairly heavy reader, yes — mostly non-fiction. I find it broadens your horizons in a way that scrolling never quite does, though I'll admit I read less than I used to.

Nothing rare there either. *A heavy reader · broaden your horizons · I'll admit · than I used to* — one collocation, one idiomatic phrase, one stance marker, one comparison structure. That is what "flexibly used" means.

YOUR L1 — ARABIC / FRENCH

L1 alert

French is a genuine structural advantage — use it deliberately

English academic vocabulary is overwhelmingly Latinate, and French is your direct route in. Look at the highest-frequency academic words in English — *analyse, approach, assess, benefit, concept, consist, constitute, context, create, define, distribute, economy, environment, establish, estimate, evident, factor, finance, function, identify, indicate, individual, interpret, involve, legal, major, method, period, principle, proceed, process, research, respond, role, section, sector, significant, similar, source, specific, structure, theory, vary* — and note that **most of them have a transparent French cognate you already own**. Your effective academic vocabulary is far larger than your study hours suggest. This is a real advantage over an Arabic-monolingual or East Asian candidate, and you should exploit it deliberately rather than studying as though you were starting from nothing.

How to exploit it safely. When you need an academic word, reach for the French one in an English shape — and then check three things before you commit it. **(1) Does the suffix transfer? (2) Does the countability transfer? (3) Is it a false friend?** Suffix and countability are exactly where French speakers give back the marks the cognates gave them.

This is not a private worry. An IELTS examiner, in an official publication, marking a band-5.5 script, wrote that there appeared to be interference from the test taker's first language and cited *alimentation* [src: ielts.org — CD Academic Writing example responses with examiner comments (PDF, 2023), Part 2, Response 1]. French-shaped word choice is visible to examiners and gets commented on. The same script also contained *cigars* for *cigarettes* and a mangled reach for a rare word.

The false-friend list

You may write	French source	What it means in English	What you meant → use
actually	<i>actuellement</i>	in fact, in reality	currently, at present, these days
eventually	<i>éventuellement</i>	in the end, finally	possibly, potentially, if necessary

You may write	French source	What it means in English	What you meant → use
assist	<i>assister à</i>	to help	attend (<i>attend a lecture</i>)
formation	<i>formation</i>	the act of forming; a shape	training, education, a qualification
sensible	<i>sensible</i>	having good judgement	sensitive
library	<i>librairie</i>	where you borrow books	bookshop
deception	<i>déception</i>	trickery	disappointment
demand	<i>demander</i>	to require forcefully	ask
support	<i>soutenir</i>	to bear weight; to back	tolerate, put up with
achieve	<i>achever</i>	to attain a goal	finish, complete
control	<i>contrôler</i>	to have power over	check, inspect, monitor
stage	<i>stage</i>	a phase; a platform	internship, work placement
significant	<i>significatif</i>	not an English word	significant
alimentation	<i>alimentation</i>	(rare, technical)	diet, nutrition, food
inconvenient	<i>inconvenient</i>	causing difficulty (adjective)	drawback / disadvantage (noun)
resume	<i>résumer</i>	to start again after a pause	summarise
comprehensive	<i>compréhensif</i>	complete, covering everything	understanding, sympathetic
actual	<i>actuel</i>	real, genuine	current, present
delay	<i>délai</i>	a postponement	deadline, time limit
large	<i>large</i>	big	wide, broad
material	<i>matériel</i>	substance, cloth	equipment, hardware
important	<i>important</i>	✓ fine — but Fr. also = <i>large in size</i>	<i>a large amount, not an important amount</i>
interesting	<i>intéressant</i>	✓ fine — but Fr. also = <i>good value</i>	<i>an attractive price</i>
experience	<i>expérience</i>	✓ fine — but Fr. also = <i>experiment</i>	<i>conduct an experiment</i>

Also: **permit to do** → *permit / allow somebody to do*. French *permettre de faire* drops the object; English does not.

Uncountables that French pluralises

Writing *informations* costs you a mark on **GRA**, and arguably on **LR** too — IELTS files "errors in word formation" under Lexical Resource and does not say which side countability falls on, so the book states the allocation as contested rather than settled ([Chapter 8](#) takes the same line). Either way it is scored, the repair is the same list, and it is instantly diagnostic to an examiner.

✗ Never	✓ Always	Counting unit
<i>informations</i>	information	a piece of information

✗ Never	✓ Always	Counting unit
<i>researches</i>	research	a piece of research, a study
<i>advices</i>	advice	a piece of advice
<i>knowledges</i>	knowledge	a body of knowledge
<i>equipments</i>	equipment	a piece of equipment
<i>softwares</i>	software	a piece of software
<i>evidences</i>	evidence	a piece of evidence
<i>feedbacks</i>	feedback	some feedback
<i>progresses</i>	progress	some progress
<i>trainings</i>	training	a training course
<i>transports</i>	transport	a means of transport
<i>pollutions</i>	pollution	a type of pollution
<i>accommodations</i>	accommodation	a piece of accommodation
<i>staffs</i>	staff	a member of staff
<i>furnitures</i>	furniture	an item of furniture

Downstream agreement rule: all of these take **singular verbs** and pair with *much / less / a great deal of / an amount of* — never *many / fewer / a number of*. ✓ *Much research has been conducted.* ✗ *Many researches have been conducted.*

Articles with abstract nouns — where your two languages agree against you

✗ *the society is changing* → ✓ **society is changing**. Same family, article-less in a general sense: *nature, life, technology, education, history, science, poverty, crime, pollution, unemployment, globalisation*.

This is your highest-frequency error class, and it is **doubly reinforced**: French *la société* and Arabic *al-mujtama'* both attach a definite article to abstract generic nouns, so both of your languages push the same wrong button. That is why it is so persistent. Note that this particular error lands on **GRA**, not LR — it is listed here because its trigger is lexical: it fires on a specific set of nouns, so you can proofread for it by scanning for those nouns. The article **returns** when the noun is specific: ✓ *the society of the nineteenth century***.

Arabic-specific issues

Rhetorical chaining. Arabic prose builds long, additive, coordinated chains, and French academic style compounds this with its own tolerance for long comma-linked sentences. In English this produces run-ons and comma splices. The lexical cost is indirect but real: examiners describe the result as *awkward expressions*, and awkwardness is scored under LR as well as CC. Break the chain — find the point where the sentence should have ended and put a full stop there.

Consonant and vowel transfer into spelling. Tunisian Arabic carries /p/ and /v/ only in loanwords, where they are usually replaced — but **you also speak French, which supplies both**, so these are not missing from your inventory (see [Chapter 6](#), where the real issue turns out to be aspiration rather than an absent phoneme). What survives into *spelling* is the older habit: consonant substitutions such as *broblem* for *problem*. Arabic script also does not represent short vowels the way English does, which destabilises vowel spelling in unstressed syllables — *independant*, *seperate*, *definatelly*.

These are pure Lexical Resource losses on computer-delivered IELTS, where there is no spellchecker.

Capitalisation. Arabic script has no upper case, so capitals are a habit you have to install rather than transfer. Sentence-initial capitals, *I*, months, days, countries, nationalities and languages.

Your standing spelling list. Learn these thirty as rote, then extend it from your own error log: *government, development, environment, maintenance, address, example, independent, receive, occurred, responsible, separate, definitely, necessary, opportunity, beneficial, recommend, achieve, believe, business, because, until, foreign, especially, immediately, knowledge, successful, accommodation, technology, sustainable, significant*.

Self-test checklist

Run this on every graded piece, before you look at any answer key. Every *no* is a named repair.

1. Can I point to at least five **collocations** in this piece that I chose deliberately, as phrases?
2. Is every "upgraded" word one where I know the part of speech that follows it, the preposition it takes, and its register?
3. Have I hedged **every** sweeping generalisation — no *all, always, never, everyone* left standing?
4. Does the piece contain at least three stance or softening markers (*tend to, appears to, in most cases, admittedly*)?
5. Have I used at least four topic-specific items from this week's topic bank?
6. Did I check that *amount* is on an uncountable noun and *number* on a countable one, everywhere?
7. Are all my uncountables singular — no *informations, researches, advices, equipments*?
8. Did I proofread specifically for spelling, as a separate pass from grammar?
9. Is my *-ise / -ize* convention consistent throughout?
10. Have I checked every French-looking word against the false-friend list — especially *actually, eventually, assist, formation, important*?
11. Is there a word here I substituted only to avoid repeating something — and would the repetition have been cheaper?
12. Is there any memorised chunk or ornate opening (*Since the dawn of time...*) I can delete?

13. In Writing: any contractions, slang, or phrasal verbs with a single-word alternative?
 14. In Speaking: did I route round every gap out loud instead of stopping?
 15. For every new item I used: has it now **survived grading** uncorrected — or is it still only *used*?
-

The 60-second summary for this chapter is at the top, before "What the test actually asks". If you are revising, start there.

CHAPTER 8

8

Grammar for Band 7, and Your Arabic/French Error Map

WHAT IT IS WORTH

A quarter of Writing and of Speaking

WHY IT MATTERS

Articles separate band 6 from band 7. This is your chapter.

FULL READ

~63 min

60-second summary

GRA is a quarter of every task — the four Writing criteria are weighted equally [src: ielts.org — Understanding and setting IELTS scores] — and because Task 2 carries twice the weight of Task 1, your Task 2 GRA alone is about a sixth of your Writing band. Writing is the weakest paper for both your L1 backgrounds — Arabic-L1 candidates averaged 5.540 on Academic Writing in the 2024–25 official data, French-L1 6.152 [src: ielts.org — Test statistics → test taker performance data 2024–25] — so this is where the band is won.

The 6→7 gate is **not more complexity**. Band 6 already credits a mix of simple and complex forms; what caps it is that your complex sentences are less accurate than your simple ones. Close that gap and you have band 7. Add complexity without closing it and you move down.

Punctuation is inside GRA, so a comma splice is a grammar error that costs you two clauses at once — and the cheapest repair, a subordinator, is also the only one that buys you a complex structure. Learn *however / therefore / moreover* as adverbs that cannot join clauses, and *and / but / because / although / while* as conjunctions that can.

The IELTS Speaking study of 73 interviews (L1 mix unreported) puts numbers on the boundary. **Articles**: 18.4% error at band 6, 7.4% at band 7 — the largest discontinuity measured, and bands 5 and 6 were not significantly different, so articles are precisely your gate. **Third-person -s**: 70.6% at band 6, 7.6% at band 7. **Relative clauses**: doubled in frequency at band 7 at a 2.2% error rate, the safest complexity you own. **Second conditionals**: all eight produced by band-7 speakers were wrong. **Third conditionals**: zero, at every band. Skip them. **Pluralised uncountables**: the only error type found at all band levels — it does not resolve with proficiency, so it needs a permanent conscious check against the nine-word list, not more practice.

French *la société* and Arabic *al-* push you toward the same generic *the* from two directions, which is why it feels natural. The rule is not "avoid *the*" — it is "no *the* with a generic", and the moment an *of*-phrase, relative clause, superlative or second mention arrives, *the* comes back. Carry the counter-list: *the environment, the government, the media, the economy, the internet, the public, the police* keep their article; *society, nature, technology, education, poverty, research* do not.

Arabic also gives you resumptive pronouns (*which ... it*), missing relativisers after indefinite heads (*many households live...*), *and*-chains, and the occasional missing *is*. French gives you *informations*, *depend of*, *discuss about*, *significative*, and sentences twice as long as they need to be. The reduced-relative repair for the missing relativiser — *many households living below the poverty line* — is worth learning first, because it deletes a transfer error and produces a band-7 structure in the same stroke.

Build noun phrases before you build clauses: pre- and post-modification of the head noun is an officially named range indicator with almost no failure mode. Participle clauses, clefts and nominalisation are reasoned advice rather than official fact — no current IELTS document names them — but they follow defensibly from the published range indicators. Use them in that order of confidence.

Then finish early and subtract. Stop at 37 minutes on Task 2 and 17 on Task 1, run the four passes — full stops, nouns, verbs, longest sentences — and in those three minutes delete and repair only. Never add. An untested complex sentence at minute 39 is the single likeliest place for a faulty one to appear, and one faulty complex sentence re-instates the band-6 limiter you spent the whole essay avoiding.

Fix articles and full stops before you fix anything clever.

This chapter has one job. Not to teach you more grammar — you already have more grammar than a band-6 script needs. To stop the grammar you have from costing you sentences. GRA is the criterion that most reliably drags your Writing task down, and the two L1s behind your English push at it from both sides at once.

The spine of this chapter, in one paragraph

Read the band-6 accuracy cell of the Writing descriptors and notice what it does **not** say. It does not say you lack complex sentences. Band 6 explicitly credits a mix of simple and complex forms. What caps it is that the complex ones are *"not marked by the same level of accuracy as in simple structures"* [src: ielts.org — Writing band descriptors (PDF, Updated May 2023), pp.5, 9]. Band 5 says the blunter version: the greatest accuracy is achieved on simple sentences.

The 5 → 6 → 7 ladder is therefore **not a complexity ladder**. It is an accuracy-parity ladder:

Band	What the complex sentences are doing
5	Attempted, mostly faulty
6	Present, but measurably worse than your simple sentences
7	As accurate as your simple sentences

The consequence is counter-intuitive and it governs everything else here: **a band-6 writer who responds by adding more complex sentences at his current accuracy moves down, not up**. He increases the count of faulty complex structures and makes the band-6 limiter more visible.

Every recommendation in this chapter is filtered through that.

How to use this chapter — read it in this order, not front to back

This is the longest chapter in the book and you are working under a nine-minute daily theory cap ([Chapter 9](#) §The daily architecture). Do not read it straight through. Read it in value order:

When	Read
First sitting, before any drill	§Your error map, ranked by expected cost — the chapter's contents ranked by what each error costs you
Week 1–2, and until automatic	§L1 alert → The over-determined error · The counter-list · The article decision procedure · The 60-second Arabic sweep · The 45-second French sweep
Every timed task, from day one	§The three-minute self-edit — this is the artefact you keep beside the keyboard
Only once your article error rate is under 10%	§Question types, one by one — the eight band-7 structures
Reference, not reading	§What the test actually asks · §Band descriptor decoder · the French and Arabic transfer tables — look them up when an error appears in your log, not on a schedule

The order matters because of the chapter's own sequencing rule: every structure in the eight-structure section creates **new article decisions**, so drilling structures before articles are automatic trades a cheap error for an expensive one.

The grammar words this chapter uses, in plain English

This is the canonical home for these terms — chapters 4, 5 and 6 use them and point back here. None of them is examiner jargon you have to reproduce; they are labels so that a correction can be generalised instead of memorised.

Term	In plain words	Example
Finite verb	A verb carrying tense and a subject — the thing that makes a clause a clause. <i>walks, walked, is walking</i> are finite; <i>walking, to walk</i> are not.	<i>Enrolment rose.</i> (finite) vs ..., <i>rising fastest after 2015.</i> (not finite)
Head noun	The one noun a noun phrase is actually about, once you strip the words piled in front of and behind it. Every article decision is made on the head noun and nothing else.	<i>the sharp fall in rural school enrolment</i> → head noun fall
Subordinator	A word that makes one clause depend on another: <i>because, although, while, since, whereas, if, after</i> . Contrast a coordinator (<i>and, but, so</i>), which joins two equals, and an adverb (<i>however, therefore, moreover</i>), which joins nothing at all.	<i>...because fares rose.</i>
Relativiser	The word that opens a relative clause: <i>who, which, that, whose, where</i> . Arabic drops it after an indefinite noun; English never does.	<i>households that live below the line</i>
Resumptive pronoun	A spare pronoun left sitting in the hole the relativiser already filled. Standard in Arabic, an error in English.	<i>✗ the reform which the ministry announced it**</i>

Term	In plain words	Example
Reduced relative	A relative clause with the relativiser and the <i>be</i> -verb deleted. Shorter, and it counts as range.	<i>the measures introduced in 2020 (from which were introduced)</i>
Participle clause	A clause built on an <i>-ing</i> or <i>-ed</i> form instead of a finite verb, with no subject of its own — it borrows the subject of the main clause. That borrowing is the whole risk. §5	Lacking reliable transport, rural students miss classes.
Cleft sentence	A sentence deliberately split in two so that one element is put in the spotlight. <i>Cleft</i> means "split". §7	It is* the shortage of teachers that* limits access.
Nominalisation	Turning a verb or an adjective into a noun and rebuilding the sentence around it. Buys register and cohesion; costs you one new article decision every time. §8	<i>cities grew rapidly</i> → <i>the rapid growth of cities</i>
Copula	The verb <i>be</i> used to link a subject to what is said about it. Arabic can leave it out; English cannot.	<i>The obstacle is the cost.</i>
Parataxis	Building prose by stringing clauses side by side with <i>and</i> rather than subordinating them. The Arabic default, and the source of your run-ons.	<i>...is cheap and it is used by many and it reduces traffic and...</i>

What the test actually asks

GRA is one of four Writing criteria, and [ielts.org](#) states that "*The criteria are weighted equally and the score on the task is the average*" [src: ielts.org — Understanding and setting IELTS scores] — so GRA is a quarter of every Writing task, and a quarter of Speaking.

The official definition is short. GRA assesses "*the range and accurate use of the candidate's grammatical resource ... at sentence level*", through four things [src: ielts.org — Writing key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p.4]:

1. the range and appropriacy of structures — simple, compound and complex
2. the **accuracy** of simple, compound **and** complex sentences
3. the **density** and communicative effect of grammatical errors
4. the accurate and appropriate use of **punctuation**

Four things follow immediately, and each is worth more to you than any advanced-grammar list.

Punctuation is a quarter of the named criteria. It is not presentation. It is scored inside GRA at every band. A comma splice is a grammar error, and because it damages two independent clauses at once it costs you two sentences, not one.

Accuracy is assessed separately by sentence type. The descriptors do not average your accuracy across the script. They compare your complex sentences against your simple ones. That is the mechanism behind the spine above.

Density is named, not just severity. How *often* an error occurs counts on its own, independently of how bad it is.

Spelling and word formation are not here. The same document assigns the density and effect of errors in spelling and in word formation to **Lexical Resource** [src: same, p.4]. A misspelling costs LR. *Significative* for *significant* costs LR. You cannot trade a clean grammar sweep against sloppy word forms — they are different criteria and they are averaged separately.

What "range" is actually made of

Nothing in any current IELTS document names a specific structure as required or impressive. The fullest official statement of what grammatical range consists of is in the Speaking key assessment criteria, which lists five indicators [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p.3]:

- the length of sentences
- appropriate use of subordinate clauses within clauses and phrases
- complexity of the verb phrase — auxiliaries in continuous and perfect aspect, modality, passive voice
- complexity of other phrases — **modification before and after the head noun**
- range of sentence structures, especially **moving elements around for information focus**

That is a Speaking document, and the Writing equivalent is thinner (it says only simple, compound and complex). But the five indicators describe range as a linguistic construct rather than a skill-specific rubric, and two of them are almost universally ignored by candidates. Both are cheap. Pre- and post-modification means a **rich noun phrase counts as range** with no subordinate clause and almost no error risk. Moving elements for information focus is the official warrant for clefting and fronting.

How accurate is "accurate enough"?

No official source quantifies band 7's "*error-free sentences are frequent*". Two things bound it. Band 8 asks for the **majority** of sentences to be error-free, so band 7 must be regularly occurring but short of a majority. And the header rule of the descriptor grid requires a script to **fully** fit a band's positive features, so a handful of clean sentences among faulty ones is not band 7.

The one empirical anchor is Roothoof & Breeze (2019), an IELTS-published study of 73 **Speaking** interviews across bands 4–8, with the L1 mix unreported. On high-frequency features — third-person -s, articles, -ing, regular and irregular past — error rates sat **below 10% at bands 7 and 8** [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019, IELTS Research Reports Online Series 2019/1 — Speaking data, L1 mix unreported].

Your working target, derived rather than quoted: fewer than one error per ten opportunities, on any single feature. Count opportunities missed, not structures attempted.

On the ratio of clean sentences: because band 8 is the band that owns *the majority*, the honest working target for band 7 is **four sentences in ten completely error-free, rising to five** — regularly occurring, but not yet a majority. Nine sentences with three clean is a band 6 however ambitious the other six; consistently above half is evidence you are arguing for an 8.

Question types, one by one — the band-7 structures

⚠ **Do not start this section until your article error rate is under 10%.** Every structure below creates new article decisions, and §Nominalisation explains what that costs. If you have not yet run the article decision procedure to automaticity, skip forward to §L1 alert and come back.

Eight structures. For each: the form, an original example, when to use it, and the part most prep material omits — when it costs more than it earns.

Where Roothoof & Breeze measured a structure, the numbers are given, because they change the advice. Reminder every time: **Speaking data, 73 interviews, L1 mix unreported.**

1. The rich noun phrase — officially named, near-zero risk

FORM

Modification before the head noun (adjectives, nouns, participles) and after it (prepositional phrases, participles, reduced relatives). No subordinate clause required.

ORIGINAL EXAMPLE

The sharp fall in rural school enrolment recorded after 2015 has not been reversed.

That subject is one noun phrase with three post-modifiers and two pre-modifiers, and it contains no finite verb but the main one. It is grammatical range under the official taxonomy [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p.3].

WHEN TO USE

Constantly, and especially in Task 1, where the data *is* a set of modified nouns. It is the only range-building move on this list with essentially no failure mode of its own.

WHEN IT BACKFIRES

Stacked bare nouns. *Government transport infrastructure investment policy* is four modifiers deep and stops being readable, which is an impede-communication event. **Cap at two pre-modifiers.** And note that every noun phrase you build creates one more article decision — see the L1 alert.

2. Relative clauses — the safest complexity you own

FORM

Defining (identifies which one): no commas, *that* allowed, the pronoun may be dropped when it is the object. *Non-defining* (adds information about an already-identified thing): commas both sides, *that* not allowed.

ORIGINAL EXAMPLES

- Defining: *Countries that invest early in vocational training report lower youth unemployment.* - Defining, pronoun dropped: *The measures the council introduced in 2019 have barely affected congestion.* - Non-defining: *Vocational training, which costs a fraction of a degree to deliver, reaches students that academic routes never see.*

WHEN TO USE

Constantly. This is the best-value complex structure in the evidence base. Roothoof & Breeze counted attempts per band — 86 at band 6, **185 at band 7** — while the error rate fell to **2.2% at band 7**, the lowest of any complex structure they measured [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019 — Speaking data, L1 mix unreported]. Band-7 speakers used relative clauses roughly twice as often *and* got them right. No other structure in that study shows both.

WHEN IT BACKFIRES

- **A resumptive pronoun left in the gap** — your Arabic transfer error, treated in full below. *X the reform which the ministry announced it in 2019* - **A comma that changes your meaning.** *Students who live far from campus miss more classes* (some students) vs *Students, who live far from campus, miss more classes* (all students live far from campus — almost never what you meant). That is a punctuation error and a content error in one stroke. - **Stacking.** Two relative clauses in one sentence usually produces a sentence you cannot finish accurately under the clock.

3. Concession clauses — the counter-argument machine, and your highest-frequency trap

FORM

Four groups that all mean "contrast" and take completely different complements.

Word	Takes	Example
although / though / even though	a clause	<i>Although fees have risen, applications continue to grow.</i>
while / whereas	a clause	<i>Whereas rural clinics are understaffed, urban hospitals turn patients away.</i>
despite / in spite of	a noun phrase or -ing	<i>Despite the rise in fees, applications continue to grow.</i>
however / nevertheless / nonetheless	nothing — adverbs, not conjunctions	<i>Fees have risen. However, applications continue to grow.</i>

WHEN TO USE

In Task 2 this is how you concede and rebut; in Task 1 it handles exceptions to a trend. It is also the cheapest unambiguous signal of subordination.

WHEN IT BACKFIRES

Three failures, all of them predicted by your two L1s.

- ✗ *Although the tax is unpopular, but it has cut consumption.* ✓ *Although the tax is unpopular, it has cut consumption.* English allows exactly one conjunction to join two clauses. Arabic and French both tolerate a contrastive marker echoed in the main clause. IDP's official grammar article names "*Although...but*" as a common error [src: ielts.idp.com — grammar article].
- ✗ *Despite the tax is unpopular, it has cut consumption.* ✓ *Despite its unpopularity, the tax has cut consumption.* ✓ *Despite being unpopular, the tax has cut consumption.* ✓ *Despite the fact that the tax is unpopular, it has cut consumption.* French *bien que* and Arabic *raghma anna* both take a full clause and both translate naturally as *despite*. English splits the job. *Despite the fact that* is clumsy but correct, and correct beats elegant.
- ✗ *Fees have doubled, however applications continue to rise.* — a comma splice. ✓ *Fees have doubled. However, applications continue to rise.*

4. Passives — required in Task 1, optional in Task 2, dangerous everywhere**FORM**

be + past participle. Add *by* only when the agent matters.

ORIGINAL EXAMPLES

- Task 1 process, present simple passive: *The harvested cane is washed, crushed and then heated until the juice separates.* - Task 2, agent genuinely irrelevant: *Tuition fees were frozen for three consecutive years.* - Modal perfect passive: *The scheme should have been evaluated before it was extended.*

WHEN TO USE

Process diagrams effectively require it. Passive voice is also named inside the official verb-phrase range indicator, so it counts as range in its own right [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p.3].

WHEN IT BACKFIRES

- **The intransitive passive**, a genuine grammatical error and a documented Francophone transfer. ✗ *A serious accident was happened at the junction last winter.* ✓ *A serious accident happened at the junction last winter.* ✗ *The number of visitors was risen sharply after 2016.* ✓ *The number of visitors rose sharply after 2016.* *happen, occur, arise, appear, exist, rise, fall, emerge, remain, consist* take no object, so there is nothing to promote to subject. No object, no passive, ever. - **Vagueness.** *It is believed that...* hides who believes it, and Task Response wants a clear position. IDP is explicit that the passive being common in academic writing does not mean using it in every sentence [src: ielts.idp.com — grammar article]. - **The band-7 trap.** In Roothoof & Breeze, passives barely appeared below band 7, then jumped to 74 attempts at band 7 with an **8.1%** error rate, against 69 attempts at band 8 with **1.4%** [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019 — Speaking data, L1 mix unreported]. Attempting passives is what band-7 candidates do. Getting them right is what band-8 candidates do.

5. Participle clauses — the most under-used cheap signal

⚠ **Reasoned advice, not official fact.** Participle clauses are not named in any current IELTS document. Their value here is derived from the band-7 requirement for a variety of complex structures, plus the official range indicators "*subordinate clauses within clauses and phrases*" and "*complexity of other phrases*" [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p.3]. Treat it as a defensible inference.

WHAT IT IS, IN PLAIN WORDS

A clause built on an *-ing* or *-ed* form of the verb instead of a full tensed one, and with no subject of its own — it silently borrows the subject of the main clause. That borrowing is where all the value and all the danger sit.

FORM

Three types, all of which delete a subject and a finite verb.

Type	From	To
-ing (active)	<i>Because they lack reliable transport, many rural students miss classes.</i>	Lacking reliable transport, many rural students miss classes.
-ed (passive)	<i>The measures which were introduced in 2020 have had little effect.</i>	<i>The measures introduced in 2020 have had little effect.</i>
having + p.p.	<i>After the council had introduced a charge, it saw traffic fall.</i>	Having introduced a charge, the council saw traffic fall.

There is a fourth use worth more to you than the other three combined, because it is tailor-made for Task 1 — the **trailing -ing clause** that comments on the main clause:

- *Enrolment doubled between 2010 and 2020, rising fastest in the final three years.*
- *Solar generation reached 40 terawatt-hours, accounting for roughly a quarter of supply.*
- *The two lines converged after 2015, remaining within two percentage points of each other thereafter.*

WHEN TO USE

Anywhere you would otherwise write a second short sentence with the same subject. It buys subordination and drops five or six words, which under a 20- and 40-minute clock is real.

When it backfires — one failure mode, and it is severe. The participle takes its subject from the subject of the main clause. Mismatch, and the sentence says something absurd.

✗ *Having banned diesel cars from the centre, air quality improved within a year.* — the air quality banned the cars. ✓ *Having banned diesel cars from the centre, the city saw air quality improve within a year.* ✓ *After the city banned diesel cars from the centre, air quality improved within a year.*

✗ *Lacking formal qualifications, employers rarely shortlist these candidates.* — the employers lack the qualifications. ✓ *Lacking formal qualifications, these candidates are rarely shortlisted.*

One-second self-check: put your finger on the word immediately after the comma. That word must be the thing doing the participle. If it is not, rewrite with *Because / After / Since*.

6. The second conditional — one pattern, owned cold

FORM

If + past simple, *would* + base. (Hypothetical present or future.)

ORIGINAL EXAMPLE

If governments taxed sugary drinks at the same rate as tobacco, consumption would fall within a decade.

WHEN TO USE

Task 2 asks you to argue about policies that do not exist yet, so one well-formed second conditional in a body paragraph does real work.

When it backfires — and the data here is blunt. Roothoof & Breeze found band 7 had the **highest** conditional error rate in the study, 27.8%, against 10.7% at band 6 and 2.7% at band 8; of the **eight** second conditionals produced by band-7 speakers, **all eight** contained an error. And across all 73 interviews at every band, there were **zero** third conditionals [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019

— Speaking data, L1 mix unreported].

Read that properly. The third conditional is not a band marker. It is a three-part structure that candidates from band 4 to band 8 essentially never produce. Reaching for it to impress means reaching for something no band-8 speaker in the sample bothered with.

The recurring wrong form: - ✗ *If governments would tax sugary drinks, consumption would fall.* ✓ *If governments taxed sugary drinks, consumption would fall.* (no *would* in the *if*-clause)

The same no-modal-in-the-*if*-clause rule governs the **first** conditional, which is a different structure — a real future condition, not a hypothetical one — but fails the same way: ✗ *If the subsidy will end next year, ticket prices will rise.* → ✓ *If the subsidy ends next year, ticket prices will rise.*

Deliberately **not** marked wrong: *If public transport was free, more people would use it.* *Were* is the formal subjunctive and the better academic choice; *was* is standard modern English and no defensible examiner penalises it. Prefer *were*, do not fear *was*.

Verdict: own the second conditional as a pattern. Skip the third. Skip mixed entirely.

7. Cleft sentences — one per essay, no more

⚠ Reasoned advice. Clefts are not named in any current IELTS document. The warrant is the official range indicator "*range of sentence structures, especially to move elements around for information focus*" [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p.3], which describes exactly what a cleft does.

WHAT IT IS, IN PLAIN WORDS

Cleft means "split". You take one ordinary sentence and break it into two halves so that the element you most want noticed is pushed into the spotlight. *The shortage of qualified teachers limits access* becomes *It is the shortage of qualified teachers that limits access*. Same content, one idea now under a lamp.

FORM

It-cleft: *It is/was* + X + *that/who* + *Wh*-cleft: *What ... is/was* + X.

ORIGINAL EXAMPLES

- *It is the shortage of qualified teachers, rather than the shortage of buildings, that limits access to education in rural areas.* - *What these figures do not show is how the cost is distributed across income groups.*

WHEN TO USE

Once, to state a thesis or to land the point you most want taken from a body paragraph. It is a rhetorical instrument, not a decoration.

WHEN IT BACKFIRES

- **Repetition reads as a template.** Three clefts in one essay stops looking like control. The descriptors penalise memorised chunks and formulaic language, and wholly memorised answers sit at band 0 [src: ielts.org — Writing key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p.1]. - **Agreement.** ✗ *What matters are the outcomes.* The subject is *What matters*, which is singular. ✓ *What matters is the outcome.* / ✓ *The outcomes are what matter.* - **Length.** It adds a clause boundary you must punctuate correctly, and punctuation is already your exposure.

8. Nominalisation — the register marker, with a tax

⚠ Reasoned advice. Not named in any current IELTS document. The warrant is the required "*academic or semi-formal/neutral*" style plus the official Coherence and Cohesion sub-skill of flexible reference and substitution [src: ielts.org — Writing test format; Writing key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p.3].

WHAT IT IS, IN PLAIN WORDS

Taking the action out of the verb and packing it into a noun, then rebuilding the sentence around that noun. *Governments regulate emissions strictly* → *strict regulation of emissions*. English academic prose does this constantly, which is why the noun version of two otherwise identical sentences reads as the more academic one.

FORM

Turn the verb or adjective into a noun and make it the subject.

Verbal	Nominalised
<i>Governments regulate emissions strictly, and this has cut air pollution.</i>	Strict regulation of emissions has cut air pollution.
<i>The population grew rapidly, which meant housing became scarce.</i>	Rapid population growth produced a housing shortage.
<i>Fewer people are willing to commute, so firms have offered hybrid contracts.</i>	A decline in willingness to commute has forced firms to offer hybrid contracts.

WHEN TO USE

Three real payoffs: register; cohesion (once you have a noun you can refer back — *This decline...*, *Such regulation...* — which pays you in CC, a different criterion); and density, since it removes a clause and with it a chance to make an agreement error.

When it backfires — and this warning is specific to you. Every nominalisation creates a **new article decision**. *Governments regulate* has no article problem; *the strict regulation of emissions introduced in 2019* has one. Articles are your most expensive error, so nominalising trades an agreement risk for an article risk, and until the article procedure below is automatic, the article risk is worse. **Sequence: fix articles first, then nominalise.**

Word formation — the LR crossover you should build alongside nominalisation

Nominalising means reaching for derived forms, and a misformed derivative costs **LR**, not GRA

[src: ielts.org — Writing key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p.4]. French supplies lookalike forms that do not exist in English. Learn the families as families.

Verb	Noun	Adjective	The French-shaped trap
analyse	analysis (pl. analyses)	analytical	✗ <i>analyse</i> as a noun → ✓ <i>analysis</i>
compete	competition, competitor	competitive	—
depend	dependence, dependant	dependent	✗ <i>dependance</i> → ✓ <i>dependence</i>
develop	development	developed, developing	✗ <i>developpement</i> → ✓ <i>development</i>
benefit	benefit	beneficial	✗ <i>benefic</i> → ✓ <i>beneficial</i>
apply	application	applicable	✗ <i>was applicated</i> → ✓ <i>was applied</i>
pollute	pollution, pollutant	polluted, polluting	—

Verb	Noun	Adjective	The French-shaped trap
rely	reliance	reliant, reliable	—
—	economy	economic / economical	see below
signify	significance	significant	✗ <i>significative</i> → ✓ <i>significant</i>

Two pairs are worth memorising as pairs because both members are real words with different meanings:

- ✗ *The government introduced economical reforms.* → ✓ *The government introduced economic reforms.* (*economic* = relating to the economy)
- ✗ *Public transport is a very economic option for commuters.* → ✓ *Public transport is a very economical option for commuters.* (*economical* = cheap to run)

Tips & tricks

Ranked by expected impact on your band.

1. Fix articles and full stops before you fix anything clever. [verified] Articles produced the largest band 6→7 discontinuity in the IELTS research literature — 18.4% error at band 6 falling to 7.4% at band 7, chi-square 80.1, $p < 0.01$, with bands 5 and 6 **not** significantly different from each other [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019 — Speaking data, L1 mix unreported]. Articles do not separate 5 from 6. They separate 6 from 7, which is your boundary. **Procedure:** the two artefacts that make this a habit rather than an intention are §The article decision procedure (run on the head noun, five seconds) and §The 60-second Arabic sweep (run on the finished draft). Do not attempt anything in the eight-structure section until sweep pass 1 finds fewer than one article error per ten *thes*.

2. Repair every comma splice with a subordinator, not a full stop. [verified] Punctuation sits inside the GRA criterion [src: ielts.org — Writing key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p4], and subordinating is the only repair that converts a punctuation error into a complex structure. Every splice in your draft is a complex sentence you failed to build.

3. Learn *however* and *but* as two different lists. [verified] *However, therefore, moreover, furthermore, nevertheless, thus, consequently, in addition, on the other hand* are adverbs and cannot join clauses. *And, but, so, because, although, while, since, whereas* are conjunctions and can. A band-6 script typically contains five to eight of the first list; if each sits in a splice, that is five to eight sentences removed from the error-free count.

4. Count opportunities missed, not structures attempted. [expert consensus] The derived target is under one error per ten slots on any single feature — the level at which the IELTS study found bands 7 and 8 sitting [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019 — Speaking data, L1 mix unreported]. **Procedure:** pick one feature per script — articles this week, third-person -s next. Count the **slots** first (every noun that could take an article; every present-simple verb with a singular subject), then count the

ones you got wrong, and write the fraction in `error-log.md`. "I made four article errors" is not a measurement; "four errors in thirty-one slots, 13%" is, and it tells you whether you are above or below the band-7 line.

5. Build noun phrases before you build clauses. [verified] Pre- and post-modification of the head noun is a named official range indicator [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p.3] and carries almost no error risk. It is the only free range on the list. **Procedure:** take any bare subject in your last essay — *enrolment, the scheme, costs* — and load it. One modifier in front (adjective, noun, participle) and one behind (prepositional phrase, participle, reduced relative), then stop. *Enrolment* → *the sharp fall in rural school enrolment recorded after 2015*. Cap at two pre-modifiers, and run the article procedure on the head noun before you move on.

6. In the last three minutes you may delete and repair. You may not add. [expert consensus] Adding a clever sentence at minute 39 is how a band-7 script becomes a band-6 script: an untested complex structure is where the faulty one appears, and one faulty complex sentence re-instates the limiter you spent forty minutes avoiding. IDP's own advice is to finish a few minutes early and check [src: ielts.idp.com — Writing advice]. Stop writing at **37 minutes** on Task 2 and **17 minutes** on Task 1 — the canonical clocks and word targets for the whole book are in [Chapter 9](#) §The numbers, in one table.

7. Convert your transfer errors into structures. [expert consensus] ✗ *There are many households rely on a single income* is an Arabic missing-relativiser error. ✓ *...many households relying on a single income* fixes it **and** produces a participle clause. The repair and the upgrade are the same move.

8. Prefer *were* in the second conditional, but do not fear *was*. [expert consensus] *If public transport were free...* is the better academic register; *was* is standard modern English and not a defensible penalty.

9. Skip the third conditional entirely. [verified] Zero occurrences across 73 interviews spanning bands 4 to 8 [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019 — Speaking data, L1 mix unreported]. **Procedure:** the trigger is thinking about the past. Whenever a sentence starts forming as *If governments had..., they would have...*, rewrite it in the past simple with a consequence: *Governments failed to act in the 1990s, and emissions rose accordingly*. Same argument, one tense, no three-part structure to get wrong under the clock.

10. Read for one error type at a time when you check. [expert consensus] Reading for meaning makes you read what you meant, not what you wrote. Four passes, in priority order: full stops, nouns and articles, verbs, then only your two or three longest sentences.

Myths that hold you back

1. "More complex sentences means a higher GRA band." Band 6's limiter is not a lack of complex sentences — it is that the complex ones are less accurate than the simple ones. Adding more at your current accuracy makes the limiter more visible. Empirically, band 7 carried the

study's highest conditional error rate and a higher passive error rate than any lower band, purely because band-7 candidates attempt more [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019 — Speaking data, L1 mix unreported]. Complexity attempted is not complexity achieved, and only the achieved kind is in the descriptor.

2. "Aim for 60–70% complex sentences." No official IELTS document states any proportion, ratio or count. The descriptors ask for *a variety* and never quantify. A quota makes you write complex sentences you do not need and cannot check, which is myth 1 with a number attached.

3. "Never write a simple sentence — they look basic." The **current** Speaking descriptor (the file created 2025-09-16) dropped the word *complex* from the band-7 range clause and now states outright that both simple and complex sentences are used **effectively** at band 7 [src: ielts.org — Speaking band descriptors (PDF, 2025-09-16)]. A short declarative is error-free by construction and is a rhetorical instrument. **But** the counterweight is equally official: IDP states that an answer written entirely in short sentences cannot receive a high GRA score even with no errors at all [src: ielts.idp.com — grammar article].

And for Writing the evidence is direct, not inferred. The official **7.5** computer-delivered Task 2 exemplar — a script the examiner praised for "a variety of complex structures with frequent error-free sentences" — was told in the same sentence that *"there is some overuse of rather short sentence forms"* [src: ielts.org — CD Academic Writing example responses with band scores and examiner comments (PDF), Part 2, Candidate Response 2, Band 7.5; verified by fresh fetch 2026-07-31]. An official Writing examiner marked short-sentence overuse down in a script that was otherwise strong. That closes the myth from the other side: short sentences are instruments, not a style.

Scope this carefully, because the change is Speaking-only. *Complex* was dropped from the **Speaking** band-7 range clause. The **Writing** band-7 GRA cell still reads *"A variety of complex structures is used with some flexibility and accuracy"* [src: ielts.org — Writing band descriptors (PDF, Updated May 2023), p.1] — the word was not dropped there. So in Speaking, simple sentences used effectively are now explicitly credited at band 7; in Writing, complex variety is still named. All-simple is capped in both papers; simple **among** complex is rewarded in both.

4. "Use the passive everywhere — it sounds academic." IDP says the opposite in as many words [src: ielts.idp.com — grammar article]. Three costs: it hides the agent when Task Response wants a position; it invites the intransitive passive, a real error; and band 8 was distinguished from band 7 not by *using* passives but by using them accurately.

5. "Memorise ten impressive templates and drop them in." The criteria name inappropriate use of memorised phrases and formulaic language as a penalised feature, and reserve band 0 in part for wholly memorised answers [src: ielts.org — Writing key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p.1]. **Learn patterns** — the shape of a second conditional — not sentences.

6. "Semicolons and dashes show sophistication." Punctuation is scored for accurate and appropriate use, not variety. A misused semicolon is an error inside the GRA count; a correct full stop is not. "Range" in the descriptors refers to structures, never to punctuation marks.

7. "Grammar mistakes don't matter if the meaning is clear." Half true, and the false half is the expensive half. Bands 6 **and** 7 both sit above the impede-communication line, so intelligibility does not separate them — the count of clean sentences does. Non-impeding errors are not harmless. They are precisely what caps you at 6.

8. "Long sentences show grammatical range." Sentence length is **one of five** official range indicators, alongside subordination, verb-phrase complexity, phrase complexity and word-order variation [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p.3]. A sixty-word chain of *and* clauses has the first and none of the other four — and it is the exact output of Arabic paratactic transfer. Length without subordination is the band-5 profile with more words.

9. "Fix articles last — they're minor." Inverted. They are the largest measured 6→7 discontinuity and the one error both your L1s push toward. They are also invisible on re-reading, which is why they need a dedicated pass rather than a general proofread.

10. "Contractions cost you marks in Writing." No current IELTS document found in the research for this book names contractions at all. The relevant official requirement is an academic or semi-formal/neutral style, which is a **register** question under LR, not a GRA rule [src: ielts.org — Writing test format]. Avoid them in Writing as sensible register practice, not as a scored rule. Note separately that *its* / *it's* confusion **is** a real scored error.

Band descriptor decoder

Paraphrased throughout. Read the official PDFs yourself for the exact wording: Writing ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/ielts-writing-band-descriptors.pdf (Updated May 2023) and Speaking ielts.org/cdn/ielts-guides/ielts-speaking-band-descriptors.pdf (created 2025-09-16). Older copies circulate widely and say materially different things.

Writing GRA — identical wording in the Task 1 and Task 2 columns

Band	Range, paraphrased	Accuracy, paraphrased	Punctuation, paraphrased
8	Wide range of structures, used flexibly and accurately	Most sentences contain no error; the occasional slip is non-systematic and barely registers	Handled well
7	A variety of complex structures, with some flexibility and some accuracy	Error-free sentences occur regularly; a few errors persist but never block the reader	Grammar and punctuation generally under control
6	Simple and complex forms are both present, but you cannot move between them freely	The complex ones are less accurate than the simple ones	Errors occur in both, but rarely block the reader

Band	Range, paraphrased	Accuracy, paraphrased	Punctuation, paraphrased
5	Limited and rather repetitive range; complex sentences are attempted but tend to be faulty, and the greatest accuracy is on the simple ones	Errors may be frequent and cause the reader some difficulty	May be faulty

That band-6 accuracy clause is the whole of the band-6 GRA definition on accuracy. **It is not bolded** — and this matters, because prep material routinely claims it is. The grid's own legend reserves bold for negative features that limit a rating, and on the descriptor pages covering bands 6 and 5 the entire bold inventory sits at **band 5: incompletely addressed, Paragraphing may be inadequate or missing, There may be no data to support the description**. The pages covering bands 9, 8 and 7 carry no bolded body text at all [src: ielts.org — Writing band descriptors (PDF, Updated May 2023), pp4 and 8; verified by per-character font extraction, 2026-07-31]. [Chapter 5](#) tells you how to run that check yourself, and you should.

The clause does not need to be bolded to bind you. It is a **positive-feature description of what a band-6 script is**, and the grid's header rule says a script must *fully* fit the positive features of a level to be rated there. Fitting that clause *is* what band 6 means.

Before → after, 6 to 7. The change is not more clauses. It is the same idea with the faults removed.

Band-6 shape. *The technology has changed the education in many countries, however many schools they still do not have the equipments they need, and this create a gap between rural and urban students.*

Band-7 shape. *Technology has changed education in many countries. Many schools, however, still lack the equipment they need, and this creates a gap between rural and urban students.*

Count what moved. Two generic *thes* deleted; a resumptive *they* deleted; *equipments* depluralised; *create* → *creates*; one comma splice converted into a full stop with the adverb correctly punctuated. Not one clause was added. The second version is no more complex than the first — it is the first, made error-free.

Speaking GRA — the current (2025) file

Band	Range, paraphrased	Accuracy, paraphrased
8	Wide range of structures, used flexibly	Most sentences contain no error; a few basic errors may persist
7	A range of structures used flexibly; simple and complex sentences both used effectively	Error-free sentences are frequent, despite some errors; a few basic errors persist
6	A mix of short and complex forms, and a variety of structures, but flexibility is limited	Errors occur frequently in the complex structures, though they rarely block the listener
5	Basic sentence forms are fairly well controlled for accuracy; complex structures are attempted, but they are limited in range	Those complex attempts nearly always contain errors, and may force you to stop and reformulate mid-sentence

Band 5 is in that table for a reason: your baseline is undiagnosed and a first recorded Part 3 can land at 5.5, so you need descriptor language for what you actually produced, not only for what you are aiming at. If what you hear on playback is *basic forms mostly right, complex attempts nearly always wrong, and a reformulation every time you try one*, that is the band-5 description, not the band-6 one. Note the ladder the four rows describe: at 5 the complex attempts nearly always fail, at 6 they fail frequently, at 7 they are as sound as your simple ones. It is the same accuracy-parity ladder as Writing, and the repair is the same — subtract the faulty complex attempts before you add more.

Two things in that table are commonly mistaught and both are load-bearing for you.

The word *complex* is gone from the band-7 range clause, and simple sentences are now explicitly endorsed as effective. Whatever you were told about never writing a short sentence in Part 3 is out of date.

Basic errors are tolerated at 7 and at 8 — but read the modal and read the quantifier. Band 7 says a few basic errors *persist*; band 8 says a few *may* persist. At 7 they are expected, at 8 merely survivable. And *a few* is a **density** claim, not an amnesty: the official Speaking criteria define accuracy partly by "*error density (the number of grammatical errors in a given amount of speech)*" [src: ielts.org — Speaking key assessment criteria (PDF, 2023), p.3]. So an *occasional* dropped third-person -s under time pressure is not what keeps you at 6 — a *habitual* one is exactly what does, and the study below puts the band-6 rate at 70.6%. Get it to occasional in writing practice first; then stop monitoring it in speech and spend the attention on making the conditional land. That tolerance is also Speaking-specific: Writing gives you checking time, and the Writing descriptors do not license the same thing.

Before → after, Speaking 6 to 7.

Band-6 shape. *In my country the people they use a lot the public transport, because the petrol is expensive, and also the traffic is very bad in the capital.*

Band-7 shape. *In my country people rely heavily on public transport, mainly because petrol is expensive and because traffic in the capital is so bad.*

Again: no new clause type. A resumptive *they* gone, three generic *thes* gone, a French adverb position (*use a lot*) fixed, and one loose *and also* turned into a second subordinate *because*.

L1 alert

This is the heart of the chapter. You are exposed from two directions at once, and the two directions mostly agree with each other — which is why your errors feel natural rather than careless.

The over-determined error: the generic definite article

The Arabic mechanism. Arabic has one article, **ال (al-)**, prefixed to the noun, and **no indefinite article** — indefiniteness is the *absence* of al-, optionally marked by tanwīn, a diacritic that is usually not even printed. Two consequences pull in opposite directions. There is no word to translate for *a/an*, so the slot simply stays empty. And Arabic uses al- with **generic** nouns — "technology in general" is *al-tiknulūjīyā* — where English uses the zero article [src: Junina 2025 (Tier 2), citing Ryding 2005].

The French mechanism. French requires a determiner on almost every noun and uses *le / la / les* with generic reference: *La société évolue, L'éducation est essentielle*. English marks generic reference with the **zero article** on uncountables and plural countables.

So *al-mujtama'* and *la société* push you toward *the society* from two different directions. This is not a coincidental slip. It is the single most over-determined error in your profile, and it is the largest measured band 6→7 discontinuity in the IELTS research literature [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019 — Speaking data, L1 mix unreported].

The rule that stops the overcorrection. The error is not *the*. The error is *the* with a **generic**. The moment a noun is made specific — by an *of*-phrase, a defining relative clause, a superlative, an ordinal, a date, or previous mention — English wants *the* back.

✗	✓	The contrast that proves the rule
<i>The society expects graduates to be job-ready.</i>	<i>Society expects graduates to be job-ready.</i>	✓ The* society in which we live* rewards specialists.
<i>The technology has transformed how children learn.</i>	<i>Technology has transformed how children learn.</i>	✓ The* technology used in these classrooms* was donated.
<i>The pollution in the cities is caused mainly by the traffic.</i>	<i>Pollution in cities is caused mainly by traffic.</i>	✓ The* pollution recorded in 2019* exceeded safe limits.
<i>The unemployment among the young people remains high.</i>	<i>Unemployment among young people remains high.</i>	✓ The* unemployment rate* rose to 14%.
<i>Governments must invest in the education to reduce the poverty.</i>	<i>Governments must invest in education to reduce poverty.</i>	✓ ...to reduce the poverty recorded in the 2019 census.

And the reverse error, which Arabic drives hardest because there is no *a/an* to transfer:

✗	✓	Why
<i>Social media has great impact on young people.</i>	<i>Social media has a great impact on young people.</i>	Singular countable, first mention

✗	✓	Why
<i>He works as engineer in a construction firm.</i>	<i>He works as an engineer in a construction firm.</i>	Singular countable after <i>as</i>
<i>Physical activity is important for health of the body.</i>	<i>Physical activity is important for the health of the body.</i>	<i>the + N + of + N</i> is specific by definition

The counter-list — abstract nouns that KEEP their article

This is the table that stops the rule from doing more damage than the error. English takes the definite article generically with a specific, lexicalised set. There is no principle that predicts why *the environment* takes it and *nature* does not. Learn it as a list.

Take the in generic use	Take zero in generic use
the environment · the government · the media · the economy · the internet · the public · the police · the countryside · the weather · the climate · the authorities · the state · the past · the future · the elderly · the young	society · nature · technology · education · health · poverty · crime · unemployment · inflation · pollution · globalisation · tourism · agriculture · industry · science · history · art · music · life · knowledge · research · transport

✗	✓
<i>Environment is the main casualty of rapid industrialisation.</i>	The <i>environment is the main casualty of rapid industrialisation.</i>
<i>Media exaggerate the risks of air travel.</i>	The <i>media exaggerate the risks of air travel.</i>
<i>Government should regulate emissions more strictly.</i>	The <i>government should regulate emissions more strictly.</i> (or plural generic: <i>Governments should...</i>)
<i>Internet has changed how research is conducted.</i>	The <i>internet has changed how research is conducted.</i>

⚠ This table is assembled from standard English usage, not from a cited reference grammar. It is reliable for IELTS purposes; if you want an authority, check Swan's *Practical English Usage* on generic reference.

The article decision procedure

Run it on the **head noun**.

STEP 1 – Is the head noun COUNTABLE?

NO (information, advice, research, equipment, evidence, knowledge, feedback, software, furniture, money, traffic, education, pollution, progress, work...)
→ NEVER "a/an". NEVER plural. Go to STEP 3.

YES → STEP 2

STEP 2 – Singular or plural? Note it. It matters only on the zero branch.**STEP 3 – GENERIC (the class as a whole) or SPECIFIC (this one)?****GENERIC**

plural countable → ZERO "Governments should invest in railways."

uncountable → ZERO "Education reduces poverty."

singular countable → avoid; if forced, "a" for a typical member

△ EXCEPT the lexicalised counter-list above

SPECIFIC → STEP 4

STEP 4 – Can the reader identify WHICH one, right now?

Identifiable if ANY of these holds:

- second mention
- followed by an "of"-phrase the number of students
- followed by a defining relative the measures that were introduced
- superlative or ordinal the highest figure, the first stage
- unique in context the sun, the government
- ranking/proportion noun the proportion, the rate, the majority

YES → "the"

NO → singular countable → "a/an"

plural countable → ZERO (or "some")

uncountable → ZERO (or "some")

Five patterns cover most of what you actually get wrong:

1. **the + NOUN + of + NOUN is almost always the** — *the number of students, the impact of technology, the cost of housing, the role of government*. This is the exact slot where Arabic L1 omits the article, and it is most of a Task 1 opening.
2. **Superlatives and ordinals take the** — *the highest figure, the first stage*. But no article after a possessive: *its highest level*.
3. **Generic plural is zero however long the modifier**. *Young people in rural areas are...*, not *The young people...*. Adjectives and prepositional phrases do not make a generic noun specific.
4. **Percentages and dates take no article**. *in 2010, 20 per cent of students* — but *the percentage of students* and *the 1990s*.
5. **Second mention takes the**. *A congestion charge was introduced in 2003. The charge raised £2bn in a decade*. Free accuracy, and it also serves the CC criterion's flexible-reference sub-skill.

Arabic: the other three transfers

Resumptive pronouns in relative clauses. In Modern Standard Arabic the relative clause leaves a pronoun in the gap. It is optional in subject and direct-object position and **obligatory** in oblique (prepositional) position [src: Alroudhan 2016 (Tier 2)]. There is a second, mirror-image rule: the relative marker appears only after a **definite** head noun, so after an indefinite head Arabic uses no marker at all. Arabic therefore predicts both an extra pronoun **and** a missing one.

✗	✓	Why
<i>The reform which the ministry announced it in 2019 has been abandoned.</i>	<i>The reform which the ministry announced in 2019 has been abandoned.</i>	<i>which</i> has already relativised the object
<i>The residents who the survey contacted them were mostly retired.</i>	<i>The residents whom the survey contacted were mostly retired.</i>	Oblique/object position — where Arabic makes the pronoun obligatory, so the hardest to suppress
<i>This is the district where the council built the tramline in it.</i>	<i>This is the district where the council built the tramline.</i>	<i>where</i> already carries the preposition; never both
<i>There are many households live below the poverty line.</i>	<i>There are many households that live below the poverty line. / ...many households living below the poverty line.</i>	Indefinite head, so MSA drops the marker; English does not

That last row is the one to internalise: the reduced-relative repair kills the transfer error **and** produces a participle clause. The fix and the upgrade are one move.

Parataxis and run-ons. Arabic prose builds by coordination (*wa-*, *fa-*) rather than subordination, and the documented result in English is long, unfocused, run-on sentences

[src: Junina 2025 (Tier 2); Abu Rass 2015 (Tier 2), 205 students over 14 years].

✗ *Public transport in the capital is cheap and it is used by many workers and it reduces traffic and it also reduces pollution and the government wants to expand it.*

✓ *Public transport in the capital is cheap and heavily used by workers. Because it takes cars off the road, it reduces both congestion and pollution — which is why the government intends to expand it.*

Count what the repair bought: one subordinator (*Because*), one non-defining relative (— *which is why...*), and one compound predicate collapsed (*cheap and heavily used*). Five clauses chained on *and* became four, two of them now subordinate rather than coordinate, and the four clause-joining *ands* went to zero — the two *ands* left join a pair of predicates and a pair of nouns, not two sentences. The repair is five words **longer**, and that is the honest trade: subordination costs words and buys range. **Range up, error surface down.**

Copula omission. Arabic present-tense sentences can be verbless — *al-madīnatu kabīra* is literally "the-city big" [src: Abu Rass 2015 (Tier 2), citing Benmamoun 2000]. Severe when it happens, but low-frequency at your level.

✗	✓
<i>The main obstacle in rural areas the cost of transport.</i>	<i>The main obstacle in rural areas is the cost of transport.</i>
<i>These measures very expensive for small businesses.</i>	<i>These measures are very expensive for small businesses.</i>

Third-person -s. Arabic-L1 corpora show clusters of omission — "*Technology play an important role ... because it help students ... It give access ... and make learning more interactive*" is four omissions in two sentences [src: Junina 2025 (Tier 2)]. The IELTS Speaking study measured **70.6% error at band 6 falling to 7.6% at band 7**, the sharpest cliff of any morpheme, with no significant difference between bands 4, 5 and 6 [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019 — Speaking data, L1 mix unreported]. The target is *occasional slip*, not *habitual omission*.

✗	✓	Why
<i>Technology play an important role in education.</i>	<i>Technology plays an important role in education.</i>	Singular subject, present simple
<i>A child who spend three hours a day online read less.</i>	<i>A child who spends three hours a day online reads less.</i>	The verb inside the relative clause agrees too — two slots, both usually missed
<i>Peoples are depend on public transport.</i>	<i>People depend on public transport.</i>	<i>People</i> is already plural; <i>are</i> + bare verb stacks two verbs; and the preposition
<i>Each of the three regions have its own transport authority.</i>	<i>Each of the three regions has its own transport authority.</i>	<i>Each</i> is singular; the plural in the <i>of</i> -phrase is a distractor

Do not overcorrect collectives. *The government have decided...* is standard British English. Leave it.

The 60-second Arabic sweep

Three passes, in this order.

1. **Every the (25 s).** One yes/no question each: is the noun after it an abstract idea talked about in general, with no *of*-phrase, relative clause or superlative attached? If yes, **delete it** — unless it is on the counter-list.
2. **Every article-less singular noun (25 s).** Any singular countable with no article, no possessive and no quantifier needs *a/an* (first mention) or *the* (identifiable). Proper nouns are exempt.
3. **Every which / who / where (10 s).** Stray pronoun after the verb (*which ... it, who ... them, where ... in it*)? Delete it. Clause with no relative pronoun after an indefinite head (*many households live...*)? Insert *that*, or reduce to *-ing*.

French: the four transfers that are not the article

French is close enough to English to be dangerous. Its errors are not breakdowns; they are high-frequency, low-severity slips of exactly the kind that cap a script at 6 without ever impeding a sentence.

⚠ The main French-learner corpus available here — Sokeng (2014), 250 students, 908 errors [src: Sokeng 2014 (Tier 2)] — is **Cameroonian Francophone** data, sociolinguistically distant from a Tunisian French/Arabic bilingual, and its article figure (5% of errors) is low enough to conflict with both the Arabic literature and the IELTS study. Its **mechanisms** transfer; its **proportions** do not. Use it for what, not how much.

1. Uncountables pluralised — the error that never resolves on its own. French pluralises freely what English treats as mass: *des informations, des conseils, des recherches, des équipements, des logiciels, des preuves*. Arabic pluralises several of the same nouns (*ma' lūmāt*), so again you get it from both sides.

This one deserves special attention because of a single finding: overuse errors against the plural (*peoples, informations*) were the **only** error type the IELTS study found at **all** band levels, explicitly reported as not resolving with proficiency [src: Roothoof & Breeze 2019 — Speaking data, L1 mix unreported]. It survives to band 8. It will not fix itself with practice. It has to be a permanent conscious check against a closed list.

The nine words: information · advice · research · equipment · feedback · knowledge · software · furniture · evidence.

✗	✓	Note
<i>The report provides several informations about rural transport.</i>	<i>The report provides a good deal of information about rural transport.</i>	or several pieces of information**
<i>The article gives many useful advices to new teachers.</i>	<i>The article gives a great deal of useful advice to new teachers.</i>	much advice, a piece of advice
<i>Recent researches show that sleep affects memory.</i>	<i>Recent research shows that sleep affects memory.</i>	The verb changes too. <i>Recent studies show**</i> is often the better rewrite
<i>Hospitals need modern equipments.</i>	<i>Hospitals need modern equipment.</i>	
<i>Students value the feedbacks they receive.</i>	<i>Students value the feedback they receive.</i>	
<i>Employers look for candidates with technical knowledges.</i>	<i>Employers look for candidates with technical knowledge.</i>	But ✓ <i>a working knowledge of statistics — knowledge takes a in the frame a ... knowledge of X</i>
<i>There are many evidences that air quality has worsened.</i>	<i>There is considerable evidence that air quality has worsened.</i>	or several findings / studies**
<i>Schools buy expensive softwares.</i>	<i>Schools buy expensive software.</i>	
<i>The office was furnished with second-hand furnitures.</i>	<i>...with second-hand furniture.</i>	

⚠ British Council LearnEnglish states the rule (uncount nouns take no plural and no *a/an*) and lists uncount nouns that have plurals in other languages — advice, accommodation, baggage, equipment, furniture, homework, knowledge, luggage, machinery, money, news,

traffic [src: British Council LearnEnglish (Tier 2)]. **That list is not complete for your purposes:** it omits *information, research, evidence, feedback* and *software*, all of which behave the same way. Use the nine-word list above, not the British Council list alone.

2. Prepositions. French governs its verbs differently and the transfer is direct.

✗	✓	Source
<i>Rural clinics depend of central funding.</i>	<i>...depend on central funding.</i>	<i>dépendre de</i>
<i>Few citizens participate to local elections.</i>	<i>...participate in local elections.</i>	<i>participer à</i>
<i>This essay will discuss about the causes of urban sprawl.</i>	<i>This essay will discuss the causes of urban sprawl.</i>	<i>discuter de</i> — English <i>discuss</i> is transitive
<i>She has been married with an engineer since 2015.</i>	<i>...married to an engineer...</i>	<i>marié avec</i>
<i>Most tourists arrive to the capital by air.</i>	<i>...arrive in the capital by air.</i>	<i>arriver à</i> — in a city/country, at a building
<i>Many workers are interested by flexible hours.</i>	<i>...interested in flexible hours.</i>	<i>intéressé par</i>
<i>The company is responsible of training its staff.</i>	<i>...responsible for training its staff.</i>	<i>responsable de</i> (Arabic 'an gives responsible about**)
<i>In the other hand, remote work reduces commuting.</i>	<i>On the other hand, remote work reduces commuting.</i>	fixed phrase
<i>The scheme consists in three stages.</i>	<i>The scheme consists of three stages.</i>	<i>consister en</i>
<i>Students suffer of exam stress.</i>	<i>Students suffer from exam stress.</i>	<i>souffrir de</i>
<i>Technology has contributed massively on how schools operate.</i>	<i>...contributed massively to how schools operate.</i>	Arabic transfer
<i>The report focuses in rural healthcare.</i>	<i>The report focuses on rural healthcare.</i>	Arabic transfer

And *since* vs *for*. French *depuis* and Arabic *mundhu* cover both. *Since* + a **point** in time; *for* + a **length** of time. ✗ *The scheme has been running since ten years.* → ✓ *...for ten years.* ✗ *Enrolment has risen for 2015.* → ✓ *...since 2015.*

3. False friends. Every one of these costs **LR**, not **GRA**, so it cannot be offset by clean grammar.

French word	What it means	✗	✓
<i>actuellement</i>	currently	<i>Actually, more than half the population lives in cities.</i>	<i>At present</i> , more than half...
<i>actuel</i>	current	<i>The actual situation is worse than in 2010.</i>	<i>The current situation...</i>
<i>éventuellement</i>	possibly	<i>Eventually, the government could subsidise fares.</i>	<i>Possibly</i> , the government could subsidise fares.

French word	What it means	✗	✓
<i>assister à</i>	to attend	<i>Thousands of students assist to the lecture.</i>	<i>Thousands of students attend the lecture.</i>
<i>demander</i>	to ask	<i>The teacher demanded the students to explain their answers.</i>	<i>The teacher asked the students to explain...</i>
<i>formation</i>	training	<i>Employers pay for the formation of new staff.</i>	<i>...for the training of new staff.</i>
<i>sensible</i>	sensitive	<i>Children are very sensible to advertising.</i>	<i>Children are very sensitive to advertising.</i>
<i>déception</i>	disappointment	<i>The results caused a great deception among parents.</i>	<i>...caused great disappointment among parents.</i>
<i>librairie</i>	bookshop	<i>She bought the textbook at the university library.</i>	<i>...at the university bookshop.</i>
<i>supporter</i>	to tolerate	<i>Commuters cannot support the noise of the motorway.</i>	<i>Commuters cannot tolerate the noise...</i>
<i>achever</i>	to complete	<i>Students must achieve their dissertation before June.</i>	<i>Students must complete their dissertation...</i>
<i>contrôler</i>	to check	<i>Inspectors control the water quality every month.</i>	<i>Inspectors check the water quality every month.</i>
<i>significatif</i>	significant	<i>There was a significative rise in energy costs.</i>	<i>There was a significant rise in energy costs.</i>
<i>inconvenient</i>	drawback	<i>The main inconvenient of this policy is its cost.</i>	<i>The main drawback of this policy is its cost.</i>
<i>stage</i>	internship	<i>He did a six-month stage at a law firm.</i>	<i>He did a six-month internship at a law firm.</i>
<i>permettre de</i>	to make it possible to	<i>Online courses permit to study at any time.</i>	<i>Online courses allow students to study at any time.</i>

That last row is grammatical as well as lexical: English *permit* and *allow* require an **object** before the infinitive. *Permit to do* is ungrammatical in every register. French *permettre de faire* has none. If you cannot supply an object, switch verb: *make it possible to*, *enable X to*, *mean that*.

4. Word order and register. French licenses a longer, more periodic sentence and a higher register than English academic prose. Combined with Arabic parataxis, you are pushed toward long sentences from two directions — one supplying the length, the other the coordination.

✗	✓
<i>In the name of progress, it is of the utmost significance to recognise that the technology has become a fundamental pillar of the modern educational sector.</i>	<i>Technology has become central to modern education.</i>
<i>I visited my friends old from secondary school.</i>	<i>I visited my old friends from secondary school.</i>
<i>I eat never at the canteen.</i>	<i>I never eat at the canteen.</i>

✗	✓
<i>During the holidays I have too much eaten.</i>	<i>During the holidays I have eaten too much.</i>

Band 7 LR asks for awareness of style and collocation. It does not reward grandeur. Precision beats elevation, and elevation costs sentence length, which costs punctuation accuracy.

One more French habit that is not a GRA error at all. *De plus, en outre, par ailleurs* transfer into a *Moreover* or *Furthermore* at the head of every paragraph. That is a **Coherence and Cohesion** cost — band 6 names cohesion that is faulty or mechanical through misuse, **overuse** or omission. Rule of thumb: if a linker could be deleted without the reader losing the thread, delete it.

The 45-second French sweep

1. **The nine words (15 s).** information · advice · research · equipment · feedback · knowledge · software · furniture · evidence. Scan for any of them carrying an -s. Delete it, and fix the verb behind it.
2. **Verb + preposition (15 s).** Check the ones that matter: depend **on** · participate **in** · discuss **Ø** · married **to** · arrive **in/at** · responsible **for** · interested **in** · consist **of** · suffer **from**.
3. **The false-friend five (10 s).** *Actually* · *eventually* · *assist* · *permit to* · *significant*. Each is wrong more often than right in your writing.
4. **since / for (5 s).** Point in time → *since*. Length of time → *for*.

Your error map, ranked by expected cost

The ranking principle: at the 6→7 boundary both bands sit above the impede-communication line, so **severity is not what separates them — density is**. Cost ≈ how often it occurs × how many sentences it contaminates, with a multiplier where the error damages more than one criterion. Nothing on this list is a **bolded** rating-limiter in the descriptor grid — bold starts at band 5 — and nothing needs to be: band 6 is defined by its positive features, and these are what stop you fitting band 7's.

#	Error	Criterion	Why it costs this much
1	Articles — generic <i>the</i> , missing <i>a/an</i> , missing <i>the</i> before <i>N of N</i>	GRA	Both L1s push the same way; largest measured 6→7 discontinuity; never impedes, which is exactly why it is invisible to you and lethal to the error-free count
2	Comma splices and run-ons	GRA (+CC)	Punctuation is inside GRA; a splice damages two clauses at once; it is the default output of Arabic parataxis plus French period length; and subordinating to repair it raises range
3	Third-person -s and subject-verb agreement	GRA	Sharpest measured cliff of any morpheme; finite, discrete, mechanically checkable in 30 seconds — best cost-to-fix ratio on the list

#	Error	Criterion	Why it costs this much
4	Uncountables pluralised	GRA, and arguably LR too	IELTS files word formation under LR and does not say which side countability falls, so do not treat the allocation as settled – either way it is scored. The only error the IELTS research reports as persisting at all band levels; nine-word closed list, so fully fixable by memory
5	Faulty complex structures – <i>Although...but, despite</i> + clause, dangles, resumptives, second conditionals	GRA	This is the band-6 limiter. Every faulty complex sentence actively confirms band 6
6	Prepositions	GRA	High frequency, rarely impedes, breaks the error-free count; top ten are a closed list, the tail is not
7	False friends and word-formation errors	LR	A different criterion – cannot be offset by clean grammar
8	Tense consistency; <i>since</i> vs <i>for</i>	GRA	Real, lower frequency at your level
9	Copula omission	GRA	High severity, low frequency. Ranked on expected cost, not seriousness
10	Linker overuse, over-formal register, repetition	CC / TR	Real, but will not move your GRA band, and GRA is your binding constraint

The one-line version: fix articles and full stops before you fix anything clever.

The three-minute self-edit, in priority order

Do not read for meaning – you will read what you meant, not what you wrote.

Pass 1 – full stops (60 s). Read only the commas. At each: cover the left, is the right a complete sentence? Cover the right, is the left? Two complete sentences with a bare comma between them is a splice. Repair with a **subordinator** if you can – that converts an error into a complex structure – a full stop if you cannot. Then hunt every *however* / *therefore* / *moreover* / *thus* / *nevertheless*: the mark before it must be a full stop or a semicolon, never a comma.

Pass 2 – nouns (60 s). (a) Any of the nine uncountables carrying an -s or an *a*? (b) Any *the* on a generic abstract with no *of*-phrase, relative clause or superlative after it – and not on the counter-list? Delete it. (c) Any bare singular countable? It needs *a/an* or *the*. (d) Anything in the frame ___ of ___? It almost certainly needs *the*.

Pass 3 – verbs (45 s). (a) Present-simple verb with a singular subject: is the -s there, including inside relative clauses? (b) *People / governments / students*: plural verb. (c) Two bare verbs stacked (*are depend, do not works*)? (d) A passive on an intransitive verb (*was happened, was risen*)?

Pass 4 – your longest two or three sentences only (15 s). *Although ... but*? Delete the *but*. *Despite* + subject + verb? Nominalise or use *despite the fact that*. Participle clause – is the word right after the comma the thing doing the participle? *which ... it / who ... them / where ... in it*? Delete the pronoun. *Would* in an *if*-clause? Change to past simple.

The rule that makes it work: in these three minutes you may delete and repair. You may not add.

Self-test checklist

Answer yes or no. Any *no* is this week's work.

1. Can you state the band-6 limiter from memory – that the complex sentences are less accurate than the simple ones – and explain why adding more complexity lowers your band?
2. Can you name the four things GRA assesses, including punctuation?
3. Do you know that spelling and word formation are scored under **LR**, not GRA?
4. Can you run the article decision tree on a head noun in under five seconds?
5. Can you recite the counter-list – the abstract nouns that **keep** *the*?
6. Can you recite the nine uncountables without looking?
7. Can you tell the *however* list from the *but* list without hesitating?
8. On your last piece of writing, did you count article errors ÷ article slots, and was it under 10%?
9. Can you repair a comma splice with a subordinator rather than a full stop, by reflex?
10. Do you check the verb **inside** every relative clause for its -s?

11. Do you scan every *which* / *who* / *where* for a stray resumptive pronoun?
 12. Can you write a second conditional with no *would* in the *if*-clause, first try, every time?
 13. Have you stopped attempting third and mixed conditionals altogether?
 14. After every participle clause, do you check the word immediately after the comma?
 15. Did you stop writing at 37 minutes on your last Task 2, and did you only delete and repair — never add?
-

CHAPTER 9

9

Study Plan, Practice System & Test Day

WHAT IT IS WORTH

Everything above, scheduled

WHY IT MATTERS

90 minutes a day, working
backwards from your test date.

FULL READ

~60 min

60-second summary

Book computer-delivered IELTS Academic at a British Council Tunisia centre — not IELTS Online.

IELTS Online "is not currently accepted for immigration purposes", institutions choose individually whether to accept it, it bans headphones, and it demands a passport. Your Malta student visa is an immigration process. TND 750, payable in dinar only. Register with your passport and bring that identical document on the day; the wrong ID means no test. britishcouncil.tn contradicts itself about whether paper is still bookable — settle it by phone, not from the website, and either way train on a keyboard.

Bring nothing else. Water in a clear bottle, no food, no phone, no watch; the centre supplies pen and paper. The only published arrival figure, 30 minutes, comes from a blog page rather than a policy page; your booking confirmation is the authority on reporting time, and on whether Speaking is the same day and face-to-face or by video call. Ask your centre about One Skill Retake, headphones, paper availability, and **AZERTY versus QWERTY** before you pay — and if the answer is QWERTY, the keyboard plan below is a week-1 task, not a week-6 one.

ielts.org publishes **2h40** for the Listening + Reading + Writing session with no delivery-mode caveat, and **2h45** as the total test time including Speaking. Plan against 2h40 seated with no breaks: Listening (two minutes to review, no transfer time), Reading (transfer inside the hour), Writing (worth most, sat in the last hour when you are most tired — so eat first). Never leave a box blank; guess one thing, inside the word limit. Copy-paste Reading completions. Flag and move on. Results: plan against five days, not two.

Study at 90 minutes a day on a fixed shape — 9 minutes theory, 63 minutes timed practice **plus marking**, 18 minutes error logging — seven days, with Sunday as review. The theory slot is nine minutes because it is meant for one named section of this book, not a chapter: §How to read this book inside the nine-minute rule tells you which section on which day. Run week 1 of the plan first and choose 6, 8 or 10 weeks on **day 8**, when you have four real bands — week 1 is identical in all three.

Writing gets the most days because it is a **gate** that moves slowly; Listening and Reading get fewer because they are **levers** that convert technique to marks fast ([Chapter 1](#)). That is not a contradiction, and §Why Writing gets the most time gives you the rule for when to shift the

balance. Mark one criterion per pass against the real public descriptors, wait 48 hours before marking your own writing, award the lower band when torn, and remember that an AI cannot hear your pronunciation and grades high unless you pin it to the descriptors. And do not chase complex sentences to reach band 7 — [Chapter 8](#)'s whole argument is that band 6 is capped by complex sentences less accurate than your simple ones, so more of them at your current accuracy moves you down.

If a section comes back anomalously low, you have six weeks to apply for a remark — and you should read your centre's own terms before you assume the score cannot move down.

What the test actually asks

The booking decision that can cost you the whole fee

Before anything else in this chapter: **do not book IELTS Online.**

British Council Tunisia offers it — the dates and fees page names "IELTS Online (IELTS Academic only)" alongside centre testing [src: britishcouncil.tn — Test dates, fees and locations]. It is convenient. It is also a **different product** from computer-delivered IELTS at a centre, and for you it carries a risk that is not worth taking at TND 750 a sitting.

Three official statements, in order of how much they should worry you:

1. "IELTS Online is not currently accepted for immigration purposes" [src: ielts.org — IELTS Online] [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Your IELTS Online FAQs Answered]. A Tunisian national studying in Malta or elsewhere in the EU needs a **student visa**. That is an immigration process.
2. Institutional acceptance is optional: "Receiving organisations can decide whether they are happy to accept results from IELTS Academic tests that are taken online or not" [src: ielts.org — Ways to take IELTS]. Your university may accept it. It is under no obligation to.
3. IELTS itself hedges: "We advise you to check with your chosen institution(s) directly before booking IELTS Online" [src: ielts.org — IELTS Online].

Two further practical penalties. **Headphones are banned on IELTS Online** — "No, headphones are not permitted"; you sit the Listening test on room speakers [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Your IELTS Online FAQs Answered]. In a test where a single missed word is a lost mark, that is a self-inflicted handicap. And IELTS Online requires a **passport** specifically, where a centre booking in Tunisia also accepts a national identity card [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Your IELTS Online FAQs Answered] [src: britishcouncil.tn — Réservez votre examen IELTS (FR)]. Results are slower too — 6–8 calendar days [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Your IELTS Online FAQs Answered].

Book IELTS Academic on computer at a British Council Tunisia centre. Five locations: Tunis, Bizerte, Sousse, Sfax, Gabes [src: britishcouncil.tn — Test dates, fees and locations]. The only situation in which IELTS Online is worth a second thought is genuine inability to reach any of those five — and even then you write to the university *and* the Maltese visa authority first, and keep their answers.

Fees, and what you pay them in

From the live ielts.org listing for British Council Tunis, checked 2026-07-31, and independently matched by the British Council Tunisia booking page:

Test	Fee
IELTS Academic	TND 750
IELTS General Training	TND 750
IELTS for UKVI (Academic / General)	TND 820
IELTS Life Skills A1 / B1	TND 640

[src: ielts.org — Test centre: British Council Tunis] [src: britishcouncil.tn — Réservez votre examen IELTS (FR)]

You want the first row. Fees change; confirm the figure at the moment you book. A lower figure of TND 690 circulates in search results but appears on no live official page — treat it as stale.

Payment is in Tunisian dinar only. Bank transfer in TND, Pay-by-Link, or cheque/bank card at British Council offices. The Tunisia page states plainly that no hard-currency transaction is accepted, and cash is no longer taken [src: britishcouncil.tn — Réservez votre examen IELTS (FR)].

One benefit worth timing your booking around: IELTS Ready Premium — 40 full practice tests with model answers and optional AI feedback — is described as "free when you book IELTS with the British Council" [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Ready]. You are booking with the British Council. Book early enough that you get the practice bank for the whole of your study plan, not for the last fortnight of it.

ID — the single most common way to be turned away

Registration in Tunisia accepts a **valid passport or a national identity card (CIN)**, and the rule is that you present **the identical document** on test day: you must show "le même passeport ou carte d'identité nationale que vous utilisez pour l'enregistrement le jour du test" [src: britishcouncil.tn — Réservez votre examen IELTS (FR)]. Global policy says the same: "You must bring the passport/national identity card you used on the IELTS Application Form" [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Frequently asked questions], and "You won't be able to take your test if you bring the wrong ID or forget to bring it" [src: ielts.org — What to expect on IELTS test day]. Tunisia states it hardest: a different, invalid or expired document will not be accepted [src: britishcouncil.tn — Réservez votre examen IELTS (FR)].

Register with your passport, not your CIN. This is my reasoning from the sourced rules rather than a printed policy, but it is sound: the ID number on your registration is what appears on the Test Report Form and what the Test Taker Portal uses to release your results [src: ielts.org — Getting and sharing your IELTS results]. A Maltese university and a visa office will match your English certificate against your **passport**. Arabic names are routinely transliterated differently on a CIN and a passport, and a mismatch is a document problem you get to explain at exactly the wrong moment. Using the passport removes it. Check, too, that the passport does not expire before you have finished

using the score — the TRF is valid two years from the test date [\[src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Frequently asked questions\]](https://takeielts.britishcouncil.org/frequently-asked-questions), though institutions may apply a shorter window and decide for themselves, so confirm the requirement with your university directly.

You will need the same ID again for Speaking [\[src: ielts.idp.com — Test day\]](https://ielts.idp.com/test-day). A photograph is taken before the test and appears on your TRF; in some countries a finger scan is also taken, and Tunisia is not named either way — expect the photo, be unsurprised by the scan [\[src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Essential Tips to Excel in IELTS Test Day\]](https://takeielts.britishcouncil.org/essential-tips-to-excel-in-ielts-test-day).

What you may take into the room

Almost nothing.

Item	Rule
Your ID	Required — the same one used at booking [src: ielts.org — What to expect on IELTS test day]
Water	Allowed only in a clear, transparent bottle [src: ielts.org — What to expect on IELTS test day]
Food	Banned [src: ielts.org — What to expect on IELTS test day]
Phone, any electronics	Banned, switched off, left outside — keeping one with you means disqualification [src: ielts.idp.com — Test day]
Any watch, smart or not	Banned; there is a wall clock [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Frequently asked questions]
Bags and belongings	Locker or secure area [src: ielts.idp.com — Test day]

Stationery reads like a conflict between two official sources, and mostly is not. The British Council rule is explicitly scoped to the paper test: "**You must use a black ink pen, supplied by the test centre, to complete your IELTS on Paper test.** Personal stationery, including pencils, are not permitted in the test room" [\[src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Test day advice, fetched 2026-07-31\]](https://takeielts.britishcouncil.org/test-day-advice). Cambridge's Academic FAQ answers a different question — which implement is acceptable — with "You can write in pen or pencil" [\[src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS Academic FAQs PDF \(269898\), p.7\]](https://cambridgeenglish.org/ielts-academic-faqs). One governs what you may *bring*, the other what you may *write with*, and both are about paper. **For a computer-delivered candidate the question is moot:** the centre provides pen and paper for notes [\[src: ielts.idp.com — Test day\]](https://ielts.idp.com/test-day), plus a login details sheet you are allowed to write on [\[src: same\]](#). **Bring nothing, and follow the instruction your centre gives you at booking.**

The shape of the day

Listening, Reading and Writing run as one block: "This takes **2 hours 40 minutes**, and there are no breaks between each section of the test" [\[src: ielts.org — What to expect on IELTS test day, fetched 2026-07-31\]](https://ielts.org/what-to-expect-on-ielts-test-day) [\[src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Essential Tips to Excel in IELTS Test Day\]](https://takeielts.britishcouncil.org/essential-tips-to-excel-in-ielts-test-day). On computer the order is Listening → Reading → Writing, with Speaking before or after [\[src: ielts.idp.com — Test day\]](https://ielts.idp.com/test-day).

You will also see 2 hours 45 minutes, and the two figures are not in conflict — they count different things. 2h45 is the *total test time* for IELTS Academic, quoted with the four component timings (Listening ~30, Reading 60 including transfer time, Writing 60, Speaking 11–14) [\[src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic test, fetched 2026-07-31\]](https://ielts.org/ielts-academic-test); 2h40 is the Listening + Reading + Writing session alone. ielts.org applies **2h40 with no delivery-mode caveat**, so this book does not invent one either, even

though the computer components sum to roughly 2h32 (Listening 30 + a 2-minute check + Reading 60 + Writing 60); the remainder is instructions, seating and administration. **Practise against 2h40 seated and concentrating**, and budget the individual paper timings below rather than either headline.

When	What happens
Night before	ID and booking confirmation by the door. Two alarms. "Leave enough time to get to the test centre without rushing" [src: ielts.org — What to expect on IELTS test day]
Morning	Eat. "Have something to eat and drink before the test" [src: ielts.org — What to expect on IELTS test day] — no food inside, no breaks for 2h40
Arrival	Your booking confirmation gives the reporting time and overrides everything else . The only published arrival figure I could find — "at least 30 minutes before your scheduled time" — is on a British Council <i>blog</i> page, not a policy page [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Test Day: Essential Advice (blog)] . Treat 30 minutes as a floor and add Tunis traffic. Arriving late may forfeit the test [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Essential Tips to Excel in IELTS Test Day]
Check-in	ID checked, photograph taken, possibly a finger scan, belongings locked away, phone off
Before entry	Go to the toilet. "Make sure you go to the toilet before you enter the test room" [src: ielts.org — What to expect on IELTS test day]
Seated	Login sheet, pen, paper. Set the volume now , during the instructions
Listening ~30 min	Plays once. No transfer time — "You will only have 2 minutes to review your answers at the end" [src: ielts.idp.com — How computer-delivered IELTS works]
Reading 60 min	Transfer time is <i>inside</i> the hour [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Reading test format]
Writing 60 min	Task 2 is worth double [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS Academic FAQs PDF]
Speaking	Same day or another day — see below. Same ID again
Results	Email link to the Test Taker Portal [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Results]

Two things about Speaking I refuse to print as a number. The scheduling window is stated three different ways across Tier 1 sources — same-day for computer delivery [src: ielts.idp.com — Test day], "may be on a different day" [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS on Computer], and no window at all on the format page [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Speaking test format]. And the format itself is disputed: ielts.org describes a face-to-face interview [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Speaking test format], while the British Council computer-delivered page says "either face-to-face or via video call" [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS on Computer]. **Your booking confirmation is the authority.** Prepare as if Speaking might land immediately after 2h40 of typing, and rehearse both a face-to-face and a screen-mediated delivery. Nothing about the criteria changes on a screen; your eye-contact habits and your articulation do.

Results timing. Official pages give different figures: about half within one day and 80% within two [src: ielts.org — Fast IELTS results], 1–2 days on the booking page [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS on Computer], and 1–5 days elsewhere [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Frequently asked questions] [src: ielts.org — Ways to take IELTS]. **Plan every university deadline against five days.** You can share results by post with up to five

organisations free of charge, and by e-delivery with as many as you like [src: ielts.org — Getting and sharing your IELTS results] — and universities verify electronically at source, so a scanned TRF is not what they trust.

Things you must ask your centre before you pay

None of these could be confirmed from published sources. Do not guess at them.

Question	Why it matters	What is actually known
Is paper still bookable in Tunisia?	Changes nothing about your plan — but settles it	Unsettled, and the website cannot settle it. britishcouncil.tn's dates, fees and locations page offers only IELTS on computer and IELTS Online [src: britishcouncil.tn — Test dates, fees and locations, fetched 2026-07-31] , and every Tunis booking link on ielts.org is computer [src: ielts.org — Test centre: British Council Tunis] . But the site's own English test pages still offer paper and quote a fee for it — "You can choose between IELTS on paper or computer" with "Paper-based: 750 TND" [src: britishcouncil.tn/en — IELTS Academic, fetched 2026-07-31] [src: britishcouncil.tn/en — IELTS General Training, fetched 2026-07-31] . So this is not a French-versus-English translation lag; the site is internally inconsistent in English. Phone the centre. Either way, paper is being retired from mid-2026 [src: ielts.org — Updates to IELTS test delivery] , and every drill in this book assumes a keyboard
Is "Writing on Paper" mode offered?	Would let you handwrite Writing	Offered "in selected markets"; no market is named [src: ielts.org — Updates to IELTS test delivery] . Unconfirmed for Tunisia — do not plan on it. Train typing.
Is One Skill Retake available at your centre, and at what fee?	Changes your entire fallback plan	Probable, unconfirmed. OSR "is currently available at selected IELTS on Computer centres" and no Tunisian centre is named [src: britishcouncil.tn — IELTS One Skill Retake] . Tunisia being computer-delivered satisfies the precondition — that is inference, not confirmation. Ask before you book
Are headphones supplied?	Listening marks	Provision varies by centre; candidates are told to check locally. Unconfirmed for Tunisia
AZERTY or QWERTY keyboards?	Typed Writing, French-keyboard typist	Published nowhere. Worth one phone call — see <i>L1 alert</i>
Is there a finger scan?	Nothing, but knowing removes a surprise	"In some countries, you may also be asked to provide a finger scan"; Tunisia not named [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Essential Tips to Excel in IELTS Test Day]

Confirmed OSR rules, globally, if your centre says yes: you must have recently completed a full IELTS test on computer, you must sit the retake **within 60 days**, and you may retake **one** section, **once**, per full test [src: britishcouncil.tn — IELTS One Skill Retake]. If it is available, your risk posture changes: land Writing at 6.0 with everything else at 7, and you retake Writing alone instead of paying TND 750 again. Do not make it the plan until the centre confirms it exists.

Question types, one by one

The "types" in this chapter are the **three study plans** — 6, 8 and 10 weeks — and the daily architecture they all share. All three are built on 90 minutes a day.

The daily architecture — 70 / 20 / 10

Every day has the same shape, so no day costs you a decision:

00-09	THEORY	9 min	one narrow technique. Never a whole chapter.
09-72	PRACTICE	63 min	timed task under test conditions, THEN self-marking
72-90	ERROR WORK	18 min	log to the three progress files; re-read the last 3 days

The 63-minute block is **practice with feedback**, not practice. Marking is not the optional half. An unmarked mock is worse than no mock, because it rehearses your current errors under time pressure and consolidates them.

The 9-minute theory cap is the rule most likely to be broken and the most expensive to break. Reading strategy articles for forty minutes converts a practice day into a browsing day, and browsing days do not move bands.

The numbers, in one table

Every clock and every word count in this book, in one place. Where another chapter differs, this table wins — so you never spend a decision on it.

	Plan	Write	Check	Stop writing at	Word target	Hard floor
Task 1	5 min	12 min	3 min	17 min	170–190	150
Task 2	5 min	32 min	3 min	37 min	270–290	250

Each row adds to its own budget — $5 + 12 + 3 = 20$ for Task 1, $5 + 32 + 3 = 40$ for Task 2 — and "stop writing at" is planning plus writing, with the check block after it. Task 1's five planning minutes are two jobs: three to read the visual and find the extremes, two to decide the grouping and compose the overview, exactly as [Chapter 4](#)'s 20-minute budget table splits them.

Reading: 19 minutes per passage plus a 3-minute sweep, all inside the hour — there is no separate transfer time [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Reading test format]. Listening: ~30 minutes plus **2 minutes** to review, and no transfer time [src: ielts.idp.com — How computer-delivered IELTS works]. Speaking Part 2: 1 minute to prepare, aim to still be talking at 2 minutes.

The floors are the published rubric minima; the targets carry a margin because copied rubric is discounted **before** the count is taken, so a weak paraphrase can leave you under length while the on-screen counter says you are fine.

How to read this book inside the nine-minute rule

The nine chapters of this book run to about 88,000 words. At a careful reading pace on dense prose with tables, that is roughly ten hours of first reading — and nine minutes a day across an eight-week plan gives you 504 minutes, about eight and a half hours, in total. **Reading this book**

once, straight through, would consume more than your entire theory budget for the entire course, and leave you nothing to learn with. So do not read it straight through. It is a reference work with a small compulsory core.

Day zero — one setup cost, outside the nine-minute rule. Before day 1, spend two sittings of about 45 minutes reading these, end to end, in this order:

1. Every chapter's **60-second summary** — they are the first section of each chapter, and nine of them together are about twenty minutes. This alone gives you the whole book's argument.
2. **Ch 1 §The strategic core** — where your marks actually are.
3. **Ch 8 §The spine of this chapter** and **§Your error map, ranked by expected cost** — the 6→7 mechanism and your personal error ranking.
4. **Ch 9** — this chapter's booking decision, the plan tables, and the numbers table above.

Name that for what it is: a one-off setup cost, not theory time. You are not expected to read this book straight through, and if you do, it costs you the budget you were going to learn with.

Then, from day 1, your nine minutes come from one named section — never a chapter. Match it to the day's skill:

Day	Command	Your nine minutes come from
Mon	/writing2	Ch 5 — one question family, or Tip 4 (claim → because → so what → instance)
Tue	/reading	Ch 3 — the order table, or one question type you lost marks on
Wed	/writing1	Ch 4 — one visual type, or the overview-and-grouping section
Thu	/listening	Ch 2 — one trap family, or the prediction drill
Fri	/speaking	Ch 6 — one drill, or the Part 2 structure
Sat	/mock or a timed section	Nothing. Nine minutes of re-reading yesterday's error log
Sun	/review, /vocab, /anki	Ch 8 — one L1 alert sub-section, in the order Ch 8 §How to use this chapter gives

Read once, then never again: the eight band-7 structures (Ch 8), the vocabulary acquisition theory (Ch 7), the test-day logistics tables (Ch 9). **Skim and come back only when an error appears in your log:** every Myths section, every Band descriptor decoder. **Keep permanently open beside the keyboard:** Ch 8 §The three-minute self-edit, Ch 8 §The 60-second Arabic sweep and §The 45-second French sweep, and the numbers table above.

From week 4 onward the theory slot changes purpose: it stops being "read the book" and becomes "read the one section that explains an error I logged this week". If your log says articles, you re-read Ch 8's article procedure. If it says nothing in particular, your log is not detailed enough, and that is the week's real finding.

Why Writing gets the most time — and how that squares with **Chapter 1**

Official test-taker performance data for 2024–25 shows Arabic-L1 candidates averaging **5.54** on Academic Writing against 5.95 overall, and French-L1 candidates **6.15** on Writing against 6.75 overall [src: ielts.org — Test statistics → test taker performance data 2024–25]. For both of your language backgrounds, Writing is the weakest paper *and* the slowest to move. It therefore starts first and gets the largest share.

This looks like it contradicts **Chapter 1, which says your cheap half-bands are in Listening and Reading. It does not — the two claims answer different questions.** Writing gets the most *days* because it is a **gate**: below 6.5 it fails your application outright, it is your statistically weakest paper, and it moves in weeks rather than sessions, so it needs continuous exposure. Listening and Reading get fewer days because they are **levers**: the technique in Chapters 2 and 3 converts to marks in a handful of sessions, which is exactly why **Chapter 1** calls those marks cheap. Cheap marks need fewer hours, not more.

The decision rule you need when you have one spare hour this week:

- Reading not yet stable at 30/40 in timed practice → give the hour to Reading. The conversion rate is higher than anything Writing will give you this month.
- Reading stable at 30/40 across three timed papers → take Tuesday back and give it to Task 2. Until then, do not.
- Writing below 6.0 in your last two graded scripts → the hour goes to Writing regardless. A gate you are failing outranks a lever you are winning.

One caveat **Chapter 1 raises and this plan has to respect: do not assume Listening is cheap for you.** In the same official data, Arabic-L1 Listening (5.70) sits **0.40 below** Arabic-L1 Reading (6.10), while French-L1 Listening and Reading sit almost level (6.95 and 7.01) [src: ielts.org — Test statistics → test taker performance data 2024–25]. Your two language backgrounds disagree about which of the two receptive papers is your cheap one, so **diagnose before you allocate**. That is what week 1 is for, and it is why the plan selection below happens on day 8 rather than day 1.

The weekly rotation

Day	Focus	Command
Mon	Writing Task 2 — the double-weighted task	/writing2
Tue	Reading	/reading
Wed	Writing Task 1	/writing1
Thu	Listening	/listening
Fri	Speaking — all three parts, recorded	/speaking
Sat	Timed section under full conditions, or /mock for the 60-minute Writing pair	/mock, or /official after a Cambridge paper
Sun	Review day. No new material	/review, /vocab (QUIZ), /anki

The eleven commands, and what each is for. These are the operating system of the plan — if a study activity does not have a command behind it, it is probably browsing.

Command	What it does	When it fires
<code>/writing2</code>	Timed Task 2 drill, then criterion-by-criterion grading	Mondays; day 1 of every plan
<code>/writing1</code>	Timed Task 1 drill, then grading	Wednesdays
<code>/reading</code>	Original passage with questions targeting your weakest question type	Tuesdays
<code>/listening</code>	Text-adapted Listening training — prediction, trap-spotting, spelling dictation	Thursdays
<code>/speaking</code>	Full three-part simulation with examiner pushback, then grading	Fridays
<code>/mock</code>	The full timed 60-minute Writing sitting — Task 1 and Task 2 together, no help during	Saturdays, weeks 4 onward
<code>/official</code>	Converts raw scores from a Cambridge paper you did offline into bands, and grades your own writing from it	After every official paper
<code>/vocab</code>	Builds the bank (ADD) or tests it strictly (QUIZ) with collocations	Sundays, and any day a graded task throws up new words
<code>/anki</code>	Exports <code>progress/vocab-bank.md</code> to <code>exports/anki-vocab.csv</code> for import into a spaced-repetition app	Sundays — see below
<code>/review</code>	Weekly review: score trends, top three recurring error patterns, gap to target, a 7-day plan	Every Sunday, without exception
<code>/handbook</code>	Regenerates <code>handbook.md</code> from your own logged data — your personal revision book	End of each phase, and in the taper week

Run the vocabulary ladder in software, not in your head. [Chapter 7](#) sets a review ladder of day 1 → 3 → 7 → 16 → 35, and by week four you are carrying roughly a hundred live items on five different intervals. Do not compute that by hand; it eats the whole five-minute slot before you review a single word. Keep items in `progress/vocab-bank.md`, run `/anki` on Sunday to export them, and import the CSV into any spaced-repetition app — the app computes the ladder and you just answer. (If you genuinely prefer paper: five envelopes marked Day 1, 3, 7, 16, 35, and a pocket diary. When a card passes, write the next date on its back and move it up one envelope; when it fails, back to envelope 1.)

Note what `/mock` is and is not: it is a full timed **60-minute Writing** sitting, Task 1 and Task 2 together, no help during. It is not a 2h40 simulation. For a real 2h40 sitting you need official material — sit it on paper or on screen from a Cambridge volume, then run `/official` to convert raw scores to bands and get your own writing graded.

Miss a day? Never double up. Drop the day you missed and continue the rotation on its normal day. Two sessions in one evening produces one good session and one bad one, and the bad one still goes into `band-tracker.md` and distorts the trend. The rotation matters more than the total.

The rewrite rule, which is the highest-leverage habit in the plan. Every Sunday, rewrite one essay you have already been graded on, applying the corrections. Producing another mediocre new essay teaches you nothing. Converting a band-6 essay *of your own* into a band-7 essay teaches you precisely what the gap feels like. (My recommendation, not a sourced claim.)

Your test date is not set — so build the plan backwards

`CLAUDE.md` records the date as NOT YET SET, so the plans below are numbered by week, not dated. The moment you book, do this: write the test date at the top of `CLAUDE.md`, count backwards, and put a real calendar date against every week below. Then rebuild `knowledge/revision-playbook.md` ch.9 to the actual number of days remaining.

Pick the plan by your **diagnostic**, not by your optimism — and note *when* you can actually pick. The selection rule below refers to all four sections, and on day one you have none of them. **Week 1 is identical in all three plans, so run week 1 and choose on day 8**, when you have four real bands in `band-tracker.md`. Do not agonise over the choice on day one; it is not available to you yet.

- No section below 5.5 → **6-week plan**
- Unknown baseline after week 1, or one section at 5.5 → **8-week plan** (the default)
- Anything below 5.5, or Grammatical Range & Accuracy visibly capping you → **10-week plan**

If you have fewer than six weeks, do not compress the 6-week plan — cut it. Keep week 1 (diagnose), week 4 (drill), week 5 (simulate) and the taper, and delete the build weeks. You will not acquire new technique in under six weeks; you will only stop leaking marks you are currently leaking. Concentrate entirely on Writing Task 2, Listening discipline, and the interface. And seriously consider moving the date: you may change your test date once, at any time before the test, provided the new date is within three months of the original — otherwise the transfer is treated as a cancellation [src: ielts.org — Cancellations, refunds, remarks and transfers].

How the hour totals are calculated, so you can check them. Seven sessions a week at 90 minutes is 10.5 hours a week: $6 \times 10.5 = 63$, $8 \times 10.5 = 84$, $10 \times 10.5 = 105$. The rotation genuinely runs seven days — Sunday is a working review day, not a day off — so these are real numbers, not aspirational ones. The only day the plans give you off is day 7 of the taper week, which takes about ninety minutes back off each total; that is what the $\approx$ is doing. Add the keyboard plan's 3.5 hours on top if §The keyboard plan applies to you.

A word used in every plan table below: *taper*. It is borrowed from endurance training and it means the deliberate reduction of load in the final week so you arrive rested rather than depleted. It is not slacking, and it is not optional — see Myth "*Study hard right up to the day before.*"

6-week plan — ≈63 hours

Week	Phase	Focus	Milestone
1	Diagnose	Day 1: full timed /writing2. Days 2–4: one timed section each of /reading, /listening, /speaking. Days 5–7: build the error map from those four scripts	Four baseline bands in band-tracker.md; top five recurring errors named
2	Build	Task 2 structure — the four question families and a paragraph template for each. Reading: the two question types you lost most marks on. Listening: prediction and spelling	Task 2 finished inside 40 min at 270+ words, every time
3	Build	Task 1: overview plus grouping — band-7 Task Achievement requires data appropriately categorised, not listed. Reading: 19 min per passage plus the 3-minute sweep. Speaking: Part 2 to a full 2 minutes without stopping	Task 1 always has an overview and never reads row by row
4	Drill	Volume week. A full timed section daily. Every 9-minute theory block must address a <i>logged</i> error, not a general topic	Your top three error patterns are measurably less frequent
5	Simulate	Two full Listening+Reading+Writing sittings — 2h40, typed, no breaks. One full /speaking simulation with pushback	You know your band under real conditions, not your practice band
6	Taper	Days 1–3: light targeted drills, no new material. Day 4: last full sitting. Days 5–6: error log and vocab bank only. Day 7: rest	Arrive fresh

8-week plan — ≈84 hours, the default

Week	Phase	Focus	Milestone
1	Diagnose	One timed task in every skill across the week, plus read both public band descriptor PDFs end to end . You cannot self-mark against a standard you have not read	Four baselines logged; descriptors read once
2	Diagnose → Build	Error taxonomy. Sort every logged error into L1 interference / structural / timing. Attack the category carrying the most marks	You can name your three most expensive error patterns
3	Build	Task 2 deep work: question families, position statements, body paragraph = claim → because → so what → instance (Ch 5 Tip 4). The <i>so what</i> is the move that turns a stated idea into an extended one, and it is what band 7 Task Response asks for	Every essay answers <i>all</i> parts of the question — the commonest band-6 Task Response cap
4	Build	Task 1 deep work: all visual types, overview, grouping, tense and comparison language. Reading: matching headings and TFNG/YNNG	Task 1 done in 20 minutes, with an overview
5	Drill	Listening + Speaking intensive. Listening: computer discipline — no transfer time, flag-and-guess. Speaking: record all three parts daily; transcribe two answers a week and mark your own grammar	Listening raw score stable; you can hear your own L1 errors on playback
6	Drill	Mixed high-volume week, a timed section every day. Theory slot = logged errors only. Rewrite two previously graded essays	Error frequency falling; timing automatic

Week	Phase	Focus	Milestone
7	Simulate	Two full 2h40 sittings, typed, plus two /speaking simulations. Mark strictly; award the lower band when torn	A realistic predicted overall band
8	Taper	Days 1–3: drills on your single weakest criterion. Day 4: last full sitting. Days 5–6: error log and vocab bank, no new tasks. Day 7: rest and logistics check	Fresh, nothing left to organise

10-week plan — ≈105 hours

For a starting point below 6.0. The extra fortnight is a language block, not more technique: below 6.0 you are usually capped by Grammatical Range & Accuracy and Lexical Resource, and no amount of essay structure fixes that.

⚠ Read this before week 3, because the obvious instruction is the wrong one. It is natural to read "below 6.0, capped by GRA" as "write more complex sentences". [Chapter 8](#) spends a chapter refuting exactly that, and the descriptors back it: band 6 **already** credits *a mix of simple and complex sentence forms*, so the presence of complex structures is not the gate. What caps band 6 is the clause immediately after — *examples of more complex structures are not marked by the same level of accuracy as in simple structures* [src: ielts.org — Writing band descriptors (PDF, Updated May 2023), pp.5, 9]. Band 7 asks for *a variety of complex structures* **and** frequent error-free sentences; range and accuracy are conjunctive, not alternative. **So adding complex sentences at your current accuracy moves you down, not up** — it multiplies the faulty ones and makes the band-6 limiter more visible.

Note also that the current Speaking descriptor dropped *complex* from the band-7 range clause altogether and now states that **both simple and complex sentences are used effectively** [src: ielts.org — Speaking band descriptors (PDF, created 2025-09-16)]. An accurate simple sentence is not a liability in either paper.

This plan therefore sets no complex-sentence quota, and you should not set yourself one. A quota makes you write complex sentences you do not need and cannot check. The measure below is a ratio — error-free sentences over total sentences — and a small repertoire you own cold.

Week	Phase	Focus	Milestone
1	Diagnose	Full baseline in four skills; read both descriptor sets	Baselines logged
2	Foundation	Grammar block 1 — articles with abstract nouns, and uncountables. Daily: 20 sentences of your own, self-corrected	<i>the society, informations, researches</i> stop appearing
3	Foundation	Grammar block 2 — a small repertoire drilled to control, not a large one drilled to coverage . Three structures only: defining relative clauses, the second conditional, and concession (<i>although</i> + clause / <i>despite</i> + noun phrase). See Ch 8	Every essay contains three complex structures you got right , drawn from that fixed repertoire — and no complex sentence you could not check. Measure the ratio of error-free sentences , not the count of clauses

Week	Phase	Focus	Milestone
4	Build	Task 2: question families, position, paragraph structure	Full essay in 40 minutes
5	Build	Task 1: all visual types, overview, grouping	Overview present every time
6	Build	Reading: every question type, then timing to 19 min/passage plus the 3-minute sweep	Full paper inside 60 minutes
7	Drill	Listening + Speaking intensive	Stable Listening; recorded Speaking improving
8	Drill	Mixed volume plus rewrites of graded essays	Top-three error patterns declining
9	Simulate	Three full sittings plus Speaking simulations, strictly marked	Predicted band
10	Taper	As week 8 of the 8-week plan	Fresh

Six rules that apply to all three plans

1. **Never practise Writing untimed.** A 70-minute essay tells you nothing about a 40-minute test.
2. **Always type, on the layout you will meet at the centre.** Every Tunis booking link on ielts.org is computer-delivered [src: ielts.org — Test centre: British Council Tunis]; typing speed and typo rate are scored variables, and spelling is marked under Lexical Resource. See §The keyboard plan.
3. **Mark before you move on.**
4. **Nine minutes of theory, from one named section.** Not nine minutes of browsing, and never a whole chapter — see §How to read this book inside the nine-minute rule.
5. **Log every session** to `progress/error-log.md`, `vocab-bank.md`, `band-tracker.md`. These are the only reason week 6 is smarter than week 1.
6. **One full rest day before the test.** Never a mock the day before.

What to practise on

Free and official first: the sample test questions and preparation hub at ielts.org, the public Writing and Speaking band descriptor PDFs, the Academic Writing example responses **with band scores and examiner comments** (the closest thing to watching your own script marked), the British Council free practice tests, and — a priority, not a nice-to-have — the **British Council IELTS on computer familiarisation tutorials**, which show you highlighting, note-taking and the real screens [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS on computer: how it works]. IELTS Ready's free tier includes a mini mock and two full mocks with feedback [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Ready].

Paid: **one** Cambridge volume is enough. IELTS 21 appears to be the current Academic volume, published July 2026 — I take that date from search listings rather than the publisher's page, which blocks automated requests, so verify it at the bookshop. Volumes 15–20 remain fully valid practice; the move to computer delivery "does not alter the IELTS skills assessed, the test construct" [src: ielts.org — Updates to IELTS test delivery]. Four authentic papers used properly — timed, marked, errors logged, one rewrite each — beat five books skimmed.

IELTS Progress Check (officially marked practice with feedback from IELTS-trained markers) is named in the official ecosystem, but I could not fetch a live product page to confirm it still exists or what it costs. Check before you buy.

Do not download "Cambridge IELTS PDF" torrents. Beyond the copyright problem, they carry OCR errors in the answer keys — and a wrong answer key actively teaches you wrong answers.

Tips & tricks

Ranked by marks.

1. Never leave a Listening or Reading box empty. [verified] Reading is positively marked — "Each correct answer receives 1 mark", with no deduction mechanism anywhere on the format page [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Reading test format] — and the official instruction is explicit: "Answer all questions — you don't lose marks for any blank spaces" [src: ielts.idp.com — IELTS Dos and Don'ts]. A blank and a wrong answer score identically. **When this fails:** two answers in one gap score zero even when one is right, and an answer over the stated word limit "will be marked as incorrect" [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS Academic FAQs PDF (269898)]. Guess — but guess *one* thing, inside the limit.

2. Copy-paste every Reading completion answer. [verified] "Instead of retyping words, use copy-paste to avoid spelling mistakes in fill-in-the-blank type questions" [src: ielts.idp.com — Want to Ace Your IELTS on Computer Reading Component?]; "You can copy and paste from the text for the Reading and Writing tests" [src: ielts.idp.com — Seven benefits of taking IELTS on computer]. Spelling is marked, and *accommodation*, *phenomenon*, *bureaucracy* eventually get mistyped under pressure. Copy-paste drives that error rate to structurally zero. **When this fails:** a drag selection grabs a trailing comma or an extra word — re-read what you pasted. And **CTRL+F does not work** [src: ieltsliz.com — Computer Delivered IELTS: Pros & Cons]; scanning is still a human skill.

3. Type a guess, flag it, eyes forward. [verified] Computer Listening gives no transfer time and "only 2 minutes to review your answers at the end" [src: ielts.idp.com — How computer-delivered IELTS works]. The Review button turns the question's square into a circle so you can find it again [src: same]. Never leave a gap blank intending to return; the two minutes evaporate. Rehearse the recovery in practice: deliberately miss one, and train the reflex.

4. Decide now what you do when the timer flashes. [verified] The countdown sits top-centre and flashes at 10 and 5 minutes remaining [src: ielts.idp.com — How computer-delivered IELTS works]. That flash is a designed interruption. For Writing it means: stop generating, start checking articles and verb endings. For Reading: stop reading, fill every empty box. Deciding this on the day is how candidates lose four marks in ten minutes.

5. Aim at 270 words and 170 words, not 250 and 150. [expert consensus] (Full targets and clocks: §The numbers, in one table.) The on-screen counter sits in the lower-left [src: ielts.idp.com — How computer-delivered IELTS works], so counting is free — but copied rubric is discounted *before* the count, so

weak paraphrasing can leave you under length while the counter says you are fine. A margin also leaves room to delete a bad sentence. Glance twice only: end of body paragraph 1, and at the end.

6. Highlight evidence, not topic. [verified] Left-click and drag, right-click, select highlight; examiners never see it and it does not affect your score [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Highlighting text (IELTS on computer)]. One highlight per answered question, on the phrase that proves it — an audit trail you can re-verify in seconds. Highlighting whole paragraphs marks everything, and therefore marks nothing.

7. Plan Writing on the paper, not on the screen. [expert consensus] The centre gives you pen and paper and a login sheet you may write on [src: ielts.idp.com — Test day]. A 60-second paper plan — position → paragraph 1 idea → paragraph 2 idea → conclusion — stays visible while you type. An on-screen note box costs mouse time and screen space.

8. Set the volume during the instructions, slightly louder than feels right. [verified] "With the volume control bar in the upper right corner, you can provide full volume control during the test" [src: ielts.idp.com — How computer-delivered IELTS works]. The room gets noisier once forty people start typing. You keep control throughout, so adjust immediately rather than straining through a section.

9. Eat breakfast. [verified] "Have something to eat and drink before the test" [src: ielts.org — What to expect on IELTS test day]. No food inside, no breaks for 2h40, and **Writing — the section worth most and marked hardest — is sat in the last hour of the block**, starting at roughly the 1h32 mark and finishing you at 2h40. Arriving under-fuelled is a Writing-band decision disguised as a breakfast decision.

10. Quarantine your mistakes. [verified] "If you feel you've made an error, don't dwell on it — move forward and focus on the next question, as stressing over a mistake can impact your performance in the remaining sections" [src: ielts.idp.com — Mastering focus for IELTS success]. On computer Listening this is the highest- value line in this chapter: the missed answer costs one mark, and four seconds of regret costs you the next three. **Procedure, so it is a reflex and not a resolution:** the moment you notice a miss, do three things in this fixed order — type any plausible word inside the limit, click Review to mark the question, and put your eyes on the next question number *before* you finish the thought. Rehearse it by deliberately skipping one question in every practice section, so the recovery is something you have done fifty times rather than something you decide on the day.

11. Use 4-4-6 breathing at three specific moments. [verified] "Inhaling deeply through your nose for four seconds, holding your breath for four seconds, and exhaling slowly through your mouth for six seconds" [src: ielts.idp.com — Tips for conquering IELTS test anxiety]. Deploy it (a) seated before the Listening audio starts, (b) the instant you realise you have missed an answer, (c) in the corridor before Speaking. The long exhale is the active ingredient — do not shorten it.

12. Rehearse a posture before Speaking. [verified] ielts.org publishes an unusually concrete protocol: work out your natural confident posture in a relaxed setting, rehearse adopting it from the feet up, walk in on the day "in a way that says: 'I'm on a mission'", take a moment on entering

to set that position, breathe deliberately, see the examiner as a human being, and wriggle your toes to sharpen focus [src: ielts.org — Using body language to reduce stress levels and improve IELTS performance]. The mechanism is not mystical: shallow high-chest breathing produces short broken phrases, and Fluency & Coherence penalises exactly that.

13. Familiarity is the anxiety intervention with the biggest score effect. [verified] "Knowing exactly what to expect on test day is an important way to manage pre-test anxiety" [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — How to Relax Before your Exam].

Anxiety consumes working memory, and working memory is what holds a Listening answer while the next question starts. Sit at least two full 2h40 mocks, typed, before test day. The goal is that nothing on the day is new.

Myths that hold you back

"Bring your own pencils and a spare eraser." The British Council bans personal stationery and says the centre supplies a black ink pen **for the paper test** [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Test day advice, fetched 2026-07-31]; Cambridge's FAQ says you may write in pen or pencil [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS Academic FAQs PDF (269898), p.7]. The two answer different questions, and neither applies to you: on computer the centre supplies pen and paper for notes. **Bring nothing.** The myth's real cost is starting your test day arguing with an invigilator about contraband.

"You get ten minutes at the end of Listening to transfer answers." True on paper [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Essential Tips to Excel in IELTS Test Day], false on computer, and you are on computer: "no extra time is given to transfer your answers"; two minutes to review [src: ielts.idp.com — How computer-delivered IELTS works]. This is the single most expensive habit to carry over from paper practice.

"Leave it blank if you're not sure — a wrong answer looks worse." There is no negative marking [src: ielts.org — IELTS Academic: Reading test format] [src: ielts.idp.com — IELTS Dos and Don'ts]. Blank converts a free shot into a guaranteed zero.

"Hedge — write both possible answers." Two answers in one gap score zero even when one is right. Guess one thing.

"Longer is safer." In Listening and Reading, over the word limit is marked incorrect [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS Academic FAQs PDF (269898)]. In Writing, every extra sentence is another chance to make the grammar error that caps Grammatical Range & Accuracy. Hit 270 and 170, then check.

"Memorise model essays and adapt them." Cambridge is blunt: "Don't waste your time learning essays by heart to use in the exam. You will be penalised for this" [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS Academic FAQs PDF (269898)]. The same FAQ says not to copy words and phrases from the question paper — and copied rubric is discounted before the word count, so copying can push you under length invisibly.

"IELTS Online is the same test, so my university will take it." Institutions decide individually [src: ielts.org — Ways to take IELTS], and it "is not currently accepted for immigration purposes" [src: ielts.org — IELTS Online]. Your student visa is an immigration process. See the top of this chapter.

"Computer results come in 24 hours, so I can book right up to the deadline." Optimistic. Official pages range from 1–2 days to 1–5 [src: ielts.org — Fast IELTS results] [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Frequently asked questions]. Plan against five — and remember a remark can take up to 21 further days.

"I'll wear my watch to keep time." No watches of any kind [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Frequently asked questions]. There is a wall clock, and on computer the on-screen timer flashes at 10 and 5 minutes [src: ielts.idp.com — How computer-delivered IELTS works].

"I'll bring coffee to stay sharp." Water only, transparent bottle only [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — Essential Tips to Excel in IELTS Test Day]. An opaque sports bottle risks being refused at the door.

"More practice tests is how you improve." Practice without marking rehearses your errors. Five unmarked mocks is twelve hours spent consolidating your current band. This is why the plan is 70% practice-*and-feedback*, not 100% practice.

"Study hard right up to the day before." The last 48 hours change nothing about your English and a great deal about your working memory. A mock the day before produces a bad score, and the bad score produces the anxiety that costs marks [src: ielts.idp.com — Mastering focus for IELTS success]. Rest is a strategy.

"There's a spellchecker in the Writing box." No official source states this either way. Nothing in any official interface description mentions one; what *is* documented is a word counter [src: ielts.idp.com — How computer-delivered IELTS works], and spelling is explicitly marked [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS Academic FAQs PDF]. **Assume there is none, and settle it for yourself in the official familiarisation test rather than on test day.**

Band descriptor decoder

Self-assessing against the real standard

Listening and Reading mark themselves against a key. **Writing and Speaking are half the test and neither has a key.** That is the central problem of studying alone, and the answer is not to guess more carefully — it is to mark against the published standard.

Step 1 — read the actual descriptors. Download both public PDFs from ielts.org: the Writing band descriptors and the Speaking band descriptors. This book paraphrases them throughout and never reproduces their wording; read the originals yourself. Then read the official

Academic Writing example responses with band scores and examiner comments [src: ielts.org — Academic Writing example responses with band scores and examiner comments (PDF)]. Seeing one real script labelled band 6 and another labelled band 7, with the examiner's reasons attached, calibrates you faster than any quantity of rule-reading.

Step 2 — mark one criterion per pass. Four passes, four separate readings. Marking all four at once produces a vague global impression, and a vague global impression is exactly the mechanism that inflates self-assessed bands.

1. **Task Response / Task Achievement.** Does it answer *every* part of the question? Is one position held throughout? For Task 1: is there an overview, and is the data **grouped** rather than listed row by row?
2. **Coherence & Cohesion.** Cover the essay. Write each paragraph's point in one sentence from memory. Any paragraph you cannot summarise has no central idea — that is a direct cap.
3. **Lexical Resource.** Count repeated content words. Count word-choice errors. Mark every French false friend by name.
4. **Grammatical Range & Accuracy.** Count sentences; count error-free sentences. **Score that ratio first** — it is the best single proxy, and four in ten clean is the working band-7 target. Then count *types* of complex structure, because band 7 does ask for a variety. But read the two numbers in that order and never trade the first for the second: an essay with four clean complex structures beats one with eight faulty ones, because band 6 is *defined* by complex sentences that are less accurate than the simple ones. If your ratio is low, the fix is repair, not addition.

Then award the lower band whenever you are torn, and write down exactly what was missing from the higher one. A script must *fully* meet a band to earn it.

Step 3 — the 48-hour rule. Never mark your own writing on the day you wrote it. You still remember what you meant, so you read your intention instead of your sentence. Wait two days and you read it as a stranger — which is what the examiner is. (My recommendation, not a sourced claim.)

Step 4 — Speaking. You cannot grade yourself live; you can grade a recording. Record all three parts. **Transcribe 60 seconds by hand** — slow, unpleasant, and the single most effective diagnostic available, because every dropped third-person *-s*, every *peoples are*, every *depend of*

appears in writing where you cannot miss it. Time your Part 2: under two minutes is a Fluency & Coherence cap. Count fillers and self-corrections per minute and track the number weekly.

Pronunciation, solo. You are studying alone, and [Chapter 6](#) is honest about what that costs: a book cannot hear you, and Pronunciation is a quarter of the Speaking band. Do not build your plan around finding a fluent English speaker to listen to your recordings — you will not reliably have one on a Tuesday evening in Tunis, and if that is the only route offered, Pronunciation quietly drops out of your preparation altogether. Two things you can actually do, both alone:

- **The [Chapter 6](#) recording review.** Play your own Part 2 back and listen for exactly three things — speech rate, stress-timing, chunking — and nothing else. Three named targets is a diagnostic; "does this sound good?" is not.
- **The speech-to-text proxy.** Play the recording into your phone's dictation set to English and read the transcript. The words it gets wrong are, roughly, the words a listener has to work for. It is a crude instrument, it over-reports, and it is not an examiner — but it is free, repeatable, and it produces a list you can drill. Track the same passage weekly and watch the error list shrink.

The criterion is intelligibility, not accent. If you *do* happen to have a fluent English speaker to hand, one question is worth asking — "which words did you have to work to understand?" — but treat that as a bonus, not the method.

Using AI as an examiner — the method and its honest limits

The method. Paste the official public descriptors into the prompt; without them an AI grades against a vague internalised average and drifts high. Demand **one band per criterion with a quoted piece of your own text as evidence for each** — a band with no quotation is an opinion, not a grade. Instruct it explicitly to **award the lower band when torn and name what was missing from the higher one**. Ask it to hunt **named** error families rather than "check my grammar": articles with abstract nouns, pluralised uncountables, French prepositions, false friends, run-on sentences. Finish by asking for the single highest-impact fix, not a list of ten.

The limits, stated plainly:

- **An AI cannot hear pronunciation.** Pronunciation is a quarter of the Speaking band. Any AI Speaking score is a three-criteria estimate wearing a four-criteria label.
- **It grades generously by default.** Unless pinned to the descriptors and instructed to round down, it rewards effort and length. Treat an unprompted AI band as roughly half a band optimistic.
- **It has no calibration.** Real examiners are trained and standardised against sample scripts; an AI has no such anchor, so the same essay can score differently twice.
- **It cannot see the real rating scale.** Only the *public* descriptors are published; examiners work from a fuller internal version.
- **What it is genuinely good at:** finding every instance of a *named* error pattern, explaining the rule behind each correction, generating unlimited original practice prompts, and marking

Listening and Reading against a key. Use it as a tireless error-finder and rule-explainer, not as an oracle for your band.

- **Triangulate.** If the AI says 7.0 and the official band-7 sample script is visibly better than yours, you are not a 7. The sample script wins.
- **When the coach contradicts this book on a rule, the source wins — not seniority.** This will happen, because this book takes positions most prep material does not: skip the third conditional entirely, a few basic errors persist at band 7, an official 7.5 script used contractions. If your coach flags one of those, ask it to quote the official document. If it cannot, this book's version stands — every rule here carries its [src:] and you can check it. If it can, log the discrepancy: the book is wrong and you have just improved it.

If the result is wrong: Enquiry on Results

You may apply for a remark **within six weeks of your test date** — confirmed independently by both partners: "within 6 weeks of the date shown on your Test Report Form" [src: ielts.idp.com — How to request a remark of your IELTS test] and "up to six weeks after your test date" [src: takeielts.britishcouncil.org — IELTS Results]. Any section can be remarked, or the whole test [src: ielts.idp.com — How to request a remark]. There is a fee, set locally and not published for Tunisia — ask the centre — and it is **fully refunded if your band score changes** [src: ielts.idp.com — How to request a remark] [src: ielts.org — Cancellations, refunds, remarks and transfers]. Turnaround runs from 2 hours to 21 days, depending on how many sections you submit [src: ielts.idp.com — How to request a remark].

One caveat you should not skip. IDP's page says the result "either stays the same or is higher" [src: ielts.idp.com — How to request a remark]. I could not corroborate that on ielts.org or the British Council pages, and the British Council terms and conditions page returns HTTP 403 to automated requests, so I could not read it. **Read your own centre's terms and conditions before you apply.** Do not treat "it can only go up" as a guarantee this book has verified.

When a remark is worth it: when one section is anomalously below your practice average *and* it is the section blocking your offer. That is almost always Writing — the section where human judgement, not a key, produces the score. Remarking Listening or Reading is usually wasted money. And watch the clock clash: if One Skill Retake is available at your centre, it must be sat within 60 days [src: britishcouncil.tn — IELTS One Skill Retake], while a remark can take 21 days to return. Applying for a remark first can burn a third of the retake window. Decide which route you want quickly.

YOUR L1 — ARABIC / FRENCH

L1 alert

The keyboard is the one Tunisia-specific variable nobody publishes. You almost certainly type on **AZERTY**. Test centre keyboards are commonly QWERTY, but this is documented nowhere I could find, for Tunisia or anywhere else. On AZERTY the A and Q

swap, Z and W swap, M moves, and punctuation moves entirely. Discovering that at minute one of a typed Writing paper costs you fluency and typos in a section where "You will lose marks for incorrect spelling and grammar" [src: cambridgeenglish.org — IELTS Academic FAQs PDF (269898)].

Phone your centre and ask. It is one call. If they cannot tell you, assume **QWERTY** — it is the more likely default and by far the more damaging surprise.

THE KEYBOARD PLAN

"Practise on QWERTY" is a sentence, not a plan. Physically it means switching your operating system's layout to English and then typing 280 words in 32 minutes on a keyboard whose printed keys now lie to you: A is Q, Z is W, M has moved, and every apostrophe, comma and full stop is somewhere else. That is motor-skill retraining, it will cost you speed for one to two weeks before it pays, and it needs its own budgeted time. Four steps:

1. **Test yourself before you assume you have a problem.** Type 250 words of your own prose on QWERTY, timed, and count clean words per minute. Task 2 needs 270–290 words in a 32-minute writing window, which is about **nine words a minute of finished text** — but that includes thinking. **If you are above 20 clean words a minute on QWERTY, you have no keyboard problem. Stop here** and spend the time on Writing instead.
2. **If you are below that, this is a week-1 task, not a week-6 one.** Twenty minutes a day for ten days, *on top of* the 90 — typing out [Chapter 7](#)'s topic word banks and your own previously graded essays. Do **not** take it out of the 63-minute practice slot: a timed essay written while fighting the keyboard produces a band you cannot interpret and corrupts `band-tracker.md`.
3. **Buy the layout, not the willpower.** Put stickers on the keys or switch the OS layout and leave it switched. Then do every [Chapter 4](#) and [Chapter 5](#) drill on it from day one, so the keyboard is never a separate skill you have to remember to practise.
4. **Re-test in week 3.** If clean words per minute has not moved, the problem is the punctuation keys rather than the letters — drill full stops, commas, apostrophes and capitals specifically, since those are what a comma-splice check depends on and what Lexical Resource scores as spelling.

Budget it explicitly: **10 sessions × 20 minutes ≈ 3.5 hours**, in weeks 1–2 of whichever plan you pick. It is the cheapest insurance in this chapter, and unlike everything else here it expires — a skill you cannot acquire in the last fortnight.

French and Arabic interference is where your Writing marks actually go, and the data agrees: Arabic-L1 candidates average 5.54 on Academic Writing, French-L1 candidates 6.15 [src: ielts.org — Test statistics → test taker performance data 2024–25]. Your error log is your real syllabus. When you sort errors in week 2 of the 8-week plan, expect the L1 bucket to be the fattest, and expect it to be worth more marks than any structural fix.

Do not resolve a booking question from the website — in either language. It is tempting to assume the French pages are a stale translation of the English ones and trust the English. That diagnosis does not survive checking: britishcouncil.tn is inconsistent **within English**. Its dates, fees and locations page offers computer and IELTS Online only, while its own English IELTS Academic and General Training pages say "You can choose between IELTS on paper or computer" and quote "Paper-based: 750 TND" [src: britishcouncil.tn — Test dates, fees and locations, fetched 2026-07-31] [src: britishcouncil.tn/en — IELTS Academic, fetched 2026-07-31] [src: britishcouncil.tn/en — IELTS General Training, fetched 2026-07-31]. So the rule is not "prefer English"; it is **prefer the centre on the telephone**, and confirm the mode again on your booking confirmation.

Name transliteration. Register with your passport, so the name on your Test Report Form matches the name a Maltese university and a visa office will be reading. An Arabic name spelled one way on a CIN and another on a passport is a problem you can eliminate for free at booking.

Payment in dinar only [src: britishcouncil.tn — Réservez votre examen IELTS (FR)]. Do not plan on paying a EUR-denominated card fee; arrange the TND transfer in advance so the payment does not delay your booking into a later test date.

Spoken English under exam stress reverts to L1 rhythm. In the corridor before Speaking, the temptation is to rehearse in French because it is faster. Don't. Spend the wait in English — narrate what you can see, silently, in full sentences. Ten minutes of French immediately before a Speaking test is how *actually, assist* and *in the other hand* find their way into Part 1.

The full interference material lives in Chapter 8, and this chapter does not repeat it. Articles with abstract nouns and the counter-list, the nine uncountables, the preposition set, the false friends, the two timed sweeps and the three-minute self-edit are all there, in one place, annotated. Do not re-derive them here — on a test-day timetable what matters is only this: the sweeps are 60 seconds and 45 seconds, they fit inside the checking window in the numbers table above, and if you have not rehearsed them until they are automatic they will not happen under the clock.

Self-test checklist

Answer yes or no. Every "no" is an action, not a reflection.

1. Have you ruled out IELTS Online, and can you say in one sentence why it is a risk to a Malta student visa?
2. Do you know today's fee for IELTS Academic at your chosen Tunisian centre, and have you arranged payment in TND?
3. Will you register with your **passport**, and does it stay valid past the two years you may need the score?
4. Do you know which document you must bring on test day — and is it the same one?

5. Have you asked your centre whether One Skill Retake is available, and at what fee?
6. Have you asked whether the keyboards are AZERTY or QWERTY — and have you timed 250 words of your own prose on QWERTY to find out whether you actually have a problem?
7. Have you asked whether headphones are supplied?
8. Have you completed the official computer familiarisation tutorials at least once, and confirmed for yourself whether there is a spellchecker?
9. Can you state how many minutes you get at the end of computer Listening — and is your answer "two"?
10. Have you written your test date into `CLAUDE.md` and dated every week of your chosen plan backwards from it — and did you make that choice on **day 8**, from four real bands, rather than on day one from a hunch?
11. Is every practice essay you write typed, timed, and marked within 48 hours?
12. Does today's nine minutes of theory come from **one named section** matched to today's skill, rather than from whichever chapter you opened first?
13. Have you read both public band descriptor PDFs end to end, and at least one set of examiner-commented sample responses?
14. Have you sat two full 2h40 sittings — typed, no breaks — before test day?
15. Do you know what you will do the moment the on-screen timer starts flashing, in both Reading and Writing?
16. Is your last study day a rest day, with ID and booking confirmation already by the door?

The night-before checklist

The audit above is a *preparation* checklist. This is the *night-before* one — thirteen tickable lines so you assemble nothing at 6 a.m.

By the door, tonight:

- The **exact ID** you registered with — passport, not the CIN, and not a different one
- Booking confirmation, printed or downloaded offline, showing your **reporting time**
- Clear transparent water bottle, filled
- Nothing else. No stationery, no watch, no snacks

Set tonight:

- Two alarms, on two devices
- Route checked, plus Tunis traffic margin on top of the 30-minute floor
- Phone charged — it goes in the locker switched off, but you need it to get there
- No mock today or tomorrow morning. The last 48 hours change your working memory, not your English

In the morning:

- Eat something substantial. Writing is sat in the last hour of a 2h40 block with no breaks

- Toilet **before** you enter the room — you are told to, and there is no break
- Arrive early enough to check in without hurrying: ID, photograph, possibly a finger scan, belongings locked away

In the first sixty seconds at the desk:

- Set the **volume** during the instructions, slightly louder than feels right — you keep control throughout
 - Say the three rules to yourself once: **two minutes** at the end of Listening and no transfer time
 - **never** leave a box blank, guess one thing inside the word limit
 - when the timer flashes at 10 and 5 minutes, stop generating and start checking
-

Appendices

The appendices are separate files so you can print or keep them open while working:

- Appendix A — Band descriptor summary tables
- Appendix B — Complete question-type index
- Appendix C — Arabic/French error quick-reference card
- Appendix D — Pre-test-day checklist
- Appendix E — Sources consulted
- Cheat sheets — the final 48 hours